Those Heirs Uncrowned
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Those Heirs Uncrowned

by Maleficar

Summary

> Mydeimos’s smile is sharp as he shrugs. “What’s your name again?”
>
> “Phainon of—” Phainon cuts himself off, looking away. It doesn’t matter where he’s from. Not anymore. “Phainon.”
>
> “Phainon of Nowhere,” Mydeimos says, and those words disembowel Phainon, cutting into his belly and slicing clean across it. “Come to bed with me. We have a show to put on.”

In the midst of an ongoing war between Okhema and Castrum Kremnos, Mydei's mother gifts him Phainon, an Okheman bed slave he neither wants nor needs. But there is more at stake for both Mydei and Phainon: between Gorgo's ploys, Eurypon's plans, and the advancing black tide, they are pulled between a growing desire for each other and the very fate of their world.

- Translation into 中文-普通话 國語 available: 【授翻/厄敌】Those Heirs Uncrowned 未冕的继承者们 by kubicphaidei

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“So, you’re what my mother sent to me.”

Phainon kneels before the sneering crown prince of Castrum Kremnos wearing little more than a loin cloth and a slave torc, burning with humiliation and shame so much greater than he expected. He expected to be stripped down, expected to be put on display, but this is so much worse.

It’s not only Mydeimos, it’s his cadre of servants all studying him with feral intensity. Half of them weigh him for how dangerous he might be to their master—and if they knew the truth, they’d probably kill him outright—and the rest leer at him with barely disguised lust. But that’s his lot in life, now, to be stared at and wanted by the slavering masses, his master the only barrier between what they want and his body.

Mydeimos slides his roughly callused palm along Phainon’s jaw, a light caress, only to sink his fist into Phainon’s hair and yank back his head. Phainon grunts with surprise more than pain, his neck arching. For a brief, fleeing moment, his eyes meet Mydeimos’s, and he reflects that the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos is a very attractive man. A mane of red-blonde hair, cold and cutting golden eyes, the well-crafted body of a Titan marked by red tattoos. Beauty aside, his face is a cruel mask of indifference, and Phainon cannot help but hate himself and his new master all the same.

Mydeimos’s fingers tighten in Phainon’s hair. With his other hand, he grabs at Phainon’s jaw, forcing it open, forcing his fingers into Phainon’s mouth.

Deeper shame burns through him, a mortification that everyone in the room is watching this humiliation.

“Good teeth,” Mydeimos says with a studied ennui, as if this is a complete waste of his time. As if Phainon is a waste of his itme.

Phainon *is* a waste of his time, which makes all of this worse.

Closing his eyes, Phainon fights the instinct to bite Mydeimos's fingers to chase them out of his mouth. Thankfully, in that same moment, those fingers withdraw, but Phainon has no opportunity to relax.

Mydeimos yanks his head to one side and then the other, wrenching his neck painfully. He tolerates the abuse wordlessly, knowing it could be so much worse.

"Well formed," Mydeimos continues. At his sides, Phainon curls his hands into fists. The tenor in the room changes all at once, a sudden violent tension vibrating in the air. He couldn't do anything if he really wanted to, but he forces himself to relax, to loosen his fists, and Mydeimos laughs low and cruel. "You couldn't hurt me even if you tried."

That's not entirely true. Phainon could do considerable damage to the prince's body with very little effort, but that effort would be for nothing. If rumor is to be believed, the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos is immortal.

Mydeimos drags his wet fingers down Phainon's neck, over the slave torc, lower. His thumb pulls across one of Phainon's nipples, and Phainon swallows thickly. He chose this. He has to remember that he chose to be here—sort of. Though he was given options, there wasn't much to choose. This or death, and he can't die yet.

"My prince," someone says from behind Phainon as Mydeimos's hand creeps lower and Mydeimos leans even closer to Phainon. If not for the iron grip on his hair, Phainon would turn his face and bite whatever part of Mydeimos is closest. But that would guarantee his death. No one assaults the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos and survives.

"Do you chasten me, Hephaestion?" Mydeimos asks mildly, dashing all Phainon's hopes that this is about to end.

There's an awkward pause. "No, my prince," the same man, Hephaestion, says.

Instead of continuing to grope Phainon's body in front of his entire household, Mydeimos releases Phainon's hair and steps back. Phainon doesn't give him the satisfaction of sagging. He remains upright, shoulders stiff and back straight, and meets Mydeimos's cold eyes.

The scuffle of feet behind him. "Show some respect," another voice snaps, but Mydeimos forestalls whoever it is with a wave of his hand.

"It's not as if he won't see considerably more of me," Mydeimos says, clearly amused. "Let him look me in the eyes."

"And give him ideas above his station?" That's the same voice as earlier, belonging to Hephaestion. Another well-built man, though lankier than either Phainon or Mydeimos, steps around Phainon's body. He approaches Mydeimos without so much as looking at Phainon, taking Mydeimos by the elbow with an intimate touch.

They know each other well. Very well. Perhaps too well, by Phainon's estimation.

He hates this. Hates being thrown into the prince's court with no idea who's who and no comprehension of the myriad relationships. There is a hierarchy here, but he understands it only in the loosest, vaguest way.

Hephaestion and Mydeimos turn away, the former speaking urgently to the latter, who seems utterly unconcerned.

"Hephaestion," Mydeimos says, censorious.

The man keeps speaking, too low for Phainon to make out anything he's saying.

"Hephaestion, enough," Mydeimos says, turning aside. His attention returns to Phainon as Hephaestion looks on, clearly furious, and Phainon catalogues him as quickly as possible.

Tall, lanky, muscled but not a warrior the way Mydeimos clearly is. Dangerous eyes that soften when they turn toward Mydeimos. A problem

for a bed slave. A rival. Hephaestion will almost certainly be an inconvenience, whether he's a jilted past lover or a hopeful future one. Great. This is just what Phainon needs. Even more complications in an already complicated situation.

"My lady mother has seen fit to be generous," Mydeimos is saying, "and offered me the gift of a new bed slave."

It's one thing to think the words himself but quite another to hear the crown prince speak them aloud. Phainon suppresses a shudder.

"I find I'd like to put him through his paces," Mydeimos continues.

Phainon's stomach turns. No matter how handsome Mydeimos is, this is—he doesn't want this. And the snickering of the household around him doesn't help, only makes his shame and disgust intensify. At them, at Mydeimos. At himself.

He chose this. He reminds himself again that he chose this knowing what it would entail, that he can handle anything Mydeimos demands of him. Even that. Especially that.

"Mydei," Hephaestion begins.

"Out," Mydeimos says.

"My prince," another voice says, and Phainon glances to the side to see an older man in a guard's uniform stepping forward, bronze breastplate shining. The servants filter out, but this man and a few others remain, all of them finely dressed. Friends, perhaps. Or valued retainers, the sons of important courtiers.

That Hephaestion has the bearing of a nobleman's son, and that other man, there, just to Phainon's left looks like some kind of scholar. Another holds a lyre. Companions or perhaps his somatophylakes. Whoever they are, they're close enough that they feel comfortable gainsaying him.

“I don’t need to hear it from you, too, Krateros,” Mydeimos says, and there’s a touch of humor in his voice, a touch of humanity. Phainon hates that. “Out, all of you.” Now, he sounds like a bored heir again, one who wants to play with a new toy. Phainon grinds his teeth together. “I want to play with my gift.”

Disgusting. He’s hated the prince of Castrum Kremnos for years, but he’d always imagined a noble, honorable rival in him, not this spoiled princeling.

“It that wise?” Krateros asks.

“Enough,” Mydeimos snaps. “Get out, all of you.”

They do, though slowly and with obvious reluctance, until Phainon, still kneeling on the cold marble floor, is alone with Mydeimos.

“Now, then,” Mydeimos says.

This is the moment that Phainon has waited for. He lunges, propelling himself forward. He grabs the blade at Mydeimos’s sided before the other man can react, unsheathes it, and drives it into Mydeimos’s belly.

Rumor has it that Mydeimos is immortal, but rumor is rarely reality.

Mydeimos grunts, and then sighs heavily, wearily. “I see we’re doing this,” Mydeimos says. And to Phainon’s shock, Mydeimos steps into the blade, pushing it deeper into his belly. He takes two steps closer to Phainon, wrapping his hands around Phainon’s own. Golden blood drips from his belly onto the floor, puddling around their feet. “Let us go over a few ground rules.” Mydeimos sounds unconcerned as he removes Phainon’s hands from the hilt. “First, you can try to kill me as often as you want, but you won’t be successful.” With the blade removed from Phainon’s hands, Mydeimos steps back and pulls it from his guts with another quiet grunt, one that sounds more uncomfortable than pained—as if he’s used to this sort of thing.

Maybe he is. Maybe all of his bed slaves have tried to kill him.

Phainon swallows, recoiling, not quite sure what to do with himself anymore. The rumors must be true, there's no other explanation. He can't die here, not yet, but he's just attacked the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos, and he—

"I'd prefer you *not* do that again. It's messy and more of an inconvenience than anything else." Mydeimos tosses the sword aside and reaches for the nearby table, heavy laden with fruits and cheeses. He removes a cloth from it and presses the cloth to his side. "Second, if *you* want to survive long enough to report back to your mistress—"

Phainon's heart pounds.

"—then you shouldn't try that again. I can clean up the mess you just made, but if Krateros or my friends think you've attacked me, I won't be able to stop them from killing you." He sounds disaffected as he drops another cloth to the floor and mops up the blood with his toes.

Golden blood. Mydeimos truly is a Chrysos Heir, one of those chosen few who can bear a Titan's coreflame, who can embody a Titan's power, a veritable god walking on Amphoreus's soil. No wonder he's immortal. Not all of them are, of course, but all of them bear a unique curse. Immortality is clearly Mydeimos's.

"Third, I won't lay a hand on you unless you ask for it." That jolts Phainon back to the present, and he recoils. Mydeimos scoffs. "You don't have to believe me." Phainon doesn't. "But I won't. I'm not interested in unwilling partners. Forcing someone holds no pleasure for me." Mydeimos pulls the cloth away from his belly, examining the wound in it. Already, the blood has stopped flowing and skin knits back together. It's an unnerving sight. "I suppose I ought to thank you for not disemboweling me," he says blithely. "That hurts much more and takes considerably longer to heal from. I wouldn't have been able to protect you from the consequences of that, either." Mydeimos sighs, bending to pick up the dirty cloth on the floor, and he throws both into a nearby brazier.

The flames flicker gold as they consume the cloths.

“Now, then,” Mydeimos says. “Do you have any questions?”

Too many, but none of them seem particularly salient. Well. Perhaps one. “You’re not going to kill me?” he asks.

Mydeimos snorts. “If I killed everyone who tried to kill me in this palace, there’d be no one left. And I’d rather know who my mother’s spy is than have to guess.” Phainon’s lips twist in a frown, which pulls a laugh out of Mydeimos. It’s a surprisingly pleasant sound. “Did she think I wouldn’t figure it out immediately?”

“She… expected it to take a little more time,” Phainon hedges.

“Of course she did. Her underhanded tactics are expected at this point, even if they lack honor.” Mydeimos makes a dismissive gesture. “Regardless, when you report to her, you will tell her that we’re sleeping together.”

“I’m not her only spy,” Phainon says carefully. “I’m not sure she’ll believe me.”

Mydeimos’s expression is utterly unimpressed. “That’s why we will act as though we are.”

Phainon stares at him. “You just said—”

“I said we will act as if we’re fucking.” He steps toward Phainon, and Phainon holds his ground, refusing to back up. “I also said I won’t force you. These two things aren’t mutually exclusive.” His lips twisted in a sardonic, pitying sort of smile. “My mother usually picks cleverer agents.”

Flushing with frustrated heat, Phainon crosses his arms—and becomes keenly aware of how little he’s wearing once more. A scrap of fabric between his legs, whereas Mydeimos is resplendent in his royal regalia. “That sounds too underhanded for a Kremnoan,” he says, wielding the words like a knife.

Mydeimos’s smile is sharp as he shrugs. “What’s your name again?”

“Phainon of—” Phainon cuts himself off, looking away. It doesn’t matter where he’s from. Not anymore. “Phainon.”

“Phainon of Nowhere,” Mydeimos says, and those words disembowel Phainon, cutting into his belly and slicing clean across it. “Come to bed with me. We have a show to put on.”

A frisson of heat runs through Phainon, one that shames and frustrates him. “I can lie to your mother—”

“Speak better of her,” Mydeimos says, leading Phainon through the suite of rooms.

“I can lie to the queen well enough,” Phainon corrects himself, bristling, staring at Mydeimos’s back as though the secret to his immortality is contained somewhere in his spine. “We don’t have to put on any acts.”

“I don’t care whether or not my mother believes you,” Mydeimos replies. “It’s not her I’m worried about convincing.”

His court. If they suspect for an instant that Phainon isn’t performing his duties as Mydeimos’s pet bed slave, they’ll almost certainly take matters into heir own hands. “Why do you care?”

Mydeimos hums. “I wonder,” is all he says, stopping beside his bed. It’s a broad thing, large enough to fit several people, or perhaps only two, considering the breadth of Mydeimos’s form. Sitting on the edge of his bed, he pulls at the laces of his sandals, kicking them aside. “Strip.”

Phainon bristles. “I thought you weren’t—”

“I’m not,” Mydeimos says. “But if anyone discovers us, we must make this look real.” Annoyance and disdain drip from his lips.

“Surely no one will enter now that you’ve dismissed them.”

Mydeimos scoffs. “Spoken like a man who has never lived in a palace.”

“We can’t all be princes.”

Mydeimos's expression shutters. "No, we can't." He strips off his chiton, leaving himself naked, and Phainon has to turn away lest he betray himself. Mydeimos is too well built, too handsome, with a thick cock heavy between his legs, and Phainon, well. It's been a long time since Phainon laid with someone, and Mydeimos is exactly the kind of man he prefers. Even if he won't prefer how Mydeimos will certainly want it.

Grimacing, he strips off his loin cloth. He casts it aside and steps around the bed before lowering himself onto his belly across it. Resting his forehead against his forearms, he waits.

"What are you doing?"

Phainon turns his head toward Mydeimos, a little bewildered. "Letting you…" He makes a vague gesture with one hand. "Mount me?"

The look on Mydeimos's face is unreadable. Some combination of annoyed, frustrated, and—and maybe amused? Charmed? Phainon can't quite figure it out. "Roll over," Mydeimos says.

Phainon has never been particularly ashamed of his body, but rolling to his back in front of Mydeimos is—well. It's not shameful, and he's not ashamed, but he's not aroused enough to lose all his sense of propriety. The bigger problem, though, is that he is aroused. A little. Only a very little. Mydeimos is, unfortunately, just his type.

"Would you prefer to see my face then?" Phainon asks blithely.

Rolling his eyes, Mydeimos leans over Phainon's body, bending low until their mouths are a mere breath apart. "Not particularly, Phainon of Nowhere."

That kills some of whatever weird erection Phainon's trying to fight, but only some, which is perhaps more miserable than if it killed all of his arousal. And maybe he does feel some shame when he lifts his chin, half expecting a kiss from Mydeimos—only because of their proximity, of course.

Mydeimos scoffs. “Down, puppy. I don’t fuck my mother’s spies.”

“Why not?” Phainon asks, forcing himself to give Mydeimos a challenging smile. He supposes that one of Gorgo’s spies would be cocky and aggressive with the prince, supposes someone in Gorgo’s employ would bite back. Gorgo, from what he understands of her, which is little, does not employ cowards.

Snorting, Mydeimos straddles Phainon, and Phainon inhales. “Because I’m not stupid,” Mydeimos says, settling his ass mere inches from Phainon’s half hard, traitorous dick. “Because that always leads to trouble, and I’m not interested in tangling with my mother.” Callused fingers brush over Phainon’s chest, and a frisson of pleasure jolts through him. His cock twitches as Mydeimos flattens his palm against Phainon’s sternum. “How good an actor are you?”

All things considered, Phainon has started to consider himself a very good actor, thanks very much. “I’m a spy, aren’t I?” he asks, another challenge.

Laughing, Mydeimos lowers his head between his shoulder blades. “Then put your hands on my hips and pretend to work.”

Fuck. Fuck, Phainon isn’t *that* good an actor. That is, he knows what he’s doing, he knows how to pretend like he’s fucking the prince of Castrum Kremnos, but he doesn’t think his dick is going to survive this unscathed, and that’s horrifically embarrassing. That’s mortifying, actually, that he might grind himself against the curve of Mydeimos’s ass and Mydeimos might find him hard and wanting.

“What if this isn’t how I’d fuck you?” he asks, but he places his hands on Mydeimos’s hips. Mydeimos isn’t sitting so far back that Phainon’s cock will graze his ass, but he’s sitting far enough forward for Phainon to see that he isn’t interested at all. Mydeimos is a soft weight against Phainon’s belly, and that really does kill his erection. Thank all the Titans.

Mydeimos leans forward. “Then how would you fuck me?” he asks in reply.

And there goes Phainon's cock, roaring back to life. He's almost fully hard as he pulls down on Mydeimos's hips, grinding Mydeimos against his belly as if they're actually fucking, and he lifts one leg, the one closest to the door, to hide the fact that he's not actually inside the prince—just in case anyone's looking. And someone might be. Given how Mydeimos keeps talking, someone probably is. Phainon's cock gets just that much harder.

"Maybe I'd put you on your hands and knees," he says.

Mydeimos arches an eyebrow. "Maybe?"

"Or maybe on your back, legs spread across my lap." He urges Mydeimos to rock forward and back, urges his hips to move, and tries not to pay any attention to the way Mydeimos's cock is flushing and filling. "With your wrists pinned above your head."

Mydeimos makes a sound that could be a grunt of surprise—or some kind of startled little moan—and that sound goes straight to Phainon's dick. It shouldn't. None of this should be anything close to arousing, but Mydeimos really is Phainon's type, and apparently would prefer to take what Phainon would prefer to give, and that's really doing something for him. It's *really* doing something for him.

"Do you truly think you could restrain me?" Mydeimos asks, but he's panting.

"Yes," Phainon says, throwing a cocksure grin up at Mydeimos, who presses harder against Phainon's sternum. Who moves faster. "Yes, I think I could. I think you'd let me." He's not usually this bold with a partner, not usually this aggressive. It's not that he can't be or that he doesn't like to be but usually he's with people who take a weird attitude toward him, and usually he isn't particularly inspired.

Unfortunately for him, Mydeimos is inspiring.

"I think you might want me to," Phainon continues, gripping Mydeimos's hips harder and dragging him over his stomach.

Heat flares in Mydeimos's eyes, which has to be a very bad thing. Phainon doesn't really want to be a bed slave, but maybe it wouldn't be so bad being Mydeimos's bed slave. Maybe he could tolerate it, if it meant pinning the man above him to the bed and fucking him hard and deep to the point of tears, to tear down the arrogant prince and reduce him to a whining wreck.

"I think you talk too much," Mydeimos says.

Phainon throws a grin at him, cocky and just as arrogant. He's no prince, but he won't let this one lessen him. "Do something about it, then, Your Highness."

Mydeimos shudders, throws his head back, and moans as his hips go still, as he grinds himself down into Phainon's stomach.

If that's not the hottest thing Phainon has ever seen, has ever heard, and it's fake. It's Mydeimos pretending. It's fake. Phainon wants to make it real. He yanks Mydeimos down harder and arches against him, dragging the tip of his now hard cock along the curve of Mydeimos's ass, and feigns a moan of his own.

They both go still, but they're both panting. Phainon can't look at Mydeimos except from the corner of his eyes, and Mydeimos seems unwilling to look at him, too. Phainon has had his share of awkward moments, but this one is definitely the most awkward, is definitely worse than any other.

Swallowing, he drops his hands from Mydeimos's hips. "So," he says.

"Be silent," Mydeimos hisses. "We are pleasantly exhausted, aren't we?"

Phainon frowns. Everyone he's ever fucked has wanted to talk to him after sex. "I guess," he says.

Abruptly, Mydeimos swings off Phainon's hips, and Phainon isn't particularly surprised to see that the prince is more than half hard. That was weird, sure, but it was hot, too, and it's a little relieving to see that Mydeimos was equally as affected as Phainon.

Mydeimos leaves his things on the floor as he takes himself and the tightest, firmest ass Phainon has ever seen across the room toward an archway Phainon hadn’t noticed earlier. To be fair, he hadn’t noticed most of the room earlier. He’d been a little worried, a little preoccupied, by how everything was supposed to go.

Propping himself up, Phainon watches Mydeimos approach the arch. “What now?” Phainon asks.

Mydeimos pauses in the archway. “Now?” He glances over his shoulder. “*I* am going to take a bath.”

That sounds nice, actually. “And what am I supposed to do?” Phainon asks, growing increasingly unsure of himself.

Mydeimos shrugs. “How am I supposed to know?”

Sitting, Phainon rakes a hand through his hair. “Well, what have your other __”

“I’ve never had another bed slave,” Mydeimos snaps, and he steps through the archway.

Phainon drops his hand to his lap, staring at his palms and his own half-hard cock. That, he supposes, could have gone much worse.

Chapter End Notes

> hello, friends, welcome! for those of you unfamiliar, i update my longfics weekly on fridays, usually around 3-4pm eastern time. i hope you stick around to enjoy this ride, because it's gonna be a wild one /looks pointedly at that unreliable narrator tag
>
> also, you may find yourself asking "reg, where does the canon end and the greek au begin?" and honestly, man, idk. it's woven in there, we'll figure it out together as we go
>
> as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Gentle lyre music fills the garden, Peucesta plucking out a melody Mydei hasn't heard before. It's a soothing tune, wandering and euphonic, pleasing despite its simplicity. It's the only simple thing he's heard all day.

"I still can't believe you fucked him," Leonnius says, popping a fig in his mouth.

Mydei chokes on his wine, but Peucesta plays on, unaffected. He does smirk, though, the little shit.

"At least I don't have to brew anything for them," Perdikkas says, laughing. "Nothing to prevent a little prince from quickening in any non-existent wombs." Mydei shoots Perdikkas a glare, and Perdikkas laughs again. "Unless there's something that's changed since last we saw you naked, Your Highness."

"Go fuck yourself," Mydei says for lack of anything wittier but in desperate need of expressing his annoyance.

"The wine, though," Ptolemy says, reaching over to pluck the goblet from Mydei's hand.

Mydei sputters, reaching for it. "I was drinking that, you knave." He grabs for the goblet, but Ptolemy turns away at the last minute.

"If you want to enjoy your new prize, perhaps you shouldn't," Ptolemy says, still grinning.

Lunging up from where he's reclining, Mydei grabs the goblet back, sloshing wine over the side and glowering at his friends. "Wine alone won't prevent me from doing what needs to be done," he snaps.

“Too much of it certainly will,” Perdikkas says, leaning forward to pluck a grape from a vine. “Or perhaps our prince already struggles to—”

“I do not,” Mydei grits out, wondering why he suffers any of these men.

They’re laughing, all of them except Hephaestion, who sits off to the side of the banquet table wearing a simple chiton and a simpler frown. He’s always been an understated man, but today more than any other, and Mydei cannot help the pang of guilt. Where Phainon will be splendidly garbed to mark his position within Mydei’s household, Hephaestion chooses to be a counterbalance.

“Your new bedmate was well pleased?” Leonnius asks, leaning forward. “Did he moan prettily for you?”

A flash of heat, of annoyance and frustration. He’s used to being teased about his conquests. “Of course,” Mydei says, trying for nonchalance. He’s not a virgin, and he’s discussed his sexual conquests with his friends before, but this is uncomfortable. It’s all a lie, and Mydei, though he hasn’t had inconsiderable amounts of practice, does not consider himself a particularly good liar. Few Kremnoans are.

“Did he moan like a whore for you? Did he cry?” Ptolemy flicks Leonnius’s shoulder, forcing the other man back, all so he can cut into a thick wedge of cheese for his bread. “The story is in the details, Mydei, you mustn’t leave them out.”

“Mustn’t he?” Hephaestion says at last.

“And you!” Leonnius cries, throwing his arms wide as he turns toward Hephaestion. “Skulking in the corner like some Okheman spy! Come join us! Celebrate our prince’s victory over his new bedmate!”

Hephaestion regards his own goblet as though all the answers to life and death are contained therein. “What difference is in this conquest as opposed to all the others?” he asks dryly, bitterly. And, before anyone can answer, he adds, “Ah, yes. This one is Her Majesty’s handpicked spy. Or did the lot of you forget that little detail?”

“So sour,” Leonnius says, rising to sidle up to Hephaestion. He drapes his drink-laden arm over Hephaestion’s shoulder, and Hephaestion attempts to shrug him off, but Leonnius cannot be moved—or Hephaestion isn’t trying as hard as his thin expression might suggest. “Come now, Hephaestion. A man with a face and body like that… that… Mydei, what’s his name again?”

“With a face and body like that, does it matter?” Perdikkas asks with a lurid grin.

Mydei bristles. “It’s Phainon. His name is Phainon.” He has no idea why he’s bristling. Has no idea why it matters. Phainon is no one, just a bed slave. But, Titans, the way Phainon looked beneath him, the feel of Phainon’s cock against his ass in those last moments, the promise of something more in their heated banter. He’d gone into the bathroom not to rinse off the faint sheen of sweat on his skin but to relieve the aching in his own cock without Phainon seeing. But no matter their repartee while playing their parts, Mydei has no intention of putting his hands on Phainon in any meaningful way. They can perhaps playact again if required, but he will not force Phainon into anything.

“Phainon of what?” Ptolemy asks. “Surely Her Majesty gave you a bed slave with some impressive lineage.”

“Of nothing and nowhere,” Hephaestion says before Mydei can reply. He shrugs out from under Leonnius’s arm and drops to the banquet table, pouring himself a generous goblet of wine—filling it almost to the rim.

Mydei acknowledges this with a salute of his own goblet. “Nothing and nowhere, yes, but even you must admit he’s fine of form.”

“I must admit nothing,” Hephaestion snaps, snatching up his goblet, spilling a portion of wine, and rocking back to his feet. “Here you all are, moon eyed over a spy from the queen.” He points at Mydei with his hand full of his goblet. “How can you trust this man in your bed? How can *we* trust this man in your bed?”

“Hephaestion,” Mydei begins, weary.

“No,” Hephaestion says, and here, at last, Peucesta’s playing ceases. “No, you don’t get to brush this aside. That man is a warrior, and you are all ignoring it.”

Peucesta clears his throat. “And to what end are we concerned?” he asks softly, his voice as melodic as his playing. “Our prince cannot be killed.”

“That means nothing,” Hephaestion snaps, “when he can be hurt, when he can be tortured.”

Leonnius groans.

Ptolem, a little sheepish, says, “Hephaestion is correct.” His gaze swings toward Mydei. “We should be wary of him.”

Rubbing his brow, Mydei heaves out a sigh. “Do you really think this man is going to torture me night after night to sway my mind?” He laughs. “Do you think such a thing would go unnoticed? Do you think I would allow such a thing?”

“Your mother,” Hephaestion begins.

Mydei cuts him off with a look. Subterfuge may be Gorgo’s primary mode of operation, but Mydei suffers no one insulting her. Not even his somatophylakes, his friends and honor guard. Let no man but one insult Gorgo of Castrum Kremnos. Let no one but him speak ill of his mother.

“Your mother,” Hephaestion begins again, and this time Mydei allows it, “is a clever woman. If she has put this Phainon of Nowhere in your household, then she has a reason for it. She does nothing without purpose.” He holds up his free hand to forestall Mydei snarling at him for the comment. “I speak truth, and it is not ill meant. Her Majesty is clever and resourceful, but she is more than that purposeful. She has a reason for sending this man to you.”

“He’s gorgeous,” Leonnius suggests.

Hephaestion turns on him with disgust.

“Well, he is,” Leonnius mutters, dropping back to the banquet table to fish for grapes. “Maybe she just wants Mydei to have a good time.”

“There is always a second angle with Her Majesty.” Hephaestion turns back to Mydei. “Always.”

The trouble is that Hephaestion is right. Gorgo is always purposeful, always making two moves with a single piece. Everything she does has multiple purposes, pushes forward myriad goals. He would be a fool not to acknowledge that. “You are not incorrect,” he says, but Hephaestion doesn’t relax. If anything he grows more irate with that, his eyes narrowing.

“But?” he prompts.

“But Gorgo’s schemes will not stop me from enjoying something pleasant,” Mydei says with a shrug.

“Perhaps Hephaestion is correct, Mydei,” Peucesta says. “Perhaps it is unwise to indulge.”

Leonnius mocks Peucesta silently, mimicking his words, and Peucesta throws a grape at his head. “What?” Leonnius demands. Peucesta throws another grape, which bounces off Leonnius’s shoulder to strike Perdikkas, and Perdikkas hurls a grape of his own back at Peucesta.

“Get rid of him,” Hephaestion says, ignoring all of this and speaking directly to Mydei. “Get rid of him before your mother can use him against you, before she can make good on whatever she’s plotting.”

“Hephaestion,” Mydei says, sighing and resisting the urge to pinch the bridge of his nose. This may not come from an entirely selfless place, but he knows Hephaestion cares. The problem is that Hephaestion cares. Hephaestion cares too much.

“No.” Hephaestion slams his hands on the table. “No, you take this too lightly, as you always do, Mydeimos. Immortal doesn’t mean untouchable.”

Mydei rubs his hands over his face. “We’ve had this conversation how many times now? I—”

“You take Her Majesty’s schemes too lightly, you dismiss and ignore them, allowing her to behave like a duplicitous Okheman, and—”

And now Mydeimos is on his feet, fury coursing through him. “Enough,” he snarls, dashing his wine on the ground. “You may insult me and the manner in which I choose to deal with my mother, but you may not insult her. She fights the only way she can, and for her that means with words instead of blades.”

“It is not how an honorable—”

“Do not speak to me of honor,” Mydei shouts, the roar of his words filling the garden courtyard.

Everyone around him goes still, his friends turning to him almost as one, their expressions shocked. Mydei rarely yells. He rarely needs to. He is effective enough when he is quiet and reserved, thoughtful in a way so many Kremnoans aren’t. But nothing gets under his skin like attacks on Gorgo, nothing, and Hephaestion should know that extremely well.

“Do not speak to me of my mother’s honor,” he says, softer this time, closing his eyes and holding up his hand to keep Hephaestion silent. “Not all battles are fought with shield and blade.” He regards the banquet table. “I find I’ve lost my stomach for dinner, but you should enjoy yourselves.” He turns.

As he walks away, crossing the garden courtyard at a clipped pace, he hears Leonnius say, “For fuck’s sake Hephaestion, let the man fucking go.”

Phainon is at his wit’s end. He stayed in the bedroom long after Mydeimos exited the bath, not sure what to do with himself, until a servant came in and gave him the most derisive and pitying look he’d ever seen. He’d expected jealousy, not disdain. Not pity.

The servant quietly picked up Mydeimos's clothing while looking everywhere but at Phainon; she left Phainon's loincloth on the floor. Eventually, he'd picked it up and asked her where he might find some clothes, and she, without a word, led him to a tiny, windowless room adjacent to Mydeimos's. There, a small bed was tucked against one wall and a trunk full of plain chitons was shoved into a corner. But while the chitons were plain, they were certainly fine, made of a soft linen like none Phainon had seen in years. Not since the King of Castrum Kremnos burned Aedes Elysiae to the ground.

Dressed, he now stands in the main room with the desire to make himself useful, but no one is speaking to him. They won't even look at him. The servants go about their jobs as though he is merely furniture, something to be stepped around but not interacted with. He hasn't been so ignored in a decade, and he doesn't know what to do with their behavior.

Finally, he reaches out and takes a male servant by the elbow. Maybe he shouldn't. A servant outranks a slave, certainly, but he has questions. "A moment of your time," he says.

The servant looks at the floor and says nothing.

"Please," Phainon says, which seems the wrong word to use, since the servant's lip curls. "I have nothing to do, and I don't like sitting idle."

At last, the servant looks up at him. "It is not your place to assist us," he says, with such a strange combination of envy and disdain, of jealousy and loathing. "Lord Phainon—" Phainon wonders how this servant learned his name. "—must not work too hard. It is our pleasure to serve him."

Phainon is very certain that is not true. "But surely there's something—"

"If Lord Phainon were to hurt himself, we would be at fault," the servant says.

Phainon can't wrap his head around this logic. "If I hurt myself, that's my own doing."

The servant’s expression flickers with something not too far from frustration. “And yet we would be punished. It is best for pretty things to look pretty, isn’t it? A flower should stay in its vase.”

Phainon recoils, catching the servant’s meaning all too well. The servant flees, leaving Phainon by himself in the main chamber of Mydeimos’s suite, a pretty flower in a cage shaped like a vase. Suddenly, he can’t breathe. If he’d known, perhaps he wouldn’t have taken this bargain. Perhaps he would have stayed—but he’d had little enough choice. This is better than the alternative.

He drags a hand down his face, staring about him, feeling as though he just needs to see a little more to understand this whole place clearly. But no answers are forthcoming, and none of the servants will speak to him. They’re all busy, anyway, and since he doesn’t want another verbal slap in the face, Phainon crosses the main room of the suite and makes his to the foyer. No one stops him when he sets his hand on the door handle. No one even looks his way. With no feedback of any kind, he opens the door and steps out of Mydeimos’s suite, half expecting all the servants to come after him in a rush. They don’t.

Letting the door fall shut behind him, he makes his way down the hallway, more curious than apprehensive. He’s never dealt with slaves, doesn’t know the rules of being one, but that servant gave him more information that perhaps he realized: Phainon is a flower in a cage, and flowers are thought to be harmless. If he’s not supposed to be out of Mydeimos’s suite, well, maybe he can feign ignorance and some kind of innocence.

Marble floors and limestone walls stretch around him. There’s a room opposite Mydeimos’s own, its door as ornate as the one at Phainon’s back, articulated with golden relief carved to honor the Titans. The wheel of Amphoreus sits above all, Kephale’s arms stretched to either side to bear it, and carvings of the other Titans decorate the sides all the way down to the bottom, where Thanatos spreads their arms to hold the dead in mirror to Kephale’s embrace. It’s a pretty enough design, and Phainon is surprised Strife doesn’t take up a more prominent place in the decoration. Perhaps the doors were carved and the palace built before Eurypon inherited Nikador’s mantle, striking down the former Titan to take his place.

Phainon’s lips twist.

Frankly, he’d expected the entire palace to be more of a war camp, an effigy to Eurypon’s conquest of the continent. From what he’s seen so far—Gorgo’s quarters, the slaves’ quarters, Mydeimos’s quarters—there’s little enough paying homage to Eurypon’s war machine, but that doesn’t mean much. Just because he hasn’t seen it doesn’t mean it’s not there.

He turns and begins down the hall, walking on bare and quiet feet. Gorgo hadn’t seen fit to give him sandals, and there weren’t any in his closet of a room adjacent to Mydeimos’s. A shudder pulls down his spine as he imagines sleeping there, the walls tight around him, closing in. Better there than in Mydeimos’s bed, and he grimaces. He’ll probably have to sleep in Mydeimos’s bed at least several times a week if they’re to keep up the façade that they’re fucking—and they will need to keep up that façade.

With some distance between himself and what he’d done with Mydeimos not two hours ago, he can appreciate Mydeimos’s actions. Gorgo strikes him as a calculating woman, strange for a Kremnoan, and he’s certain she has other spies in Mydeimos’s household. If her son doesn’t enjoy her gift, she’ll hear about it, and she’ll want to know why. It’s better to play into her hands, at least in this. For peace and quiet. Not that Phainon is in the habit of placating the powers that be, but here…

He looks at his palm. Clenches his fist. Stares at the veins running beneath his skin.

Here, it’s best to be overlooked.

“You,” says a familiar voice, dripping with disdain.

Phainon draws up short, meeting the gaze of the grizzled old soldier, Krateros, from earlier. A somatophylax, clearly, a bodyguard tasked with Mydeimos’s safety. And it occurs to him now that the noble young man, Hephaestion, was likely a somatophylax as well. “Me,” he says casually, not sure at all how he should behave. There are no slaves in Okhema. “I was—”

“Where are you skulking off to?”

“I wouldn’t say I’m skulking,” Phainon says.

Krateros narrows his eyes, and Phainon realizes he’s blind in one of them, a scar cutting across his face. If Krateros is a somatophylax, that scar isn’t an indication of weakness, and Phainon isn’t about to test himself against the other man to find out just how functional he still is.

He holds up both his hands. “I wanted to explore.”

“Explore what?” Krateros demands.

Phainon reflects that that’s an incredibly stupid question to ask someone who arrived in the palace a day ago at best. “The palace,” he says.

Krateros steps forward, one hand on his sword, which seems like something of an overreaction from anyone who isn’t a somatophylax but perfectly in keeping with their kind of bullshit. “For what purpose?”

“Curiosity,” Phainon replies, which is true enough. “Listen, Krateros, was it?”

“Do not sully my name with your dirty lips.”

Oh, but Phainon can have fun with this. “That’s probably not how you want to talk about the lips that were on your prince not—”

And there’s a blade at his throat. He should’ve expected that, and he shouldn’t have played so fast and loose. “Do not sully my prince’s name or reputation in such a way,” Krateros snarls.

He holds up both his hands. “No harm meant.” He really doesn’t need to bleed on these marble floors. Certainly not today. That would ruin quite a number of well-laid plans. “If I’m not supposed to leave the prince’s room alone, I didn’t know.”

Krateros’s eyes narrow. “You’re not supposed to go anywhere without permission, slave.” Krateros lowers his sword. “You’re Okheman, aren’t

you?”

Phainon offers an easy smile, lowering his hands. “Yes,” he says, which isn’t entirely true, but Krateros doesn’t need to know that. Maybe he’s better at this spy stuff than he realized. Lying isn’t all that hard when it’s about where you’re from and then pretending to fuck someone as attractive as Mydeimos. If that’s all he has to do in Castrum Kremnos (it’s not and he knows it), he’ll be just fine.

Snorting, Krateros sheathes his blade. “There’s no trusting your kind,” he sneers. “Every one of you, a snake in the grass, lying in wait, ready to bite at a moment’s notice. You shouldn’t be allowed to go anywhere alone.”

“I’ll bear that in mind,” Phainon says with no intention of following through.

“And you shouldn’t be anywhere near our prince.”

Yes, well, if he had his way, he wouldn’t be anywhere near Mydeimos either, exceptional ass be damned. Being Mydeimos’s bed slave is making all this quite a bit harder, if only because he has no idea how Kremnoan bed slaves are supposed to behave.

“I’m not here to cause Mydeimos trouble,” Phainon says.

And there’s the sword at his throat again. It’s impressive how smoothly and quickly Krateros draws his blade. If not for the fact that they might as well be mortal enemies, Phainon would want to learn from him. But he imagines that’s something that bed slaves aren’t supposed to ask, and it’d probably only serve to agitate Krateros even more.

“You dare address our prince with your barbarian tongue?” Krateros demands.

“My mistake,” Phainon says, hands going up again. “I’m not here to trouble His Highness. Truly.” There’s movement down the hall; a smear of red against the white limestone.

Mydeimos turns toward them, falters, and then resumes a steady stride in their direction.

Krateros is far too focused to hear his approach. “You’re Gorgo’s creature,” he spits at Phainon.

That’s a generous but not exactly incorrect assumption. “She gave me to His Highness,” he concedes.

“I don’t trust you,” Krateros says.

Phainon flicks his gaze over Krateros’s shoulder, to where Mydeimos is slowing to a stop, his arms crossed over a very generous chest—a chest that Phainon saw naked not three hours ago as he—no. No, no, no. Not thinking about that, not getting aroused in front of an angry old somatophylax with his sword out.

“And I plan to tell our prince not to trust you, either,” Krateros continues.

“You should do that,” Phainon agrees, doing everything he can not to burst out laughing and mostly failing. He can’t stop his lips from twitching.

Krateros whips around, sheathing his sword, and comes face to face with the very prince in question. He stutters out a shocked, “Your Highness!” as Mydeimos lifts both brows.

“Another person warning me against my mother’s gifts,” Mydeimos says with a heavy, clearly aggravated sigh. “What has he done to deserve your ire in particular, Krateros?”

Krateros flings a finger into Phainon’s face, and Phainon leans back to avoid taking it up his nose. “He wanders the halls alone, clearly searching for—for—”

“Secrets,” Phainon volunteers.

“You see! He confesses to being a spy.”

Mydeimos rubs his chin. “We all know he’s Gorgo’s spy, Krateros. Better the snake we can see.” He glances at Phainon, leaving Phainon with the distinct impression that he’s apologizing. How strange.

“And he was trying to escape,” Krateros adds.

Ice jolts down Phainon’s spine. “I was most certainly not,” he says, knowing he’s walking a very tight rope. Protest too much or too little and Mydeimos will think he’s lying. Krateros is a lost cause already, so Phainon isn’t particularly worried about him. But if Mydeimos thinks he’s trying to escape, that’s going to cause him very significant trouble.

“And where would he go, Krateros?” Mydeimos asks, but his eyes are fixed on Phainon’s face. “How would he get out? He would be dragged back to the slave quarters and whipped to death before he made it through the inner courtyard.”

Mydeimos is canny, watching Phainon for any hint of reaction. Phainon keeps his expression as neutral as he can even though this is information worth absorbing. No going out the front door—not that he knows where the front door is. That’s not how he and the other slaves Gorgo purchased were brought in.

“Perhaps he knows secret ways through the palace,” Krateros proposes.

“He’s been here for a day, and some of that time was spent in my bed, Krateros.” Mydeimos sounds so patient, but patiently annoyed. Krateros flushes and flusters, stumbling through a reply that Mydeimos speaks right over. “If Phainon has learned all the palace’s secrets in the time since my mother purchased him and I let him out of my bed, then perhaps we deserve to have our confidences broken.”

Krateros sputters.

A full-bodied laugh rumbles out of Mydeimos, and he uncrosses his arms to slap Krateros on the shoulder. “You give the slave too much credit.”

Heat replaces ice, fury replacing fear. It’s stupid to react to those words, but Phainon does, remembering years of relentless teasing as a child. He’d wanted to lean to fight, to defend Aedes Elysiae, and while that was a noble calling, plenty of his peers had declared him too stupid to learn strategy, numbers, and letters.

“I—” He cuts himself off when Mydeimos lifts his brows again. Turning away, Phainon rakes a hand through his hair.

“You see?” Mydeimos steps around Krateros and places his hand on the small of Phainon’s back, guiding him to turn around. “Nothing to worry about from this one.” He presses his hand a little lower, his fingers curving over Phainon’s ass, and now Phainon burns with as much shame as fury. “Come, then, Phainon. I’ll have more use of you.”

As much as Phainon realizes Mydeimos says that to get them away from Krateros, he burns even hotter.

They don’t have to walk far, but it’s far enough for Mydeimos’s hand to leave what feels like a permanent mark on Phainon’s ass, and Phainon wants to tear Mydeimos’s hand from his wrist.

“Perhaps,” he hisses as Mydeimos guides him back into his room, “Krateros doesn’t give me enough credit.”

“Watch yourself,” Mydeimos murmurs.

“Perhaps my master left me alone and bored with nothing to do, so I took it upon myself to learn about the palace.”

“A dangerous form of entertainment,” Mydeimos says. He crosses the foyer to the main room, collapsing onto a settee near an empty table, raking a hand through his hair and tipping his head back. For a brief moment, he looks utterly exhausted. Then he fixes Phainon with an expression of pure disdain, and Phainon snaps.

Striding up to the table, Phainon leans over it. “I’ve been tossed between masters since I arrived here, abandoned by my latest one after he so

callously used me—” He notes the way the servants in the room have become far more fixed on their work but every last one of them has turned an ear toward the conversation. Good. Let them think Mydeimos has been cruel to Phainon. “—and left to starve.”

Mydeimos looks alarmed, but not at the accusation of cruel use. “No one has offered you food?” The servants return to their duties at a brisk pace, rapidly emptying from the room, but not before Mydei kicks back his chair. “Just because I didn’t explicitly order you to feed Phainon doesn’t mean you can neglect him,” he snaps. “A meal,” he commands the room. “Enough for two.”

Mydei resists the urge to press his fingers into his eyes. “Don’t look so surprised, Phainon of Nowhere,” he says, trying to disguise the weariness in his voice and unsure of his success. “I take care of what’s mine.”

Something flickers across Phainon’s face, there and gone; he doesn’t consider himself Mydei’s, but that’s not surprising. His loyalty certainly rests with Gorgo, with whatever she promised him in return for his work.

“If that’s true, then you could explain what’s expected of me here,” Phainon says, settling at the table.

Mydei groans, no longer able to contain the depths of his exhaustion. “My mother didn’t tell you?”

“Your mother acquired me yesterday and gave me to you today.”

Foreboding washes over Mydei. “How long have you been a slave?”

“A week,” Phainon replies.

Mydei swears softly. This explains so much. Phainon’s attitude, his ignorance, his spirit. The way he challenged Mydei when they were naked and playacting sex. A week. No one has broken him—and it would be a shame if they did. He’s fully himself, and that will get him destroyed. Fool boy.

“How?” Mydei asks.

Phainon shrugs. “The usual way. Your father’s forces razed my village to the ground as they advanced on Okhema, killed the elderly and the young, and enslaved the rest of us.”

Mydei studies him. His words are too casual, but perhaps Phainon is avoiding as much of the painful truth as he can. Perhaps this casualness is studied, deliberate. Regardless, Mydei doesn’t believe him. “I…” He exhales and shakes his head. “Never mind. A first lesson, then. Slaves don’t sit until they’re invited to do so.” He looks pointedly at the chair Phainon has availed himself of.

“Oh.” Phainon doesn’t sound the least bit contrite.

“Another man would have you whipped for this,” Mydei says.

“But not you?”

“Truthfully, I cannot be bothered.” Whipping Phainon would take too much of Mydei’s waning energy, and, frankly, he doesn’t want to do anything to damage Phainon’s spirit. It’s refreshing. Even his servants are somewhat broken, functioning forever in fear of the threat of the palace’s slave master. Periander isn’t their master, and they are not slaves, but one wrong word from Mydei could condemn them. They are bent and bowed despite his efforts, and completely unlike Phainon.

He rather likes Phainon.

“Thanks, I guess,” Phainon says. “But, uh, I don’t think the prince of Castrum Kremnos is really the right person to instruct a slave.”

A wan smile curls Mydei’s lips. “No, but my servants certainly won’t.”

“I did get that impression. Something about how flowers are meant to look pretty?”

The metaphor is lost on Mydei, so he ignores it. “Bed slaves have privileges that others don’t. They often have their master’s ear and are better off for

it.”

Phainon groans. “Are they—” He breaks off as a servant comes in with a platter of fruits, cheeses, and breads. Another servant follows with a pitcher and a goblet. These are left on the table directly in front of Mydei, and the servants bow themselves out of the room when Mydei waves his hand at them. “Are they jealous of me?” Phainon asks, sotto voce, as soon as they’re alone.

“Yes,” Mydei replies. “Your next lesson: a slave eats only what his master has discarded.”

Phainon wrinkles his nose. “You’re kidding.”

Mydei tears a hunk of bread, spreads a creamy goat cheese onto it, and takes a bite. “I am not.” He pours himself not wine but pomegranate juice and takes a sip of it. He regards the plate in front of him and groans. “I’ve eaten already.” He pushes the plate at Phainon. “Help yourself.”

Phainon doesn’t hesitate. He tears into the meal, devouring it as though he hasn’t eaten in two days. Perhaps he hasn’t. But as voracious as Phainon is, he has manners. He isn’t an uncouth barbarian. He knows to rip his bread into pieces, to use it as a vehicle for his cheese, to cleanse his palate with fruit between bites of bread and cheese and sips of juice.

Fuck, but this is going to be a problem. Perhaps that was Gorgo’s whole goal: not to spy on her son, particularly, but to sow discontent between him and his somatophylakes and his household at large. Perhaps she wants him on the backfoot so she can plot something else, so she can unravel some other part of his life.

To what end, though? He has sworn off women—not just because he has no interest but because he doesn’t wish to threaten his father’s throne. Eurypon is already paranoid enough of Mydei himself, and Mydei has no desire to add to that paranoia. This can’t be about succession. Gorgo knows better than to push there; she has done so historically, and the last time led to him refusing to speak to her for several months. Proud though Gorgo is, she is weak for her son, and she caved to his whims.

If not women and heirs and succession, he can't imagine what Gorgo is plotting. Her schemes are opaque to him, but he would prefer to leave them that way. While she is comfortable in the shadows, he is not and never has been. He is too much his father's son for that, disgusting as that is.

Mydei pinches the bridge of his nose. Not two days in the palace and Phainon is causing him considerable trouble—and they're not even fucking each other. Bed slaves are supposed to be an indulgence, not an irritation, and if it wouldn't offend Gorgo hideously, he'd send Phainon back to her. Between his household and his friends, everything is messy. Especially his friends.

Hephaestion has never been so candid with him before.

He rubs a hand over his face, letting his eyes focus on Phainon, who has polished off the almost the entire plate on his own.

"Like what you see?" Phainon asks, grinning.

Mydei can't help himself. He laughs. This whole situation is absurd, but there's nothing he can do about it without offending his mother and causing himself even more problems. Better to have Gorgo on his side than against him. "Looking at you is no great difficulty," he admits, because it's also better to have a friend than an enemy in his bed. Phainon is certainly his mother's creature, but that doesn't mean they can't get along with each other.

Reaching out, Mydei smears his thumb through a soft cheese as he rises from his seat. He leans across the table, pressing his fingers to Phainon's jaw and his thumb to Phainon's lip. "Eat," he says, his voice a low rumble.

Phainon's nostrils flare as he looks up, as he meets Mydei's eyes. No one ever does that. He's picked his lovers from among the sons of the citizenry, never taking servant or slave to bed, but no one has ever met his eyes. They've all avoided his gaze. All but this man, too new to being a slave to know any better.

Slowly, Phainon parts his lips. He takes the cheese from Mydei's thumb with a stroke of his tongue, and Mydei wonders what that tongue might feel like on his cock. His friends weren't wrong. Phainon is extremely handsome in just the way Mydei appreciates. Strong, good looking, a boyish sort of charm. The way he'd expected Mydei to take him, too, was as amusing as it was painfully annoying. Too many partners assume Mydei will fuck them when he has next to no interest in taking that role.

Heat kindles in his belly as Phainon's tongue pulls over the pad of his thumb a second time.

Unfortunately, what he wants is irrelevant. As long as Phainon is his bed slave, Phainon isn't his to touch, no matter what anyone else thinks.

That doesn't stop him from saying, "Good boy." Phainon's eyes go dark, and Mydei's cock goes hard beneath his skirt.

No. This is inappropriate. Others might take advantage of this scenario, but Mydei will not. He will be better than his kinsmen who abuse their slaves and take advantage of their power. He withdraws his hand, and Phainon watches it with fixed interest. A shame, though, since there's so much clear attraction between them.

"You should bathe," Mydei says.

Phainon cocks his head to the side.

"My bathroom is yours. As my bed slave, much of what is mine is yours. You needn't seek my permission to use any part of this suite," Mydei explains. "The gardens, the bathroom, they're all yours. But you shouldn't venture beyond the suite without me."

"As we saw," Phainon says dryly.

"As we saw," Mydei agrees. "Enough, then. Bathe and come to bed. The hour grows late, and I'm weary."

Phainon's expression goes shuttered and wary.

How strange to flirt with the man so openly but then see him grow uncomfortable at the thought of them having to sleep together. “Where did you think you’d be sleeping?” he asks, trying to tease but sounding gruff instead.

“The tiny bed in the closet.”

Mydei scoffs. “No. No, I wouldn’t put my worst enemy in that claustrophobic closet. And we must convince my mother that you’re doing your job.”

“I suppose we must,” Phainon says, though he doesn’t sound happy about it. He pushes away from the table, his expression still shuttered. “I’ll take that bath, then.”

Mydei gestures to indicate the way to the bathroom, which is unnecessary, really. Phainon already knows where it is because he was quite literally right there earlier. Something like shame, like self-loathing, burns its way through Mydei as Phainon ducks into Mydei’s bedroom. He stares at the empty plate, inhaling deeply, fighting off the guilt. He did what he had to do to maintain the charade, and Phainon had been apparently amenable. Phainon is too new a slave. Surely, he would have fought back if he felt the need.

Disgust tightens Mydei’s stomach, and he shoves himself away from the table. Dwelling on his past actions won’t help him. He can’t afford to be mired in regret when he has to try, somehow, to outsmart his mother.

For now, though, he needs a distraction. Any will do. He wanders over to a shelf of scrolls and selects from his collection a treatise on the Chrysos Wars. It’s been decades since the Chrysos Heirs warred with each other to obtain the powers of their respective Titans, too busy fighting off the inevitability of Castrum Kremnos. Eurypon’s accession as Strife, succeeding Nikador, had been violent and bloody thing decades ago, and it had changed the face of Amphoreus, uniting and stabilizing the Chrysos Heirs against a common foe. A foe they have been unable to turn back.

Mydei's jaw clenches, and he takes the scroll away from the shelf, opening it as he goes. Considerable military wisdom came out of the Chrysos Wars, and while Eurypon rarely seeks Mydei's counsel, Mydei refuses to go into battle ill-prepared. His education on combat and strategy was considerable, yes, but the wisdom of the ages should always be studied. And, if nothing else, the treatise will occupy his mind.

Settling on his bed with the scroll in hand, Mydei kicks off his sandals and reclines, propping himself on one elbow as he reads the same line of the scroll over and over and over. The splashing from the bathroom is a terrible distraction. Every five words, his mind helpfully provides him with a mental image of Phainon's naked chest, dripping with water, and he has to bite the inside of his cheek viciously to drag his attention back to the treatise in his hands.

He's read the same sentence of the same paragraph at least five times when Phainon emerges from the bath, wrapped only in a scrap of linen, his skin still damp. Mydei's mouth goes dry. Though he's had years of practice hiding his expression, he doesn't do a good job of it now. Phainon's lips twist.

"Would you like me to prepare myself for you, Your Highness?" he asks with a mocking half bow.

"Don't be crass," Mydei says, refusing to rise to Phainon's obvious bait. "I've told you already I have no intention of actually fucking you."

"Then why are you staring?"

Mydei despises himself more in that moment than he has in his entire life. He looks away from Phainon and makes a show of returning his attention to his scroll. "It is not my intention. There are clothes in the adjacent room."

"I know."

"Then dress," Mydei snaps.

"And here I thought you liked the look of me."

Infuriating man. Mydei refuses to dignify the comment with a response, rereading the same damn sentence yet again.

But Phainon drifts into his closest, rummaging noisily through the trunks of clothing, and when he emerges, he has a proper skirt wrapped around his waist and his chest is less damp if still, unfortunately, on prominent display. Mydei is no beast. He's been around handsome, half-naked men for much of his life. Phainon, he tells himself, is no different than them. Can't be any different than them.

Mydei picks up his scroll, laying it across his legs as Phainon approaches the bed. Outside, beyond the open windows, the sun kisses the horizon. The light will be gone soon, and wise men will find their rest. "There's room," he says, trying to sound disinterested.

With clear reluctance, Phainon eases onto the bed and beneath the thin blanket atop it. "Are you not going to sleep?"

"Not yet," Mydei replies, attention fixed on the scroll. He doesn't see a single word written on the papyrus.

Phainon grunts, rolling to his side with his back to Mydei, but even then, Mydei can't relax. Phainon's presence is too much, too new, too overwhelming and strange, and he'll have to adjust to this, to having someone in his bed every night, sharing his space. Breathing his air.

Unlike his friends—unlike Hephaestion—he's not particularly worried about a knife in his back. Certainly, a knife in a very particular place in his back would be wildly inconvenient, but knives in general aren't much of a bother. No weapons are. Phainon can do him no harm except as an inconvenience. He's a complication Mydei doesn't want, and he only wishes he could make sense of Gorgo's machinations. But such musings are useless. Trying to unravel Gorgo's motivations never ends well—he's tried, and the results rarely fall in his favor.

He forces himself to read, making his way slowly through the scroll as the sun sinks into the cradle of the earth's embrace. By the time he reaches the end of the long-dead general's musings, he's squinting to make out the

words on the papyrus—and Phainon is still awake, his breathing even but not deep with slumber.

There's nothing to be done about it, so Mydei rolls up his scroll and sets it on a nearby table before stripping off his chiton. He tosses the cloth on a settee before returning to his bed.

"You're really going to sleep next to me," Phainon says abruptly, looking over his shoulder.

With a quiet laugh, Mydei slips beneath the sheet. "And what will do you, Phainon of Nowhere? Kill a man who cannot be killed?" He settles against his pillows on his back, tucking his arms behind his head.

Phainon makes a quiet sound, something like an acknowledgement, as if he's accepting all the many rumors that swirl around Mydei's immortality.

The night deepens around them.

Mydei remains on his back, staring at the ceiling, acutely aware of how the bed dips around him, the weight of another person at his side. Even though he can't be killed, the idea of rolling to his side and giving Phainon his back makes his skin itch—and he usually sleeps on his side. How inconvenient.

"Why are you keeping me if you know I'm a spy?" Phainon's question is quiet, as though Phainon fears breaking the darkness surrounding them.

Mydei considers all the answers to that question, the truths and the lies. Gorgo would spin a pretty tale for Phainon, something reassuring and comforting, but Mydei is not a liar. Not like that. "If I refused you, it's more likely that you would go to the general slave quarters rather than back to my mother," Mydei says. "Periander is not a kind master."

"And you are?"

"Phainon, not only are you my first and only bed slave, you are my first and only slave."

There's a sharp inhalation from the other side of the bed.

“I don’t put much stock in the institution. I don’t own slaves.”

“But you permit them to exist.”

Mydei grinds his fingers into his eyes. “I permit nothing.” He has no power, no influence over his father or Castrum Kremnos. “I wouldn’t expect an Okheman to understand.”

“What’s there to understand?”

To be fair, it’s a question Mydei has asked himself on numerous occasions. If Okhema can manage without slaves, surely the far superior Castrum Kremnos can do the same. “I will not abandon you to a cruel fate,” Mydei says.

“How noble.”

Mydei drags a hand down his face, recognizing the losing battle before him. “Go to sleep,” he says, finally turning to his side, as much to dismiss Phainon as to end the conversation.

“I don’t need your protection.” How unsurprising that Phainon won’t relent.

“And yet you have it,” Mydei says, closing his eyes. He expects to lie there for hours, disquieted by the other man’s presence, hyperaware of the sound of his breathing. Instead, Mydei is asleep in minutes.

Chapter End Notes

everyone's unhappy~

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> hey friends, this chapter features some vaguely described violence. if you're worried and want more details, click the additional warning below
>
> ▶ additional warning

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon wakes before the dawn, as he always does. He doesn’t rise, though, too painfully aware of the warm presence of another body at his back—and too hard. Mydeimos plagued his dreams last night, fractured scenes of them together throughout Aedes Elysiae in various states of undress and debauchery. Every time he pressed Mydeimos against a wall or turned him around a shadowed corner or tugged him through a darkened threshold, someone found them, laughed at them—at Phainon, jeered at him, mocked him. He’d been so fucking hard, had wanted a minute of quiet just to get into Mydeimos’s body, and now he’s awake and aching and miserable for it.

Who the fuck gets hard for the man who owns them? Who the fuck wants to hold him down and fuck him until that haughty expression breaks, fractures into one of pure ecstasy?

Phainon, apparently.

But he’s not low enough to touch himself. He’s not. He’s absolutely not.

He grinds the heel of his hand against the base of his cock for the relief, not the pleasure, but there isn’t any relief. There’s only the throb of need, the pulsing desire for *more*.

Fine.

He presses harder against his cock, listening for the sound of Mydeimos's breathing. It's steady and deep at his back. The prince is still asleep.

Slipping his hand beneath the fabric wrapped around his waist, he palms himself, and the glide of callused skin against his cock only serves to make him harder, hotter, needier. Closing his eyes, he tries to remember someone, anyone, he'd wanted from Aedes Elysiae, but he can't think past his dream. Mydeimos with his head thrown back and his legs around Phainon's waist, their cocks rubbing together in Phainon's fist as they rut against each other. And this time, Phainon is awake. This time, there aren't any frustrating oneiric interruptions. This time, he can imagine tumbling Mydeimos onto a bed and fucking into the tight heat of his—

No. No, he's not fantasizing about fucking the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos as he strokes himself off. There has to be someone—anyone—better than *him*. But Phainon's imagination fails him, or perhaps his mind isn't clear enough to think of anyone else, because now he's fantasizing about Mydeimos on his hands and knees and begging for Phainon's cock.

Flushed cheeks. Glazed eyes. The bow of his back, the svelte lines of his waist tapering into a firm, tight ass that Phainon wants to sink his teeth into.

Phainon squeezes beneath the head of his cock, pressing his face into his pillow. He grinds his teeth together, breathing heavily through his nose, swallowing back the hungry groans constricting his throat. Not a sound. Not a fucking sound. Masturbating in Mydeimos's bed is profoundly stupid, and he knows that somewhere deep in the cogent bits of his brain, but the rest of him is too horny to be smart. And maybe part of him wants Mydeimos to roll over and realize what he's doing. Maybe part of him wants Mydeimos to insist he fulfill his duties.

Pleasure burns through him, his cock twitching against his fingers as he strokes himself. Sweet, sticky ecstasy collects low in his belly, gathering into a roaring conflagration. His toes curl as he tenses, doing everything he can to keep from thrusting into his hand as he imagines Mydeimos's body spread before him, a veritable feast. He'd look at Phainon over his shoulder, all arrogant and condescending, and—and that's what does it for him.

Shuddering, Phainon comes with a sharp inhalation. He spills into his hand in little bursts, his body rigid, his muscles tight.

The desire to throw up hits him before the pleasure of his orgasm ebbs.

He throws himself out of the bed and goes right to the bathroom, not as concerned about waking Mydeimos as he should be. The last thing he wants is to deal with Mydeimos right now, but he's running from himself, from his own actions, and he knows it.

Splashing into the bath, he sinks up to his knees, his waist, his chest. He ducks beneath the warm water, floating facedown for a handful of heartbeats as he presses his face into his hands and burbles out a groan. There must be something wrong with him. Who would ever masturbate to —? But, apparently, he would. Apparently, he's that messed up or confused or *something*.

Lifting his face from the water, he tosses his head, flinging droplets of water across the tiled bathroom. A startled servant on the far end of the bath stares at him, frozen in place, and Phainon wonders how long the man's been there. The servant drops his eyes, finishes feeding wood into the fire that warms the bath and then scurries out wordlessly. For once, Phainon isn't annoyed; he doesn't want to justify his behavior to anyone, not even himself.

He only remains in the bathroom for a little while, long enough to scour himself clean. It's still dark when he emerges, and he's pretty sure Mydeimos remains asleep. The prince hasn't moved in his bed, and that's a relief.

Phainon is used to waking early, but, historically, he's had something to do. As soon as he's dressed, he realizes he's at an impasse. Exercising is risky when all he knows are sword drills. Anyone with an ounce of intelligence will recognize his skill, and he doesn't want to reveal himself. He suspects that strength training will be equally suspicious, unless he can somehow paint himself as vain and shallow when it comes to his body's appearance. That's probably what he should do, and it probably won't be too hard.

He grimaces. A flower in a vase.

Drifting across Mydeimos's room as quietly as he can, he steps out onto a terrace. It overlooks a small garden, cozy and enclosed by high walls. This is clearly the prince's private sanctuary, a place where few are allowed to intrude, and Phainon realizes abruptly how small his new cage really is.

His cage grows smaller over the next few days, closing in on him. When he asks Mydeimos what he can do with his time, the prince answers only, "Whatever bed slaves do." There's only one thing he can think of that bed slaves are supposed to do, but Mydeimos refuses to touch him. Which is a good thing. With the exception of that bizarre first morning, Phainon doesn't want to be touched.

None of the other servants want to talk to him, so they're useless for help, too. He wanders Mydeimos's small suite, claustrophobia increasing, the hours whiling away at a torturously slow pace. He doesn't dare reveal that he can read, which means the shelf of Mydeimos's scrolls are out of the question—especially because he's realized they're all treatises on battlefield tactics. Not exactly light reading for a slave. There are no instruments in Mydeimos's room, not that Phainon can play, and he doesn't know any of the old epics well enough to recite them for his own amusement. He's not a particularly talented storyteller, anyway.

In the end, he takes to making himself a fairly contained exercise routine using his own body as resistance, but that only takes up so much time in his day. The remaining hours, he nibbles on grapes while staring vacantly into space and sipping pomegranate juice but never wine, not unless Mydeimos is with him.

His ennui is probably for the best. The servants—he has finally acknowledged that he's the only one in Mydeimos's household wearing a slave torc—ignore him more every day, and he has no hope—or desire—for them to warm to him. When he meanders through Mydeimos's suite, they bow their heads and stand to the side, and they never question his errant presence.

He tests Mydeimos’s assertation that the suite is his, pushing into closed rooms he’s certain the others will eject him from. They don’t. By the end of the first week, he’s comfortable enough in the suite that he can walk around it with his eyes mostly closed, including the private office Mydeimos maintains off the main sitting room. If there’s any room that should be forbidden to him, it’s that one, but in the end, everyone in Mydeimos’s household sees him for what he is: another ignorant bed slave.

More fool them, really.

None of them stop him when he slips int Mydeimos’s office one afternoon about a week after he arrived at the palace. None of them so much as look his way. Their lack of regard doesn’t lend itself to outsized confidence, though; he remains wary as he approaches a pair of tall shelves at the back of the room. Thick scrolls and newer codices line the shelves, and Phainon can’t help but marvel at the expense. There’s enough papyrus here to keep all the people of Aedes Elysiae—

His throat closes. Regret burns his eyes, and he closes them briefly to wash away the threatening grief. Now’s not the time.

With a glance over his shoulder at the door, he rifles through the codices and the scrolls. More treatises, more theories on battlefield tactics, more wisdom from the long-dead generals of the Chrysos Wars, and none of them helpful to him. He abandons the shelves, leaving them as he found them, and turns to the table in the middle of the room. There’s little enough on its surface, and he grimaces. But of course Mydeimos wouldn’t be so foolish as to leave important information out where anyone could find it, even a slave, especially when his newest slave is his mother’s agent.

Frustrated already, even though he knew going into this that he’d need patience, Phainon turns to an unlocked box on the surface of the table. He opens it, rifling through the fragments of papyrus inside, but there’s nothing of note there, either. Either Mydeimos is neurotically secretive or he—

Voices rise in the hallway, and Phainon quickly shuts the box. He steps away from the table, pausing in front of a window that overlooks the small

garden, and he’s pretending to contemplate it when Mydeimos strides into the office.

A coldness burns through Phainon, an icy terror, but Mydeimos pays the room little attention. “Come,” he says, reaching for Phainon and grabbing him by the wrist. There’s faint commotion beyond the office, the sound of tables being dragged across marble floor. “Now,” Mydeimos says with emphasis, pulling hard on Phainon’s wrist.

“Why?” Phainon asks, but he allows himself to be pulled out of the room if only because he doesn’t want Mydeimos wondering why he’s there at all. “What’s going on?”

“We don’t have much time,” Mydeimos says, leading Phainon into the main room. “Barely any.” He snarls with frustration, all but shoving Phainon toward a trio of servants clustered in the cleared center of the room.

Phainon catches himself before he can stumble into the trio. There are baskets of cloth, long needles, thread—seamstresses and a tailor, he surmises. That doesn’t stop him from whipping around to Mydeimos. “What—?”

“You will let them dress you,” Mydeimos says, pacing in a restless circle around them.

“What’s wrong with the clothes I already have? I—” Phainon glances at the servants’ faces, all of them white with disbelief. Of course. It’s not like most people fight with the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos.

Mydeimos continues his pacing, clearly agitated. “Now is *not* the time.”

Unease ripples through Phainon, leaving him disquieted and off balance. The servants clustered at the edge of the room are also tense, their expressions tight with unhappiness, and Phainon realizes more is happening here than he understands. Acting in ignorance is a quick way to end up dead.

And he doesn’t want to get the servants in trouble.

“Alright, then,” he says, turning to the seamstresses and tailor. “What first?”

“Strip,” the older seamstress says.

He should’ve figured that command was coming. Sighing, he pulls at his plain chiton, tugging it free of the simple fibula at his shoulder. Fabric pools around his feet, leaving him naked except for the torc around his neck. While the seamstresses and tailor are professional enough, a little murmur moves in a wave across the room from Mydeimos’s servants—a wave Mydeimos halts with a vicious scowl. That’s enough to scatter his household back to their chores, leaving Phainon more or less alone with the prince and his clothiers.

“My father,” Mydeimos begins, “has seen fit to host a party this evening.” There’s a strange edge to his voice, a nervous tension that Phainon can’t make sense of, almost like Mydeimos is afraid. But that makes no sense. “One that the entire court has to attend. As my bed slave, you’re counted among that number.”

Phainon frowns at Mydeimos as the clothiers begin draping him with a finer linen than he’s ever worn in his life, the hems embroidered with purple threads. “But none of your other servants?”

Mydeimos makes a frustrated sound in the back of his throat, muttering an oath. “Did my mother teach you—no.” He waves the question away. “It doesn’t matter. Bed slaves are almost always personal attendants.”

“Almost always,” Phainon says. “We both know…” He trails off, not certain he wants to reveal his own ignorance in front of the servants dressing him. They’ve tied a braided cord of red and gold around his waist and stepped back to discuss the look among themselves. Then, almost as one, they strip him of that chiton to dress him in another.

“We do.” Mydeimos inclines his head. “But to bring someone else would insult my mother and denigrate your position within my household. I will do neither.”

So noble, this monstrous prince. Phainon bites the words back; insulting Mydeimos when it's just the two of them is one thing. He doubts he'll get away with being an ass to the prince in front of servants, and he's not willing to push his luck. And he has a more pressing concern: the fact that he's going to have to make a public appearance. Pretending he belongs isn't hard when he's roaming around Mydeimos's suite. There's no way he's going to fool an entire banquet hall.

Fuck. Fuck, but he's going to be dead within the next day cycle. He's had more time to prepare for this than Mydeimos thinks he has, but no one taught him how to act in front of the Kremnoan royal court. No one taught him how to navigate the politics of being an Okheman slave in Castrum Kremnos. Everything about this is extremely bad, but Phainon doesn't see a way out of it. Feign sickness, maybe, but if a physician is called and proves him a liar, he'll certainly be punished for that.

He swallows hard, dreading the cut of a whip across his back. It's too much to hope that Mydeimos will have a light hand when it comes to punishment.

Mydeimos continues pacing around him, offering the clothiers the occasional opinion on Phainon's new and hurried wardrobe. That's too obviously out of fashion, that will make him look like he's from a vassal state he has no affiliation with, that makes his skin look sallow and sick. He has more critiques than compliments, at least until the clothiers start draping Phainon in jewelry. Heavy necklaces, thick armbands, torcs of pounded gold.

"This will do," he says at last, when there's a pile of several bolts of fabric draped across the nearest kline and a small mountain of gold on the table beside Phainon.

Phainon himself stands garbed in red and gold, so clearly marked as the prince's prize. His stomach twists. The torc around his throat is suddenly suffocating, but he refuses to pull at it.

"Out," Mydeimos commands, and the clothiers collect their chests and flee, leaving Mydeimos and Phainon alone. "What do you know of serving a prince?"

Phainon barks out a laugh. “I was a free man two weeks ago.”

Resuming his pacing, Mydeimos studies Phainon. “Do not slouch.” Phainon rolls his shoulders forward even more, and Mydeimos scoffs. “You must stand straight. To serve me is an honor.”

“Of course it is.”

“You must behave as if it is unless you wish to die for your insolence. My father suffers nothing less than disrespect. If you slight me, he will view it as a slight against himself.” Mydeimos pauses. And then, exasperated, he adds, “I am trying to help you.”

Phainon eyes him. What a strange man Mydeimos is. He values the one slave he owns enough to want to keep him alive when most Kremnoans view their slaves as little more than chattel. “Why?” he asks. “Why bother? I know nothing of serving a prince, and you clearly don’t want a bed slave. Why not let me die?”

Mydeimos looks away from him. “You wouldn’t understand.”

“Try me.” Phainon sets his hands on his hips.

With a frustrated sound, Mydeimos drops onto a lounging bed. “Your death would insult my mother.”

“You don’t strike me as someone who is desperate for his mother’s approval.”

“It’s not about her approval.” Mydeimos exhales heavily. “Did you meet her? When you were brought in?”

Phainon shakes his head. “We saw her from a distance, but we weren’t allowed anywhere near her.” At the time, he assumed it was because they weren’t good enough to share the queen’s air. Now, he wonders if there’s more to it.

“Then you’ll understand better at the feast.” Mydeimos leans forward, bracing his elbows on his knees, expression serious. “You will be expected

to serve me," he says. "Food will be brought by other servants, but you'll pour my wine and taste it and the meal. Can you manage that?"

Phainon's lips twist. "How hard can it be?" He may not know how to be a slave, but pouring wine is easy enough.

"Can you manage it?" Mydeimos presses.

Phainon could choke the man. "Yes, of course. I have two functioning hands, don't I?"

That pulls a sneer across Mydeimos's lips, there and gone in an instant, leaving Phainon to wonder if he saw the expression at all. "So you do. The rest of your role is purely ornamental. You're there," he says, gesturing to Phainon's new attire, "to make me look better."

How delightful. "I've always wanted to know what an accessory feels like."

"Now, you will." Mydeimos rises, glancing at a nearby clepsydra and then toward a window and the sun falling slowly beyond it. "Come, help me dress, and then we'll be on our way." There's a weariness about him in the way his body momentarily curves in on itself, and Phainon frowns. Shouldn't a prince be excited for some court party instead of so obviously reluctant?

But Mydeimos straightens, his face neutral once more, and he makes his way into his bedroom. Phainon follows, trying not to think of the wealth he's wearing in fabric and jewelry, trying not to feel uncomfortable in his own skin. He's never been a rich man, and now he's a rich man's slave. He chose this. He has to remember he chose this.

In his room, Mydeimos removes from a chest a chiton even finer than what Phainon wears, the fabric dyed red and hemmed in gold. Phainon will match him. The clothes communicate very clearly, even more than the torc around Phainon's neck, that Phainon belongs to the prince. His stomach churns. He chose this.

Neither speaks as Phainon helps Mydeimos out of his more casual clothing, as he pins and belts him into the finer linen. Mydeimos brushes him aside once dressed, going to a nearby table and opening a small box. From it, he removes a necklace of gold plates studded with sapphires and he drapes it around his neck, his shoulders. Golden bands for his arms, an earring for one ear. Thus adorned, he's even more handsome, and Phainon looks away, unable to bear the sight of him and repulsed by his own stirring desire.

"We'd best go," Mydeimos says, turning toward the door. "I'm sure the festivities have already begun and we—" He presses his lips together. "We don't want to be too late."

"Does your father prize punctuality?" Phainon asks, wielding the words like a knife.

Mydeimos's expression shutters. "Something like that. When we're in the halls, stay two steps behind me."

Phainon's pride isn't so great that he takes offense—and he knew he'd lose most of it in this endeavor anyway—but bile floods his mouth. Being ignored by the servants in Mydeimos's suite is tolerable. Going forth into a situation that will beat the truth of his situation into him… He'll have to bear it. He chose this, he chose this, he has to remember he chose this.

He follows Mydeimos, two paces behind.

"This won't be an enjoyable affair," Mydeimos says over his shoulder, his voice almost too soft to hear as they make their way down the hall.

Distant sounds of festivities—music and the dull rumble of conversation—fill even this part of the palace. But, then, Phainon has no real idea of the palace's layout. That's a closely kept secret, and it's not as if Gorgo's people taught him anything.

"What—?"

"Be silent. You must always be silent, even if someone speaks to you. Do not respond. Do not look anyone in the eye. Stay in my shadow,"

Mydeimos continues. “Understand that this isn’t for any of us. Not for me, not for the generals, not for my mother, and certainly not for you. This is for the king.” He falls silent as they pass an intersection manned by a palace guard.

Phainon stays in Mydeimos’s shadow, a frown on his face as discomfort and unease spreads through him. Mydeimos isn’t treating this like it’s going to be a fun party or even a political chore. He’s acting like he’s going into battle.

“Because you’re the newest addition to the royal court,” Mydeimos says once they’ve passed the guard, “you’ll be subjected to additional scrutiny. You will be mocked and insulted. You must not react.”

“I—”

Mydeimos draws up and turns, his expression so serious that it’s frightening. “What part of *be silent* did you not understand?”

Phainon presses his lips together, his fingers twitching not with irritation but with the kind of anxiety that only comes over him before stepping into a fight. Grinding his teeth together, he gives Mydeimos a clipped nod. Mydeimos understands this world, he does not, and Mydeimos is giving him every impression that failure to adhere to the rules will have serious consequences. Life and death consequences.

“Good.” Mydeimos relaxes, but only the slightest bit, as if he’s accepting that he won’t have to be uncertain of Phainon at his back. “My last bit of advice to you.” He reaches out, catching Phainon’s chin.

Heat jolts down Phainon’s spine.

“No matter what happens, no matter what you see or hear or what is said to you, you must not react.”

He wants to speak. Wants to protest that this is a party. The severity of Mydeimos’s expression stays his tongue as his unease grows. He nods once, sharply, and uses the gesture to pull his chin free of Mydeimos’s grasp.

Mydeimos drops his hand. “Good.” He resumes his brisk walk, and Phainon follows, two steps behind, his fingers curling. He wants a sword, a dagger, a knife, but all he has is fine linen, a fibula at his shoulder, and a belt around his waist. The pin on the fibula might be long enough to—to what? Put out someone’s eye?

Phainon smothers a laugh and grinds his teeth together. Right, exactly what he wants to do: put a pin through someone’s eye. He’s a slave now. He needs to think like one.

Mydei steps through the grand doors to the great hall and knows this is going to be bad. At a glance, he sees all his father’s generals, all the citizens of standing and the senators—for what good they are. Braziers line the walls, and a haze of smoke crowds out the high ceiling. In the center of the hall, half-naked slave girls dance around a central pyre, their skirts swirling around them, the bangles on their wrists and ankles jingling in time to the musicians’ music. Among the players, Mydei spies Peucesta, and their eyes meet briefly, but Peucesta is, as always, too focused on his music to communicate anything of value in that glance.

Phainon crowds his back, and Mydei hisses. Phainon’s too close, but Mydei can’t acknowledge that without breaking several rules of etiquette, and while he’s fine flaunting many traditions, he’s not stupid enough to flaunt them in front of his father.

Eurypon sits above them all on a throne atop an elevated dais that overlooks the banquet hall and the dancers, and a brazier at the center of everything.

Stomach turning, Mydei waits for his father to notice him before giving a little bow. Eurypon looks away, and Mydei closes his eyes, his only outward show of relief. That’s one blade dodged.

Trusting Phainon to stay close—which is perhaps more trust than Phainon deserves—Mydei makes his way through the crowd. While he would prefer to find an empty table and take up residence there for the evening, a prince is expected to play a certain part at these events. He’ll start with—

“Mydeimos.”

—his mother.

She steps smoothly from the crowd, flanked by her two closest slaves, and she looks beautiful in the warm light from the braziers, her skin cast in bronze. Like Mydeimos, she wears red, and it suits her, suits the copper of her hair and the blazing amber of her eyes. Unlike Mydeimos, she wears sleeves tied to her chiton, and they drape long down her arms, far past her wrists. Her slaves hold her goblet of wine and a plate of foods easily fed to her—dolmas, fritters, and spanakopita.

A wide smile blooms across her weathered face, and he knows her well enough to see that it doesn’t quite reach her eyes. She, too, is wary of this sudden feast. Her smile grows, though, when her gaze slides over his shoulder. “I see you’re taking good care of my gift,” she says.

Mydeimos can feel the way Phainon prickles, and he offers a prayer to any Titan that may care to listen that Phainon holds his tongue. “He is easy to care for,” he replies.

“How wonderful to hear that.” She steps around Mydei, and he makes room for her, allowing her to approach Phainon.

Now, he prays that she doesn’t touch the man; he can’t imagine Phainon tolerating that, and then there will be a scene, and he’ll have to whip Phainon in public. Which he doesn’t want to do for a whole host of reasons he’s not particularly interested in reflecting on.

The gods must hear him, for Phainon remains still as Gorgo leans toward him, canting her head to inspect him. “Your color remains good. And there’s still meat on your bones.”

Oh, but there’s an obvious tension to the way Phainon smiles at the Queen of Castrum Kremnos. Miraculously, he remains silent.

“My son isn’t neglecting you then,” Gorgo says, and Mydeimos could sink into the ground and die.

“Mother.”

She rolls her shoulder, her way of dismissing him. “Allow a mother her affectations. I am happy that you seem so content with my gift. He is a fine specimen, isn’t he?” At last, she pulls away from Phainon and turns back to Mydei, who really could perish on the spot. “You are enjoying him?”

His own smile grows tense, fragile. “I am sure you know.”

She doesn’t even look offended. “It’s different to hear from your own child rather than through the lines of palace gossip.”

“Forgive me if I prefer not to have this discussion with *my mother*.”

She laughs, the sound rich and throaty. “I have given you exactly what you enjoy most. The finest specimen of a man—”

“Mother.”

“—who is tall and well-muscled—”

“*Mother*.” Mydei sends a terrified glance at Phainon, but the tension has eased from Phainon’s mouth. Or, rather, now the tension stems from holding back laughter. His pale eyes sparkle with mirth. Their eyes meet, briefly, and Mydei knows he’s enjoying Gorgo’s teasing.

Gorgo is carrying on. “—firm of body and certainly of—”

“Enough,” Mydei says, mortified, his face burning. “This is hardly appropriate for a feast.” Or anywhere, really.

Gorgo merely laughs again. “It is my hope that you are truly enjoying the gift I’ve given you,” she says.

She knows, then, that while they share a bed, they’re not sleeping with each other. She knows her gift isn’t being used in the way he’s meant to be used, and Mydei wonders which of his servants she’s paying behind his back.

Phainon snorts.

Neither Mydei nor Gorgo acknowledge him.

“I find Phainon very pleasing, Mother, thank you,” Mydei says. “Your insight is, as always, sharper than any blade.”

Her lips curl, and she turns to her slave. The slave lifts the goblet to her lips, and Mydei marvels, as he always does, at how she can maintain her dignity being thus fed. Gorgo is a stronger woman than he a man. But she is also terrifying, and the longer he spends talking to her, the more of his secrets—what few remain his—will unravel for her.

“Forgive me,” he says, “but I see Hephaestion, and I—”

“Go to your friend,” she says, stepping away from the goblet. “Can’t be seen too long with your mother, after all.”

He gives her a small smile. “You know that’s not the case.”

Her gaze is sharp, wickedly so. “Do I?” she asks dryly.

And because he is too afraid to answer that question, he steps around her and moves away. Phainon follows, shaking, and Mydei glances over his shoulder. Low enough so that he can’t be overheard, he says, “React to *nothing*.”

Before he swings back around, he catches the roll of Phainon’s eyes, and he could kill the man. At least he’s managed to stay silent; there are small mercies from the Titans after all.

He wasn’t lying to his mother about Hephaestion. Mydei cuts a direct path to his friend even as he reflects that this is probably a bad idea. Hephaestion has made nothing but denigrating comments about Phainon, as many deserved as not, and bringing the two men together certainly promises conflict—or at least more of Hephaestion’s derision. Unfortunately, Hephaestion navigates the court in a way that Mydei can’t. He’ll have a deeper knowledge of what’s going on that Mydei does, and Mydei needs that knowledge.

He just doesn’t expect Hephaestion to lead with, “I hope you’ve adequately prepared your newest acquisition for tonight’s festivities.”

Mydei fully expects Phainon to react poorly. He’s neither subdued nor broken, and he doesn’t have any understanding of what it means to be a slave in Castrum Kremnos. But he’s taken Mydei’s warnings and instructions to heart: while his jaw flexes, he remains silent in Mydei’s shadow.

Relieved, Mydei sighs heavily, a little too heavily, but he’s trying to make a point to Phainon as much as to Hephaestion. “Can we not begin this way?”

Hephaestion regards Mydei, crossing his arms and paying Phainon no further mind. Just as the silence between them grows uncomfortable, he lowers his voice and asks, “Have you heard about the mercenaries?”

Cold dread crystallizes in Mydei’s stomach. “You’ll need to be more specific.” There are always mercenaries coming and going from Castrum Kremnos, supplements to Eurypon’s armies of conquest, but he can already guess where this conversation is headed. Eurypon only throws feasts like this for a specific set of reasons, but he’d hoped, perhaps, not this time.

“They’ve come back from a village near the Grove of Epiphany,” Hephaestion says. “And they didn’t return emptyhanded.”

“How many?” Mydei asks, that dread climbing into his chest, his throat. It strangles him.

“Five.” Hephaestion glances toward the head of the banquet hall, toward a doorway to the left of the base of Eurypon’s elevated dais. “There are children, Mydei.”

Mydei’s vision tunnels, and he has to remind himself of his instructions to Phainon. React to nothing. Not even this. He cannot show weakness. “There have been children before.” Oh, but this will be so much worse than he expected. Bad enough to have one of these feasts, but for Phainon’s first of these ordeals to feature children is even worse.

Hephaestion grimaces, too much emotion on display, and Mydei instinctively shifts to block Hephaestion from Eurypon's line of sight. No one is allowed to have anything less than a wonderful time at these feasts. "There are at least two," he says.

At Mydei's back, Phainon shifts restlessly, and Mydei can all but feel his frustration over their opaque conversation. But he doesn't demand clarity. He doesn't interrupt.

"Mydei, this is getting worse."

"I know." Mydei reaches out, picking up a goblet from a nearby table, unconcerned with who it might belong to, the picture of a spoiled prince. He waves it in front of Phainon's face, and though Phainon takes two seconds too long to get the message, he does as he should and picks up the pitcher on the table. He pours while Mydei continues. "But what are we to do?"

"There's nothing… I just wish…" His lips pull in a grimace. "There's nothing that can be done."

There isn't, but somewhere in the most secret corners of his heart, Mydei wishes something could be done. That, unfortunately, would mean treason, and Eurypon is terrifyingly good at sniffing out even the smallest hint of treason.

Mydei places his hand on Hephaestion's shoulder, ignoring the way Hephaestion's eyes light too much. "Find the others. If nothing else, we can…" He sighs. "We can be together for whatever comes next." Hephaestion reaches for Mydei's hand, but Mydei pulls away before they can touch. He shouldn't have reached out at all.

Hephaestion's expression hardens. "Of course, Your Highness," he says.

Mydei doesn't have the energy to take offense to the cold tone. He waves Hephaestion away as Phainon crowds close with his pitcher. "Don't," he warns Phainon.

“What was all that about?” Phainon asks in what he must think is a whisper but is much too loud.

Narrowing his eyes, Mydei gives Phainon a withering look. “Be silent,” he hisses, “and react to nothing.”

“Not even—”

“Not even this.” He turns his eyes heavenward, wondering why Strife has seen fit to curse him in this way, and then decides to throw Phainon a bone. “Later,” he says, trying to laden the word with meaning.

Phainon withdraws, but his expression is barely concealed frustration and anger. Wonderful. The court will see Mydei trailed by an angry new slave. Exactly the image he needs to project. He—

“How refreshing to see Your Highness here with a slave in attendance!”

Mydei plasters a pleasant expression on his face as quickly as he can, turning to face the man who has approached them from the side. Themistocles is the greatest of Eurypon’s generals, a brilliant tactician and charismatic leader, but he’s also a carousing drunkard, and Mydei wants Phainon nowhere near him. For no particular reason.

“Themistocles,” he says, trying to inject some measure of warmth into his voice. “How good of you to notice.” Fuck, but he hates politics. Kremnoans aren’t above political maneuvering even though they like to pretend they are. They’re just usually more cutthroat and direct than their Okheman adversaries. “A gift from my mother.” He gestures to Phainon with his goblet and prays—remarkably—for peace instead of Strife.

He all but feels the loathing radiating off Phainon and hopes desperately that Phainon is keeping his expression at least neutral.

“Well,” Themistocles says, “you mustn’t let such things distract you, eh?” He lifts his brows. Mydei considers putting a fist through Themistocles’s face, but that’s too direct, even for a Kremnoan. “Not when our victories are so close at hand.”

Mydei shifts his weight to subtly insert himself between his Okheman slave and the general in front of them. “I assure you: I am committed to my father’s cause.”

“As you should be.” Themistocles tosses back a generous mouthful of his wine, splashing some of it on his chiton, and Mydei pretends not to notice. “Okhema is on its last legs. Soon the entire continent will belong to Strife—to our god and king.” He lifts his goblet in salute toward Eurypon.

Eurypon, engaged in a conversation with another general, doesn’t even acknowledge Themistocles, forcing him to hang his hand in the air for a lengthy and awkward moment. Finally, realizing he’s not going to get anything out of the king, Themistocles lowers his hand and returns his attention to Mydei.

“The Okheman scourge will be destroyed.” He flicks a disparaging look Phainon’s way, a pitying look. “Gutless cowards will be better served as our slaves than managing a city-state of their own.”

Phainon shifts forward, and Mydei grabs his wrist with his free hand, squeezing hard enough that bones grind together. “Excuse me, General,” Mydei says, already starting to drag Phainon away. “There’s something that requires my attention.” It’s not a graceful exit but it’ll do, and Mydei hauls Phainon after him, setting his wine aside as he passes a table.

“You—”

“Shut. Up,” Mydei snarls over his shoulder, pulling Phainon through the crowd of guests, ignoring their gawking looks. There’s a small nook at the back of the banquet hall that is usually occupied by trysting citizens, but it’s empty at the moment, and Mydei all but throws Phainon into its shadowy depths. “How many times do I have to make it clear to you that you can’t react to any of their goading? How many times do I have to remind you to stay quiet?”

In the darkness, Phainon scoffs. “Do you really expect me to take that many blows to my pride?”

“Yes.” Mydei crowds Phainon, pushing him deeper into the nook. “Yes, I do. I expect you to be silent when I tell you to be silent and to school your expressions and to listen to me because I’m not telling you any of this for my own health. Do you understand me, Phainon of—” He pauses. “Where are you really from?”

“Okhema,” Phainon replies too quickly.

“Liar. Where?”

“I—”

“I cannot protect you if you aren’t honest with me.”

That causes Phainon to jerk back. The darkness doesn’t do enough to hide his surprise. He regards Mydei before turning away. “Aedes Elysiae,” he says.

Mydei groans. He knows the name of every city-state Eurypon has absorbed into his empire, every town and village he’s sacked and razed in pursuit of his conquest, and Aedes Elysiae is one of them. He wasn’t there—was too young for the conflict—but he’s heard plenty of stories of a brutal, bloody campaign that ended with more bodies in pieces than whole, with more dead than enslaved. That Phainon hails from Aedes Elysiae complicates things enough, but more complicated still is that can only mean he’s an Okheman refugee. His mother sent Phainon to him knowing he’s an Okheman refugee from Aedes Elysiae.

There’s a play there, but he can’t see it, not yet.

“And you’ve been in Okhema all this—” There comes a mighty clanging, the sound of spears hitting shields, and Mydei yanks himself away from Phainon. “Fuck,” he mutters, too off balance to moderate his language. “This conversation isn’t over. Follow me—and remember what I’ve said.”

He spins around and vacates the nook, not pausing to ensure Phainon is behind him. Phainon isn’t stupid; he’ll follow.

The banquet tables aren't arranged in any particular order, but everyone knows Gorgo sits opposite Eurypon and Mydei takes the table to her immediate right. They settle in their places, Mydei giving his mother a brief nod of acknowledgement, and he's relieved when Phainon leans over his shoulder to pour him another goblet of wine. Before Mydei can drink from it, though, Phainon lifts it to his own lips, taking a sip—just as he should to test for poison. Only then does he set it in front of Mydei.

And Mydei hates it. Hates the subservience of it, hates the necessity of it. Poison can't kill him anymore than a blade can, but Phainon is supposed to risk his life for Mydei's own immortal one because of all the rules surrounding slaves in Castrum Kremnos. Phainon was right to cut into him that first night.

There's little time to reflect on his own moral shortcomings, however. Eurypon rises from his throne, stepping forward to the edge of his dais. He lifts his hands, and music and conversation ceases. Everyone in the room, from senator to general to slave, turns their attention to the King of Castrum Kremnos, bearer of the coreflame of Strife, Titan of Strife, god of war. He's old, nearing sixty, but still possesses a striking gravitas that draws everyone in the room to him. Even in anonymity, Mydei supposes, Eurypon's magnetism would capture the attention of the masses.

"My friends," he says, his voice booming through the banquet hall. A broad smile cuts across his handsome face, a face that informs Mydei's own. He has his mother's coloring but his father's features. "My friends, we are standing on the precipice of a new age. The Chrysos Wars, that time of turmoil as men vied to become gods, are a century behind us and now at last we can see the future forming ahead of us. A time of unity, of peace—"

It takes all of Mydei's self-control not to snort.

"—where our daughters grow fat on the riches of our harvests and our sons no longer go to war to defend our very way of life," Eurypon continues. "That time is coming. Soon, Castrum Kremnos will bring all of Amphoreus into this bold new future." There is roar of approval from the audience, the generals and senators cheering. Mydei lifts his goblet in deference to the occasion, but the sentiment is hollow. "Our enemies retreat further every

day, crumbling beneath the lines of our legions. Their borders shrink, their refuges fall alongside their villages and their towns. Soon, we will stand before the Holy City—" He scoffs. "—and we will take it as we have taken all the others." Another roar of approval, another half-hearted salute of Mydei's cup as he watches his father and prepares for the inevitable turn in this pretty speech. "And yet we must acknowledge the insidious forces working against us."

There it is. Mydei rolls the goblet around its base, maintaining the perfect picture of indolence. A shame there's no preparing Phainon more than he has. He can only hope Phainon maintains his own emotionless façade.

Eurypon gestures toward the doorway to the side of his dais. Rough-hewn mercenaries tumble through it, dragging with them a young man, bound and gagged. The young man is complacent only long enough for the realization of his location to register, and then he struggles, kicking his feet against the marble ground and making desperate, urgent sounds muffled by the gag.

Mydei's stomach churns.

"We have conquered Amphoreus through our force of will and the strength of our determination, yes," Eurypon says as the young man is thrown to his knees at the front of the dais. "But also because we suffer no threats to our empire. Threats like these."

One of the mercenaries steps forward. He tears the young man's chiton from his chest as another unsheathes his blade. This farce is practiced; Eurypon has done this enough times for everyone to know the steps in the dance, and yet the onlookers are as riveted as if this is the first time, as if they've never seen these events unfold before. The second mercenary slashes across the young man's chest, his cry of terror and pain smothered, and steps aside.

Gold blood pours from the young man's chest.

"The Chrysos Heirs are as much a plague on the world as the Okhemans," Eurypon declares. "At every turn, they threaten the stability of our empire."

Every Chrysos Heir is an existential threat, an heir apparent to Strife himself. Even Mydei, especially Mydei, who occupies a precarious niche in the royal household.

He sees his own face reflected in that of the young man's.

Behind him, Phainon has gone preternaturally still. Mydei can't offer him any reassurance; to act would draw attention to them both, and neither of them can afford the court's attention. But he understands. Long have the Okhemans placed their faith in the Chrysos Heirs, certain one of them will somehow overthrow Eurypon's reign in accordance with prophecy. None has, and Eurypon has done everything in his power to purge the Chrysos Heirs from his conquered lands.

"Let us suffer no Chrysos Heir to live," Eurypon says.

The young man makes a shrill, terrified sound from behind his gag as the mercenaries grab him, as they drag him toward that central brazier. He grows more hysterical, fighting wildly against them, but they are too many and too strong.

Phainon's breathing is hard, is loud enough for Mydei to hear it.

Mydei studies his goblet, doing everything he can to appear utterly disinterested. The senators and generals are, of course, riveted, but they're not the primary audience for this show.

The mercenaries pull the young man into the brazier, chaining him with bronze in its center as he flails and sobs, as golden blood drips down his chest.

Eurypon descends his dais, fixing his gaze on Mydei.

Mydei debates yawning. No, that would be too much. This is a delicate balance. Any interest, any fear, and Eurypon will draw this out as much as he can—but he's just as likely to do the same in an attempt to make his point if Mydei looks too bored.

“My son,” he says without a drop of parental warmth. “Had you not been so otherwise occupied this past week, this glory could have been yours.”

Sighing, Mydei runs his finger around the edge of his goblet. “The queen’s gift is far more interesting than the conquest of yet another Chrysos Heir,” he says.

Phainon hisses, and Mydei burns with the knowledge that his expression is a far cry from neutral.

“Such an attitude doesn’t commend you,” Eurypon says easily. He paces the length of the banquet hall, approaching Mydei with a congenial smile that doesn’t reach his eyes. “If we are to ensure peace and prosperity, we must purge Amphoreus of the Chrysos Heirs. There is no greater calling.”

“My king needs only make the request of me.” Mydei leans to the side in his chair, closer to Phainon, trying to put himself between the Okheman and his father. “I would, of course, find it in me to pull myself away from the queen’s gift.”

The words are carefully crafted. He’ll do only what’s asked of him, not anything more, but Eurypon craves initiative from his vassals. With two sentences, he has reminded Eurypon that he doesn’t care for the murder of the Chrysos Heirs and that he’ll only participate when he’s ordered to take action against his own kin. It’s enough to make Eurypon’s pleasant expression turn cruel.

Good.

“Let us remind our beloved son the cost of being a Chrysos Heir within our empire,” Eurypon says, as though he is amused instead of infuriated, but Mydei can read the tightness around Eurypon’s eyes and the flare of his nostrils. Turning, the king makes his way back toward his dais as the half-naked slave girls wend through the gathered attendees, torches in their hands.

The young man on the brazier screams and thrashes, but his chains hold. They always do.

As the first torch touches the kindling at the young man's feet, Mydei gives an affected sigh.

"This is madness," Phainon whispers, hoarse. Mydei flicks a glance at him as he falls to his knees, his expression stark and horrified. "How can you sit here and—"

"Be silent," Mydei reminds him.

As he gains the steps to the dais, Eurypon flings his wine-dark cloak behind him and faces his rapt audience. "My people, fear not! Though my son is often errant, the soldiers of Castrum Kremnos do their duty." How insulting, calling barbarian mercenaries soldiers of Castrum Kremnos. Mydei's lip curls. "I will purge Amphoreus of the taint of the Chrysos Heirs." He tips his face toward Mydei—and then toward Phainon.

Mydei freezes.

"Do you not agree?" the king asks Phainon. "Is this not the most noble of callings?"

The young man screams through his gag. Heat wafts over Mydei's face accompanied by the sweet stench of burning flesh, and Mydei clutches his goblet to hide the shaking of his hand, offering prayers to all the Titans—all except Strife—that Phainon doesn't fuck this up. Phainon is Gorgo's agent. Surely, surely, he isn't a complete fool.

"As you say, Your Majesty," Phainon says, with surprising clarity. With surprising conviction.

The tension drains out of Mydei, and he downs a generous mouthful of wine.

But Eurypon isn't done yet. "So little to say? Surely you have an opinion, Okheman slave."

All the tension comes back. Mydei forces himself to lounge in his chair, to remain boneless and unaffected. He can play this game. His mother can,

too. Even his friends can. But Phainon is too new, too unbroken.

“My opinion is my master’s,” Phainon replies.

Mydei could weep with relief.

“And what is his opinion?” Eurypon asks. He holds up a hand, forestalling Mydei. “No. You answer me, slave. Not him.”

At last, Mydei turns to Phainon, who remains kneeling beside the table, his eyes downcast, his head bowed. He is the picture of a contrite man, a broken slave. “That the mighty King Eurypon deals out only justice to the people he rules.”

A terrifying smile cuts across Eurypon’s face. “Even Okhema’s snakes can acknowledge the truth!” he declares, and a cheer goes up from the crowd. “Do you hear that, HKS?” he asks, turning to the Chrysos Heir burning alive in the center of the room. “This is justice.” Eurypon’s smile stretches wider.

The scent of cooking flesh fills the room alongside the young man’s hysterical, agonized cries. Mydei’s grip tightens on his goblet as he watches the young man die for the uncontrollable sin of his birth, keenly aware of how easily he could find himself on that same pyre. One misstep, and Eurypon won’t hesitate to burn him, either, won’t hesitate to kill his son and heir—and the only credible threat to his godhood.

Forcing himself to sigh, Mydei takes a sip of his wine and turns his attention to the ceiling, as though he can’t be bothered with the horrors before him. Eurypon wants his fear, so Mydei refuses to give it.

Eurypon’s patience is, thankfully, a threadbare thing. Perhaps a minute passes, marked by the snapping of wood and the screams of the young man, before Eurypon gestures irritably to one of the mercenaries. The man steps forward, angles his spear, and plunges it into the young man’s chest. Golden blood spills down his front, sizzling when it hits flame.

Beside the table, Phainon shudders. His hands curl into fists against his thighs, but he doesn't give any other reaction. Mydei could weep with relief, but he takes another sip of his wine before picking through a plate of grapes despite a complete lack of appetite. His stomach heaves in protest—both of the wine and the grapes—but he eats a few anyway, forcing himself to remain utterly disengaged.

Eurypon turns toward a much more receptive audience, his senators and generals hanging on his every word as he says, "This, then, is the price of disobedience, of harboring a criminal."

One the generals, almost certainly Themistocles, bangs his fist on his banquet table. The others pick up the rhythm of it, beating their fists on their own tables. Mydei finally allows himself a yawn, using it to hide his horror when another cadre of mercenaries march in four more people.

Five. Hephaestion had warned him there were five.

A mother, a father. A teenaged girl. A young boy. The mother and daughter weep openly, the father is stone-faced, the boy confused but clearly afraid.

They are forced to their knees at the foot of Eurypon's dais, the mercenaries holding blades to their throats. The young boy at last comprehends the truth of what's about to happen to him, and he begins begging for his father and mother's help.

Mydei doesn't look away from them. His stomach churns, his chest aches, and a cold sweat covers his skin; no matter how many times his father has done this, he can't grow used to it. He will never grow used to it.

"What fate is there for such treasonous scum except death?" Eurypon asks the assembly, raising his voice to be heard over the pounding of their fists. "We will not suffer them."

The mercenaries pull their blades across four throats. Blood gushes down their fronts, spilling down their chests, and the mercenaries release them. The little boy falls immediately, twitching on the marble floor as he bleeds out. The father remains upright the longest, his eyes upturned, his lips

moving, but the Titans are uncaring creatures. They don't answer his pleas. He dies alongside his family in a mixed pool of their blood as the senators and generals cheer for their king.

Mydei swallows his gorge, setting his wine aside.

"These rodents were found just outside of the Grove," Eurypon says. "And where there is one rat, there is always another."

Breathing through his mouth, ignoring the growing scent of charred flesh and the coppery tang of blood, Mydei meets his father's eyes. He knows exactly what Eurypon is about to say.

"Since my son is so eager for my command, he will lead a force to the Grove and unearth any other traitors." Eurypon's smile is cold. "Go forth, my son, and root out the corruption in our empire."

As soon as they return to Mydeimos's suite, Phainon shoves past the prince. He rushes to the bathroom, heedless of anything or anyone in his path, finds a bucket, and vomits bile into it. His stomach clenches, twists, and heaves again.

Cold sweat coats his skin. He shudders as he vomits a third time. Only then does his stomach settle, and he sinks even lower on the floor, pressing his forehead against cold tile despite his shivering. The room tunnels around him, his vision speckling with black dots, and he sucks in desperate mouthfuls of air to keep from passing out.

But he's not so disoriented that he doesn't hear Mydeimos's footsteps.

"Are you well?" Mydeimos asks, so softly that it's an insult.

Phainon shudders once more and then shoves himself to his feet. The world spins as he does, whirling around him as he faces the crown prince. "How could you just sit there?" he demands. "How could you just let all that happen?"

There isn’t an ounce of contrition on the prince’s arrogant face, not a drop of compassion. “We were lucky,” he says.

“Lucky?” Phainon laughs, wild and disbelieving. “Lucky to watch five people die in front of us like it was some amphitheater tragedy?”

“Yes.” Mydeimos leans against the wall and has the gall meet Phainon’s gaze without any shame. “We were lucky it was that fast, that my father got bored of the Chrysos Heir’s screaming and ended him quickly. That he had the family’s throats slit instead of torturing them for weeks in an attempt to get more information about their neighbors out of them. You think my dispassion is disregard, but it’s not.” He shoves away from the wall, advancing on Phainon.

Phainon doesn’t move, holding his ground. “Then what is it?”

“Armor,” Mydeimos snaps. He touches the side of his throat. “I bleed gold. Do you not understand that every last one of those killings is a message to me? One misstep, one whiff of treason, and my father will bind me to that same pyre and burn me alive over and over and over.”

“So you’re just a self-serving bastard,” Phainon snarls back.

Mydeimos’s lips curl with disdain. “I am keeping myself safe.”

“To what end? To serve your father’s murderous whims? To—”

Mydeimos lunges forward. Phainon swings out of his way quickly—too quickly—he’s betraying himself with that reaction, he knows it, but he won’t take the hit that Mydeimos clearly had planned. But Mydeimos isn’t trying to strike him.

“Shut up, you utter fool,” Mydeimos hisses, grabbing him by the shoulders and slamming him hard enough against the wall that the wind gets knocked out of him. Wheezing, Phainon struggles for breath. “Do you think I can protect you if *anyone* hears you speaking like that?”

“Why would you bother?”

“Because you’re an innocent man.”

What an ignorant thing to say, but Mydeimos’s ignorance is Phainon’s salvation. He inhales as deeply as he can, reminding himself that he’s here to play a part. He’ll never be the sulking, well-behaved slave, but Mydeimos isn’t wrong. Speaking out so boldly will get him killed, and his death will betray why he’s here at all.

He looks away from Mydeimos.

“Understand,” Mydeimos says, “that the more uncomfortable an audience he has, the longer my father will draw out someone’s death. If you can feign disinterest, if you can pretend what you’re seeing doesn’t affect you at all, he’ll end it faster.”

“You could do something. Help them,” Phainon says, but even as he speaks, he knows he’s wrong.

“No. I can’t.” There’s pain in Mydeimos’s voice. Regret. It’s enough to make Phainon wonder if he hasn’t somehow misjudged the prince. “You did well,” Mydeimos says, releasing Phainon’s shoulders and stepping back. “In the end, you did very well.”

Hollow, empty, meaningless praise. Phainon says nothing.

“It’s late. Come to bed, Phainon.”

More bile climbs Phainon’s throat. He doesn’t move away from the wall.

Mydeimos lingers for only a moment before exhaling heavily and leaving Phainon in the bathroom.

Alone, Phainon slides down the wall, collapsing onto the floor and drawing up his legs. He rests his forehead against his knees, covering his head with his hands. The razing of Aedes Elysiae was a terrible thing to survive, but he’s had years to distance himself from the bloody violence. Those murders —he’s never seen anyone so calmly execute another human being, so casually take away someone else’s life.

All at once, the clothing and jewelry he’s wearing become too much. He rocks forward, onto his knees, and yanks off the bangles, the necklace. He almost dashes them to the ground, but he hesitates. If he breaks something, his flesh will pay the price, and that’s not a price he can afford to pay. He drops the jewelry to the tiled floor and carefully unpins his chiton, shouldering out of it. The fabric pools around his hips until he stands, shuffling out of it.

Naked, he stares at the inset pool nearby. Dirty. He feels so dirty.

And helpless. Titans, he’s so utterly helpless.

He steps into the bath, sinking into it up to his shoulders, but water can’t wash away this kind of pain, this kind of disgust. The murders cling to him, staining his soul like blood on fresh linen. He’s not responsible for them, but he did nothing to stop them.

Laughing mirthlessly, he splashes water on his face.

Doing anything to stop those deaths would compromise him. He’s no better than Mydeimos, in the end, chained by duty and regret—and the reality of appearances. He realizes now how tenuous his position is in Castrum Kremnos. One misstep, one angered nobleman, and he’ll be exposed.

He’ll be dead.

He takes his time washing himself, scrubbing away invisible splatters of blood and the scent of charred flesh, numb. When he closes his eyes, he sees the screaming youth writhing on the pyre, and he knows he won’t cleanse his mind of that vision for months. He knew this would be dangerous, but tonight’s feast has made all that theoretical danger very, very tangible.

Swallowing, he leaves the bath and towels himself dry, standing before a mirror of beaten copper and regarding his reflection. A man beautiful enough, strong enough, to tempt the prince of Castrum Kremnos, to get close to him. He drags a hand over his mouth. Rubs it over his chest.

He chose this.

He goes to bed with Mydeimos.

Chapter End Notes

so, anyway, that's why mydei is the way he is. i wonder if yall will figure out some of what's up with gorgo, too...

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mydei is exhausted. He stands at the heart of the Grove of Epiphany with Hephaestion, overseeing the kind of work that leaves him ill at ease. His legionnaires have been raiding homes since dawn, barreling through doors to ransack houses in search of trapdoors and hidden rooms where Chrysos Heirs have been hidden away. They haven't found any. He doesn't expect them to find any.

He does expect this to sour the citizens of the Grove on the empire as a whole, however, and even now a family regards him and Hephaestion with hurt expressions as their home is turned upside down in search of what certainly isn't there. These are citizens, and they should be better treated, but Eurypon's paranoia knows no end.

All it takes is one well-placed Chrysos Heir assassin to end his long reign.

The Sages observe, too, watching from a distance, as if distance will somehow save them. If a Chrysos Heir is by some twist of fate discovered in any home within the Grove, the Sages's lives will be forfeit, too. Eurypon is merciless: he will blame their weak leadership for allowing someone to harbor an enemy of the state.

A legionnaire approaches him and Hephaestion, offering a quick salute. "Your Highness," he says, addressing Mydei before turning to Hephaestion. "All clear on the east. Nothing to report." He hands a scrap of papyrus to Hephaestion, who glances over it to note the completed raids on his own scroll.

"Thank you, legionnaire."

The man salutes once more and backs away.

“This is a waste of time,” Mydei mutters.

Hephaestion shoots him a warning look.

“Am I wrong? How many houses have we done?”

“Most of them,” Hephaestion admits.

“And what have we found? Nothing.” He tips his head back, letting cool air wash over him.

Phainon stands slightly behind him, fan in hand. He didn’t fight the job when given it. Since the feast, he’s been far more biddable, which Mydei finds worrisome, but he hasn’t had the time to deal with it. The morning after the feast, Mydei assembled his century and his somatophylakes and began the three-day march to the Grove. Since then, he’s been consumed by the march, too tired at the end of each day to have more than a passing conversation with Phainon, and they’ve fallen into Mydei’s bed without speaking. Phainon has been withdrawn and contemplative on the march, resulting in his lingering silence—and Mydei can’t complain about that. Mydei is, frankly, relieved about that. If Phainon is silent, he can’t get himself into trouble.

“Go check in with Leonnius,” Mydei says to Hephaestion. “See if his region is clear as well.”

Hephaestion gives him a clipped nod and trots off, trailed by an aide.

He’s more alone with Phainon now than he’s been in the past three days, even in his own tent, and he turns toward the man. Phainon wears a bored expression as he moves the fan mechanically up and down, as if he’s not mentally present. His eyes take too long to focus on Mydei.

“Deep in thought?” Mydei asks, amused.

Phainon’s lips quirk in a frown, there and gone. He’s taken Mydei’s advice almost too well since the feast, barely emoting at all. “Merely doing as my prince commands,” he replies.

He’s been more obedient, too. He hasn’t pushed back against a single command, acting dutifully when requests have been made of him, and Mydei doesn’t like it. He’s always been bothered by subservience in slaves especially, but this makes him even more uncomfortable.

“I find it hard to believe you don’t have an opinion on what we’re doing here,” Mydei says, not entirely sure why he’s trying to tease this out of Phainon but dogged in his pursuit of conversation.

Phainon flicks his eyes toward the nearest cohort of legionnaires, far enough away that their conversation won’t be overheard, and turns a bland expression on Mydei. “I wasn’t under the impression that the empire treats its citizens so poorly.”

With that simple statement, Mydei finds himself curiously inclined to defend an act he doesn’t agree with. Wrestling down that strange instinct, he shakes his head. “Not something you should say in public.”

“You invited commentary. I gave it. I wouldn’t want to disappoint my prince.”

Mydei frowns. “Phainon,” he begins.

A nearby commotion cuts him off, and he turns. His legionnaires have surrounded a tall man with greenish hair, a man Mydei recognizes at once. Anaxagoras, founder of the Nousporists, a man who walks the knife-edge of treason with a casual disregard for his own life at every opportunity. He weaves his seditions into pretty words, disguising them in metaphor, and has thus far managed to keep himself alive, but everyone in Castrum Kremnos knows it’s only a matter of time before he walks into his own grave at Eurypon’s behest.

The legionnaires crowd him back, holding him at bay.

Mydei resists the urge to pinch the bridge of his nose. “Let him through,” he says, loudly enough to be heard. He steps away from Phainon only to pause, glancing back. “Put down the fan and follow me.”

With a little shrug, Phainon obeys, passing the fan to another servant. He falls into step two paces behind Mydei, not that they go very far.

Anaxagoras meets them. “Since when does the empire violate the rights of its citizens?” he demands.

Delightful. “Since the citizens of the empire have made themselves complicit in treason,” Mydei replies. The words sound hollow even to him.

“And what proof do you have?” Anaxagoras presses.

“The tanner’s family from Orini harbored a Chrysos Heir in secret.” Mydei plumbs the depths of his patience. Anaxagoras should know better than to fire these questions at him in public. “The empire has reason to believe—”

“The actions of one man hardly reflect on his family, his village, or the neighboring city state.”

Scholars. They’re all so Titansdamned argumentative, and Mydei has no interest in defending his father to even one of the Sages—especially when he agrees. There was no reason for Eurypon to order this raid on the Grove except to exert his control and soothe his paranoia. “A man is a product of the environment that raised him,” Mydei says.

Anaxagoras snorts. “So, you *did* pay attention to your tutors.”

“Some of them.”

“You’re wasting your time here, Your Highness.” Anaxagoras manages to make the title a sneer without actually sneering, which is impressive, really. No one has ever so openly disdained Mydei, and while it’s irritating, it’s also refreshing. This is why he likes Phainon so much. “You will find nothing but loyal citizens. The true concern is beyond the city.”

“Does an army of barbarians lie in wait?” Mydei asks dryly.

Anaxagoras fixes him with a look that would flay the skin off most men’s bones. “The black tide encroaches.”

Mydei's stomach drops. The black tide, that inexorable and ancient enemy of Strife, the one his father has neglected for nearly a century. Every inch of land Eurypon claims for Castrum Kremnos at the frontlines, the black tide erodes at the far edge of their borders. "The danger of the black tide is overstated," he says, parroting the tract favored by his father's politicians.

Now, Anaxagoras does sneer, and Mydei knows whatever regard the man might have held for him as dropped considerably. "I was under the impression you were smarter than that."

"It is the position of Castrum Kremnos that—"

"The position of Castrum Kremnos is ill-conceived and misinformed."

Mydei lifts a brow. The first interruption he could ignore. This one, he cannot. "Interrupt me again, scholar, and you will not live long enough to regret it." His men look on, silent and still, but he can't let one man undercut his authority in front of them. It's taxing. It's annoying. It's frustrating, and he hates this game more than most others.

"Then do not be—"

"Mind your tongue," Mydei says, ignoring the fury that flashes over Anaxagoras's face. "You speak to your prince. And while I am not as quick to anger as some, my patience has limits."

In silence, Anaxagoras regards him. Certainly, he's smart enough to understand the warning Mydei is giving him. Indeed, instead of snapping back, Anaxagoras smooths out his expression. "If Your Highness has the time, I would show you the real danger."

They've danced around each other long enough for politics and pride. "Very well." Mydei turns to the legionnaires. "Fetch me Hephaestion, Leonnius, and Perdikkas."

The men salute, two heading in search of Hephaestion and Leonnius and the other for Perdikkas.

“A prince without his somatophylakes is as good as naked,” Anaxagoras observes.

From another man, that would be a threat. “If the prince is mortal, perhaps.” Mydei shrugs. “I am not. My friends are a formality.”

“Friends. How interesting.”

Mydei doesn’t dignify that with a response, allowing an awkward silence to fester between them and keenly aware of the weight of Phainon’s gaze on his back. Anaxagoras shared Phainon’s question, and Mydei finds himself caring more that his answers satisfied his slave than the Sage. He wants a genuine moment alone with Phainon in a place where there are thick walls instead of the thin fabric barrier of a tent. Perhaps tonight he’ll have an opportunity to press Phainon. They’ll stay overnight at the Grove to be feted by the Sages, no matter that it’s for show. The rooms in the Grove have real walls, if walls made of trees, and while Mydei has no doubt Cerces will listen through her many branches, they can at least speak in vagaries.

At last, his three friends return, approaching at a brisk jog, the legionnaires who summoned them directed to other work.

“The Sage believes the black tide encroaches too closely on the Grove,” he says with a nod toward Anaxagoras. “I believe it’s in our best interests to investigate his claims.”

Leonnius grins, punching his fist into his palm. “It’s been too long since I’ve had a good fight.”

Perdikkas rolls his eyes. “All you think about is fighting.”

“Because it’s fun.” Leonnius drops his arm on Perdikkas’s shoulder, leaning heavily on him even when Perdikkas attempts to shake him off.

“We’re investigating,” Hephaestion says. “Not necessarily taking action.”

“But we’re not necessarily *not* taking action,” Leonnius replies as Perdikkas shoves him. Hard. He doesn’t budge.

Mydei allows a faint smile, a brief show of humor. “We’re investigating,” he says, echoing Hephaestion, “and we’ll see what actions might be necessary.”

Hephaestion grins, and for a second, everything is the way it was a year ago: they’re in lockstep with each other, in perfect sync. Then Hephaestion’s eyes flicker to Phainon, and his grin falls. “You should send the slave to your quarters.”

If Hephaestion hadn’t spoken, Mydei almost certainly would’ve sent Phainon to their room in the Grove, but the presumption is one Mydei can’t leave unanswered. “No,” he says, stomping down his weariness. “No, he comes with us.”

“Your Highness,” Hephaestion begins.

“He comes with us,” Mydei says again, tone brooking no argument.

Thankfully, Hephaestion relents—Mydei has no desire to take action against his oldest friend.

Hephaestion turns away from Mydei and toward Anaxagoras. “Where is this, then? And how do we know you’re not leading our prince into a trap?”

“Trapping the immortal prince of Castrum Kremnos would only put the Grove—and by extension my research—in danger. I would do no such thing,” Anaxagoras replies, clearly offended. “The practicality of springing a trap that could hold him—*tch*.” He clicks his tongue. “Who are you? Who taught you?”

Hephaestion pulls himself up to his full height, just as offended.

“The black tide,” Mydei reminds them both. “If it is such an emergency, we shouldn’t wait.”

Mydei expects the black tide to be a few miles off from the Grove. But when Anaxagoras takes them to the hills beyond the city state, it's closer than he imagined, all but licking at the roots of Cerces's tree. He stands a few paces from the boundary, keenly aware of the monsters roaming the desiccated remains of the land, keenly aware that they've noticed him and his companions. There are far too many of those misshapen creatures approaching the boundary and on it in either direction, lingering there as though uncertain they can walk on fresh grass. But then they do, and the black tide creeps after them, a slow and inexorable wave of destruction.

"If the tide isn't pushed back," Anaxagoras says, "it will consume the Grove within a week."

Mydei has no reason to mistrust that calculation, and it carves cold horror through him. The black tide has wiped out countless villages in its approach. Even from where he stands, he can see their distant remains. Worse, the black tide has destroyed fertile farmland and the people who can till it.

"We must call for the king," Hephaestion says. "Urgently. He will need to push back the tide."

Perdikkas steps forward. "I'll go."

But even Perdikkas can't run the distance he needs to cover fast enough. The march that took them three days will take Perdikkas two, yes, except the greatest trial won't be racing back to Castrum Kremnos. It will be convincing Eurypon to act. It will be convincing Eurypon to turn away from the front lines of his war with Okhema to view the second front of this conflict that he so stubbornly ignores.

Mydei rakes a hand through his hair.

"The monsters already test our defenses," Anaxagoras says. "The tide may consume the Grove in a week, but the monsters at our walls will take us much sooner."

"Do you have no warriors to defend you?" Leonnius asks.

A foolish question.

“All the able-bodied young men are on the frontlines,” Anaxagoras says in a tone as close to mockery as possible without crossing the line into outright treason.

“What about you?” Leonnius pushes.

Anaxagoras laughs. “I am but a feeble scholar.”

Mydei has his doubts about that. Anaxagoras doesn’t carry himself like a so-called feeble scholar.

“Why have you not evacuated?” Hephaestion demands. “Why stay here? And for that matter, why not send an emissary to Castrum Kremnos?”

“They did,” Mydei says. He looks over his shoulder where the others stand several feet back, as though even this is too close to the black tide. “The king ignored them.”

Hephaestion bristles. “How do you know?”

“I was there,” Mydei says, “when my father laughed the first one out of the room and jailed the second.” This is a battle his father isn’t interested in fighting. He chokes those words down; that’s a line he cannot cross. “The Grove didn’t send a third.”

“Not after we lost two of our best minds,” Anaxagoras agrees. He thinks better of this. “Perhaps two of our most adequate minds. In a time of intellectual drought, one takes what one can get.”

They have to take what they can get, too. Mydei regards the tide, far too close for comfort, and the monsters advancing on them at a slow, shuffling pace. “Hephaestion was right to ask. Why didn’t you evacuate?”

“And leave our research and all our knowledge behind?” Anaxagoras sounds aghast, as though Mydei has asked him to amputate his own hand.

“Surely you can take some of it,” Perdikkas says.

Anaxagoras scoffs. “Spoken like a man who doesn’t value the completeness of a thing. You ask us to pick and choose between our insights? What good is incomplete knowledge?”

“What good is the destruction of all knowledge?” Hephaestion fires back. “Take the most important pieces—”

“As if importance can be ascribed—”

“Enough,” Mydei says. “The black tide can be pushed back enough now that we can buy time for the Grove.” He turns to Anaxagoras. “In that time, you and the other Sages will organize your people to evacuate.”

“But—”

“Do you gainsay your prince?” Mydei asks, crossing his arms and dropping his voice. He doubts the threatening tone will have all that much impact on Anaxagoras, but it does shut him up for a moment. “The knowledge of the Grove will survive. The black tide corrupts people, not codices and scrolls, but without your people to interpret that information, it’s as good as useless. You will leave, you will flee to Castrum Kremnos, and I will make my father see reason and address the black tide here. For now, I can buy you time.”

All three of his somatophylakes speak at once, voices tumbling over each other in a harmony of protests. Phainon remains too quiet behind them all, his eyes focused with surprising intensity on Mydei.

Mydei holds up a gauntleted hand. “I am the only Chrysos Heir among us. My blood is enough to push the tide back, to buy you extra time.” He turns his attention back to Anaxagoras. “You will use it.”

Anaxagoras returns his gaze, his own thoughtful. He is, blissfully, silent, but his expression is otherwise inscrutable.

“Leonnius.”

Leonnius snaps a brisk salute. “My prince.”

“Left flank. Hephaestion, right. Perdikkas, return to the Grove and bring Peucesta and Ptolemy in case any of us are injured.” Neither are known for their battlefield prowess but underestimating them for their ancillary skills would be a mistake.

Perdikkas gives a quick salute before turning and racing away, his speed a truly remarkable thing.

“And me?” Anaxagoras asks.

“Stay out of the way,” Mydei replies, quite seriously, very certain that the so-called feeble scholar will almost certainly find a way to get himself involved in the fight. Only a fool wouldn’t have noticed the weapons concealed beneath his chiton, and Mydei isn’t a fool. “Keep an eye on my slave and ensure he comes to no harm.”

Phainon chokes, and it’s the most noise he’s made since they’ve exited the Grove.

Anaxagoras reels back. “Am I his master? Am I—”

“His keeper,” Mydei says. “Because I decree it, yes. You are.”

Anaxagoras looks furious. Phainon remains quiet, his expression still thoughtful, which disturbs Mydei on some fundamental level. Phainon has been too docile lately, too reserved. For now, though, that’s a boon.

“Stay here,” he tells them both, and he turns away.

The monsters have come closer, drawn by their conversation. Though not particularly quick, they are relentless things, driven by some strange urge to infect others as they have been infected. Already, Hephaestion and Leonnius have engaged the creatures on either flank, pushing them back with brutal cuts of their blades.

There is no glory in this. There is no honor. Mydei could twist the story and make it about protecting the people of the Grove, but that only puts in sharper relief the terrible truth: Castrum Kremnos failed the outlying

villages. Since the black tide's first appearance, it has been Strife's holy duty and most noble calling to beat it back, often aided by Chrysos Heirs vying to be Strife's successor. Eurypon's ascension changed all that.

Now, the black tide erodes everything that Eurypon gains, eating away at the back of their empire as he expands it at the front lines. Now, the black tide consumes their people, their farmlands. Mydei clenches his jaw. They can't afford to lose more of their farmlands.

If there was a way to purify the people, perhaps this wouldn't be so terrible. Oh, there would surely be a moral and ethical critique to be had, letting the citizens of the empire fall beneath the tide, but if they could be saved at a later date, maybe immediate sacrifices could be allowed. But they can't. Once taken by the tide, a human is forever consumed, freed only, one hopes, in death. Thanatos has been silent on the subject.

Mydei draws his sword and steps forward, onto the surface of the black tide.

While his friends must fight at the borders of it, minding their feet so they don't make contact with the reddish black substance, Mydei—and all the Chrysos Heirs—has no such concern. Whatever the black tide is, it can't corrupt them the way it can the common man.

Turning his hand palm up, he draws his blade across his forearm just beneath the bend of his elbow and above the line of his gauntlet. Immortality hasn't dulled pain for him. He hasn't grown used to it. But he is better at hiding his discomfort than most men. Years of practice hiding his disdain for his father has, perhaps, sharpened the talent.

His blood drips from his arm and onto the surface of the black tide. Immediately, the monsters engaging his friends surge toward him.

Hephaestion and Leonnius are too good at what they do to let all the monsters escape them, but some do, and Mydei steps deeper onto the black tide to engage these strays. In the distance, other monsters howl with rage, and they begin racing toward Mydei as well, as though he is a disease that must be eradicated. Perhaps, to them, he is. Perhaps all Chrysos Heirs are.

The first creature to engage him loses its head. The second creature is gutted—or it would have been, had it had anything left in it resembling guts. It disintegrates despite the lack, dissolving into red and black nothingness.

As is always the case with the black tide's monsters, the more he cuts down, the more appear before him. The death of their kin summons them, the destruction calling them from vast distances. Soon, he is surrounded on all sides, the monsters ignoring his friends to come for him. His blood is as much a lure as the death he deals out.

They reach for him without coordination, jamming their hands together as they grab at his wrists. He cuts through their limbs and then removes their heads, but he's losing his maneuverability. More and more cluster around him, pressing in, pressing close, and though they don't wield blades and can't corrupt him, they have their own dangers. One gets its hand on his shoulder, and a strange buzzing vibrates through his brain. Another gouges its nails down his back. The first is trouble, the second a mere nuisance. His blood splatters on the ground, the black tide receding even more, and the creatures hiss and wail, dancing back with it.

Driving his elbow backwards, he dislodges the creature clinging to him. He whips around, slicing through the monster's neck, and barely has the time to duck away from another that leaps for him.

Hephaestion and Leonnius call out code words that tell him they're advancing in his direction. Good. He needs the support.

He grabs another creature by the face and throws it backwards into another large pack, causing them to stumble and buying himself some time.

Beneath his feet, the black tide retreats faster, as if desperate to escape his blood. And then the ground begins to shake.

Shit.

"Clear the rabble," he shouts to his friends, and they do what they can on the border of the black tide, but the trouble is that Mydei has the attention

of every monster within half a mile. They converge on him as a hulking behemoth appears on the horizon, barreling toward him at an alarming speed.

Mydei cuts a path through the monsters even though that means putting them at his back. He trusts Hephaestion and Leonnius to defend him—though not even they know how dangerous a maneuver this is.

Racing ahead of the black tide's retreat, Mydei readies his sword.

The behemoth roars, its form massive even at a distance. As it closes on him, it grows only larger, but he's not particularly worried. Its legs carry it quickly, but it lacks agility. He drops, sliding across the slick, red surface of the tide as it brings down a meaty hand, pummeling the ground where he just stood.

Twisting to his feet, he launches himself forward, cutting his blade across the behemoth's side. At the same time, he hazards a glance over its shoulder. A line of monsters has followed him, stranding Hephaestion and Leonnius at the edge of the tide. They've switched from swords to bows, and they're picking off the stragglers with arrows through throats, but they're not fast enough to make much of a difference.

Muttering an oath, Mydei swings around the behemoth as it twists, flailing to strike him. This has to be quick. Too long, and the other monsters will be on him, and then he'll have too many battles to fight. With a twist of his blade, he ducks under a fist the size of a wine barrel. His sword meets the behemoth's wrist, cutting deep—but not deep enough. While it roars with pain, its hand remains attached to its arm. Enraged, the behemoth sweeps both arms toward Mydei, stomping after him as he dances backwards, trying to lead it further away from his friends.

"Mydei!" Hephaestion shouts, frustration coloring his cry.

He hasn't led the monsters out of bow range, so he ignores his friend. Hephaestion and Leonnius continue to pick off the more humanoid creatures, taking potshots where they can, as he weaves around the behemoth. It crashes after him, rushing toward him with a speed that

catches him by surprise. It’s all he can do to lift his sword as a makeshift shield. The behemoth crashes into it, driving Mydei backwards, toward the edge of the tide.

Better to be closer to the boundary, where his friends can use their swords if necessary.

Planting his left heel, Mydei swings around. The behemoth stumbles forward, losing its balance, and Mydei drives his blade into its side. Using his sword as a fulcrum, he launches himself up and onto its back, drawing a dagger from the sheath on his thigh. He drives the dagger into the behemoth’s back, anchoring himself, and yanks at his sword.

It sticks in the creature’s side.

Mydei clings to the dagger as the behemoth flails, reaching up to pound at its back, forcing Mydei to roll across it and dodge its gargantuan fists. One crashes down directly next to his head, and his heart hammers, chest hollowing. For a brief moment, he can’t breathe. But he doesn’t have time to panic or even feel relief that he’s not inconveniently dead. He throws himself across the creature’s back, grabs the hilt of his sword, and yanks.

The blade comes free with a shrill scream. Mydei hauls himself up, bracing one foot on his dagger. His balance is precarious, but he only needs one good hit—and he finds it, swinging his sword across the behemoth’s neck.

Its head tumbles from its shoulders, and then he’s falling the six feet to the ground to land awkwardly on his ankle. Pain reverberates through him, but not enough to suggest he’s broken anything. It’ll heal, anyway.

With the behemoth gone, the monsters break. They flee in every direction but toward the Grove, and Mydei turns his back to them once more, approaching his friends with an irritating limp but a smile on his face.

“And so we meet with success,” he says, sheathing his blade and spreading his arms wide.

Anaxagoras studies him, but Hephaestion has one hand over his face and Leonnius has dropped to lay on the ground, staring upward.

“Next time,” Hephaestion says, “don’t run where we can’t—”

There’s a hideous screech from behind him.

Mydei goes for his sword. Hephaestion slings his bow back around, Leonnius rocks to his feet, but it’s Phainon who moves fastest. He has one of Anaxagoras’s knives in his hand, is yanking Mydei forward, is driving the dagger’s blade into the monster’s chest, right where its heart should be.

Everything hangs, suspended in a strange, liminal moment.

And then Mydei’s sword finishes the job Phainon began, cutting across the monster’s neck to sever its head. The creature pulses with red light as it crumbles in blackish cubes, disappearing into so much aether.

Phainon drops the knife and all but leaps back from it, his hands raised. Leonnius is already on him, grabbing his wrists, yanking them back. “I just reacted,” Phainon says, a wild look on his face.

Mydei lowers his sword, sheathing it as he and Hephaestion trade a knowing look. That was a swordsman’s speed and instinct.

“He saved my life,” Mydei says to Leonnius.

Hephaestion retrieves Anaxagoras’s knife, handing it back to the scholar, who takes it with a strange expression on his face, as though he can’t quite believe any of what he just saw.

There’s no resistance in Phainon as Leonnius pulls his arms behind his back. “A slave who wields a blade should be put to death,” Leonnius says.

Phainon’s wild look grows wilder, almost terrified. “I didn’t know,” he rasps.

“Did he wield a blade?” Mydei asks Leonnius. “I saw only my sword in the monster’s neck.” He is asking Leonnius to lie for him—asking every man

present to agree to his lie—but he is the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos.

Hephaestion doesn't hesitate. He bows his head. "I saw only our prince's strike," he says, though his tone is tight, begrudging.

Leonnius looks from Mydei to Hephaestion and back again, bewildered for only a moment before understanding what Mydei is intimating. He presses his lips together in a thin line. Of all Mydei's somatophylakes, he is most likely to refuse to accept the lie. But he, too, inclines his head. "It is as my prince says." He releases Phainon and steps back. "No slave could move so quickly or strike so true."

That's a warning, and Mydei would be a fool not to hear it. He gives Leonnius a nod of acknowledgement before turning to Anaxagoras.

Anaxagoras sweeps his eyes over all of them. "Interesting." He tucks his blade back into his chiton. "You are an interesting man, Your Highness."

That's a warning, too, though Mydei doesn't understand it quite as well. "Am I?"

"A prince of Castrum Kremnos who defends a slave, who fights back the black tide with his own blood." Anaxagoras makes a thoughtful sound. "How uncommon."

Mydei's lips twitch. "Anyone would have done the same."

"No," Anaxagoras drawls. "No, anyone would not have, as we discussed earlier." Mydei stiffens. "And if Chrysos Heirs alone could push back the black tide, perhaps we would not be in so much danger."

"Are you suggesting there are Chrysos Heirs secreted away in the Grove?" Mydei asks sharply, eager to change the course of the conversation.

Anaxagoras's smile is almost feral. "Of course not, Your Highness. Harboring Chrysos Heirs would be treasonous, and we are, all of us, loyal citizens."

Anxiety claws through Phainon as he and Mydeimos make their way back to the prince's apartment in the Grove, flanked by a pair of legionnaires and those two somatophylakes, Hephaestion and Leonnius. Both regard him with outright suspicion.

He really did fuck up earlier, and he can't figure out why Mydeimos didn't kill him on the spot. Leonnius's words—*a slave who wields a blade should be put to death*—circle in Phainon's mind, a song trapped in the cage of his skull, relentlessly badgering him with the stark truth. He's going to die. Mydeimos has to kill him. There's no way Leonnius and Hephaestion will stay silent. Rumors will circulate, and they'll force Mydeimos's hand, and then Phainon will have failed.

But when Mydeimos reaches the door to his apartment, neither somatophylax says anything about Mydeimos keeping a dangerous slave with him when he's alone. They salute him alongside the legionnaires and depart, leaving Phainon and Mydeimos alone.

Mydeimos shuts the apartment's door behind them both.

Expectation weighs heavily on Phainon's shoulders. He should speak. Should defend himself. But what is there to say? He betrayed his skill to save Mydeimos's life, and he still doesn't know why he did it. Ultimately, Mydeimos wouldn't have stayed dead. But he saw a man in peril, and he simply reacted. He followed his instinct to protect. And that instinct will surely see him dead.

"I…" He turns to Mydeimos.

"Death is unpleasant to recover from," Mydeimos says, stepping away from the door and into the apartment. It's warm and cozy, much smaller than his suite in Castrum Kremnos, with walls made of wood. So late after the feast the Sages prepared for them, darkness blots out the details of Mydeimos's face and blurs the edges of the room.

Candles aren't permitted in the Grove.

“So, in that way, I owe you my life,” Mydeimos continues. “Which makes you profoundly lucky.” Phainon pulls a hand over his face, still certain that Mydeimos is about to name him a dead man. “A life for a life, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

His legs feel like water. Feeling blindly behind him, he finds a kline, and he sinks onto it. He’s shaking and lightheaded, his vision, what little he has, tunneling in the darkness of the room. “You’re not going to kill me?”

“No.”

“Because I saved… Because I prevented you from having to come back from death.” This feels surreal.

“Because I saw your feet, Phainon,” Mydeimos says.

Oh. Oh, fuck, that’s even worse. He hasn’t betrayed his skill with a sword and marked himself a dangerous man, he’s betrayed his identity.

“I saw where you stood.”

He remembers his stance with frightening clarity, one sandaled foot on soft grass, one on the slick, red-black substance of the black tide.

Phainon has been through hell. He watched his friends and family cut down and slaughtered by Eurypon’s army, heard the screams of the dying left in the streets, saw heads trampled beneath horse’s hooves. And yet the terror of that day has faded so much that it cannot compare to his fear in this moment.

“Killing you would be a tremendous inconvenience,” Mydeimos says.

“Your father.” Phainon clasps his trembling hands. “He’ll kill you if you kill me.” Phainon’s blood will mark Mydeimos a traitor.

“Yes.”

“You’d come back.”

Mydeimos tips his head to the side. “Have you ever drowned, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae?” he asks softly. Phainon’s eyes widen. “I have. Ten times, chained to a boulder beneath the water of a palace pond. I was five.”

Phainon shudders, unable to imagine it. The horror of his life leaving him. The terrifying knowledge he’d come back to same, miserable extinction. “Then this is self-serving.” He’s never been so grateful for someone else’s sense of self-preservation.

Mydeimos exhales. “Not entirely.” He stands in front of Phainon, close enough that Phainon can make out his features but not his expression. “I am tired of death.”

How telling. Mydeimos isn’t tired of dying. He’s tired of death.

“Two counts of treason,” Phainon says quietly.

“It could just be one. The forests to the south are dense and dangerous, but someone like you…” Mydeimos trails off.

Someone like Phainon, a trained fighter and a Chrysos Heir, wouldn’t struggle to survive. He could slink off in the night, find a way to remove the torc from his throat, or even make his way back to Okhema. But to leave would be to betray his people and the memory of Aedes Elysiae. “The black tide,” Phainon offers in meager protest. “It’s in the forest, too.”

“By virtue of your blood, you will be fine.”

Phainon isn’t so sure of that. He’s bled all over the black tide before, and it’s never retreated for him the way it did for Mydeimos. “Do you really believe that, son of Strife?”

Even in the darkness, Phainon sees the grimace twist Mydeimos’s lips. “Strife’s meager protection isn’t all that holds back the black tide.”

Another thing Phainon isn’t sure of. From all the stories he’s heard, of all the Titans, only Strife is strong enough to stand against the tide. “Leaving would condemn me,” Phainon says, almost reluctantly. “I can’t go.”

Mydeimos's lips twist even more, sardonic but not cruel. "Because of what my mother has you up to."

Shaking his head, Phainon looks away. "It's not that." And then he huffs out a dry sort of laugh. "I'd like to see the world one day, you know. Explore what's beyond the city states of Amphoreus. Supposedly, there are other continents. It'd be nice to see them. But…" He looks at his hands. "I can't."

"You're not alone in that," Mydeimos says softly, like he's giving up a secret. "There is a whole world beyond us, and what we see, what we live in, is only a small part of it." What an unexpected sentiment from the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos. "Watching the whole of our world crumble into Castrum Kremnos's shadow…" Regret tinges his voice.

They've come close to treason several times already, but this is the closest brush, and it catches Phainon by surprise. "You," he says, lifting his face to regard Mydeimos in the darkness, "aren't what I expected."

Mydeimos snorts. "A brute?"

"Something like that." Telling Mydeimos what he really expected probably won't get him killed, especially based on the conversation they just had, but Phainon doesn't want to risk his current good favor. A brute, a tyrant like his father, a bloodthirsty madman. Okhema has many rumors about Mydeimos, and all of them are wildly misinformed.

"Not everyone agrees with what Castrum Kremnos has become," Mydeimos says. "But to discuss such things outright would be to court treason."

Phainon swallows. Eurypon's message to his son was couched in theatrics, but Phainon understands it now. Understands Mydeimos better now. "You're a better person when you do," Phainon says carefully.

Mydeimos inhales sharply. He's so close, having drifted into Phainon's space as they've talked, that Phainon can feel the warmth of him. "A strange sentiment from you," Mydeimos says, lifting his hand. His fingers ghost along Phainon's jaw, and Phainon shivers with heat.

“An honest one.” He forces himself to stay relaxed, fighting not to turn his head into Mydeimos’s touch.

“Have you been dishonest with me?” Mydeimos asks.

Yes. Titans, yes, he’s been so dishonest. But there’s only one safe answer to that question. “I’ve never lied to you,” Phainon replies, and he hasn’t. He just hasn’t always told the truth, either.

Mydeimos’s hand smooths over Phainon’s jaw, and Phainon doesn’t pull away. Mydeimos is trapped, playing a political game with his father that runs counter to his nature just to survive. “You truly are my mother’s creature,” Mydeimos says with a quiet laugh, but he doesn’t sound angry or upset.

Slowly, Mydeimos leans toward Phainon, and Phainon, despite himself, doesn’t pull away. He tips his head up, anticipation a sweet drug curling through his veins.

Mydeimos kisses him, a barely there touching of their lips, their eyes open and fixed on each other. Staring someone down like this should be strange and awkward, but it’s not. Phainon shifts forward, pressing his mouth firmly against Mydeimos’s own.

The Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos isn’t a brute, isn’t a mindless soldier, isn’t his father’s loyal lackey. He is trapped, as Phainon is trapped.

Mydeimos’s fingers slide deeper into Phainon’s hair. His eyes drift shut, and his mouth moves against Phainon’s own, a lingering but hesitant caress. And then he’s drawing back, dropping his hand and stepping away, his face turned to the side.

“Forgive me,” Mydeimos says. “I should not have forced myself on you.”

Dazed, confused, Phainon stares up at him. “You—”

“Good night, Phainon,” Mydeimos says, and he hurries away, deeper into the apartment, leaving Phainon sitting on the kline, shaken.

He didn’t dislike that kiss. He doesn’t dislike Mydeimos. He—he drags a hand down his face. He can’t let Mydeimos be too human, too real, too relatable. Phainon has a purpose here, and it isn’t to lust after his captor.

Chapter End Notes

and now that cat is somewhat out of the bag :3

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“No Chrysos Heirs?”

There’s nothing good about that question, nothing good about the disbelief in Eurypon’s tone.

Mydei remains expressionless, a soldier reporting to his commanding officer, not a son speaking to his father. “Not a single one, Your Majesty.” He stands at the far end of a long table in Eurypon’s council room, meeting his father’s gaze and ignoring those of his father’s generals. The generals share glances between them, most echoing Eurypon’s disbelief, not a single original thought among them. But it’s better to fall in line with the king.

“I find that hard to believe,” Eurypon says, folding his hands together. He leans forward. “Did you check *every* home?”

Mydei knows better than to vociferously defend his men against the implied slight. “We did.” He extends one hand, and Hephaestion steps forward, laying a scroll across his palm. “The details are here, should Your Majesty wish to review them.” Eurypon will. He’ll pour over the scroll for hours, will probably summon Mydei back to him in private and berate him for not finding what Eurypon expected him to find.

“Themistocles,” Eurypon says, and Mydei passes the scroll to the nearest general, who in turn passes it up the table to Themistocles.

Sober, the man is canny and terrifying, crafting the strategies that have seen Castrum Kremnos crush Amphoreus beneath the gears of its war machine. Themistocles opens the scroll, eyes scanning back and forth across it.

“Rats,” Eurypon says, his gaze fixed on Mydei, “are insidious. They breed ceaselessly and infect every home with their presence. How did you find

nothing, boy?”

Mydei keeps his expression as neutral as he can. “The people of the Grove are far more concerned with the approach of the black tide.”

A groan goes up from the table, the generals rolling their eyes and scoffing —and throwing quick glances at the king to ensure their reaction is the correct one. Eurypon snorts, chuckles, and then outright laughs, leaning back in his kline.

“The black tide? A passing distraction,” Eurypon declares. His generals agree with him.

Mydei remains where he is, still and disaffected by their laughter, sorting through the various arguments he can present to his father. None of them are particularly promising, but he gave Anaxagoras and the other Sages his word. He will try to sway his father’s opinion.

“When we arrived, it was licking at the Grove’s walls,” Mydei says. Facts won’t matter. He needs to appeal to Eurypon’s paranoia without suggesting the Grove may be hiding Chrysos Heirs capable of pushing back the black tide.

Strange, though, that Phainon behaved as if such a thing isn’t possible.

“Monsters prowled the fields beyond the Grove,” Mydei continues. “According to the Sages, they make regular incursions against the city state.”

Eurypon waves a dismissive hand before reaching for his wine. “This is a problem for the Grove to solve,” he says.

Until Eurypon ascended to Titanhood and took up Strife’s coreflame, the histories are quite clear: Nikador regularly battered the black tide back from civilization.

“If the Grove falls to the black tide, we will lose our most brilliant minds,” Mydei says, testing one of his arguments.

“As if we need an educated citizenry,” Themistocles says, and the generals rumble their agreement.

Eurypon pushes himself upright and leans to the side, slapping Themistocles on the shoulder.

That had always been a losing argument, but Mydei had wanted to start with it in some vain hope that, perhaps, his father would understand the dangers of an ignorant citizenry. But for a country at war, smart men are an inconvenience. Smart men question their leaders while fools fall in line.

He tries again. “With the fields subsumed by the tide, our food stores are decreasing. If we wish to keep our troops fed, we should not overlook the damage the tide is doing.”

Again, Eurypon waves him off. “The black tide is nothing more than Okheman trickery,” he says.

Mydei takes a deep, calming breath and says nothing.

“They have used it—Kephale has used it—throughout time to occupy the kings and Titans of Castrum Kremnos, forcing us to play defense on their behalf. When they are gone,” Eurypon says, “the black tide will go with them.”

It is an alarming thing when the king of an empire believes his own propaganda so thoroughly. Perhaps if his generals weren’t seated with him, Eurypon would be more honest, but Mydei doubts that. Eurypon has always sought refuge in his own lies. This lie, however, will lead to too many deaths, will see not just the farmlands destroyed and the farmers transformed into monsters, but Castrum Kremnos’s army starved.

“The writings of Herodotus tell us the tide existed before Okhema was founded,” Mydei says, keeping his tone neutral.

Eurypon slams his goblet on the table, spilling wine over his scrolls and his maps. The generals all fall silent, recoiling. Mydei has pushed his father too far, even though he has barely pushed at all.

He bows his head. “Forgive me, Father, I—”

“Do you think me an ignorant fool?” Eurypon demands. “Do you think I don’t see what you’re trying to do, boy?”

Dread curls down Mydei’s spine, puncturing him with icy fingers. Eurypon’s temper is always mercurial. He should have kept silent.

“You are no better than the Okhemans, are you?” Eurypon rises to his feet, bracing his hands against the table and leaning over it. His blood-red wine pools at his fingertips, staining them. “I will not have my attentions split between the front lines and an old wives’ tale used to scare children into behaving.” Eurypon laughs, cruelly.

A few of the generals laugh, too.

“The black tide’s monsters will steal you away if you don’t behave.” Eurypon’s voice drips with mocking derision. “Are you so terrified of legends?”

Mydei says nothing. Feels nothing. Not even the earlier dread remains. He is empty, a void, and his father’s mockery washes over him without affecting him. But Eurypon demands a reaction.

“Did I raise a coward?” the king demands. “Did I raise a son who is afraid of his own shadow? Did I allow you to be coddled by that insubordinate creature the lot of you dare to call my queen?” The room is completely silent as Eurypon leans over the table, snarling at Mydei.

Though Mydei’s heart hammers, he remains outwardly calm and keeps himself that empty void. He allows himself no rage, no fury on his mother’s behalf. “No, Your Majesty,” he says, keenly aware that failure to manage his father here will see him tied to a stake in the great hall. Some would think Eurypon’s threats empty, but Mydei isn’t a fool. Eurypon will wring every drop of use out of Mydei and then, when Mydei is more a danger than useful boon, Eurypon *will* find a way to kill him, immortality be damned. He prefers not to hasten his own end—or to experience it over and over as Eurypon tries and fails.

“Then why do you waste my time with legends?” Eurypon demands. “Why do you bother my generals with such preposterous drivel when we are at war? Do you mean to undermine us, to split our forces?” Eurypon points at him, finger shaking. “Is my own son a traitor in my home?”

A cold sweat gathers on Mydei’s skin. “I am loyal to the crown and Castrum Kremnos,” Mydei says. “And I obey my king in all things.”

“And yet you fail to bring me the Chrysos Heirs hidden in the Grove!” Spittle flies from Eurypon’s mouth. “A disgrace! My own son is a disgrace!” Those words no longer hurt him. Mydei bows his head lower and says nothing. “A failure.” Eurypon sucks his teeth, derisive. “Get out.”

Mydei does not hesitate. He bows, deeply respectful, and flees the room, Hephaestion wisely close behind.

As soon as the door to the war council closes, Hephaestion reaches for him. “Your Highness—”

But there are guards outside the doors, and Mydei will show the court nothing of weakness or affection, whatever lingers between him and Hephaestion still. “No,” he says, cutting Hephaestion a warning look. Hephaestion should know better.

Chastened, Hephaestion drops his hands.

They begin down the hall, side by side, and Hephaestion drops his voice. “That could have gone much better.”

“We could be dead,” Mydei says. “But, yes, it could have.” Eurypon rarely descends into a rage so terrible he blackens Gorgo’s name. When he does, the situation is dire. Mydei rubs a hand over his chest.

“Even Ptolemy has said it,” Hephaestion murmurs. “Statistically, there should have been several Chrysos Heirs. That there wasn’t even one…”

Mydei grimaces. He isn’t a fool, he understands Ptolemy’s numbers well enough, but what frightens him most is that there was a Chrysos Heir. They

are, all of them, lucky that no one else noticed Phainon's status as one. "And are we to condemn men for the status of their birth?" Mydei asks.

Hephaestion grimaces. "I understand this is a sensitive thing for you."

"Sensitive. Yes. You might say that."

"You are different," Hephaestion says.

Revulsion heaves in Mydei's belly. "Enough, Hephaestion. We survived my father, and I upheld my oath to Anaxagoras." He sighs, weary. "I would like to rest." He is drained and exhausted.

Hephaestion smiles broadly. "Come rest with me." Mydei's expression must slip, because he adds, quickly, "And the others. Peucesta can play something to calm your nerves. We can enjoy wine, and—"

"I would like to be alone," Mydei says, turning away from Hephaestion at the intersection that will bring Mydei to his rooms. "Understand this." He draws away from Hephaestion, and Hephaestion, thank the Titans, does not follow. Mydei doesn't look back, doesn't want to see the grief on Hephaestion's face. Doesn't want to be the reason for it yet again.

Something on his face must turn away his own servants. They don't approach him when he enters his suite. He spares a glance for Phainon and eventually spies him beyond a window, in the shade of the courtyard's strawberry trees. If Phainon were truly his bed slave, Mydei might call him in. Might lose himself in the pleasure of someone else's body. But Mydei wasn't lying to Hephaestion. He doesn't want to trouble himself with complicated company.

He sinks onto his bed, bundling a pillow in his arms and pressing his face into it.

There's only so long Phainon can avoid Mydeimos's bedroom. He's done his best to occupy himself in the courtyard, but now the sun is low on the horizon, and he's not just tired, he's hungry. The servants in Mydeimos's

household can eat whenever they want, but he's only afforded the scraps from Mydeimos's plate. Whatever supposed benefits come with being a bed slave are surely offset by all these terrible, humiliating rules.

At last, with a gnawing pain in his stomach, Phainon climbs the three steps into Mydeimos's bedroom.

A low groan issues from Mydeimos's bed. Phainon stills, peering through the growing darkness, wondering if Mydeimos is, perhaps, not alone. But no, there's only one Mydeimos-shaped lump on the bed, and that groan isn't a pleasurable one. It's distress.

Phainon crosses the room without any attempt at stealth. His sandaled feet slap against the marbled floor, but Mydeimos doesn't stir, not even when Phainon sits on the edge of the bed. He hesitates and then touches Mydeimos's shoulder.

Mydeimos surges upward, one hand wrapped around Phainon's throat. Phainon gasps, grabbing at Mydeimos's wrist, and finds himself on his back before he can react any further.

"Phainon?"

"Yes," he gasps out, squeezing Mydeimos's wrist.

Mydeimos releases him and pulls away, pressing his face into his hand. "I don't do well when startled awake," he says.

"Obviously." Phainon pushes himself up, folding his legs to sit across from Mydeimos on the bed, and he wonders at how Mydeimos has lived to react so violently to someone waking him. An immortal man need fear no assassin, but Phainon supposes pain is still unpleasant and assassins remain an inconvenience. "You were having a nightmare."

"Yes." Mydeimos lowers his hand. In the darkness, his expression is impossible to discern. "I…" He shudders.

Phainon leans toward him. "I've always found talking about it helps."

“I am not a child in need of comfort.”

And Phainon leans back. “Never said you were,” he says, rebuffed.

Exhaling heavily, Mydeimos tips his head to the side, regarding Phainon. “It was the black tide.” He falls silent, and Phainon realizes he’s expecting mockery, derision, contempt. This is a man who has learned that any vulnerability is met with cruelty.

Phainon stays quiet, expecting that any comforting gesture will shut Mydeimos down.

Abruptly, Mydeimos continues. “I was drowning in it.” He turns his face to the bed, staring at the sheets. “It was all around me, a living thing, consuming me. A lake of it, an ocean of it.” He shudders. “When I kicked toward the surface, the monsters pulled me back down. I couldn’t breathe.” Absently, he rubs his chest. “It was just like…” His voice trembles. “It was so real.” He sags. “Even now, my chest burns.”

They’re not close enough for this. Mydeimos knows one of Phainon’s secrets, but they’re not intimate. They’re not even friends. “Your somatophylakes,” he begins.

“No,” Mydeimos says, and then he laughs bitterly. “Such friends as those will only poke fun at my weakness. The mighty crown prince of Castrum Kremnos, disturbed by a mere dream of drowning?” He shakes his head.

Phainon keeps his face expressionless, wondering how many of Mydeimos’s friends know how Eurypon once drowned him. Surely, they wouldn’t mock him then. But that is largely immaterial. He leans forward. “Not just a dream of drowning,” Phainon says, feeling out his words with great care. “The king… he ignored your warning?”

A snort from Mydeimos. “You are too clever.”

“And here I believed you thought me a fool.” Phainon’s lips quirk, and he shifts into a faint patch of light so that Mydeimos might see his expression more clearly. When Mydeimos offers no response, Phainon continues. “The

king ignored your warning, and you… you aren't an unkind man. In the Grove, your concern was for the people. You ordered your men to be as reserved as possible, and you didn't tolerate when they went too far in searching homes. Didn't tolerate them harassing the people. And when Anaxagoras confronted you about the tide, you listened. You defended the city state, even though you didn't have to." He hesitates and then makes an assumption. "Even though it would vex your father."

Mydeimos makes a quiet sound of affirmation.

"It takes a brave man, a good man, to risk the king's wrath," Phainon says, thinking about the Chrysos Heir burned in the banquet hall, the slaughtered family, Mydeimos's drownings.

"Some would say I don't risk enough."

"A man whose father tortures him repeatedly can't help anyone." Phainon reaches out and tentatively lays his hand on Mydeimos's knee.

Mydeimos jumps beneath his touch but doesn't shake it off. "You owe me nothing for my silence, Phainon of Nowhere," Mydeimos says, weary.

"I'm not buying your silence," Phainon replies. "When I was young, my mother used to take me to the baths after a bad dream. She said the only way to wash away the work of such evil spirits was to cleanse myself with water."

"Are you offering to bathe me?" Mydeimos asks.

Phainon licks his lips. He hadn't meant to imply he would, but now? Now he can't get the idea out of his head: Mydeimos, naked in the water, lit by moon- and starlight, with rivulets running down the sculpted musculature of his torso. "Isn't that my duty?"

Mydeimos makes a soft noise, incomprehensible.

Sliding off the bed, Phainon extends a hand. "Come on, Your Highness. Wash away your nightmares."

Finally, Mydeimos places his hand in Phainon’s.

The water is warm as Phainon wades into it, urging Mydeimos to enter after him. They’re both naked, and the late hour wraps them in sultry shadows, disguising the handsome form Phainon has seen on numerous occasions. In the darkness, Mydeimos is more alluring than he should be.

Mydeimos isn’t the man Phainon thought he was. He isn’t a cruel tyrant. He isn’t a monster. He is trapped in almost as many ways as Phainon is, but Phainon knows there is sweet relief at the end of this. For Phainon, this isn’t forever. For Mydeimos, it is. Forever trapped in a palace with a father who fears and despises him, who wants him dead, who doesn’t listen to him, who’s willing to torture him.

There is still much to hate about him: Mydeimos still takes to the battlefield to kill Okhemans, still supports a man who would destroy and subjugate all of Amphoreus. But he does so without any other choice. When your options are obedience or endless death, you have no options at all. Phainon understands. Phainon made a similar choice. Has made that choice many times.

The idea that he and Mydeimos have anything in common isn’t as upsetting as it should be.

Phainon slides onto an underwater shelf, spreading his legs wide. “Sit,” he says, entreating, and he draws Mydeimos onto the shelf between his legs.

Mydeimos is tense, rigid, so Phainon just sits with him. He releases Mydeimos’s hand to settle both of his own on Mydeimos’s hips. Water licks at their waists and the edge of the tiled bath, a quiet burbling as they settle.

“Let me wash your hair?”

“Do as you will,” Mydeimos replies, still tense.

Phainon hums his assent but doesn’t move his hands from Mydeimos’s hips. He rubs his thumbs into the divot of Mydeimos’s back instead, just

sitting. Waiting. Time crawls by slowly, but Phainon doesn't mind. His attention stays on Mydeimos as the prince begins to relax over the span of achingly long minutes. Only when his shoulders relax and roll forward does Phainon lift one hand and draw the nearby basket of soaps and perfumes closer.

From the basket, he fishes out a vial. "Duck under the water?" He makes it a question not out of deference to his position and Mydeimos's but out of politeness and care for Mydeimos's current disposition.

Mydeimos exhales heavily, leaning forward. Phainon almost expects him to decline, but after a fragile moment, Mydeimos slides off the shelf and dips beneath the water. He comes up with a head of soaked hair, and he slicks it back from his face without looking at Phainon once. Resuming his position between Phainon's legs, he tips his head back, a silent offering.

Phainon pours oil from the vial into his palm, rubs it into his skin, and runs his fingers through Mydeimos's hair slowly, parting the longer ends of it. He combs his fingers closer and closer to Mydeimos's scalp, giving him plenty of time to pull away. He doesn't.

In silence, Phainon works the oil into Mydeimos's hair. It smells faintly of olives. Only a prince could be so rich. Beneath his fingers, Mydeimos's hair is soft. It slides like silk from his hold, well cared for and nothing like Phainon's coarser locks. How nice it would be to live in such luxury. And he could have that, he realizes. He could take this over everything else, all his hardships—at the small cost of all his principles. Strange how tempting it is.

Phainon's life has never been easy. "My father was a farmer," he says, because he has to speak, he has to break this silence, he has to justify aloud why he can't whore himself out to Mydeimos. "We had little, and no one expected much from me." His fingers find Mydeimos's temples, and he massages gently, rubbing away the tension he finds there. "Others in Aedes Elysiae mocked me for wanting to learn to read and write. For wanting to learn… to learn how to fight." There's no point in hiding that; he and Mydeimos both know what he did at the Grove was the result of long practice. "I suppose I have your father to thank for that."

“Because he razed Aedes Elysiae to the ground.” Mydeimos makes a thoughtful sound. “That was years ago.”

“It was. And I was… I was so full of rage.” Phainon works his fingers through Mydeimos’s hair, massaging his scalp, breathing in the warm scent of the olives. “When I made it to Okhema, I dedicated myself to learning swordsmanship. Combat. I wanted to be on the frontline. To make a difference. To defend other villages against what mine had suffered.” He still does; he can’t forget the screaming, the death, the piled-high bodies.

“How were you not taken as a slave then?” Mydeimos asks.

“My mother hid me,” Phainon replies. “She put me in the small cellar beneath the house and led Castrum Kremnos’s soldiers away.” His jaw flexes. He has wondered, many times, what his mother endured before her death. “I watched your father’s men butcher people through the small gap in the door. When I emerged from the cellar, after the fires died and everything was quiet, I saw what was left, and I hated you. I hated every last one of you.”

Mydeimos doesn’t shake off Phainon’s hands. “How did you come to be here?”

Phainon trails his fingers down Mydeimos’s neck and across his shoulders. “Rinse.”

Strangely obedient, Mydeimos does. He slips under the water and rakes his hands through his hair once, twice, before he resurfaces and settles once more between Phainon’s legs.

“There are groups of us that go to villages on the front,” Phainon says, running his fingers once more through Mydeimos’s hair. “We help the villagers evacuate before your armies arrive, and we bring the refugees to Okhema.”

Mydeimos groans. “Of course you are one of those. How my father hates you.”

“One more secret to keep from him.”

“What’s one more?” He pinches the bridge of his nose. “My mother surely knows.”

Phainon nods. “She may. I don’t think the soldiers who caught us realized who we were. They didn’t put us to death. They bound us and brought us to Castrum Kremnos to be sold.” He swallows. “Your palace slave master… Periander?”

“Yes.”

“He bought me along with some others, and then your mother chose me from that group once we were brought to the palace itself.” Phainon lowers his hands to Mydeimos’s back, resting them against his shoulder blades.

“How can you stand to touch me?” Mydeimos asks, so full of self-loathing.

Phainon doesn’t lift his hands. “Because I don’t think you’re the monster Okhema believes you to be.”

A tremor runs through Mydeimos. “My father certainly is.”

“Yes. But you’re as much his slave as I am yours.” Another tremor. “And you have your own impossible choices to make.” Phainon bends, pressing a kiss to the curve of Mydeimos’s shoulder, where it joins with his neck.

Voice raw, Mydeimos says, “I wouldn’t ask this of you.”

“You’re not asking anything of me,” Phainon says, drawing his fingertips down Mydeimos’s back and sliding them over his hips. “I’m choosing to give you something instead.” His fingers brush along Mydeimos’s cock.

The prince slides off the shelf, standing in the water.

Phainon pushed too far. He drops his head. “I—”

And then Mydeimos is astride him, bending over him, water-warm hands on Phainon’s jaw. Pressed together, the heat of their bodies is almost too

much, but Phainon doesn’t mind. He doesn’t mind this at all. His hands curve around Mydeimos’s waist, urging Mydeimos closer until his cock rubs over Phainon’s stomach.

“What a pleasant way to chase away miserable dreams,” Mydeimos says, his lips so close to Phainon’s own.

It’s Phainon who closes that scant distance. He lifts his face and presses their lips together, a soft kiss, an inviting kiss. His hands slide over Mydeimos’s waist, hungry for more of him, and he draws Mydeimos closer still until there’s no space between them.

Their lips brush back and forth, meeting and parting in small, tremulous caresses. Phainon isn’t entirely sure of Mydeimos; the moment feels fragile, and Mydeimos has maintained his position. He won’t touch Phainon—if Phainon doesn’t want him to. Right now, Phainon very much wants Mydeimos to touch him, to grind against him, into him. He wants the slick slide of wet flesh against wet flesh, wants Mydeimos’s tongue in his mouth, wants—wants to forget who he is, where he is, and the questions he’s wrestling with and a past that won’t leave him in peace. And if he erases Mydeimos’s own woes at the same time, all the better.

Mydeimos sinks lower, no longer on his knees but sitting across Phainon’s thighs. Phainon’s fingers bite into his ass, holding him close, and he arches upward, rubbing his half-hard cock against Mydeimos’s own.

They both groan, their mouths parting, their breath feathering over each other’s lips.

Phainon surges forward. He pushes Mydeimos against the bath’s opposite wall as he fixes their mouths together in a harder kiss, a hungrier one. His tongue plays across Mydeimos’s mouth for the simple pleasure of tasting him, water and wine and lingering dreams, and Mydeimos’s lips part for him. His tongue slicks into Mydeimos’s mouth, and he groans. Pleasure burns through him, rushing along his spine and pooling low in his stomach. His cock twitches and hardens as he rocks his hips into Mydeimos’s, as Mydeimos’s fingers curl around his shoulders to clutch him closer, too.

Their tongues press together, and Phainon is surprised when Mydeimos doesn't fight but rather invites him deeper, coaxing Phainon's tongue into his mouth. Phainon is surprised by all of this, but desire clouds reason, chasing it away. He hasn't touched someone, hasn't found comfort in someone else's body, in so long. Mydeimos isn't a poor substitute for someone else. Phainon isn't so desperate that any body will do, but he supposes they must both be lonely and hungry.

Maybe he's a traitor to his people for this. Maybe he's betraying his own morals. Maybe he just wants to do something that feels good and deal with the regret and shame later.

His fingers dig harder into Mydeimos's ass, and Mydeimos growls into their kiss. Submissive, yes, but not pliant. Not weak. He gives up control because he wants to, and Phainon's keenly aware that he could take it back at a moment's notice—and wouldn't that be hot, fighting for Mydeimos's submission.

Fuck, the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos is giving himself over to him, to Phainon—to Phainon of Nowhere, of Nothing—would probably let Phainon fuck him, would—

Cock hard, Phainon reaches between their bodies, creating just enough space to take his cock and Mydeimos's in his hand.

Mydeimos pulls back from their kiss long enough to let out a shuddering groan. "Good," he says, and then he's kissing Phainon again, one hand curved around the back of Phainon's neck and the other pressed to the small of his back.

The heat's becoming too much, but Phainon ignores it, ignores the sweat dripping down his spine in favor of the man against him, kissing him. They devour each other as they begin to move, thrusting awkwardly at first into Phainon's fist, the both of them figuring out the rhythm they need. Mydeimos finds it first, a slow and steady roll of his hips, and Phainon matches pace with him, groaning. Soft skin sliding against soft skin, the slick wetness of their bodies, the clench of his hand. It's good, it's so good. Mydeimos is good, is hard and hot against him.

The bathroom fills with the sound of their breath, of water sloshing over the edge of the bath. They break their kiss, resting their foreheads together as they fuck into Phainon's fist, their panting loud, a bellows.

"Fuck," Phainon grits out. "Fuck, you feel so good." He squeezes beneath the heads of their cocks, and Mydeimos makes a wicked, aching sound at the back of his throat. "Keep moving like that."

Mydeimos claws into one of Phainon's shoulders, clutching him tight, and Phainon's lips curl. Mydeimos likes that, the dirty talk. Maybe even being told what to do. Fuck, but the thought of that, of pushing Mydeimos down on the bed and telling him to fuck himself on Phainon's cock, that has Phainon aching, has him throbbing. Pleasure scalds him, hotter than even the bathwater, than their bodies. He's on fire even though he's soaking wet, desperate for more, panting against Mydeimos's mouth.

More wicked rolls of Mydeimos's hips, more of the drag of flesh on flesh. Phainon squeezes again, and Mydeimos groans. He strokes his hand down their lengths, and Mydeimos makes a sound suspiciously like a whine. Not that he's in much better shape. He gasps with each roll of his hips, climbing closer to the sweet edge of his own demise. He's chasing his own pleasure as much as Mydeimos's, stroking a little harder, a little faster.

"Titans," he breathes, wrapping his free hand behind Mydeimos's neck, too. They both cling to each other like that, pulling each other closer, grinding into each other, moving together until Phainon breaks with a low and wicked moan. Shuddering, he drops his forehead to Mydeimos's shoulder, rutting blindly into his own hand as cum spills over his fingers and into the water.

The touch quickly becomes too much. He releases himself, grinding lazily into Mydeimos's thigh, and he strokes Mydeimos's cock just that much faster. "Like this?" he asks, and Mydeimos closes one hand around Phainon's hand.

"Like this," he says, and he shows Phainon exactly how he likes it, the speed, the grip, the twisting of Phainon's hand.

Phainon groans, nuzzling deeper into Mydeimos's neck, breathing in the scent of olives and half convinced he'll never be able to smell them without thinking about sex again.

Mydeimos's head falls back. His back bows. He groans, grasping Phainon's wrist, and then he's coming, too, his cock pulsing in Phainon's hand. Phainon strokes him through it, trying to eke out every last drop of pleasure he can, ignoring the unease trying to creep over him. Morality—guilt—is for later. He won't think about it now while Mydeimos is still soft and warm against him, his breaths hot on Phainon's ear.

Stilling his hand, Phainon releases Mydeimos. He pets over the prince's thigh, his hip, rubbing small circles with his thumb as he slows the grinding of his own hips. When he lifts his head, Mydeimos watches him with an almost pained expression.

"That bad?" Phainon says, trying for levity.

"I should not have allowed that," Mydeimos replies.

Funny, this. How they're both grappling with guilt, just guilt of different origins.

Phainon takes Mydeimos gently by the chin, liking the way the prince's eyes grow infinitesimally wider. "As if I didn't want any of that." He squeezes, liking, too, how Mydeimos's lips part. "Don't apologize to me."

Mydeimos's eyes flash. "I wasn't—"

"You were." Phainon releases Mydeimos's chin, running his hand along Mydeimos's neck, over his shoulder, down his arm. He takes Mydeimos's hand, blocking out his own shame, his own guilt. That shouldn't have happened. Rather, he shouldn't have instigated it. But maybe, maybe, he can use this to his benefit. He is, after all, something of a talented actor.

Drawing Mydeimos from the bath, he towels them both dry. His hands linger, and Mydeimos's eyes remain glassy and dark with pleasure and interest.

Yeah. Yeah, he can convince himself this is a good thing, that he can use this to his advantage. That's all this is; it's a play, a ploy. Nothing more. This doesn't mean anything.

He brings Mydeimos out of the bathroom, leading him through the bedroom. Easing onto the bed, he pulls Mydeimos down with him, a little surprised by how pliant and biddable the prince is. Maybe it shouldn't be a surprise, really. For all the time they've spent together, even in the company of Mydeimos's friends, Mydeimos has always seemed aloof and set apart. That, Phainon supposes, is the weight of being a prince, the heir to a crown and a legacy that doesn't want you. That fears you.

Mydeimos settles atop him, between his legs. "We aren't fucking," he says, but there's less conviction in the words this time.

"Aren't we?" Phainon asks. "Aren't I offering?"

Mydeimos swallows. "We aren't," he says again.

Phainon rolls them over, pinning Mydeimos beneath him. "Then we won't," he says, conciliatory, as he presses a kiss to the corner of Mydeimos's mouth.

This is a game, he reminds himself, and maybe he should've played these moves sooner. Maybe wrapping Mydeimos around his finger with pleasure was something he should've done at the start.

His mouth finds the curve of Mydeimos's jaw, the line of his neck. He smooths his hand down the length of Mydeimos's body, a long caress, and Mydeimos arches into the touch.

"Phainon," he says.

"Mm?"

"This isn't—this isn't necessary. I don't expect—"

Phainon rakes his teeth down Mydeimos's throat, and a broken, needy sound spills from Mydeimos's lips. "I know you don't. I want to." He really

is a good actor. Mydeimos relaxes beneath him, bonelessly sinking into the mattress. But this isn't acting, not entirely. It's confusing as hell, and there's a comfort in convincing himself he's doing this to get what he wants out of Mydeimos, but the simple truth is that he really does want to do this. He wants to wrap his lips around one of Mydeimos's nipples, so he does. He wants to fit himself between Mydeimos's legs and grind lazily into him, so he does. He wants the taste of Mydeimos's skin on his tongue and the feel of him beneath his hands, so he licks and strokes his way down Mydeimos's body as Mydeimos pants beneath him, clutching at the sheets.

The sun is fully set, and darkness a cloak around them. Clouds cover the moon and blot out the stars, isolating them in Mydeimos's bedroom. Remembering that there is no such thing as being alone in Castrum Kremnos's palace is a struggle. There are, surely, servants lingering outside Mydeimos's bedroom, listening to them, eager to report back to their myriad masters.

This, Phainon thinks as his tongue maps the dips and valleys of Mydeimos's abdomen, is a good thing. They've slept in the same bed, but not together. Since that first day, they haven't even playacted sex. This news needs to get back to any number of people. It is, all of it, a performance.

Phainon lifts his face from Mydeimos's skin, gazing up the length of the prince's body. In the darkness, he can barely make out the curve of Mydeimos's chin, his head thrown back and tipped up. He might be the only one in all of this who isn't acting. Phainon's gut twists, but he ruthlessly suppresses the feeling.

Bending once more, he presses an open-mouthed kiss to the crease of Mydeimos's thigh. Beneath him, the prince's hips jump off the bed, and he gasps softly. Fingers brush against Phainon's ear, a brief caress, and Phainon tuns his head into the touch—tacit permission. Mydeimos slides his hand into Phainon's hair, and for a moment, Phainon can't help but remember the day they met, the cruel way Mydeimos jerked him around by his hair. There's no cruelty in his touch.

No, even Mydeimos is an actor. They all are, carefully performing their parts.

His mouth brushes over Mydeimos’s half-hard cock; his hand curves over Mydeimos’s thigh. Sweat slicks the prince’s supple skin, a faint sheen of it.

A shame, Phainon thinks, that there isn’t any light, that he can barely see the man beneath him, for surely Mydeimos would be glorious to behold.

With his lips trailing down the length of Mydeimos’s cock, Phainon shifts him, lifting one of the prince’s legs over his shoulder and encourage the other to splay wide. Mydeimos’s breath shudders in his chest, an audible susurration, and pleasure surges through Phainon, a wicked satisfaction that he can reduce the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos to this. It’s a primal and primitive thing, unrelated to political games, a prurient thrill that makes his own cock twitch with renewed interest.

“Do you have oil?” he asks, nuzzling into the curve of Mydeimos’s thigh.

Mydeimos tenses. “We’re not—”

“We’re not,” Phainon assures him. “Just my fingers.” His mouth pulls at the base of Mydeimos’s cock. “I want to make you come on my fingers.”

Mydeimos swallows hard, loud enough to hear. “Here,” he says, his voice wavering, and that’s delicious, too, taking away all the self-assured confidence that so often hangs in Mydeimos’s every word. He shifts across the bed, but not away from Phainon’s mouth as he continues planting lingering kisses closer and closer to the line of Mydeimos’s cock. Mydeimos fumbles something on a nearby table—it’s too dark and Phainon is too occupied to see clearly—and then Mydeimos presses a vial against Phainon’s hand.

Taking the vial, Phainon drags his lips up the length of Mydeimos’s cock. He tastes fresh and clean, of crisp water, until Phainon’s tongue pulls over his tip. Precum beads there, salty and bitter but so very good. Parting his lips, Phainon takes the tip of Mydeimos’s cock into his mouth, suckling as he uncorks the vial and tips a smear of it into his palm.

Caught between Phainon and the bed, Mydeimos groans. Pants. His fingers curl tighter in Phainon’s hair only to relax a second later, as if he, too,

remembers that first day and disdains his own behavior.

Stoppering the vial once more, Phainon sets it aside and focuses his attention wholly on the man beneath him. He pulls Mydeimos's hardening cock deeper between his lips, delighting in the way Mydeimos's fingers spasm against the side of his head. Braced on one arm, he gives himself room to drag his fingers over Mydeimos's perineum, stroking down to his hole.

It surprises him still that the crown prince would prefer this, would want to take someone into his body rather than the opposite, but he is far from opposed to it. No, he quite prefers this, prefers to rub his fingers against Mydeimos's rim as he sucks the prince deeper, as Mydeimos groans softly, quietly.

Mydeimos's cock slides against Phainon's soft palate, and he has to pull back to keep from gagging. He's out of practice but willing to persist, to try again, and so he sinks back down Mydeimos's length, suckling around him to more of Mydeimos's aching little moans. The prince is so quiet, as though afraid to betray himself with sound. Phainon wants to pick him apart until he's singing, until his moans are an amphitheater's chorus.

Not now, though. Now, Phainon wants the heavy darkness to obscure them, both sight and sound, wants to keep this moment to himself if only so he can pretend they're not a prince and a slave.

His finger presses against Mydeimos's hole, and Mydeimos jumps, gasps. He presses just a bit harder, pushing past Mydeimos's tight rim, and Mydeimos groans, going boneless beneath him one more. Strong fingers clutch at Phainon's hair, not to yank or manhandle but merely to hold. Now, Phainon groans, too—groans at the way Mydeimos's body lets him in, the scalding heat of him, the way he clenches around Phainon's fingertip as if to pull him deeper.

One of Mydeimos's heels presses into the small of Phainon's back, and Phainon absently grinds himself against the bed beneath him. He's hard, but his own pleasure is a pleasant background noise, distant and faraway, compared to the desire to give Mydeimos more.

Sliding his finger deeper, he crooks it, searching for that one spot that always drives his partners mad. And when he finds it with easy drags of his fingertip against Mydeimos's scorching hot insides, Mydeimos makes a fractured, broken sound.

He wonders how many other men Mydeimos has taken into his bed and if they've been attentive and desperate to please or if they've been only as pleasant as self-serving ambition demanded. But comparing himself to others is no good, and he knows it; he shoves down on those thoughts too as his tongue laves up the length of Mydeimos's cock and his finger curls a second time, a third.

"*Phainon*."

His cock throbs in response, pleasure churning low in his stomach. Hearing his name on a lover's lips—he's not Mydeimos's lover, he has to remember that—has always made him ache. Hearing his name on Mydeimos's lips is some balm of heaven, something profound and borderline divine.

"Phainon, *more*."

He licks over the tip of Mydeimos's cock, parting his lips to take a hungry breath, and then swallows him down again, sliding along Mydeimos's length until the tip hits his soft palate. Maybe a real bed slave would be able to take all of Mydeimos's considerable length to the root, but Mydeimos doesn't have any complaints about this, no. He arches his back and rolls his hips, chasing the pleasure that Phainon doles out, and Phainon allows himself a moment of satisfaction.

His finger curls again, rubbing over that spot on Mydeimos's hot walls, a steady back and forth in time with the rolling of Mydeimos's hips. He slides his mouth along Mydeimos's cock, too, in perfect rhythm, matching the pace the prince sets. And Mydeimos sinks both hands into Phainon's hair, his hips twisting, his back bowing. Gasps and moans, soft and abbreviated, fall from his lips, almost hiccupping like he's swallowing them back or cutting them off, like he doesn't want to be heard, like he wants to share this with Phainon and Phainon alone.

Phainon works his own hips against the bed, grinding into the mattress as Mydeimos's hips move faster, as his cock fucks deeper between Phainon's lips. His finger curls and presses, stroking that sweet spot over and over until Mydeimos makes a cracked and desperate noise.

"Phainon—"

Phainon releases Mydeimos's cock, licking down the length of it, but doesn't stop fingering him. He looks up the length of Mydeimos's body to find it arched and tense, to find the prince bent like a bow strung too tight.

He is beautiful, the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos, is resplendent as he chases his bliss and then falls into it. Mydeimos moans as he comes apart, as he paints his belly white with his own spend. Phainon doesn't stop stroking over him, pulling that pleasure out as long as he can, watching fixedly as Mydeimos's cock twitches and pulses, as cum spills over his skin.

Watching him is exquisitely arousing, is so fucking erotic that Phainon can't stop his own orgasm. He grinds into the mattress, spilling into the sheets. He groans quietly, brows knitting, but still doesn't stop fucking Mydeimos with his fingers. Only when Mydeimos grabs Phainon's wrist does Phainon relent, easing his finger out of Mydeimos's body.

They're both panting, both gasping, as Phainon slides up the length of Mydeimos's body, pulling two fingers through the cum splashed across his belly and presses those fingers to Mydeimos's lips.

Mydeimos's tongue flicks lazily over Phainon's fingers. Despite the darkness, Phainon discerns the dazed expression on the prince's face. "Good?" he asks, a little embarrassed by how badly he needs to hear Mydeimos say it.

"Mm." Mydeimos laves Phainon's fingers before turning toward him. "Good." Satisfaction hums through Phainon; as much as he enjoys praising his partners, he enjoys receiving praise even more, delights in knowing when he's done well.

“Let me fetch my prince a towel,” he says. “And a new sheet.”

“Leave the sheet,” Mydeimos says, slurring, and that, too, is its own praise.

Phainon, turned away from Mydeimos as he eases off the bed, allows himself a smug smile. “As you wish.” He returns to the bathroom to find one of the linens they’d discarded earlier, wiping his fingers and his own cock. Then he returns to the bed, sitting on the edge of it.

Mydeimos lays sprawled across the bed, arm resting over his face.

“Here,” Phainon says, setting the towel on Mydeimos’s stomach and rubbing him clean. “Maybe now Your Highness will sleep soundly.”

Mydeimos makes an irritated little sound. “My prince,” he says. “Your Highness.” He drops his arm, and the clouds outside part, allowing a sliver of silver moonlight to spill across his face. “When we are alone, you should call me Mydeimos.”

“Mydeimos,” Phainon says, and this, he thinks, is the better prize than the prince’s body. This is the prince’s trust.

Chapter End Notes

> earlier this week, i would've told you that i've added a single, additional chapter in the middle of this fic. now that 3.4 has happened, i'm reconsidering the ending and some of the direction of this fic. not to say it will be abandoned!! my original intent has changed :3 i'm in the process of outlining what that change will look like (either more to this fic or a sequel to it), and i'll let you know what that looks like when i've got it figured out. tldr you're getting more of this either way
>
> as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> as in chapter 3, this chapter features some potentially triggering, but not graphically described, violence. if you're worried and want more details, click the additional warning below

▶ additional warning

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sweat drips down Mydei's back. Above him, the sun hammers down mercilessly, but heat isn't a reason to forgo practice. He's on the training pitch with his century, working with one of his centurions, a back-and-forth dance of spears. They circle each other carefully, each studying the other, looking for openings. Mydei has gone out of his way to ensure his century is home to some of the best men in his father's army, which certainly hasn't gone unnoticed. No, it's another reason for Eurypon's unrelenting suspicions.

Mydei feints right, lunging forward. The centurion, a young man named Drakon, ignores the feint and meets him blow for blow. They dance across the training field, testing each other rather than trying to launch believable attacks; this is more about reaction times than it is trying to win the bout.

A flurry of activity to the side of the pitch draws Mydei's attention, and he just barely steps out of the way of a brutal thrust. Knocking the spear tip away from his throat, he sidesteps and holds up a hand. "Hold," he says, and Drakon immediately bows back.

Leonnius stands on the side of the pitch, engaged in quiet but furious conversation with Hephaestion, whose stormy expression threatens thunderous wrath.

An uneasy feeling crawls across Mydei's back. He trots over to them as Hephaestion says, "His Highness needn't be bothered with—Mydei. This

isn’t important.” Unfortunately, those words betray Hephaestion. Whatever’s going on is almost certainly important.

“I can judge that for myself,” Mydei says, turning to Leonnius. “What tidings, then?”

“Phainon,” Leonnius says, and the ground beneath Mydei’s feet rolls. There are precious few reasons Leonnius would come running about Phainon, and none of them are good. His mother must have— “Krateros found him trying to escape over one of the back walls.”

Mydei’s blood runs cold. He isn’t surprised, though he is a little annoyed. Mostly, though, he is afraid. “Periander?” he asks.

“Mydei,” Hephaestion says as Leonnius nods. “Mydei, he’s a *slave* and your mother’s spy. There’s no reason—”

But Mydei has already tossed his spear to the quartermaster and set off at a brisk pace. Sweat drips down his skin and sand cakes his frame. He probably looks frightful. Good. He’ll need all the presence he can muster to cow Periander before the slave master brings his whip down on Phainon’s back. And then he will need to understand why Phainon was trying to sneak over the back of the palace instead of simply arranging a meeting with one of Gorgo’s contacts inside the walls.

Scrubbing a hand over his face, he hurries through the palace’s halls, vaguely aware of Hephaestion and Leonnius at his back. Hephaestion has given up calling for his attention; Leonnius, meanwhile, is a quiet shadow trailing behind him. An ache grows behind his eyes, a throbbing that zings along his scalp to the base of his skull. Trouble. Gorgo’s agents are always so much trouble, and he wouldn’t be so bothered if Phainon wasn’t also a Chrysos Heir. No one deserves to die the way Eurypon executes Chrysos Heirs. No one.

Mydei is so tired of watching people die.

The slave quarters open onto a large, sandy courtyard, and it’s there that Mydei goes. He steps onto the sand, unsurprised to find Phainon bound to a

whipping post already. There's a small crowd, because of course there is, a smattering of citizens and senators, a general. His own father. Eurypon stands at the edge of a covered balcony, looking down from the second story of the palace, his expression shadowed. There's no sign of Gorgo. Unsurprising. She's never tolerated mistakes from her agents, instead choosing to let the Titans decide their fates.

With Eurypon overlooking the courtyard, there's no way this won't be a spectacle. A muscle twitches in Mydei's jaw, an irritating flex.

Periander stands over Phainon, a scourge in hand. He is a thick man, with broad shoulders and a full beard, handsome and, generally, congenial—except when it comes to his slaves. There, his humor dies, and he is a heartless, ruthless master, quick to punish with the most brutal tools.

Mydei spares a quick glance for Phainon, who has a white-knuckled grip on his restraints. He stares ahead of himself, jaw set, and doesn't acknowledge Mydei at all.

"Periander," Mydei says, quickly organizing his thoughts. Periander is never swayed by emotion, only by practicality; the law is his most powerful weapon. "What right have you to harm my property?" His stomach curdles with disgust.

Phainon doesn't move, doesn't turn his head, barely even breathes.

Periander turns toward Mydei with a sweeping bow, perfectly polite in every way. "Your Highness!" His dark eyes flick to Leonnius over Mydei's shoulder, and his expression falters if only for a moment.

Oh, but he's been waiting for an opportunity like this, a chance to exert his power of Mydei's household, but Mydei has never owned a slave and so Periander has never had the chance.

A charming smile pulls across Periander's face as he rises from his bow. "I mean only to assist Your Highness," he says, "as it has never been the prince's pleasure to punish an errant slave. Perhaps his arm would grow tired before the required fifty strikes."

Fifty? Hell. “It is mine and my household’s business,” Mydei says, casting a brief glance toward his father. “Not yours.”

Periander taps the scourge into his open palm. “An escaping slave is certainly my business,” he says cheerfully. “We must laud Krateros for his keen eyes, no?”

“Of course,” Mydei says, his expression tight but pleasantly polite. “I would still manage my slave and my household.”

“It would not do,” Periander all but purrs, “if the prince were to do nothing.” They all know Mydei is a soft touch with his staff. They all know he abhors the practice of slavery. They all know he’s maneuvering to get Phainon released without punishment at all. Even one strike of a Kremnoan scourge is too many. “If a slave attempts escape and is not reprimanded, others may mistake us as soft. Weak.” His congenial smile turns sharp, malicious. “But our prince is not weak.”

The vultures in the open halls surrounding the courtyard lean in.

Hell. Any other slaveowner would take the whip from Periander’s hand and mete out punishment himself, but if Mydei does that, Phainon burns. There is the principle of the thing—Phainon doesn’t deserve to burn, not even if he was attempting to escape—and something deeper that Mydei doesn’t have the time to examine closer.

Phainon cannot, should not burn. Not for this.

He must think like his mother. Gorgo would come at this from the side, stepping around the issue of punishing her slave entirely, nimbly twisting the situation to her advantage while maintaining her position. But Gorgo is cleverer than Mydei; he may be her son, but he doesn’t see the world the way she does. He suppresses a grimace. He sees one path forward where his mother would surely see several. It’s an unpleasant path, but he has no time to outsmart the whole of society.

“No,” Mydei agrees. “No, I am not.” At least this path will reinforce that truth: that Mydei isn’t weak. “A slave is a reflection of his master, isn’t he?”

Periander chuckles. “Are we to engage in philosophy, Your Highness?”

“When a slave acts, he does so on his master’s behalf,” Mydei continues, ignoring the question. “He acts with his master’s authority. His mistakes are his master’s.” A few of the vultures have drifted closer still. Eurypon himself leans over the balustrade, still in too much shadow for Mydei to make out his expression. He’s sure it’s feral with delight. Eurypon isn’t stupid; he’s almost certainly realized what the other vultures have. “Is that not true, Periander? Are a slave’s actions not a proxy for his master?”

Periander’s smile has slipped. “This is true,” he says slowly. He hasn’t caught up to Mydei’s circuitous logic.

A sharp inhalation from behind tells him that Hephaestion has, but Hephaestion is, in this at least, too smart to speak.

“Then I am guilty of my slave’s mistakes, and it is as fitting to punish me,” Mydei says, closing his trap around Periander, “as it is to punish him.”

The courtyard is hushed, and Periander is no longer smiling. He glances toward Eurypon, clearly ill at ease, before saying, “Certainly, I could not punish the crown prince for a slave’s indiscretion.”

But he could. There is precedent for it. “Has my mother not taken blows meant for me?” Mydei asks softly. Periander’s face pales. “Did Homeros not accept strikes meant for Kyrillos?” The two are borderline mythical, heroes from an age long past. Homeros took a beating meant for his slave, and his slave won a major battle in one of the myriad Chrysos Wars.

“I would not presume—”

Eurypon lifts his hand, and the entire courtyard’s attention shifts to him. Mydei, too, studies his father, his face lit just enough for his expression to be clear. Amusement. Delight. “Who are you, Periander, to argue with the Crown Prince?” Eurypon asks mildly.

That’s all it takes for the tenor in the courtyard to change. Periander is all smiles once more, and the onlookers buzz with excitement.

“As the king says.” Periander gives Mydei a mocking bow.

Many times throughout his life, Mydei has mocked Periander in turn. His staunch refusal to accept slaves from beneath Periander’s thumb has destroyed any equanimity between them. Periander has loathed Mydei for a decade.

Ignoring Periander, Mydei turns to a pair of nearby slaves. “Free my slave,” he says. He ignores Phainon, too, who is now staring at him with a mix of disbelief and horror—and bald understanding. Mydei has no idea if Phainon had reckoned with his own death, but he can only imagine the sudden change in outlook has shaken him.

As soon as Phainon is freed, Mydei beckons Leonnius forward. “Take him back to my rooms.”

Leonnius gives a curt nod.

Phainon, of course, doesn’t intuit the unspoken command. “What are you doing?” he hisses, approaching Mydei directly.

This man. This impossible man will get himself killed. “You walk a dangerous line,” Mydei replies, taking Phainon by the upper arm and yanking him close. Quieter, in his ear, he murmurs, “Do not make this worse for me. I have saved your life as you did mine. Go with Leonnius. Behave, just this once, for both our sakes.” He squeezes hard on Phainon’s bicep.

Phainon meets his eyes, but, thankfully, only briefly. He bows his head. “Yes, my prince.”

Mydei releases him, giving Leonnius a meaningful look.

Irritation and disdain flicker across Leonnius’s face as he places his hand between Phainon’s shoulder blades and shoves. “Move, slave,” he says.

“No.” Once more, every head in the courtyard turns to Eurypon. “How will the slave learn his lesson if he doesn’t watch?” Eurypon gestures Leonnius

and Phainon toward the side of the courtyard. “He stays.”

This isn’t ideal. Mydei doesn’t want Phainon anywhere near his father. Doesn’t want Phainon anywhere near the courtyard. The longer Phainon is here, the more likely he is to make a mistake, and then all of this will be for nothing. But no one will gainsay the king.

Leonnius jerks Phainon to the side of the courtyard, taking up a post there, holding Phainon by the upper arm. Hephaestion joins them, stone-faced. Disappointment flashes in his eyes when he looks on Mydei, but it barely matters. Mydei cares about Hephaestion, yes, but his ego is independent of Hephaestion’s judgement. It has been for months, now.

Rolling his shoulders back, Mydei approaches the post meant for Phainon. Fifty strokes. He’ll probably die once. “Get on with it, then,” he says, gripping the circumference of it. He forces himself to relax, and he waits.

This is a farce. It has to be. There’s no way the slave master of Castrum Kremnos will whip his crown prince in a public courtyard while the king watches. And Mydeimos—sure, Phainon saved his life in the Grove, but Mydeimos allowing himself to be whipped in Phainon’s place is almost unthinkable. Phainon understands the alternative. He understands that if Periander whips *him*, his gold blood will give him away and then he’ll burn. But Mydeimos can’t possibly value him so much to take these hits on Phainon’s behalf.

At any moment, this whole circus will surely collapse in on itself, and Phainon, standing between Hephaestion and Leonnius, waits for it.

Periander turns to Mydeimos as Phainon waits.

Periander raises his whip as Phainon waits—and a chill goes down Phainon’s spine.

No one has bound Mydeimos to the whipping post. No one has moved. The king leans over the balustrade casually. The citizens stand in the shadows, still and silent. Someone, he thinks, will say something.

Periander’s arm is fully raised. He stands ready for one second, two.

Someone will say something. These two somatophylakes on either side of him. The one who caught him, who brought him here, who all but worships the ground Mydeimos walks on. Hell, the king himself. Surely the king will burst out laughing and declare this all a joke at—

The whip cracks across Mydeimos’s back.

Now. *Now* someone will speak up. Surely this is all for show and the actors have all played their parts.

Again, the whip cracks across Mydeimos’s back, and the metal bits on the end of the leather tassels draw golden blood.

“Periander,” the king says, and Phainon sags with relief as the slave master turns toward Eurypon. “Put your back into it.”

Bile rises in the back of Phainon’s throat. His head jerks from Eurypon to Leonnius and then Hephaestion, but their faces are blank. They stare straight ahead, neither looking at either their king or their prince. They are —they cannot be cowards, not if they’re the prince’s somatophylakes, but Phainon can’t help but think them so.

Another crack of the whip, and Phainon forces his eyes back to Mydeimos, who clings to the whipping post but has yet to make a single noise.

He can’t do anything. He’s powerless. He has been powerless for weeks, yes, but standing to the side as Periander strips the skin off Mydeimos’s back drives that home for him. There’s nothing he can do—there’s nothing Mydeimos can do—they’re both trapped, they’re both under the thumb of a half-mad tyrant, and that half-mad tyrant knows it.

Eurypon has a goblet in his hands. He’s drinking wine as he watches a slave master whip his own son, his crown prince.

None of the onlookers do anything. They don’t speak. They don’t move. They watch with fixed interest, as though all the blood pouring down

Mydeimos’s back is more palatable for its golden hue.

A Chrysos’s Heir’s muscle, it turns out, is as red as a normal human’s.

And Mydeimos is doing this for him, to pay back his life, surely, so that Phainon doesn’t burn.

Mydeimos slips to his knees but doesn’t make a sound. When he begins to list to one side, Periander pauses, ordering him tied to the post. He’s only delivered eighteen strikes, and Phainon isn’t sure he can watch any more of this even though he knows he has to. This, like the banquet, is a test from Eurypon, and if he doesn’t perform his part, he’ll burn anyway, and Mydeimos’s sacrifice here will mean nothing.

A prince allowing himself to be whipped in place of a slave. Of course Eurypon wouldn’t end this after one strike. This kind of sacrificial nobility undermines everything he stands for. Now, he has to make a point.

But Phainon won’t burn. Mydeimos will probably die, but Phainon won’t burn. He can’t decide if that’s a good trade off, even if Mydeimos is immortal. Immortality doesn’t prevent pain.

He chances a quick glance at Hephaestion. Hephaestion still faces forward, expression blank, but he trembles. When he, too, turns his eyes toward Phainon, there’s rage in them. Phainon did this. Phainon’s the reason Mydeimos’s back is a morass of gold and red.

He hopes Eurypon will lose interest like he did at the banquet, but hope is a fool’s errand. The king watches as he drinks his wine, seated on the balustrade with his back against a mighty column. No one leaves the courtyard. The slaves and servants and citizens alike watch their crown prince’s silent torture.

It only lasts ten minutes.

When Periander lowers his arm for the last time and steps back, slick with sweat and red of face, Mydeimos kneels, unmoving, in a pool of gold.

Phainon moves first. Perhaps he shouldn’t. Perhaps this will make everything worse for him and Mydeimos both, but to remain still would be to minimize Mydeimos’s sacrifice.

He goes to the prince’s side, kneeling in Mydeimos’s blood to free his wrists. The rough rope has rubbed them raw and golden. Mydeimos is breathing, somehow, shallow and rasping, but his eyes are closed and his body is limp. He lists to the side, and Phainon catches him about the waist, carefully slipping beneath one of his arms. He has no idea how he’s going to get Mydeimos to his bed, not with his back shredded, but he’ll be Titan damned if he doesn’t try.

Staggering to his feet, he pulls Mydeimos’s arm firmly over his shoulder. The agonized sound that comes from Mydeimos wounds Phainon’s soul.

And then Hephaestion is there, ducking under Mydeimos’s other arm. He says nothing, doesn’t even look at Phainon, but they don’t need to look at each other. They carry Mydeimos from the courtyard, leaving streaks of golden blood behind them. Leonnius silently leads the way.

“You,” Periander snaps. “Clean this up. And you, clean up after them before the blood stains the marble.”

How vile and utterly unsurprising.

Laboring under Mydeimos’s weight, even with Hephaestion’s assistance, is no easy thing. They’re both breathing heavily when they reach Mydeimos’s room. The servants there have already heard the news, clearly: there is a basin of fresh water and several piles of clean, folded linen strips waiting for them in the bedroom.

With great care, they maneuver Mydeimos onto his bed, and Phainon is grateful he’s unconscious. He can’t imagine the pain Mydeimos would otherwise be in.

“I know what to do,” Phainon says, reaching for the linens.

Hephaestion grabs him by the upper arm, and he reacts without thinking, breaking the hold and retaliating with a strike of his own. But Hephaestion is agile. He dodges, knocks Phainon off balance with a well-placed kick to Phainon's knee, and then slams him into the nearby wall, knocking all the wind out of him. "You," he snarls.

Phainon's head rings, his chest caves, and he gasps valiantly for breath.

"Hephaestion—" Leonnius grabs Hephaestion's shoulder, but Hephaestion won't be moved.

"Who the fuck are you?" Hephaestion demands, his face a mask of rage. "Who are you that Mydei would take that on your behalf?"

There's no way to safely answer that question, and even if he wanted to, he can't; he's still sucking in desperate gasps of air.

"Hephaestion!"

Hephaestion shakes Leonnius off, takes Phainon by the throat and the shoulder, and slams him against the wall a second time. "Why would he do that for you?"

Sure, there's no safe answer to that question, but the wild emotion in Hephaestion's eyes makes one thing very clear: he won't relent until he gets an answer that satisfies him. And for all Phainon knows, Hephaestion will kill him in an attempt to get that answer. He can't die. Not yet. Not when Mydeimos has just saved him.

He needs a good lie, but as he struggles to breathe, only one comes to mind. "I love him," he gasps, grabbing Hephaestion's wrist.

The fury drains out of Hephaestion's face, replaced by stark horror and utter bewilderment. "You—you what?"

"I love him," he says again, wheezing, scratching Hephaestion's skin. Hephaestion's grip doesn't relent. "We're in love."

Hephaestion squeezes harder, snarling. “You don’t know him. He doesn’t know *you*. You are a conniving, deceitful, traitorous sack of shit. You—”

Leonnius comes between them, driving his elbow into the bend of Hephaestion’s arm, breaking Hephaestion’s hold on Phainon’s throat. “Enough,” he says, bullying Hephaestion back.

“He’s *lying*,” Hephaestion howls, throwing himself against Leonnius as Phainon sags against the wall, gulping down precious air.

“So what if he is?” Leonnius asks, driving Hephaestion further back, more than likely sparing Phainon’s life.

Phainon touches his throat, wincing, certain it will bruise. Leonnius, he decides, is a good man. Or at least a more levelheaded one. Straightening, one hand on the wall for grounding support, he studies Hephaestion and his rage.

“So what if he’s lying?” Leonnius says again. “Mydei chose to take that whipping for him, sparing his life. It doesn’t matter *what* he says to you. Mydei’s actions say more.”

Hephaestion’s sneer is terrible and ugly, the loathing in his expression would kill lesser men. “He should be executed.”

“That would undo everything Mydei just fought for.” Leonnius shoves Hephaestion again. “Get out of here,” he says. “Get out and cool your head. Your anger doesn’t belong in this room.”

“My anger—”

“Get out, Hephaestion, or I will drag you out myself.”

Hephaestion sobers, staring Leonnius down, and Phainon tries to decipher whatever else is passing unsaid between them. Unfortunately, for all his weeks here, he has spent little enough time with Mydeimos’s somatophylakes, and he can’t read anything beyond Hephaestion’s anger.

With a disgusted sound, Hephaestion relents. He steps back, both hands upraised. “I’ll go,” he says, but not before turning a murderous look on Phainon. “Don’t mistake me, slave. I will come for you for what you’ve cost him.”

Phainon swallows back the desire for a witty retort, having no interest in suffering Hephaestion’s touch again. In his silence, Hephaestion departs, leaving him alone with Leonnius. The servants, it seems, have all fled.

Heaving a sigh, Leonnius turns to him. Studies him. Phainon lets him, peeling away from the wall and approaching the linens and the basin.

“Do you know how to care for these wounds?” Leonnius asks.

“Yes.” Phainon takes a long strip of linen and lays it across Mydeimos’s ruined back. Already, the skin on the edges is beginning to repair itself. “Will his quick healing change anything?”

“No,” Leonnius says. “He’ll need the same care as anyone else who survives Periander’s whip, it just won’t take as long for him to recover. But he’s still vulnerable to blood rot.”

Phainon trades the strip of linen for another, mopping up the blood, trying not to see too clearly what remains of Mydeimos’s back. He did this. “Has that ever killed him before?”

“Once,” Leonnius says. “Gut wounds are a bitch.” He hovers near the bed. “I can still send for a physician.”

Phainon replaces the strip of linen. “If the servants keep bringing me what I need, I’ll be able to manage.” He doesn’t look at Leonnius. “He saved my life today.”

“He did. And you probably took his at least once. You might’ve prevented a death in the Grove, but this math doesn’t balance out,” Leonnius says, and Phainon realizes that Leonnius doesn’t much like him, either, but his hatred isn’t as virulent as Hephaestion’s. “Maybe he does love you, maybe you’re not a liar, but best you even out all these scales.”

Not just the ones between him and Mydeimos but the ones between him and Leonnius, too. “I understand,” he says.

“Good. I’ll keep Hephaestion off your back, but Ptolemy will want to come by. Don’t piss him off.” Leonnius doesn’t wait for Phainon’s response. Warning and advice dispensed, he leaves.

Phainon sits on the edge of Mydeimos’s bed, sopping up his blood, and staring sightlessly over Mydeimos’s shoulder.

Love.

It had seemed, in the moment, the best lie. The most believable lie. Why else would a man take fifty lashes meant for a slave if not for love? Surely, Phainon’s own life is not worth so much. Surely, his saving Mydeimos’s life as he did could not require such a steep price in return. He isn’t familiar with Castrum Kremnos and its laws and traditions, but there must have been some other path than Mydei putting himself on the sacrificial pyre for Phainon’s sake.

A shudder rolls through him. Perhaps that’s not the best metaphor when Eurypon quite literally has a pyre in his banquet hall.

“Why?” he asks Mydeimos’s unconscious body. “How do you value my life to make this cost worth it?” He trades out the bloodied linen for another clean sheet, moving mechanically. When he looks too long at Mydeimos’s back, his stomach heaves, and he swallows his gorge as he turns away.

He did this. He’s the reason Mydeimos is barely clinging to life, the reason Mydeimos certainly died once in that courtyard. Mydeimos traded his life and well-being for Phainon, and while maybe Mydeimos views his life as cheap, he still suffered.

Mydeimos is a good man.

Mydeimos is a better man than Phainon is; Phainon would not have made that sacrifice. In Mydeimos’s position, to save his own skin, he would have let himself die.

Maybe the comparison is unfair. He has to stay alive. He has things yet to do, and Mydeimos has made that possible. Leonnius is more right than he knows about the balance between Phainon and Mydeimos.

Gold blood soaks the linen in his hands.

He changes it out again.

Fire. He's on fire. He *burns*.

Pain blazes through his body. Every breath is a new and unique agony.

His limbs are heavy, his brain foggy except where pain breaks through in staticky bursts and renders coherent thought impossible.

A broken sound spills from his lips.

Cool hands touch his arm, his hip.

A voice speaks, the words distant and distorted. There's an ocean of space between him and—and that's not Hephaestion speaking. Those hands aren't Hephaestion's.

The hands pull back. Something ceramic touches his lips, and he parts them. Bitter liquid floods his mouth. He coughs, and agony razes all conscious thought until there's nothing but numbness.

Not Hephaestion. If not Hephaestion, then…

The pain dims. The fog returns, blessed relief, but for one thought, one name.

Phainon.

"Come back to us."

Sleep and pain cling to the edges of his blurred awareness. He can’t open his eyes. Doesn’t want to. Morpheus sings sweet lullabies to him.

“Come back to *me*.” Ah. Hephaestion. “I miss you so much.”

His tongue is too thick, his pain too intense, his dreams too strong. He cannot manage a reply, and he doesn’t want to. They’ve had this conversation before.

“Won’t you come back for me?”

He slips away.

Once more, he drifts from sweet unconsciousness to the reality of a body on fire with pain. He doesn’t whimper, doesn’t groan, doesn’t make any noise to betray himself. He can’t. If anyone knows his weakness, he will surely be destroyed.

Phainon.

Phainon knows. But Phainon is caring for him. Phainon is—

“—not what was agreed to,” a woman’s voice says. Familiar. He knows that voice, struggles to place that voice, wrestles with his own memories until a sun-worn face coalesces in his mind. Mother. That’s his mother.

“I can’t stay trapped here when there is more to do,” a man’s voice replies. Phainon. He recognizes Phainon immediately.

“So you put my son in danger?” Gorgo demands. She is angry, so angry. He has rarely ever heard her this angry. He can’t remember the last time she was so angry on his behalf. Anger is deadly in Castrum Kremnos. Only Strife, Eurypon, Father, is allowed to be angry. “Do you truly expect me to believe that *you* are the best she could send me?”

The pain grows. It radiates across his back, and at last he makes a noise of discomfort.

“Mydeimos,” Gorgo says, her voice breaking. She kneels beside him, and he turns his head to look at her, trying to focus his blurry vision. “My precious son. Why have you done this thing?”

She doesn’t know. If Gorgo doesn’t know, then no one knows. Phainon is safe.

“More poppy milk,” Phainon says.

Mydei makes a rasping noise and tries to shake his head. No. No poppy milk. The pain is bad, but better to be awake and aware under agonizing pain than drugged into a stupor. He tries to push himself up, but his arms are heavy and even that small motion pulls his damaged back. Unbelievable agony rips through him.

“Here,” Phainon says, replacing Gorgo at Mydei’s bedside. “Not much more of this, I promise.” He’s so gentle, Phainon of Nowhere, of Okhema, of Aedes Elysiae. Phainon of the Chrysos Heirs, enemy of Castrum Kremnos. No, enemy of Eurypon. The Chrysos Heirs have never been Mydei’s enemy. “Drink.” A spoon touches his lips.

Mydei drinks.

“…you an apology. Probably a lot of them.”

The agonizing pain of previous wakings is now only a dull ache, and Mydei sighs softly with relief. He’s healing well, but he has no idea how long he’s drifted in and out of consciousness. Bitterness lingers on his tongue, the familiar taste of poppy milk, and he knows Phainon has kept him blissfully unaware of his own pain. A kindness.

“For messing up your life,” Phainon is saying. “Getting you whipped probably to death.”

Had he died? Mydei doesn’t remember. It’s possible. He doesn’t always remember his deaths.

“For everything with Hephaestion.”

Mydei opens his eyes. He’s facing Phainon, head turned toward him, and he wheezes out a dry laugh. “Hephaestion is… not your fault,” he croaks.

Phainon startles visibly, knocking the chair out from beneath him, and sinks to his knees at the side of Mydei’s bed. “You—” There are tears in his eyes.

Fog clouds his reasoning. Mydei reaches out, touching his fingertips to Phainon’s face, to the arch of his cheekbone. “Hephaestion has… always been trouble for me.” His eyes, still heavy, flutter shut. “Love is a difficult burden when it isn’t reciprocated.” He forces his eyes open.

Phainon’s fingers wrap around Mydei’s wrist loosely. His thumb rubs over veins that stand out all the more for Mydei’s dehydrated skin. There are tears in Phainon’s eyes before he bows his head and, to Mydei’s surprise, weeps.

Chapter End Notes

> phainon, last chapter: i got mydei's trust
> phainon, this chapter: so about that trust
>
> anyway, we're clinging to that happy ending tag, but i stg it's real. the boys just have to, you know, go through it first
>
> as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon weeps, and Mydei doesn't understand why. Maybe it's the lingering haze of the opium he's been drugged with. Maybe it's the residual pain, though he feels none right now. Maybe it's the days of disorientation.

"Why?" he asks, wetting his tongue. "Why do you weep?"

Lifting his face, Phainon clutches Mydei's wrist. Tears track down his cheeks, and they don't look at all like they belong there. Phainon isn't a man who should weep, not like this. "Why did you *do* this?" Phainon demands. Perhaps it's relief, then, that drives Phainon to tears.

Exhaling, Mydei drops his head. "Because it was the right thing to do."

"To let yourself die?"

"My deaths are cheap," Mydei says without looking at Phainon. He can't bear to look at Phainon. Phainon who weeps for a man who never stays dead. "Yours would not have been. Nor would it have been an easy death."

"Your suffering—"

"Since when do you care about my suffering?" Mydei asks, laughing. He presses his hand to Phainon's cheek. "No, don't answer that. Instead, tell me this: why did you run now rather than at the Grove?"

Phainon's fingers loosen around Mydei's wrist. "Don't ask me that."

"I know the answer." Phainon stiffens. "Because it wouldn't be right. For whatever reason you're here—" He recalls Phainon's argument with Gorgo in brief flashes, nothing of substance lingering in his mind. "—you could not run then. Likewise, letting you burn would not have been right." Mydei

lifts his eyes to meet Phainon's watery gaze. "I have done so many wrong things. I am so tired of doing wrong things. In this, I wanted to do right."

Phainon stares at him.

"This," Mydei says, lowering his gaze to Phainon's neck.

"Hephaestion," Phainon volunteers.

Mydei frowns, beginning to ask, and then turns away from it. Hephaestion can wait. His anger can, too. He doesn't want to be angry right now, least of all with Hephaestion. "How many days has it been?" he asks instead.

Now, Phainon looks bewildered. "Five."

"Five days for me to heal is nothing compared to the hundreds of days you would not have lived." Mydei is so tired of seeing people die. Men, women, children. Chrysos Heirs. His empire, if he is to inherit one at all, will be an empire of corpses if his father is allowed to continue down his current path. "I'm glad to be able to let you live, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae."

Once more, Phainon's fingers curl around Mydei's wrist. This time, they tighten with purpose, with intent. He draws Mydei's hand along his cheek, turning his face into Mydei's palm, and he presses his lips to Mydei's skin. A kiss.

Heat kindles within Mydei's stomach.

Not just one kiss. A second, a third. Phainon leans forward, his lips a lingering caress along Mydei's wrist. Phainon releases him, wrapping one hand around the back of his head, drawing him close, and it's only at the last possible moment that Mydei's sluggish mind realizes what's about to happen. He tips his head to the side. Their mouths come together.

Kissing Phainon is no revelation. The world doesn't suddenly make more sense. If anything, Mydei's world unravels in new and unpleasant ways. Phainon is a slave—his slave—his mother's slave—a Chrysos Heir—and he shouldn't do this with him. Phainon has no right to refuse him—but he

reminds himself that Phainon has only been a slave for a handful of weeks. If any man could refuse him, it's Phainon. Phainon who could have turned him over to a physician but chose not to. Phainon who spent five days by his side, tending his wounds.

"Would you deny me?" Mydei asks against Phainon's lips, his eyes drifting shut.

Phainon laughs against his mouth. "If I told you I didn't want you now, it'd be a lie, Your Highness." More heat curls in Mydei's stomach, smoldering and sweet, a kindling brazier.

"We're alone," Mydei says, sinking his hand into Phainon's hair and drawing him closer, onto the edge of the bed. "You know you can call me by my name."

"Mydeimos," Phainon says, and then he kisses Mydei again.

Groaning, Mydei sinks toward Phainon, and Phainon catches him. His hands are careful, one on Mydei's upper arm and the other on his waist, far away from the healed but still tender wounds on his back. There's a tension in Phainon's hold, everything about his posture saying that he wants very much to wrap his arms around Mydei but is holding back.

Mydei can't remember the last time he genuinely wanted someone's arms wrapped around him. Can't remember the last time he craved someone, desired someone enough to want them all around him and under his skin and inside him. Even Hephaestion, that brief mistake, he didn't want the way he wants Phainon now. And he shouldn't want Phainon. Phainon is a slave and an enemy, is a complication he doesn't need. Phainon is the reason his back was ruined, but Phainon defended him and Phainon gave him a safe place to land after his nightmare and Phainon—

Phainon is almost certainly using him. The realization is sudden, but it does nothing to dampen Mydei's ardor. Everyone who has ever come to Mydei's bed has wanted to use him. What's one more?

His lips part, and Phainon takes his invitation, his tongue sweeping into Mydei's mouth. Mydei makes a soft, hungry noise, one Phainon swallows down, and he tugs Phainon closer, urging him deeper into the bed. Phainon obliges him, shifting to sit against the headboard. He takes Mydei by the hips, tugging gently, and Mydei allows himself to be moved, allows himself to slide once more into Phainon's lap. How familiar this is, just like that evening in the baths, but this time Phainon wears a chiton. Mydei, though, is just as naked.

"We shouldn't," Phainon says against Mydei's mouth. "Your back—"

"Is fine," Mydei says. It's not completely healed, it's still tender, but he can manage, and he wants to feel something good. He wants to feel something good with Phainon, wants to pretend none of this is happening. For just a moment, he wants to truly be Mydei instead of Mydeimos, instead of the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos. "Tell me you would deny me. That there is nothing owed between us."

Phainon pulls Mydei closer by his hips, grinding him down on Phainon's cock. "There's nothing owed between us. I would deny you anything if you pissed me off, Mydeimos."

Mydei rests his forehead against Phainon's, groaning as their cocks come together through the thin fabric of Phainon's chiton. The front of it is damp from their precum, little wet splotches spreading across it. "Mydei," he says.

A frisson of something—tension? Uncertainty?—runs through Phainon, enough for Mydei to feel it. Perhaps he's overstepped, but he just wants to be a man, and he—

"Mydei," Phainon breathes, tipping his head back and capturing Mydei's mouth with his own.

Mydei moans. He braces his hands on Phainon's shoulders, grinding against Phainon's cock, his own full and thick with arousal. Desire churns through him, a need to have someone inside him, to remind him he's alive. He's *alive*, it's always a rush to be *alive*, and he wants to be alive with Phainon,

even though he shouldn’t. Titans, Phainon is the last person he should want, but he can’t help himself, and Phainon’s hands are warm and rough on his hips, a swordsman’s hands, but they’re gentle and coaxing, too, urging him to keep moving, to keep grinding down.

One of Phainon’s hands pulls over Mydei’s hip, calluses dragging over Mydei’s skin. Phainon wraps his hand around Mydei’s cock, and Mydei moans again, his hips jerking forward, driving his cock deeper into Phainon’s hold.

“Like last time,” Phainon says, thumbing the tip of Mydei’s cock, rubbing precum into his skin. “My hand on your cock and my fingers inside you.”

A shudder runs down Mydei’s spine. Desire pools in his belly, hot and syrupy and sweet. He doesn’t want Phainon’s fingers. Not this time. “Tell me no,” he murmurs, bending his mouth to Phainon’s as he rocks into Phainon’s hand.

Slowly, a smile unfurls across Phainon’s lips. “You want more than my fingers, don’t you?” he asks, squeezing beneath the head of Mydei’s cock as his other hand spreads wide over Mydei’s ass. His fingers push between Mydei’s cheeks, pulling lightly over Mydei’s hole, and Mydei can’t stop the reedy sound that catches in his throat. “Do you want my cock, Mydei?”

Pleasure surges through him, sharp and vicious. His cock twitches in Phainon’s hands, and his eyes flutter shut. “Yes,” he says, unashamed, burning with the heat of Phainon’s words. “Tell me no.”

“I won’t,” Phainon replies, rubbing his finger against Mydei’s hole as he pulls his hand down Mydei’s cock. “I want to watch you on my cock.” Mydei groans, not sure if he should push that finger into his hole or fuck into Phainon’s hand. He’s torn between two ecstasies, the faint pain in his back a mere afterthought. “I want to watch you swallow it up and then ride me.”

Another broken little noise, another gasp. Phainon takes his mouth in deep, hungry kiss, fucking his tongue past Mydei’s lips. His tongue fills Mydei’s

mouth like Mydei wants Phainon's cock in his ass, taking him in long, deep strokes that have him panting.

Phainon pulls back. "What if I make you come first?" he asks, stroking harder, faster. "What if I open you up with your own cum on my fingers?" An embarrassing sound spills out of Mydei. Just the thought has his mind empty except for thoughts of Phainon's cock carving deep into him. He half wants Phainon to throw him onto the bed and take him hard and fast, but while he can handle some of roughness, he knows his tender skin won't hold up to something like that. "Do you want that?" Phainon asks. "How many times could I make you come for me tonight?"

Too many, Mydei thinks blearily. He's always been sensitive, but he has no doubt that Phainon could take him apart more easily than anyone else has ever managed.

"Another night," Phainon says, squeezing the base of Mydei's cock. Mydei groans, biting at Phainon's lower lip, plaintive. "We need to be gentle. Your back's not that healed."

"It's fine," Mydei assures him. "Fine enough for this." He can't imagine Phainon turning him aside, even though he's begged Phainon to tell him no. Titans, this is a wicked trap of his own making.

Phainon makes a thoughtful sound. "Gentle," he says, still stroking Mydei. "We need to be gentle with you." No one has ever been gentle with Mydei. No one has ever wanted to be. They've all had so many suppositions about him, about his preferences, and no one has treated him gently. "I don't want to hurt you again."

Mydei can almost believe that. "A little bit of pain is—"

"You deserve better than that," Phainon says, licking into Mydei's mouth, and something in Mydei breaks. Or maybe something broken clicks back into place.

You deserve better than that.

Phainon's touch is tender, is reverent as he continues to stroke Mydei, as his finger presses against Mydei's hole in a facsimile of penetration, a playful tease that has Mydei gasping. He clutches at Phainon's shoulders, groaning, fucking harder into Phainon's fist.

"Phainon," he breathes, and then Phainon makes a hungry, broken sound. Phainon surges against him, capturing his mouth. Phainon is suddenly as desperate and needy as Mydei is, kissing him like he can't breathe without their lips pressed together.

The stroking of Phainon's hand grows more urgent, and Mydei falls into the rhythm of it, thoughtlessly chasing his own pleasure as Phainon licks into his mouth, as Phainon tastes him, makes wicked demands of him. Ecstasy bubbles in his veins, bright and effervescent. He's alight with it, alive with it, and it's still so good to be alive. Panting into Phainon's mouth, licking along Phainon's tongue, too, he finds himself drowning in the pleasure of Phainon's hand on him, in the quick snap of Phainon's wrist and the twisting of his hand until, at last, he breaks with a soft cry.

Phainon drinks down that cry, swallowing it with the press of his mouth as Mydei's hips stutter and lose their rhythm, as his cock throbs and pulses. He comes all over Phainon's hand, deliriously thinking that Phainon really will use his cum as lubricant, and that makes him come all the more, makes his cock twitch again in Phainon's hold. And Phainon doesn't stop stroking him. He eases the speed of his hand, but he keeps drawing his palm along Mydei's length, pulling every last drop of pleasure and cum from him, until Mydei twists and tries to escape.

"No," Phainon says, and that one words makes pleasure burn in Mydei's belly. "No, you wanted this."

He did. He does. He gasps as Phainon reaches around him with his cum-slick fingers, and he moans when Phainon presses one of those fingers against his hole. Phainon smears cum into Mydei's skin, and Mydei trembles with the force of his sudden need, with the intensity of it.

"You wanted me to fuck you." Mydei groans. "Touch me, Mydei."

Mydei yanks at Phainon's chiton, undoing the belt across his waist and casting it aside. He pulls the chiton from its fibula, pushing fabric out of his way to bear Phainon's body, and he's drunk on the sight of him. Pulling his hands down the length of Phainon's chest, his abdomen, Mydei wraps his fingers around Phainon's cock, thick and long and arching over his stomach. The dichotomy of him, soft and hard at the same time, has Mydei panting, has him moaning, has him pressing his face into the crook of Phainon's neck.

One of Phainon's fingers pushes into him, and Mydei bites back a sharp cry of pleasure. Outside the bedroom, he knows there are servants listening to them, and he doesn't want to share more of this intimacy than he has to. This is for him and no one else.

"Oil?" Phainon asks.

"Bedside table," Mydei gasps out, stroking over Phainon's cock, coaxing it impossibly harder, drunk on the knowledge that he'll have Phainon inside him soon enough.

Phainon leans to the side, and Mydei presses against him as a counterbalance. With his free hand, Phainon fishes the vial of oil out of a basket. Righting himself, he uncorks the vial and pours the liquid over his fingers. "You're sure?" he asks Mydei, mouthing at the hollow behind Mydei's jaw.

Something lurches in Mydei's chest. He should be the one worrying after Phainon's ability to turn him down but Phainon is making sure Mydei is comfortable, that Mydei wants this. The power structures between them make no sense; they crash together into a tangled mess that Mydei quite frankly doesn't want to undo. Not right now. And maybe that's a personal failing on his part, but he can't begin to care as he nods. "Inside me," he says, arching his back, squeezing Phainon's cock.

Groaning softly, Phainon rubs two fingers against Mydei's hole, testing his body. Mydei arches his back more, pressing his ass against those fingers, and he moans as they push ever so slightly into him. The stretching burn of penetration feels so damn good, is everything he wants right now. Phainon

pushes one finger deep, gliding it into Mydei's body, but it's not enough. Mydei wants *more*, wants Phainon's cock, and he shudders and groans again.

"Another," he demands, lifting one hand to wrap around the back of Phainon's neck. His fingers push into Phainon's hair, curling in the short strands.

"You deserve better," Phainon reminds him, easing his finger in and out and tugging at Mydei's rim with each languid thrust. "Let me be good to you."

Mydei shudders again. They shouldn't be coming together like this. It should be rough and angry—shouldn't it? Phainon should hate him, but Phainon's touch is easy, is worshipful, is reverent. He's slow and steady as he fingers Mydei open, tugging until it's easy to slide a second finger inside Mydei's body. Together, those fingers press deep, and they find that spot within Mydei that has him gasping, panting. He clings to Phainon, his hand on Phainon's cock slowing as he rocks backwards, fucking himself onto Phainon's fingers.

With each thrust, Phainon rubs his fingers over Mydei's prostate, and Mydei's spent cock twitches back to life, filling slowly.

"Phainon—"

"Easy," Phainon murmurs, squeezing Mydei's hip with his free hand. "Just like this. Ride my fingers for me until you're nice and soft and open." Mydei makes a strangled noise but obeys, continuing to grind himself onto Phainon's fingers. Two become three, and they press against Mydei's prostate until he's gasping, until he's swallowing back aching keens of need, of desire. Heat burns in his stomach, and his cock is hard and flushed and full once more. He rubs himself against Phainon, delirious with his wanting, desperate to feel even more. "So good," Phainon says, raking his teeth along Mydei's throat.

He withdraws his fingers from Mydei's ass, pouring more oil into his palm before slicking down his cock. Only then does he press his cock against Mydei's hole, and Mydei is so ready, is desperate. He exhales and shifts

back and down, letting the weight of the world pull him down onto Phainon's cock.

It's too good. Phainon is thick and broad, spreading him wide, splitting him open. His entry burns, but in the most delicious way, adding a sweet garnish of pain to the pleasure throbbing through Mydei's body in time with his heartbeat.

Phainon mutters an oath, his hands on Mydei's waist as he guides him lower still. "Mydei, Mydei," he breathes, brushing kisses along Mydei's jaw, and the sound of his name is better than any praise Mydei has ever received. "So *hot,* so *tight*." Phainon smooths one hand over Mydei's ass, rubbing the pad of one finger along Mydei's hole, stretched so tight around Phainon's cock, and that feels so good Mydei could cry. "Feels so *good*. You feel so good, Mydei."

His name on Phainon's lips does something wicked to Mydei; no one has ever used this nickname in bed with him. Even in his intimacies, Mydei has been Mydeimos, crown prince of Castrum Kremnos. But Phainon treats him like a man, calls his name the way a man does.

Panting, Mydei finally settles fully in Phainon's lap, his cock speared deep in Mydei's body. His hole clenches and squeezes, and he moans, so glad to be filled, so hungry for it and finally fulfilled. He is *alive*, this is *living*, and it's with Phainon, which is somehow better in ways Mydei doesn't want to examine. Not now.

Mydei drapes his arms across Phainon's shoulders and grinds himself in slow revolutions against Phainon's stomach, on Phainon's cock. The pull of that thick cock inside him is indescribably delicious, and he chases more of the sweet pleasure of it as he moves. Phainon keeps one hand on his waist; the other stays on his ass, that finger rubbing over Mydei's rim.

"Want you to come for me," Phainon pants, finding Mydei's lips at last. They watch each other through eyes glazed and heavy-lidded. "Want to feel you." He squeezes Mydei's waist.

Burying his fingers in Phainon’s hair, Mydei gets his legs under him so he has the leverage he needs. “Then fuck me,” he growls, eliciting a little laugh from Phainon; they both know that Phainon doesn’t have any leverage, that Mydei has to do all the work. And then Mydei moves, rising and falling on Phainon’s cock, delighting in the slide of Phainon’s length inside him, against his rim. When he lowers himself, the head of Phainon’s cock pushes against his prostate, and he swallows strangled moans of pleasure.

Phainon pants against his mouth, pressing the occasional, lingering kiss to Mydei’s lips as Mydei moves, as he fucks himself on Phainon’s cock. No one has the right to feel this good, to fill him so well, but Phainon is cast as though from Mydei’s body, fitting him so perfectly, carving deep and nudging his prostate with every roll of Mydei’s hips.

Mydei lets himself sink into the pleasure, lets himself drown in it. His head falls back, and Phainon leans forward to bite at Mydei’s throat, pressing open-mouthed kisses to his neck. Mydei works himself harder on Phainon’s cock, and Phainon purrs encouragement, filthy words of endearment and pleasure, until Mydei’s cock drips precum and is so hard he hurts. But Phainon doesn’t touch his cock, no, he keeps his hands where they are, wickedly teasing at even more penetration against Mydei’s hole.

“Touch me,” Mydei manages. “I’m close, I—touch me.”

“No,” Phainon says, sucking at the curve of Mydei’s neck. “You’ll come like this or not at all.”

Pleasure crashes like lighting through him, sharp and sweet. Mydei buries his face once more in Phainon’s neck, ignoring the bite of the slave torc against his cheek, grinding himself onto Phainon’s cock and into Phainon’s stomach until he’s gasping, until the ocean of pleasure consumes him, until he can’t even breathe. And then he comes undone, gasping Phainon’s name as he ruts into him, as he spills cum between them.

“That’s it,” Phainon croons. “That’s so good, Mydei.”

Mydei whines, clawing down Phainon's back as pleasure hammers through him. The ecstasy of his orgasm is so sweet, is so good, and it gets only better when Phainon shifts them, when Phainon sprawls backward, sets his feet on the bed, and fucks into Mydei with purpose.

Gasping, Mydei clings to Phainon. He's so sensitive, now, that every flex of Phainon's body against his spent cock is almost too much; the feeling of Phainon's cock inside him is too much. He's too full, and he needs to get away from it, but he needs Phainon to come in him more.

"Was it good for you?" Phainon asks, his lips against Mydei's ear. "Tell me, Mydei. Tell me if it was good for you."

Mydei moans, squeezing his ass tight around Phainon's cock. "It's good. Phainon, you feel so *good* inside me."

That's all Phainon needs. With a long, low groan, he drives deep and spills inside Mydei, a wash of liquid heat that makes Mydei's toes curl. Phainon's panting breaths fill Mydei's ear as he grinds into Mydei's ass, eking out every last drop of pleasure, and then he goes slack and boneless beneath Mydei.

Mydei makes a quiet, aching little noise as he comes back to himself, as he realizes all that motion has made his back burn with renewed pain. As he realizes what he's just done with a man who is his slave.

You deserve better than that.

Phainon would have told him no. Phainon had so many opportunities to say no, but he hadn't. Neither of them had. And Mydei wonders if they both needed this, needed the facsimile of human connection, the pleasure of intimacy.

Phainon presses soft, chaste kisses to Mydei's shoulder, and Mydei groans. Phainon stills. "Your back," he says.

"A small price to pay." Mydei pushes himself up. Phainon's cock is soft and sliding out of him, and cum spills sticky and unpleasant on Mydei's thighs

and ass. Mydei smothers a grimace. He doesn't know how to behave. Doesn't know what to say. "We should clean up."

Phainon's thumbs rub small circles against Mydei's hipbones before a subtle pressure urges Mydei up and off his lap. "I'll get more poppy milk for you."

"No," Mydei says sharply. And then, softer: "No. No more of that. I am well enough, now, that I don't need more."

Phainon gives him a disbelieving look as Mydei climbs off him. More cum drips down Mydei's thighs, and this time he does grimace. "Your back is bleeding," Phainon says, swinging his legs over the bed. He rises, brushing his fingers down Mydei's side, a surprisingly tender caress. "We'll wash up and change your bandages."

Mydei studies him for a long moment, wondering if this, too, was a mistake. Wondering if he's allowed Phainon too close. "As you say," he says, and he strides into the bathroom, Phainon trailing behind.

Mydei sleeps most of the next few days, which is a relief to Phainon in some ways. He doesn't have to justify any of his behavior, nor any of what he said when they were together. The silence, however, gives him too much time to think about it, and he replays their intimacies over and over, not just for his own pleasure—which is surely wrong of him—but to recall how soft he was with his enemy. But this must surely be good. When Mydei wakes, he regards Phainon with softer eyes. Maybe Phainon hasn't completely fucked up by getting caught. Maybe fucking Mydei has earned him more affection.

He drags his hands through his hair. He'd claimed love motivated Mydei to protect him, and now he wonders if there is some deeper affection between them—on Mydei's side. The prince might not be what Phainon expected, but he's not a man deserving of Phainon's love. He's not.

On the fifth day after their indiscretion, Mydei is finally well enough to spend most of the day awake. He moves carefully, mindful of his still-

healing back, and Phainon hovers at his side, mindful of the remaining damage. Mydei takes lunch with his friends, and none of them talk about what happened or even acknowledge Phainon's presence, not even Hephaestion, but their loathing is thick in the air. They regard him with thinly veiled disdain when they regard him at all, and Phainon doesn't know what to do with so much hatred. No one's ever looked at him like this.

When they leave at last, Mydei beckons Phainon to his side. "Eat," he says, offering Phainon a grape from his fingers. Phainon accepts it, licking at Mydei's fingertips. Heat burns in Mydei's eyes. "We have much to discuss," Mydei says.

Phainon has no interest in those conversations, so he eases into Mydei's lap, sucking Mydei's fingers deeper between his lips. Mydei's own lips part on a silent gasp. "Phainon," he says, and Phainon releases Mydei's fingers to take his mouth in a long, lingering kiss, tipping his head back to slip his tongue inside.

Disgust curls in his belly alongside kindling heat. His cock fills, and he hates himself for resorting to this, to reaching between his and Mydei's bodies to take their cocks in his hand and grind them together until Mydei is panting and groaning. It's effective, though. When Mydei comes back to himself, Phainon between his legs, licking the cum off his stomach, and there isn't a thought left in his head.

"Phainon, I require your honesty," Mydei says two afternoons later as they sit beneath the strawberry trees.

"Then let me be honest," Phainon replies, and he crawls once more between Mydei's legs to take his cock into his mouth. He sucks Mydei until Mydei falls back into the soft grass, until his legs splay wide and urgent whines spill from his lips, until he comes down Phainon's throat with an exultant cry. He's beautiful in his pleasure, and Phainon wants to give him more of it even as he hates himself.

His respect for himself has disappeared. Back in Okhema, when they'd hatched this plan, several of the generals had called him Aglaea's whore,

and he'd sworn he wouldn't resort to this. But here he is, between Mydei's legs, using sex to distract Mydei from their inevitable conversations.

Mydei is too smart not to realize what he's doing. Phainon knows he's not going to get away with this forever, that he'll have to answer Mydei's questions soon enough, but when Mydei sits on the edge of his bed the next night, watching him, Phainon doesn't want to answer those questions. Mydei must not really want to ask them, because he lets Phainon bear him to the bed, lets Phainon ease between his legs and grind against him. Mydei lets Phainon take his face in his hands and kiss him slowly, deeply.

Fuck, but being with Mydei is too good. Beneath him, Mydei arches and gasps, the veneer of the cold and disdainful crown prince falling away in the face of a passionate and demanding lover. They're so good together, too, each of them anticipating what the other wants. Tonight, Mydei rolls Phainon to his back. With hungry, demanding kisses, he pins Phainon to the bed as he strips out of his chiton and removes Phainon's, too. His hands linger as he pets down Phainon's body, as he leans over him to wrap his mouth around Phainon's cock.

Fisting his hand in Mydei's hair, Phainon groans. He rolls his hips in shallow thrusts, pushing his cock deeper, deeper, until Mydei sputters and gasps. Mydei, he's learned, isn't particularly good at giving pleasure, but there's something charming in the way he tries to reciprocate, in the way he wants to learn. Phainon assumes Mydei has been the object of so much sexual attention all these years that he hasn't had to teach himself any of this, but he tries for Phainon.

"Mydei," he breathes, eliciting a broken moan from Mydei as he sucks Phainon deep once more. The wet heat of his mouth is too much, is too good, and Phainon fights not to come; that's not his plan for this night. "Ah —that's—that's so—" He strains beneath Mydei's mouth, as Mydei's tongue flicks over the tip of his cock, lapping up precum.

Mydei drags his lips down Phainon's length. "Do not think you can distract me like this," Mydei says, panting heavily. He sucks at the base of Phainon's cock, and Phainon's hips jerk off the bed. "There's still much we have to discuss."

And Phainon wants to discuss none of it. He catches Mydei by the jaw, pulls him up the bed, and kisses him savagely, hungrily, with such domineering force that Mydei sinks to the bed beneath him. Mydei claws at his back as they grind against each other, Phainon rocking their cocks together until Mydei comes for him. But it's not enough. He uses Mydei's cum in place of oil, fucking two fingers into Mydei's hole to push against his prostate, to stroke over it until Mydei is hard again.

"Phainon," he gasps, and there's nothing better than the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos begging to be allowed to come again, there's nothing better than his name on Mydei's lips. It's too good, and Phainon fights his own mounting desire as he gets Mydei off a second time.

With oil slicking his cock, he fucks into Mydei's ass from behind. Flexing his hips, driving his cock against Mydei's prostate, he makes Mydei come again, again. His hand pulls down Mydei's oversensitive cock, and the prince, overstimulated, tries to claw away from him. Phainon doesn't allow it, fucking him harder, faster, making him come yet again. Only when Mydei pleads for relief—and how strange to have the prince of Castrum Kremnos beg for mercy—does Phainon finally come inside him.

He wipes himself and Mydei down, cleaning them both up as Mydei drifts to sleep.

Phainon rakes a hand through his hair, glancing at the courtyard. Anxiety churns in his belly, but he has no recourse. He's weeks late already.

Sliding into his chiton, he fastens it at his shoulder and leaves his belt behind. He carries his sandals to the grass of the gardens, slipping them on only once he's cleared the stones. Making no noise, he finds one of the tallest of the strawberry trees, its boughs weighing heavy over the wall. He hauls himself into the tree, grabbing branches to pull himself higher, higher. He reaches for the wall to pull himself over it.

A hand closes around his ankle.

Phainon whips around.

Mydeimos stands there, holding him in an iron grip, a snarl on his face. “What the fuck are you doing, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae?”

Chapter End Notes

> the tldr of this chapter phainon has a single brain cell and he never engages it ~~or does he, i ask, tapping the unreliable narrator tag~~
>
> as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Fury doesn't come easy to Mydei. He doesn't lose his temper quickly, doesn't lash out the way his father does. He refuses to be like Eurypon, tamping down on his anger until he has no choice but to utilize it as a blade against his enemies. He wields it now as he drags Phainon out of the tree, heedless of the damage he does to Phainon's skin.

Phainon falls out of the tree with a quiet shout, and Mydei yanks him to his feet, shaking him by the shoulders. "This is how you repay me?" Mydei demands. "I take fifty lashes for you, and you try to escape *again*?"

Phainon finally reacts, knocking Mydei's hands away, but Mydei is ready for this. He's seen Phainon move once already, knows he's a warrior trained, and so he anticipates Phainon's actions. He grabs Phainon by the wrists as Phainon hisses at him, both of them trying to keep quiet—though why he doesn't wake the whole fucking palace, Mydei doesn't know. Betrayal cuts so deep, deeper than the bite of the scourge's tassels.

"It's not—"

"Don't you dare try to defend yourself," Mydei snarls. Phainon, for all his dreams of being a warrior, was a farm boy first. While he tilled the fields and played at swordsmanship, Mydei received training from the best teachers in the empire. It is no great struggle to get Phainon's arms behind him, held in Mydei's unrelenting grip. He shoves Phainon forward, steering him back into the bedroom.

Servants cluster in the doorway, staring, as Mydei shoves Phainon inside. "Out," Mydei says, and when they don't respond immediately, he shouts the command. "All of you, *out*." He drags Phainon after him, all but chasing his servants out of his suite, and he bolts the main door behind them. They've fled to their own quarters, but this should buy him a minute of peace.

Not that Phainon is peaceable. No, Phainon struggles wildly in his hold, attempting to break it, but Mydei has years of training on Phainon and is more equipped to deal with a squirming fool. He shoves Phainon back into the bedroom, tossing him onto the bed.

Phainon scrambles across it, a wild look on his face. “Mydei—”

The nickname is a brutal strike. “Do not call me that.” Mydei stalks toward the foot of the bed, trying to climb on top of his fury, his betrayal. “Fifty strikes, Phainon. I *died* for you on that sand, and this is how you repay me?”

“I can explain.”

“Can you?” Mydei demands. “Do you truly think you can justify this? That I could—that I would—protect you a second time for the same stupid, asinine behavior? If you need to meet my mother or even one of her agents —”

“It’s not your mother!” Phainon exclaims.

Mydei throws himself onto the bed, onto Phainon, slapping his hand over Phainon’s mouth. He bears down on Phainon, pinning him beneath his own weight. “If you are going to give up your secrets, don’t be so loud about them,” he hisses. “Even with my servants gone, the walls have ears.” He presses his hand harder to Phainon’s mouth, ignoring the way Phainon struggles and flails beneath him. “You will tell me what you mean. You owe this to me. Fifty lashes, Phainon. You owe me the truth.”

Phainon abruptly goes slack beneath Mydei, his eyes closing. Mydei doesn’t relent, doesn’t let Phainon up. He does, however, remove his hand from Phainon’s mouth.

“Explain,” Mydei says, “or I will turn you over to Periander myself.”

Phainon tries to free his arms from beneath Mydei’s knees, but Mydei doesn’t give him an inch. Warm hands curve over Mydei’s legs, and Mydei sneers.

“Do you think to distract me with your touch this time?”

“No,” Phainon says, defeated. He opens his eyes, and they are resigned. “It’s not entirely your mother. It’s Aglaea.”

Mydei stares at him, dumbfounded, but only for a moment. So much suddenly becomes clear to him. “Your Aglaea is working with my mother. This is why she made you my bed slave. The men who captured you didn’t know who you are, but my mother knew you were Aglaea’s agent.”

Phainon looks away, and Mydei knows he’s right.

A sneer pulls across Mydei’s lips again. “Do you think yourself some savior?” he demands. “Some deliverer for all of Okhema and the rest of Amphoreus?”

Phainon’s face snaps back to Mydei’s, and he bares his teeth in a snarl. “Someone has to stop your father. He’s a monster, and you know that, Mydei.”

The nickname breaks his heart. “Don’t call me that.”

“You know that,” Phainon says again, ignoring him. “You’ve all but said it yourself! Someone has to do *something* to put a stop to Eurypon’s advance. We aren’t winning. Every time we meet your father in combat, he pushes us back further. So, yes, I thought I could deliver—” He spits the word. “—my people from your father and—well. Aglaea sent me into the woods to be captured, and your mother picked me for this purpose specifically.”

Mydei reels back, sitting on Phainon’s hips, pressing a hand to his forehead. His mother. His mother has orchestrated all of this. His mother is acting against Eurypon in the shadows, and now he knows, unequivocally, and he realizes he stands at a crossroads. She has maneuvered him into this choice with masterful strokes, pushing him to this place without him even realizing it. He has never felt as though he could act against Eurypon, too afraid of the tortures his father could visit on him. But now, with Phainon, with a man connected to the Goldweaver herself…

“Will you turn me into him?” Phainon demands. “You who claim to be so tired of death? Will you—”

“Shut up,” Mydei says, hanging his head between his shoulders. He grabs the pillow to either side of Phainon’s head, trying to breathe, trying to ground himself. He is at a crossroads, yes, but there is only one choice. There has only ever been one choice, but he’s been standing here for so long, so capable of making the choice but unable to commit to it.

He is so tired of death. He is so tired. But not so tired that he cannot act.

Lifting his head, Mydei meets Phainon’s gaze. “You want to save the world, Deliverer?” Mydei asks, weary. “Then I will help you.”

Phainon jerks beneath Mydei, his ire transforming into the surprise of a man who has never had anyone’s support. “What?”

“I will help you,” Mydei says again.

“Why?”

Mydei laughs, mirthless. “I protect you from my somatophylakes, I tell you my feelings about the empire, I allow myself to be whipped in your place, and you ask me why?”

“You didn’t have to do any of that.”

“No, but I did,” Mydei says. He sits back, shifting his knees off Phainon’s shoulders. He lowers his voice. “I will admit to you that I am… I am very afraid of my father.”

Phainon’s fingers tighten on Mydei’s calves. “He can’t kill you,” Phainon reminds him, softly, gently.

“No, but he can hurt me. And he can hurt the people I care about.” Mydei exhales heavily. “He has already hurt my mother, and he wouldn’t hesitate to hurt…” He trails off, looking away from Phainon, gazing over the dark courtyard beyond his room. “He wouldn’t hesitate to hurt anyone else. Nor would he hesitate to chain me at the bottom of another lake for the rest of

my life.” His lips twist in a wry smile. “No blade nor poison, but I age. Perhaps Thanatos will find me in my old age, after I’ve drowned hundreds of thousands of times.” He shakes his head. “I’m afraid of my father, Phainon, but I will help you.”

Phainon pulls his tongue across his lips and says nothing. Good. Mydei could not bear to reveal more of himself right now. This is enough.

With a heavy sigh of his own, Phainon rubs his thumbs against Mydei’s calves, soothing strokes. “I’ve been trying to reach a contact in the city,” he admits. “I haven’t been able to establish any communication yet. I’d hoped to sneak out. Obviously.” He snorts. “That didn’t work for me.”

“Either time,” Mydei agrees, and Phainon has the grace to look chagrined. “Where in the city to you need to go?”

“The agora. My contact is a merchant in the agora. I don’t want to reveal much else. You understand.”

Mydei nods. “The less I know, the less someone can torture out of me if we are discovered.”

With a grimace, Phainon says, “Yeah. That.” Though Mydei thinks there’s more to it. Phainon’s trust is not easily won. Clearly.

Mydei studies him in the darkness, the world-weary wariness to him, the haunted look of a man who has seen too much, and considers their options. Neither of them are prisoners in the palace—technically—though it often feels that way. “We will go to the agora then,” Mydei declares, and he slides off Phainon’s hips.

Letting him go, Phainon levers himself up. “Are you—you’re serious? That easily?”

“That easily,” Mydei says with a shrug. “I wish to go shopping, and it’s only right for you to accompany me. We will have to go with my full somatophylakes, so you will need to be careful.” He pauses. “And smart,” he adds, meaningfully.

Phainon bristles. “I—”

“Have not been smart about this,” Mydei says. “Twice, you have tried. Twice, you have been caught. Which increases the danger.” And he does wonder why Phainon is so cavalier with his own life—and the lives of others. Phainon isn’t the kind of man who would think so little of life, Mydei is sure of that. Phainon saved him in the Grove. He can’t make sense of the inconsistencies. Not yet.

“My contact won’t meet me if you’re there. If the whole group of you is there.”

Mydei shrugs again. “This is the best I can do for you.”

“If your somatophylakes realize…”

“Then we should make sure the risk to you is worth it.” Mydei has no idea what information Phainon already has, but it certainly won’t be enough to justify all the time he’s missed connecting with this contact. “And you will endeavor not to be so Titans-damn stupid.”

Phainon splutters. “I haven’t been stupid!”

“No, it wasn’t your stupidity that got my skin stripped from my back,” Mydei replies dryly. It might be a low strike, a dirty one, but it makes his point.

The horror and regret in Phainon’s eyes speaks volumes. “Fine,” he says, looking away, at least a little ashamed. “A little stupid.”

“Profoundly.”

Phainon’s eyes narrow.

Mydei smiles faintly. “Now, let us make a mess of my room and half the rest of the suite so my servants believe we were particularly passionate tonight.”

“And they say Kremnoans can’t be sneaky and duplicitous,” Phainon says, venturing a tentative laugh, a hopeful expression on his face.

Mydei lifts a brow, reaching behind Phainon’s head. He pulls Phainon close. “There will be no sneaking about this,” he says, sealing his mouth to Phainon’s.

“The Okhemans are reinforcing their lines along the Acheron,” Themistocles says, pushing pieces across the war map. “They are gathering additional forces here, here, and here, shoring up their defenses. Breaking them here will send them back to the Holy City itself.” He leans back, crossing his arms. “And they know it. This is the last place they can stand against us before we turn to siege warfare.”

Mydei watches his father from the opposite end of the war table, studying Eurypon’s fixed expression. He is calmer today, his father, intent on the map before him. These days of terrifying clarity are worse than the others, when Eurypon is paranoid and barely lucid. Days like these, Eurypon condemns men to die in strokes of tactical brilliance.

“Then we must meet them,” Eurypon says. “This will be our most decisive battle yet.”

“If he wishes for decisiveness,” Hephaestion murmurs, “then he should deploy you.”

Mydei hisses, turning his face toward Hephaestion but keeping his eyes on his father and the map. “And make me Castrum Kremnos’s hero? No, he would never.”

“He—”

“Be silent,” Mydei says, ignoring the way Hephaestion stiffens and shifts his weight to lean away. Let Hephaestion be angry; it is his default state of late, and Mydei finds Hephaestion’s anger more tolerable than his affection.

At the head of the table, Eurypon is speaking again. “They are afraid,” he says, and here he falls prey to his own propaganda. “They know if we push them back to the city, they will break.”

That isn’t true, but Mydei bites his tongue. Siege warfare is the worst kind.

“We won’t even need to take it,” Eurypon continues, a wild glint in his eyes. “Not if we break them at the Acheron.” He laughs. “Yes, Themistocles, do you see? If we shatter their forces at the Acheron, if only their citizens await in the Goldweaver’s city, then we shall have them.” A manic smile stretches across Eurypon’s face. “We have already won.” He spins out the fantasy in real time, and it is an uncomfortable thing to witness his delusional madness. “We have destroyed them, crushed them already. They are broken.”

A murmur of assent goes up from the generals—but not, Mydei notices, from Themistocles. The generals offer their congratulations to Eurypon, and Eurypon basks in their adoration.

Mydei leans forward, resting his fingertips on the table. “If Okhema is broken,” Mydei says, “then we need not deploy any forces at all.”

The room goes silent. The generals look everywhere but at him. Themistocles meets his eyes and gives a minute shake of his head.

And Eurypon, his smile suddenly fragile, turns his face slowly toward Mydei. “I cannot have heard my son correctly,” he says, low and dangerous.

Mydei considers the map in front of him. With the knowledge that Eurypon will deploy forces to the Acheron with the intent to break Okhema—for that is the heart of this discussion, no matter what Eurypon believes now—he has enough to give to Phainon to pass on to his contact. But it’s not enough, not for him. Not anymore, now that he’s turned from the crossroads and started down his own path to either decades of torture or, perhaps, salvation.

“If Okhema is already broken, then why deploy your forces at all?” Mydei asks. “Are they not better spent tilling the fields? Our people are starving. The black tide licks at our borders.”

Beside him, Hephaestion sucks in a sharp breath. Softly, he says Mydei's name in warning.

Mydei ignores him. "Perhaps the king should consider building the empire up, if his enemies have been so soundly defeated already," he says.

"Unfilial," one of the generals says abruptly, his lips curling with disdain. "Unfilial and treasonous." There's a round of affirmations. Themistocles remains silent.

"Is it unfilial and treasonous to inform the king that Castrum Kremnos stands on the brink of starvation?" Mydei asks, his gaze fixed on his father.

Eurypon's expression is unmoving, a rictus grin.

"All the wealth we've stripped from Okhema in the face of their endless retreats, from the city states we've conquered, it's all gone back into our war machine," Mydei continues. "Our farmlands either lie fallow or consumed by the black tide, and we have taken much of Okhema's farmland, too."

"Then let them starve when we lay siege to them," a second general declares, glancing nervously at Eurypon.

Mydei's expression is tight. "Then we will starve, too. We cannot afford a lengthy siege of the Holy City."

"So we will break them on the banks of the Acheron," says the first general, gesturing broadly to the table.

"I thought we did not need to do that," Mydei says softly. "Winter will come down from the north soon enough, and it will end not just Okhema, but us, too, if we stretch ourselves as thin as this campaign."

It happens in an instant, before Mydei can react. One moment, he's leaning over the table. The next, his father has him against the wall, impacting it so hard all the breath knocks out of him, a blade at his throat. Red crystal bursts from Eurypon's arms, his face, forming a glittering chrysalis of

armor. “Betrayal,” Eurypon snarls, pressing the blade hard enough to Mydei’s throat that skin parts and golden blood drips down his skin. “My own son, turning against me and the empire he stands to inherit!”

Mydei has no doubts that he will never inherit Eurypon’s empire. The Titanblessed live until they are killed. Mydei is a comfort to the people but doesn’t factor into Eurypon’s reign. He never has. “I do not want our empire to fall, Father,” he says, his throat scraping against Eurypon’s blade with each word.

“You would have me pull back,” Eurypon hisses. “You would have Okhema walk all over us, destroy us, strip us of our very way of life. They are vermin, demanding everyone bow to their laws, their whims, their rules.”

The irony is not lost on Mydei. “They do not deserve to live,” Mydei agrees, placating. “But will you sacrifice your empire for their decline?”

Eurypon reels away from him. “I am the chosen child of Strife,” he snarls, whipping his blade through the air to fling Mydei’s blood off it. He smears it against his hip, wiping what remains of golden blood on his chiton, on the heavy fall of his robes. “I will have the entire continent, the entire world, as is my *right*, and you would tell me to stand down! To let the Okhemans take back what is rightfully ours!” He brandishes his blade at Mydei once more, and then spins about, pointing his sword at his generals. “And there are those among you who agree with him.” The words emerge a hiss.

The generals react as one mass, protesting in increasingly hysterical tones.

Themistocles alone remains silent, his lips pressed together in a fine line. And yet Eurypon is clear minded enough not to round on Themistocles. No, he grabs one of the generals near the end of the table by the arm, the glittering red crystals extending from Eurypon’s shoulder to his wrist. The general stares at them with utter terror in his eyes.

“You have always held my son in high regard, Stasanor,” Eurypon says, far too calm.

Heart pounding, Mydei peels himself away from the wall. “Father,” he begins. This cannot be allowed to go on.

“Do you, perhaps, agree with him now?” Eurypon asks.

Stasanor, his eyes fixed on the crystals sprouting from the back of Eurypon’s hand, shakes his head. “No, my king. I am with you! I believe we must crush the Okhemans completely. I believe—”

“You do not think they are already broken?” Eurypon demands.

“No!” Stasanor’s eyes are so wide there’s white all around his irises. “I mean—that is—I believe my king when he says—”

Eurypon snarls, animalistic, a virulent red energy wafting from his body.

“Father,” Mydei says again, urgently, reaching for Eurypon’s shoulder. “Father, Stasanor is—”

Strasanor is a shower of blood. The crystals move too quickly to be seen, exploding out of him, tearing him apart, popping him like an overfilled waterskin. Mydei turns away, closing his eyes against the gruesome sight. He has wondered many times if Eurypon’s crystals could truly end him, and there is a part of him terrified to find out. But he should have done more to prevent Strasanor’s death. The old general didn’t deserve it; he held no great regard for Mydei, no matter what Eurypon said.

“This,” Eurypon says, his voice shaking with fury. “This will be *you*.”

Mydei opens his eyes and turns to face his blood-spattered father, aghast. He did this. Pressing Eurypon killed a man who didn’t deserve it. Not like this. Strasanor’s actions have killed so many people, but he didn’t deserve to go like that, torn to pieces by crystal. “Father,” he says, imploring.

“I will do this to you, you insolent child, if you think you can turn my men against me.”

He holds up both hands, tense to keep from shaking. “I don’t,” he says. “I won’t.”

“I should have thrown you back into the Sea of Souls after that whore you call a mother saved you from it,” Eurypon snarls. “I have fed you, clothed you, taught you, raised you—” He has done none of those things, except, perhaps, for allowing them to happen. “—and this is how you repay me!” He lunges for Mydei, and Mydei, keenly aware of the crystals pulsating on Eurypon’s hand, ducks away, his hands still upraised. “If you are so ready to end this war,” Eurypon continues, “you can do so. It will be *you* on the frontline in ten days’ time.”

Cold dread grips Mydei’s spine, but he immediately drops to his knees. “Yes,” he says, acquiescing and hoping this will defuse his father. “As my king commands.”

A scalding hot hand descends on his shoulder, but when he glances at it, he is relieved beyond measure to find only human flesh there. Burning flesh, flesh that makes Mydei’s own scream with pain, but a human hand nonetheless. “That is the son I raised. Obedient.”

There must be more to this. Even in his madness, Eurypon wouldn’t put Mydei in a position to help him win the war. Eurypon must be the hero that Castrum Kremnos wants, Eurypon demands the adulation, the adoration. Now, it will fall to Mydei, if he is successful.

Perhaps Eurypon knows something Mydei does not, something that will see him fail.

Eurypon turns his hand, patting his scorching hot palm against Mydei’s cheek. He pulls away, tottering back to his kline, and he sinks into it. “Wine,” he says.

Wasting no time, Mydei rocks to his feet. He bows to his distracted father and turns, all but fleeing the war room.

Hephaestion is on his heels. “What was that?” he demands as the doors close behind them.

Mydei presses thumb and forefinger to his eyes, digging deep, trying to ignore the unimaginable pain from his burned shoulder.

“Why did you provoke him like that?”

Weary, Mydei drops his hand. He doesn’t even care that there are guards behind them that might overhear this conversation. “I have been thinking about things differently, lately,” he admits, extending an olive branch to Hephaestion and hoping Hephaestion will take it in the way it’s meant.

Hephaestion steps in front of him, taking him by the arms, only then noticing the burn across his shoulder. But that doesn’t stop him from saying, “This is your bed slave’s doing. He is Okheman, we all know it. He—”

“He isn’t to blame,” Mydei says, gently brushing aside Hephaestion’s hands.

Hephaestion hisses. “He said you love him.”

Mydei stills and then slumps just the slightest bit. Of course this is about Hephaestion’s jealousy, his desire to still be in Mydei’s bed, his anger that he isn’t. He doesn’t understand—has struggled to understand—that Mydei never loved him the same way. Could never give him what he wanted. But there’s a profound sadness in Hephaestion’s face that softens Mydei. He is afraid, Mydei thinks, that he’ll be replaced. Even by a slave.

“You’re the one who ended our relationship,” Mydei reminds him. “So, don’t use Phainon as a weapon against me now.”

Hephaestion reels back. “If you could only try,” he says, his expression breaking. “If you would give me another opportunity to prove to you my ardor.”

“It was never you, Hephaestion,” Mydei says, still so very weary. “Please. Leave me in peace. I have much to think about.”

“Will there ever be enough room in your life for me?” Hephaestion asks.

Mydei gives him a sad smile and pulls away, leaving Hephaestion in the hall.

“Your shoulder,” Phainon says. “What the fuck happened to your shoulder?” Mydei sags in the doorway to his bedroom as Phainon lurches out of the bed. “How did this happen?”

“My father,” Mydei says, half collapsing against Phainon.

Phainon catches him, holding him, wrestling with the sudden fury that courses through him. His hatred for Eurypon is an old, comfortable thing, but it burns brighter, now. Eurypon took his family from him, yes, but those wounds are old and scarred. Eurypon abusing Mydei is—is fresh and strange, and Phainon doesn’t like it. “How? Did he pour hot oil on you? Why does that look like a hand?”

“Strife’s fury is a physical thing,” Mydei says. He rests his cheek on Phainon’s shoulder, and Phainon gently touches one hand to Mydei’s back; it is healed, now, no sign of injury, not even the smallest of scars. “It burns.”

“Why was he mad at you?” Phainon asks, bewildered. “You were just—” He drops his voice, bending his lips to Mydei’s ear, a lover’s caress. “You weren’t going to antagonize him.”

“Oops.”

Phainon slides one hand into Mydei’s hair, holding him, his other hand stroking up and down his back, a bed slave comforting his master. Except it’s not as much an act as he’d like it to be; comforting Mydei is easy when Mydei took a risk to learn information for Phainon’s sake. “That wasn’t what we planned.”

“It was right,” Mydei replies, tipping his head back to brush his mouth along the curve of Phainon’s jaw. “He means to attack at the Acheron.”

Phainon grits his teeth. “Alright.”

“And he means to use me as his blade.”

Phainon jolts, swallowing back a strangely instinctive denial. “You? Why would he risk making a hero out of you?”

Mydei grimaces. “A question to which I, too, would like answers.” He exhales heavily. “We have ten days, Phainon. Is that enough time?”

Phainon’s stomach drops. He swallows hard. “Yes.” For his contact, that is plenty of time.

Chapter End Notes

> yall are very adament that phainon is very stupid, and while he is perhaps not acting rationally from an outside pov... /taps the unreliable narrator tag/ he is downplaying, avoiding, and omitting stuff from his narration by design. most of you will probably figure out why in a few more chapters
>
> in other news, as i was writing ch11, ptolemy asked a very important question which literally unraveled the back half of this fic. i've finally figured it out, gotten it under control, and we're now looking at probably 20 chapters plus an epilogue. for whatever reason, i've been playing really fast and loose with chaptering for this fic (by which i mean i keep changing where chapter breaks fall and adding content), so it's entirely possible that we may gain another chapter at some point ¯_(ツ)_/¯ i suppose that's a good thing tho. regardless, the outline is fixed and the story fully plotted
>
> as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon breathes in the air of the agora and realizes it's not all that different from the air in the palace. It's fragrant with spices and human bodies, but the palace smells like that, too: smells like oregano and basil, though the palace also has the sweet-smelling strawberry and olive trees. He'd expected the agora to feel like freedom, to taste like it. It doesn't. Maybe that's because Mydei's somatophylakes have fallen in around them, a barrier between him and Mydei and the rest of the world. It seems silly, the way they protect Mydei, but appearances go a long way, he supposes. Can't have the crown prince running amok in the city unguarded and looking vulnerable.

The agora itself disquiets him, too much like Okhema's own agora to provide much comfort. Vendors hawk their wares, aggressively shoving goods at the men surrounding him and Mydei. Children run underfoot, their fingers wily and clever, and Phainon isn't surprised when Peucesta catches one trying to take his coin purse. He's not surprised, either, when Peucesta lets the child go with enough coin to buy food; Mydei's friends don't like him, but they don't seem like bad people. Bright colors slash across dull limestone walls, strips of fabric for decoration and sale, and Leonnius wraps himself in one of these lengths of fabric, wearing it as a skirt, while the others laugh at him.

Even the smithies, laboring to create weapons for Castrum Kremnos's war machine, are familiar to him. Many are closed, their owners behind the frontline, but the ones that are open serve up blades for cooking and for farming. It all feels too normal, too much like home. He wants to hate the agora, but he can't. The people here are innocent of Eurypon's decisions, caught up in a mad king's paranoias and fantasies.

“Phylo’s!” Leonnius calls, disentangling himself from the slash of bright red fabric. He bullies the group of them across the thoroughfare, to a restaurant with seating around the front of it. “Ho, Phylo!”

Even Hephaestion, usually so surly, is smiling, and he claps a hand to Leonnius’s shoulder, leaning over his back and into the restaurant to speak with the proprietor. “How goes it, friend?”

They know people here. They are friendly with people here. They, too, Phainon hates to admit, are people trapped in Eurypon’s schemes. So many of them must obey Eurypon out of the same fear Mydei possesses.

“Wine skins,” Mydei says, slapping Leonnius and Hephaestion on the back. He doesn’t try to push forward, staying behind them as the other three form a barrier at his sides and back, Phainon close to his flank.

Ptolemy makes a disdainful little noise, and Perdikkas says, “We shouldn’t while we’re at our work.”

“What work?” Mydei asks, laughing. He gives Perdikkas and Ptolemy both light shoves, dislodging them from their formation. “You all know I’m more than capable of protecting myself. Let’s enjoy ourselves. A bit of drink won’t see me dead, and even if it did, what harm is that?”

“You are too glib,” Ptolemy says, sighing heavily. “Your mother would see us destroyed if you died on our watch.”

Phainon startles at that, surprised Gorgo would respond so viciously to Mydei’s meaningless deaths, but he supposes he has his protections from Gorgo’s wrath.

“Never mind my mother,” Mydei says, reaching between Leonnius and Hephaestion to take a wine skin in hand. “Enjoy.” He presses the skin on Ptolemy, who glares half-heartedly but takes a sip regardless.

How curious, then, that Mydei passes wine to everyone and saves none for himself.

“Is my prince not thirsty?” Phainon asks, lowering his voice and arching his brow.

Mydei smiles at him, a rakish grin that has his heart stuttering in his chest. “Not for wine,” he says, and Phainon’s heart hammers at the warmth in Mydei’s voice, in his eyes. This is a game, surely. They have to look like a besotted master and slave in public.

“He blushes!” Leonnius crows, pointing at Phainon with both hands before taking a swig of his own wine skin. “Behold!”

Phainon scowls, but Mydei—and his friends, even Hephaestion—laughs.

“Not used to being teased?” Perdikkas asks from Phainon’s side.

“Is that what this is?” Phainon returns dryly. “Teasing?”

“From Leonnius, certainly.”

Scoffing, Phainon crosses his arms, acutely aware of the torc tight around his throat. “I can’t imagine why. Unless it’s because I’m an easy target.”

“Harder, if only for our prince’s affection, I would think,” Perdikkas says.

Phainon doesn’t know what to do with that, so he falls silent as his eyes catch on a vendor’s table. The other somatophylakes close around Mydei as Phainon pulls away, attended by Perdikkas, and he makes a great show of examining the jewelry on display. Thick cuffs and heavy bracelets for men, delicate necklaces dripping with gemstones for women. He lets his fingers wander over several different pieces before holding one up, turning it into the sunlight so he can look past it and study the other vendors.

“Can you afford that?” Perdikkas asks, but with a grin so charming that Phainon can’t be offended.

Phainon focuses on him instead of the cuff in his hand. Dry as the desert, he replies, “I thought His Highness’s assets were my own.”

“Specific assets, maybe.”

Phainon sputters.

Laughing heartily, Perdikkas plucks the cuff from Phainon's hand. "Mydei has plenty of pretty baubles. If you want to get him a gift, that's not the way to go."

Heat burns across Phainon's cheeks. "I—"

To his increased shock, Perdikkas throws his arm around Phainon's shoulder—impressive, since Phainon has several inches on him, which forces Phainon to duck down—and drags him away from the jewelry. "No, no. If you want to get him something, you should go with food."

"Food," Phainon says, scanning the vendors as if looking for a snack.

There, four tables down, is his contact. She wears a black and blue chiton edged with gold with a linen cloth draped over her hair, but Cipher's features are obvious to him. Her eyes meet his and then slide past him with feigned disinterest. He still catches the flicker of relief on her face.

He's so long past his deadline to meet her. It's a small miracle she's still here.

"Food," Perdikkas is saying, "is the clear way to our prince's heart."

"Is it?" Phainon asks.

"Mydei loves food," Perdikkas says, with the confidence of someone who has known Mydei for a very long time—and it occurs to Phainon that he doesn't know Mydei well at all. Perhaps he knows the critical facets of Mydei's character, but he knows nothing of Mydei's likes and dislikes, his preferences, his beliefs. They are new allies, but Phainon imagines only until they accomplish whatever Mydei believes their shared goal to be. Phainon hasn't been forthright.

This isn't just about turning Castrum Kremnos's war machine aside. If it was, he might have convinced Aglaea to send someone else to Gorgo. No, only a Chrysos Heir can accomplish Aglaea's goals. But surely Mydei

realizes that. Surely Mydei must have guessed that if Aglaea sent another Chrysos Heir, she means to strike at Eurypon himself.

“When we’re on campaigns, we leave the cooking to him,” Perdikkas is saying, dragging Phainon down the street. They stop in front of Cipher’s table, heavy laden as it is with fruits and candies.

“To the prince?” Phainon asks, stunned.

Perdikkas nods. “He loves to cook.”

The Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos loves to cook, loves to feed his friends. But that doesn’t surprise Phainon as much as he expects. Maybe he does know Mydei well enough, because this knowledge fits easily with the rest: Mydei is a man who cares, and who cares for his loved ones. He has never been anything but thoughtful and protective toward Phainon, and Phainon… Phainon is here to potentially betray him again and kill his father.

Surely, Mydei will understand the need to put Eurypon in the ground, the need to end him instead of simply imprisoning or exiling him. Surely, Mydei would support him. But familial bonds, even twisted ones, aren’t so easily usurped.

“Then should we not get him fresh ingredients?” Phainon asks.

Perdikkas slaps his back. “Clever man! We could! But for now.” He leans close, dropping his voice theatrically. “Pomegranate is his favorite fruit.” And then he pulls back, bustling toward the opposite end of the table, as if to give Phainon some measure of secrecy while he makes a selection.

Cipher lifts a brow, clearly unimpressed with him.

Clearing his throat, Phainon points to the candied pomegranate seeds, arranged in little pouches. “Ten,” he says, a cold sweat growing on his skin. Perdikkas is occupied with a pile of fruit, but he could return at any moment, and suddenly Phainon doesn’t know how to make this conversation sound natural.

“Seeds, or bags?” she asks blandly.

His first message communicated, he leans back, crossing his arms to hide the nervous trembling of his hands. Lying is easy enough, but this, communicating in broad daylight with his contact, is nerve wracking. “Maybe just two pouches, then,” he says. As she collects the pouches, he pretends to study her. “Are you from the area near the Acheron?” he asks.

Her hands don’t falter. “Further north,” she says, confirming she’s received his message.

“More peaceful up there,” he says, hoping that’s not too revealing to everyone around them. But surely most people know Okhema is building their forces along the Acheron already. “I’ve heard there’s a great rock at the center of the Acheron,” he continues, trying to figure out how to explain that Mydei will be there.

“A rock,” she deadpans.

“One painted red and gold that can’t be destroyed,” he says, taking the pouches from her.

Her eyes go momentarily wide. “How inconvenient that must be for those who wish to travel the river.”

“Extremely,” he says, turning toward Perdikkas. “My lord?”

Perdikkas looks up from the small amphora he holds. “Ah, money! Yes, yes.” He scuttles over, reaching into his chiton to remove the necessary payment. “I see you found something appropriate.”

“I did, yes.” He glances at Cipher, but she’s paying him not attention, her focus now on Perdikkas.

They exchange payment enough to cover the treats Phainon picked out and whatever’s in Perdikkas’s amphora, and then Perdikkas is guiding Phainon back toward Mydei and his other somatophylakes. Hephaestion watches their approach, his fingers lose around the neck of his wine skin, and there’s

a strange sadness about his features, the downturn curve of his lips and the hollowness in his eyes.

Mydei pushes through his friends. “Phainon,” he says, his hands upraised. In them, he holds leather armguards.

Phainon tucks his sweets away in a pouch at his hip, frowning. “Your Highness?”

“What do you think of these?” Mydei asks, holding the armguards out to Phainon.

Taking them slowly, glancing at each of the somatophylakes in turn, Phainon turns the leather over in his hands. Supple, strong, with tight and tiny stitching. He whistles quietly. “A fine make,” he observes. There’s no harm in it; Mydei knows who he is, and he’s sure Hephaestion and Leonnius have told the others of his skill with a blade.

It strikes him, then, that his continued well-being has quite a lot to do with Mydei’s friends. They could destroy him if they wanted—slaves aren’t allowed to wield weapons—and here is Mydei, asking for his opinion on armor.

His gaze flicks toward Hephaestion, whose sadness has deepened.

Phainon rubs his thumb along the curve of one armguard, nodding. “A fine make indeed,” he says. “Worthy of a prince.”

There’s something soft in Mydei’s eyes. Something warm. “They aren’t meant for a prince,” he says.

They return to the palace at dusk, possessed of a strange camaraderie. Though Hephaestion sets himself apart, the other members of Mydei’s somatophylakes jostle and bump Phainon with the same lack of regard they do their prince. Phainon is left with the uncomfortable feeling that, if not for the torc around his neck and the war between them, he might be friends

with these men. He might like them. He *does* like them, and he doesn't like that at all.

Hephaestion breaks away from them first, offering a paltry apology for his departure, but he's followed by the others, until only Leonnius remains with them. "Have to see Your Highness back safely," he says, offering a lazy salute when they reach Mydei's door. "Even if maybe you'd be fine with just him." He nods his head toward Phainon.

Mydei sucks his teeth. "Watch yourself, Leonnius."

"So many secrets." Leonnius heaves out an exaggerated sigh before fixing Phainon with a meaningful look. "Remember what I said about those scales."

"And what," Mydei asks as he shuts the door behind them, "was that about?"

Phainon shrugs. "Not a clue," he lies—and he dislikes how easily the lie comes. He doesn't like this, either, how he's become a liar, even if it's for a noble cause.

"Phainon."

"More importantly," Phainon says, ignoring Mydei's censorious tone and quietly departing servants. "What's Hephaestion's problem with me?"

With a heavy sigh, Mydei pinches the bridge of his nose. "What did Hephaestion do this time?"

"Nothing," Phainon is quick to say. "It was more how he kept watching us and how quick he was to get away when we got back." Well, now that he says it out loud, the answer seems obvious. And, too, there was that thing Mydei said when he woke up after being whipped. Hephaestion isn't Phainon's fault. Love being a burden when it's unreciprocated. Phainon grimaces. "Oh, it's because he…" He can't finish the sentence.

“You deserve the whole story,” Mydei says, lowering his hand from his face. “It’s not a long one.” He gestures toward the bedroom, and Phainon goes easily; they have the illusion of privacy in Mydei’s bedroom. When they’re together, the servants rarely enter. “We have been together since infancy.”

Phainon snorts. “But it’s not a long story?”

“There’s not much to say about the intervening years,” Mydei replies. “His mother was my wetnurse, so we were raised together. We were the closest of friends.” He sets the small box he’s been carrying all this time on a table, and Phainon’s stomach twists. He still can’t believe Mydei bought those armguards. “Virtually inseparable. It was almost a foregone conclusion that we might harbor tender affection for each other.”

“Oh,” Phainon says, at a loss for anything better to contribute.

“But we are a poor match.” Mydei turns, leaning against the table and bracing his hands against it. He studies Phainon, and Phainon tries to keep his expression as neutral as possible as he waits for Mydei to volunteer more. “Rather, I am a poor match for him. Hephaestion… I care for him deeply, but I could never love him the way he wanted to be loved.”

Phainon lowers his head. “That must not be easy.”

“No, but even he saw it. He’s the one who ended what little was between us, and that was nearly six months ago.”

A strange relief runs through Phainon, and he realizes he was afraid he’d somehow come between Mydei and Hephaestion. It’s good to not be responsible for the end of their relationship. “That must have been hard for you,” he says. “Not being able to love someone the way they love you.”

Mydei laughs softly. “It’s a difficult thing,” he agrees. “When love isn’t returned in the way you yearn for it.” He reaches behind himself, picking up the wooden box. “Where would you like these?”

The armguards are too fine a gift for a mere slave, but a mere slave can't refuse his master. Phainon has no doubt that by morning the entire palace will know Mydei has purchased this outrageous gift for him, and most of them will wonder why Mydei has chosen armor. They'll make their suppositions, and rumors will follow, but at least those rumors will remain mere conjecture. Still. Phainon doesn't want to draw more attention to himself. There's just no way to say no to Mydei. Not about this.

"Ah, you're concerned this is too bold, aren't you?" Mydei asks, leaving the box behind him and pushing away from the table. He approaches Phainon slowly, his gait a prowl, and Phainon's heart does something strange before landing somewhere in the vicinity of his throat, where it absolutely should not be.

"Am I that obvious?" Phainon asks, trying to make the question light.

Mydei slips into his space, canting his head to the side as a lazy smile curls his lips. "Tremendously." He laughs, setting a hand on Phainon's hip, and Phainon eases closer, shifting his weight so their bodies come together.

This is so easy, now, falling into Mydei's orbit. Mydei still asks Phainon to tell him no, but he openly invites Phainon's touch—a touch Phainon is more than willing to give. Even now, uncertain of a gift that says too much about who Phainon is, Phainon wants to put his hands all over Mydei's body, wants to hold him close.

"Let me be even more obvious, then," Phainon says, bending his lips to Mydei's. He takes Mydei's mouth as he settles his hands on Mydei's hips and turns them both, pressing Mydei against the closest wall.

With no space between them, he fits his hips into the cradle of Mydei's own, and Mydei hitches one leg high on his waist. Desire kindles in Phainon's stomach, a rolling wave of it as he presses closer still to Mydei. His mouth trails over Mydei's jaw, down his neck, tasting sweat and dirt from the day's adventure.

"Tell me no," Mydei says, tipping his head back against the wall. His arms come around Phainon's sides, his fingers catching on Phainon's shoulders

as he pulls their bodies together.

“I won’t,” Phainon replies, raking his teeth down Mydei’s throat and nipping at one prominent tendon.

Groaning, Mydei rolls his hips against Phainon’s. His nails sink into Phainon’s shoulders, and Phainon embraces the sharp pain, lets it garnish the pleasure churning within him. Falling into Mydei is so easy. It shouldn’t be. He should agonize over every time they come together, should hate himself for wanting Mydei, but he doesn’t. Mydei looks at him, and Phainon wants. Phainon *burns*. Like a sun, he burns for a man he shouldn’t want, can’t have, and certainly can’t keep.

“Tell me you don’t want the armguards,” Mydei insists as Phainon sucks on his throat, laving his skin with his tongue, tasting him and the agora that lingers on his flesh. Mydei wants him to deny the gift, but Phainon can’t, not just because Mydei remains his master, not just because Mydei is the crown prince and his enemy, but because he does want the armguards. He wants the gift. He wants Mydei’s gift to him, to wear them on his arms and let the whole palace knows that Mydei really does own some part of him. He wants to be someone who deserves gifts from Mydei. “I’ll give them to someone else. I—”

Phainon surges against Mydei, catching his face in his hands and taking his mouth in a demanding kiss. His tongue fucks into Mydei’s mouth, and Mydei grabs his wrists, groaning into Phainon’s mouth. Phainon swallows the sound in desperate gulps, licking across Mydei’s tongue, tasting as much of him as he can as he grinds their half-hard cocks together through their clothes. When he pulls back, it’s to whisper, “No,” against Mydei’s mouth.

Groaning, Mydei slides his hands up Phainon’s arms. “Again,” Mydei says, pulling at the fibula holding up Phainon’s chiton. “Say it again.”

“No,” Phainon says again, biting at Mydei’s lower lip.

Against him, Mydei shudders, and it’s always so erotic to have a man like Mydei trembling against him. Always makes Phainon’s heart pound and his

cock ache. He aches now as Mydei pulls his chiton away from his body, leaving him naked.

“You want—”

“I want,” Phainon agrees, breathless, taking Mydei’s chiton to the ground, too.

Naked, they grind against each other. Their foreheads rest together, their lips a scant breath apart as they pant heavily, as Mydei reaches between them to take their cocks in his hand. Their cocks slide together, the friction not entirely pleasant, but Phainon is too drunk on Mydei to care. And as more precum drips down their cocks, it makes the glide smoother, easier, and Phainon pants harder into Mydei’s mouth.

He aches, he burns, he wants to be inside Mydei more than he wants to take his next breath. He wants to be the kind of man who receives gifts from his lover, who deserves them, but he’s neither. Responsibility weighs heavily across his shoulders, crushing his back. Mydei can’t know. Can never know. No one—Mydei squeezes around their cocks, and Phainon makes a desperate, broken sound before taking Mydei’s mouth in a rough, hungry kiss.

Blindly, Phainon reaches to one side. His fingers hook in the edge of the basket containing their oil, and he tugs it closer to fish the vial out. Devouring Mydei’s mouth with his own, grinding his cock against Mydei’s own, he uncorks the vial and pours oil over his fingers. When he reaches between Mydei’s legs, Mydei moans, and Phainon drinks the sound down even as it goes directly to his cock.

Phainon smears oil against Mydei’s hole, pressing against that tight ring of muscle until it softens beneath his touch, until Mydei softens, until the press of Phainon’s chest is keeping them upright more than Mydei’s own legs. How wicked that is, how alluring, how decadent to have Mydei half wrapped around him, trembling, with only Phainon as his support.

That, too, is an impossible thing that Phainon shouldn’t want, but Phainon is used to wanting impossible things.

One finger pushes into Mydei’s hole, and Mydei makes a cracked and broken sound. “The bed,” he says.

“Here,” Phainon insists, working that finger deeper and then pulling the tip of it over Mydei’s prostate. Mydei sags against the wall, gasping against Phainon’s lips and releasing their cocks to clutch at Phainon’s shoulders instead. He keens into Phainon’s mouth, another sweet sound for Phainon to devour, to secret away in the depths of his heart so he can carry its memory into eternity.

He fucks Mydei open on one finger and then two, playing with him until he’s making desperate, hungry little sounds in the back of his throat, short and abbreviated like he’s trying but failing to choke them back. Phainon loves these noises, loves the proof of how he can pick Mydei apart with just his touch. Mydei’s fingers slide into his hair, clutching at the short locks of it, and he groans as he works his hips back to take Phainon’s own fingers deeper. Nails rake across his shoulders and scalp, scratching pain that serves as a sweet garnish to the pleasure churning low in his gut.

“Phainon,” Mydei gasps.

Phainon withdraws his fingers. He tips the vial into his palm again, pouring more oil across his skin, and casts it aside without much attention to where it falls, rubbing that oil onto his cock. Then he’s pushing slowly into Mydei’s open body, and Mydei groans, his lips slack and his mouth open, his eyes shut and his expression beatific. Titans, but he’s beautiful, and he’s even more beautiful as Phainon eases deeper and Mydei’s brows come together in a look of splintered rapture.

“Mydei,” he breathes, pressing his lips to the corner of Mydei’s own.

Mydei answers with a low whine.

Rocking deeper, Phainon wraps his hands around Mydei’s thighs. Slick heat closes around him, tight like a vice as he thrusts into Mydei’s body. Around him, against him, Mydei shivers and groans. Together, they hoist Mydei’s other leg over Phainon’s hip, until it’s the weight of Phainon’s chest and the drive of his hips holding Mydei against the wall.

The sound Mydei makes is obscene. He gasps Phainon's name again, wrapping himself around Phainon's shoulders and pressing his face into Phainon's neck.

"I've got you," Phainon says, a truth and a lie braided together. He wishes it could be the full truth. Wishes he could tell Mydei the full truth.

Grasping Mydei's thighs, he moves in slow and steady thrusts as Mydei's cock rubs over his stomach, as they gasp and moan together to a shaking, shuddering peak. Mydei comes first, untouched, spilling himself over Phainon's stomach, and that tips Phainon over the edge. Mydei's pleasure almost always has that effect. He comes with a low and aching groan, and he stumbles away from the wall. With Mydei in his arms, he collapses on to bed, his own legs finally giving out.

They sprawl across the sheets, panting, only for Mydei to push himself up with a low and sultry laugh. "Am I too much for you?" he asks.

And Phainon, who even now can't stop himself from rising to a challenge, quirks his lips in a wicked grin. "Never," he says, but he's laughing, too. They're both laughing as Mydei eases off of him and collapses onto the bed.

"Perhaps I should buy you more gifts," Mydei says.

Phainon doesn't balk, but he does seek out his chiton with his toes. Finding it, he pulls it closer and then lifts it, grabbing the belt with his hands. He opens the small pouch dangling from the belt, removing the packets of candied pomegranates. "I got you something, too," he says, suddenly feeling shy. "It's not much." He presses the packet into Mydei's palm, looking everywhere but Mydei's face.

Taking the little packet, opening it, Mydei makes a soft sound of surprise. "Pomegranates," he says. Phainon watches from the corner of one eye as Mydei pops a candy cluster into his mouth. His eyes close as he savors the taste, humming low in the back of his throat. "Did you know they're my favorite?"

Phainon scratches his shoulder, looking away again. “Perdikkas might’ve said something about you liking them.”

Mydei chuckles. “Perdikkas is helping you buy my favor.”

Now, Phainon grins. “Well, that,” he says, “I already have.”

Mydei rolls over him, pressing their mouths together. His kiss tastes sharp and sweet.

Sunlight pours into their bedroom—it’s still Mydei’s first, Phainon supposes, but Phainon doesn’t use the little closet attached to it at all—as they lounge together, licking goat cheese from each other’s fingers and trading bites of dried figs. They’re still coasting off the high of their victory in the agora three days ago, of Phainon delivering the news to Cipher about the mobilizing of Eurypon’s army and Mydei’s own involvement, due to depart on the morrow. Okhema will know. Okhema will be prepared. Maybe they’ll even be able to push Eurypon back, gaining a small victory.

Maybe this time—

“You’re in a good mood,” Mydei says.

“I am,” Phainon agrees, smiling. He lays on his stomach, and Mydei bends over him, pressing kisses to his shoulders and spine, and though they’ve already had sex twice this morning, Phainon’s cock stirs with renewed interest. “All things considered, I’m… content.” It’s a strange admission. He hasn’t been content in a long, long time. He shouldn’t be now, either; nothing is set in stone. The future is still malleable, but he’s done good here in Castrum Kremnos.

A delicate cough sounds from the doorway.

Phainon glances toward it, not at all embarrassed by the servant standing there, averting her gaze. A flush darkens her olive skin. He should be embarrassed. He’s sleeping with Mydei in broad daylight. But he’s not. Not anymore.

“What is it?” Mydei asks, rising. The sheet that covers them slips low, revealing a hint of his thigh.

Phainon still has some shame. It’s the only thing stopping him from bending over and biting into fleshy muscle.

“Your father has summoned you, Your Highness,” the servant says.

Phainon’s contentment evaporates.

Hephaestion peels away from the wall as Mydei approaches, ill at ease. He threw on his clothes quickly, abandoning Phainon without much explanation—though Phainon helped him dress, neither of them spoke, and it was almost certainly better that way. Speculating about Eurypon’s mercurial moods rarely benefited anyone, and if the wrong people heard such speculation, it was as good as treason.

“Hephaestion,” Mydei says. “What news?”

“Little,” Hephaestion replies, his brow furrowed. “Okhema’s lines have shifted. Your father is furious.”

Mydei’s stomach drops. “What does this change?”

“I’m not sure,” Hephaestion says. “That’s all I’ve heard so far.” He reaches for the door to Eurypon’s war room, holding it open as Mydei passes through, and then falls in behind him.

Eurypon and his generals are hunched around the map table, their forms blocking Mydei’s view of it. But his ears are unobstructed as one of them says, “We can’t fight her.”

And Mydei knows.

A horrible dread seizes him, a terrifying certainty.

“If we throw men at this problem, we *will* lose,” another general says, and the boldness with which he speaks only cements Mydei’s terror. The

generals would only say such treasonous words in one awful, horrifying scenario.

His hands shake as he approaches, and the generals turn to him. They part, making room at the war table, and Eurypon finally looks up. He is calm for now, though that means little, his expression drawn. In his hand, he holds a figurine: a lion painted red and gold. He doesn't smile when his eyes drift over Mydei, and that's, perhaps, more frightening than anything else. Eurypon's resignation is even more upsetting than his unhinged fervor.

"It seems," Eurypon says, "that you will finally have the chance to prove your immortality." He waves the figurine toward the table, and Mydei turns his gaze to the organization of troops.

There, at the Acheron, is a lone dragon figurine, so dark a violet that it is almost black.

Servant of Death, Maiden of War, Daughter of the River of Souls. Okhema's only remaining offensive Chrysos Heir.

Castorice.

"She arrived last night," Themistocles says. "One of our men ran through the night to deliver the news." He pauses, the silence weighty. "He's dead, now." Not everyone is Perdikkas. Not everyone can run like he can.

Mydei places his hands on the edge of the table to hide their shaking. He stares at the map, only barely noticing how the black tide, too, has advanced at their rear. "What changed?" he asks, hoarse, but he knows. "They never deploy her."

Because Castorice doesn't just kill men. She destroys plants and animals, poisons earth and water. In a stone city, her deadly powers aren't as dangerous. In the wilds, she is a blight and a pestilence.

"We're uncertain," another general says.

“A rat,” Eurypon muses, his gaze on Mydei. “The Goldeweaver deploys her winning piece in the hopes that we will retreat.” He leans forward, placing Mydei’s lion piece across the Acheron from Castorice’s. “We will finally discover how immortal you really are, my boy.”

“Do not send me at all,” Mydei says, “and perhaps Okhema will withdraw Castorice. She is a sword that bleeds both sides. If they think the threat of me is gone—”

“No,” Eurypon says. “This is the decisive play, the one we’ve all been waiting for, is it not? Two would-be Titans meeting each other for the final conclusion of this war. You will go. You will go *now*.”

Mydei swallows hard. He can fix this, somehow. “Father,” he begins, but he has no arguments to make.

“Do not make me take things from you as motivation,” Eurypon murmurs, silky and kind.

People are not things, but Mydei doesn’t correct his father as his knuckles go white on the edge of the table. If Eurypon takes Phainon, and he will, then he will learn the truth. He will torture and maim Phainon. He will kill Phainon. Mydei’s heart hammers. His stomach turns. Bile climbs his throat, and he forces himself to swallow again, to choke it down.

“Let us find out how powerful your immortality truly is,” Eurypon says.

Mydei bows his head, staring at that figurine. “As my king commands.” Staring at Castorice, the only person in Amphoreus who might actually have the power to end his life.

His or Phainon’s.

Hephaestion places his hand on Mydei’s back, and Mydei doesn’t shrug it off.

Chapter End Notes

no good deed goes unpunished, i suppose

also it has come to my attention that leonnius is actually the runner, not perdikkas, and i honestly don't know how i switched them up like that, but here we are, suffering. one day, i will fix it in post. for now, pls forgive me

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon paces the main room of Mydei's suite, raking his hands through his hair. Somehow, Eurypon has discovered the truth. That's the only reason to summon Mydei at such short notice. But if Eurypon knew they'd conspired to get battleplans to the Okhemans, surely Eurypon would arrest Phainon, too. There would be centurions banging down the very door Phainon paces in front of, and they'd bind him and bleed him—and then Eurypon would light him on fire. None of that is happening, so Eurypon mustn't know. But if he doesn't know, then something has changed. Something about the battle has—

Cold dread shivers down his spine, and Phainon drops his hands. He stares blankly ahead of himself.

No. Aglaea wouldn't. He'd told her, he'd warned her against it, but if she felt backed into a corner—

She wouldn't. She won't. She's too much of a strategist. There have to be other avenues for her to take. Anything but this one. Anything but—

The door opens, and Phainon turns toward it, toward Mydei, whose expression is stricken. "Phainon," he says, shutting the door. He crosses the room and embraces Phainon, pulling him close, and Phainon is certain, now.

"Castorice," Phainon says.

"Castorice," Mydei confirms.

They stand there holding each other as minutes crawl by, as horror turns Phainon's blood to ice.

He was clear with Aglaea before he took this mission: she wasn't to send Castorice into the field. Castorice is too dangerous, incapable of destroying Castrum Kremnos without also annihilating Okhema in turn. In Okhema, cocooned in the power of Aglaea's threads, Castorice is contained and relatively harmless. Beyond Aglaea's reach, she is the embodiment of death, Thanatos's harbinger.

"You can't go," Phainon says, drawing back and taking Mydei's face in his hands. "Mydei—Mydeimos." He rubs his thumbs along Mydei's cheeks, burying his fingers deep in Mydei's hair. "Mydeimos," he says again, for the weight of it. "You *can't* face her. She will kill you."

"Nothing kills me," Mydei says, wrapping one hand around Phainon's wrist. "Not permanently."

"She will," Phainon insists. "I've seen the effect she has on the world around her. You—"

Mydei closes his eyes. "I know. I've heard enough stories."

"Then why are you doing this?" Phainon demands. "This is the moment. This is. Stand against your father. Refuse the order."

"I can't do that," Mydei says, resigned.

Frustrated, Phainon steps closer to him, into him. "You can. You're the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos. Mydei, you—*nothing* is worth facing Castorice in battle."

A small, sad smile curves Mydei's lips before he closes the space between them. His lips find Phainon's, his kiss salty as he licks into Phainon's mouth. And Phainon, still cradling Mydei's face in his hands, sinks into that kiss even though it's meant to distract him. There's more to it, a subliminal conversation that he can't understand. For a man whose only desire has been to make others happy, he's never been particularly good at reading the people around him, particularly Mydeimos.

There are unspoken codices in Mydei's kiss, so many essays full of meaning, and Phainon can't puzzle out any of them, so he kisses Mydei back, fierce and demanding, but Mydei doesn't rise to his passions. He remains quiet and calm under Phainon's mouth, gentle until Phainon gentles, pliant until Phainon becomes pliant, too. Even then, Mydei is soft, reserved. His kisses are slow and easy things, lingering but somehow still desperate, as though he can't bring himself to lift his lips from Phainon's own.

His hands press against Phainon's chest. Slowly, Mydei urges them back, walking them from the main room into the bedroom, a faint and gentle pressure that has Phainon's legs hitting the bed. He tumbles into it, sprawling across it, and then Mydei is straddling him, has his hands in Phainon's hair, is kissing him again.

The desperation is back, vivid against the backdrop of their bedroom. Mydei rolls his hips down, rocking against Phainon's hardening cock, and Phainon can't breathe, can't think. He needs to, needs to piece together everything Mydei is telling him with his body.

His hands slide to Mydei's waist as his tongue slips along Mydei's lips. Mydei opens for him, suckling Phainon's tongue into his mouth, tasting him, and Phainon groans. He arches beneath Mydei, grinding lazily into Mydei's ass as Mydei pulls at their chitons, bearing their bodies, stripping them.

Mydei's hands pull down Phainon's chest, and he tears his mouth from their shared and hungry kisses to press suckling ones beneath Phainon's jaw, along his neck. Heat burns through Phainon as Mydei laves at his pulse, and he groans, grasping harder at Mydei's waist. His cock fills even more, throbbing in time with his now pounding pulse.

"Mydei," he manages, strangled, but Mydei ignores him.

Wet heat cuts across Phainon's collarbone as Mydei runs his tongue along it. Mydei's fingers map the muscles of his sides, the ladder of his ribs. He strokes and plays as rolls of his hips drive his hard cock against Phainon's stomach, leaving smears of precum behind.

Phainon reaches for him, but Mydei catches his wrists in his hands, bearing them back to the bed. “Don’t,” he says, his mouth pressed to Phainon’s sternum.

With a bewildered laugh, Phainon says, “Don’t what? Touch you?”

“Mm.” Mydei’s breath is hot across Phainon’s chest as he turns to one of Phainon’s nipples. “I… Just, don’t.” He laves his tongue across Phainon’s nipple, and Phainon groans. His hips arch off the bed, and he grinds into the curve of Mydei’s ass, relenting. Relaxing. He can’t possibly go slack beneath Mydei, but he lets go of some of his aching tension, giving Mydei the latitude he clearly wants.

His reward is the suckling pull of Mydei’s mouth around his nipple, and Phainon gasps. He groans again, tipping his head back.

In all their encounters, he’s focused his attention on Mydei, and he’s never let Mydei take much lead. It’s been too dangerous, and he has, until these past few days, used sex as a distracting weapon. Now, it almost feels like Mydei is doing the same, like Mydei is lavishing him with attention so he doesn’t notice something, so he doesn’t put something together. How embarrassing that it’s working.

Each tugging pull of Mydei’s mouth goes to Phainon’s cock, making him ache. He flexes his wrists, and just that’s enough to have Mydei pushing him harder into the mattress, all that strength and muscle holding him down. Phainon’s never cared much for this before, has never liked being at someone else’s mercy, but this isn’t about mercy. It’s about something else. Not control, not ownership, but something almost tender. Something needy and wanting and emotional.

One of Mydei’s hands drifts away from his wrist, fingers trailing across his skin, a caress unexpectedly soft. All of this is soft, from the tug of Mydei’s lips around his nipple to the way Mydei touches him, lingering but ephemeral. Phainon swallows hard, turning into Mydei’s touch, trying to get more of it, but Mydei’s caresses remain featherlight, teasing and tantalizing, promising so much while delivering so little. A delicious tease, one Phainon wants more of. Craves more of.

Mydei's hand presses against the curve of Phainon's waist, bracing as he pushes himself down Phainon's body, mapping the peaks and valleys of his abdomen with lips and tongue. He paints the topography of Phainon's body with his mouth, and Phainon lets his head fall back. Phainon groans softly, his eyes drifting shut. Devoid of vision, he feels so much more: each scorching touch of Mydei's tongue, the suckling pull of his mouth, the softness of his lips, the soft tickle of his hair.

"Mydei," he breathes, lifting his hands slowly and sinking them into Mydei's hair when he receives no rebuke.

The wet line of Mydei's tongue cuts down the center of Phainon's body as Mydei moves lower, lower. With wordless murmurs of admiration, Mydei leaves lingering kisses on Phainon's hips. Tension coils low in his belly as Mydei's breath washes over his cock, and he groans.

"Mydei," he says again, carding his fingers through Mydei's hair, pushing it back from his face. Phainon opens his eyes to find Mydei between his legs, his leonine eyes dark with lust, his tongue wetting his lips. Breath coming in harder pants, Phainon watches Mydei. "You don't…"

Mydei's lips quirk. "Will you deny me, Deliverer?" he asks.

Phainon's brows come together. Of all the things to call him. Of all the appellations to use. He huffs. "I—" The tip of Mydei's tongue touches the head of his cock, and all the air hisses out of Phainon's lungs. His hips roll off the bed, and he groans, his eyes going wide.

There's little more erotic than the sight of Mydei's tongue on his cock. Mydei parts his lips to lave the head of Phainon's cock a second time, and the sight is exquisite, it's divine. They're supposed to be little piece of divinity, fragments of it, but their bodies can't be as holy as this act, as Mydei tonguing Phainon until he forgets to breathe. Heat burns through him, lightning in his veins as it settles at the base of his spine, a throbbing knot of desire.

"Shut up, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae," Mydei says, "and let someone take care of you for once."

But Mydei has been taking care of Phainon from the start. Mydei has protected him at every turn, and Phainon, in his devotion to his quest, has repeatedly put Mydei in the way of political, social, and bodily harm. The secrets Mydei keeps, he keeps willingly, yes, but he doesn't have to. He chooses to. Every day, he chooses to take care of Phainon, and Phainon has returned that care with pain and hardship.

His throat closes before he can manage a protest, and in those seconds when he can't speak, Mydei's fingers curl around his cock and Mydei takes him into his mouth.

Phainon's back bows. His head falls back. Arching off the bed, he delves his fingers deep into Mydei's hair. The heat of Mydei's mouth threatens to unmake him, splintering him with its intensity. Mydei's tongue pulls over his tip, lapping up precum, before swirling around his head, and Phainon groans, his nails scraping over Mydei's scalp.

Aside from Mydei, Phainon can't remember the last time he let someone else this close, let someone else give him this kind of pleasure. Trust doesn't come easy to him, not anymore, not after so much time, but trusting Mydei is so easy. Mydei has given Phainon every reason to trust him, and Phainon has betrayed Mydei at almost every opportunity.

Leonnius is right. He needs to balance those scales. He's going to. His very purpose is to balance those scales, but perhaps such a vision of the world is too grand for Mydei to accept.

Mydei's mouth sinks lower as he takes Phainon deeper, and Phainon exhales heavily, all the air punching out of his lungs. With practice comes skill, and Mydei has learned his lessons well. He takes Phainon deeper, deeper, until his mouth meets his hand, squeezing around Phainon's cock. The head of him nudges against Mydei's soft palate, but he doesn't choke, doesn't gag. Saliva drips down Phainon's length, but that just makes it easier for Mydei to pull back, to pull off him only to sink back down again.

With every stroke, his hand squeezes the base of Phainon's cock, and Phainon groans. His hips find an easy rhythm, and he thrusts shallowly into Mydei's mouth, letting him control the pace and the depth and everything

else. His movements are instinctive, needy, and he needs more of this, more of Mydei.

“Mydei,” he murmurs, embarrassed by the tightness in his voice, the rough hunger in it.

Mydei hums in response, the sound vibrating along Phainon’s cock, but he doesn’t stop. He suckles harder on Phainon’s tip, and he rubs the flat of his tongue along Phainon’s length when he pulls up.

The ecstasy of it is delicious, yes: Mydei’s mouth is hot and slick and perfect. The care is what threatens to undo Phainon. Tenderness fills Mydei’s every touch, a tenderness Phainon certainly doesn’t deserve, and he tries to gently push Mydei off him, but Mydei won’t be moved. He persists, sucking on Phainon’s cock until Phainon’s hips move in an uncontrolled roll, until Phainon is gasping and arching off the bed.

“Close,” he says, and Mydei sucks on him still, pulling him closer and closer to the edge, the pulsing throb of pleasure hitting harder and harder until—

Until Mydei pulls off him and squeezes the base of his cock, warding off his orgasm. “Not yet,” he says, and Phainon opens his eyes, baffled, to stare down the length of his body. Mydei smirks up at him, the expression lacking its sharp edges. “Not until you’re inside me.”

Pleasure pulses through him, and Phainon’s sure that if Mydei had let go of his cock, that would’ve made him come. “Let me open you up.”

“No.” Mydei leans away, picking up the vial of oil from his bedside basket. He pours a generous amount on his own fingers. “Not today.” Bending back to Phainon’s cock, he resumes his suckling as he reaches back, as he—Titans, he’s fucking himself open on his own fingers, and the heat and need that surges through Phainon is so close to an orgasm that his eyes almost roll back in his head.

Except he can’t look away. He can’t stop watching Mydei swallow down his cock as Mydei’s own fingers push between his legs, as Mydei makes

quiet, choked back little sounds around Phainon's length in his mouth. The thickness of Phainon's cock stretches Mydei's mouth wide, and he knows Mydei's jaw must be bothering him, but Mydei continues. Mydei doesn't stop. Mydei sucks Phainon deeper, deeper, until Phainon's cock is down the back of his throat and Phainon can't feel anything except the tight, wet heat.

He wants to offer praises, but he can't. His tongue is too thick in his mouth, his brain too dumb. Watching Mydei shuts his brain down, the way Mydei sinks down the length of Phainon's cock until his nose touches Phainon's stomach. Muscles bunch and release in his arm, and Phainon's fingers twitch against Mydei's scalp. He wants to be inside Mydei, wants it so badly he can barely breathe, and his fingers comb through Mydei's hair with increasing urgency. This is too much, Mydei fingering himself open as he sucks Phainon off, and Phainon—his head falls back as his hips roll into Mydei's mouth, as he gasps, as pleasure cuts through him like the blade of a sword.

And then Mydei releases Phainon's cock, the cooler air a cruel shock. Mydei shifts up the length of Phainon's body, and when Phainon starts to push himself up, Mydei shoves him back down. "No," he says again, like the imperious prince he is, and Phainon's cock *aches*. It throbs.

Mydei settles across Phainon's hips, reaching back to take Phainon's cock in hand. Phainon pants heavily as Mydei pushes down against his cockhead, and groans loudly as his cock eases into Mydei's body. He grabs at Mydei's waist, clinging, barely able to stay on top of the pleasure that Mydei's tight, hot body gives him. Mydei's like a vice around him, fitting him so well, and he wants to drive hard into the man above him, but he knows Mydei won't allow it.

How strange to submit himself to someone else's desires. How strangely freeing.

Mydei rakes one hand through his hair, pushing it out of his face as he takes Phainon to the root. Beneath him, Phainon trembles. He clutches Mydei's waist, straining against the desire to come already. The heat of Mydei beckons him toward ecstasy, but not yet. He won't acquit himself so poorly.

He can’t. He has to—has to—has to what? Prove himself? What’s he trying to prove? That he’s good for something?

“Phainon,” Mydei says, bending down and curving his hands around Phainon’s face.

Phainon stares at the man above him, gasping as Mydei grinds down, grinds onto his cock, takes him deeper into that impossibly hot tightness.

“Watch me,” Mydei says, releasing Phainon’s face, and Phainon watches. Phainon watches Mydei fist his cock as he moves, watches Mydei stroke himself as he rocks his hips forward and back, finding a wicked rhythm that blanks every thought from Phainon’s mind but one: this is for his benefit. Every time they’ve had sex, it’s always been for Mydei’s benefit. This time? This time is purely for Phainon’s, and Phainon doesn’t know what to do with that. But he watches still, his eyes riveted to Mydei’s fist and then dropping lower, watching where his own cock sinks, slick and shiny with oil, into Mydei’s body.

He whines despite himself, dropping his hands to Mydei’s thighs. He squeezes and massages them, staring, staring, staring as Mydei moves over him, against him. Part of him wants to feel used, but Mydei isn’t using him. It would be easier if he was. Mydei is still writing wordless codices with the meeting of their bodies, and Phainon wishes he was a better hand at reading these silent messages.

His hands rub into Mydei’s thighs as Mydei works himself harder. Precum spills from Mydei’s cock, dripping down his hand and splattering onto Phainon’s belly.

“Please,” Phainon gasps, not entirely sure what he’s asking for. But he’s on the razor’s edge of his own pleasure, wound so tight that every roll of Mydei’s hips hurts in the best, most wicked way. “Mydei, Mydei, I—” He breaks off on a groan as Mydei squeezes around him.

“Not yet,” Mydei pants, and Phainon shoves his own needs down, staving off his orgasm through sheer willpower as Mydei’s hand works harder, faster, as Mydei pleasures himself with his hand and Phainon’s body.

Phainon reaches for him, needing desperately to help, to do something, and Mydei brushes him aside. “Watch,” he says again, and Phainon does.

Phainon watches as Mydei throws his head back, watches as Mydei’s back bows, watches as Mydei comes apart with a breathless and aching sound of pleasure. Cum spills from Mydei’s cock onto Phainon’s belly, a hot wash of liquid across Phainon’s skin, and Phainon devours the sight of Mydei’s face, the way his throat works, the way he shakes as his orgasm washes through him. Mydei pulls slowly at his cock, fucking himself through the pleasure of it, and that’s too much for anyone to bear.

Gripping Mydei’s waist, Phainon arches into him, eking out what pleasure he can until he comes apart, too, until his body is rigid with ecstasy. It takes so little for him to fall to pieces beneath Mydei, coming for him with a broken little moan of his own, and Mydei leans down, takes Phainon’s face in his hands, and kisses him. It is a long kiss, a slow kiss, the kind of kiss that belongs to parting lovers and, oh, that’s what this is.

Phainon wraps his arms around Mydei, clutching at his shoulders.

This is a goodbye.

Mydei is asleep, but Phainon is still awake, sitting with his arms draped across his raised knees. He stares at the wall opposite the bed without seeing it, at a loss. This, too, is a familiar feeling, an old friend come back to him. Uncertainty is his constant companion.

But not Mydei’s.

Phainon eases out of bed, grabbing his chiton. He ties it around his waist, walking silently from the bedroom to the courtyard beyond it. He’s figured out the palace better, and he knows some of its secrets. This one, he didn’t discover on his own; Hephaestion revealed it when he came to visit Mydei while Mydei recovered from his lashes.

Down one courtyard wall, hidden by a large sweet bay, is a door. Phainon eases between the wall and the plant, ignoring the boughs scraping across

his skin, and finds the door handle. He pushes it open, steps inside, and finds himself in the suite adjacent to Mydei's.

Hephaestion's.

The man himself stands over a desk, a scroll spread before him, and he spears Phainon with a virulent look. "That door is only for use in emergencies," he spits, "and this can't possibly be—"

"Why is Mydei going to fight Castorice?" Phainon asks.

Hephaestion stills. His eyes close, and he sighs heavily as he sinks into a nearby chair. Pressing his face into one hand, he beckons Phainon into the room with the other. "He told you?"

"He did."

There's no place for Phainon to sit, so he stands in front of Hephaestion's desk, glancing at the scroll spread across its surface. It's a map, but not of the front. No, Hephaestion's map shows the rear of the empire and the progress the black tide has made across it, reaching deeper and deeper into their lands.

A cold terror runs down Phainon's spine, but the black tide isn't his immediate problem.

"What else?" Hephaestion asks. "What else did he tell you?"

"Nothing. Just that he has to face Castorice. But that's insanity. Nothing and no one survives Castorice." Phainon leans over Hephaestion's desk, placing his hands on either side to brace himself. "He has to know that. His father has to know that. Why would the king—"

"Because the king doesn't care for Mydei's life," Hephaestion says softly. "Surely *you* know that." There's scorn there, but not as much as Phainon might've expected. "The Titans don't die, not unless they're killed. Eurypon doesn't need an heir for his immortal empire."

Phainon bites back a scoff. "A little short-sighted, isn't that?"

“Perhaps. But who knows the mind of a Titan?” Hephaestion asks with a shrug.

“That’s a coward’s answer, and we both know it.”

Hephaestion inclines his head. “But it’s an answer that keeps men alive.” His gaze on Phainon is sharp, assessing, and Phainon shoves back, frowning. “You don’t really love him, do you?”

That catches Phainon entirely by surprise. “What?”

“You don’t truly love Mydei,” Hephaestion says again, accusatory.

Phainon rubs his hand over his mouth. “What does that have to do with this?” he asks, a little too sharply, maybe.

“Think,” Hephaestion says, sharp. “Apply the brain you must surely have in that head and *think*, Phainon of Okhema.”

Phainon gropes wildly for a coherent thought, but he can’t get past the conversation he’s having with Hephaestion now about Mydei’s motivations —nor Mydei’s motivations for using sex as a way to say goodbye. He can’t stop thinking about either of those two things, but the more they spiral together in his brain, the more they coalesce into a shape he doesn’t like. “No,” he says with dawning horror. “My—His Highness—”

Hephaestion rolls his eyes. “Don’t bother.”

“Mydei,” Phainon says firmly. “Mydei wouldn’t do this to protect me.”

A sad smile pulls across Hephaestion’s face. “Wouldn’t he?”

“Then the king… he threatened me. If Mydei doesn’t go.” Phainon staggers back a step. Goodbyes. Protection he doesn’t deserve, that he shouldn’t have. This has all gone so unexpectedly wrong. He’d thought—but it doesn’t matter what he thought at the start. He’s here, now, and he’s not in control anymore. Briefly, bitterly, he wonders if he’s ever been in control. “Why does he care?” Phainon rakes both hands through his hair, driving it away from his face. “Why would Mydei be so swayed?”

Hephaestion laughs, but it’s not cruel, it’s as sad as his smile. “We both know you’re smarter than that.”

“He has no reason to care about me,” Phainon insists, dropping the back of one hand into his palm. “No reason.”

“According to the philosophers, love precludes reason.” Hephaestion’s expression is so shattered, so sad, so resigned, that it catches Phainon utterly by surprise.

“No,” he says. “No, that’s…”

“Phainon,” Hephaestion says, gentle like a parent to a child. “I remember how Mydei looked at me when he thought he loved me.”

“No,” Phainon says again, watching everything he’s worked so hard for fall through his fingers. It wasn’t supposed to go like this.

“His regard for you is so much more tender than it ever was for me.”

Chapter End Notes

> enjoy that breather because it's the last one we're gonna get for a while. next chapter, we make it to the front and have the showdown with castorice soooooo :3
>
> as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

> please mind the tags for this one, and remember that "happy ending" is among them. the more tenderhearted among you may want to wait until next week to read this chapter

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The journey to the frontline doesn’t take long, even for Mydei and his century. They march too well, too efficiently, and the weather is good and clear. He resents their swiftness, wishing for more time to mull over his own potential demise, to cajole Phainon into opening up to him, but they accomplish the march in a little under two days.

Phainon rides with him at the center of his somatophylakes, at the head of the century, but refuses to give more than clipped responses or quiet grunts, leaving Mydei baffled. Phainon’s uncharacteristic silence is inscrutable, and he doesn’t know how to coax Phainon out of it. In the end, he decides it’s not his place. They can playact at being lovers, but the truth is that they aren’t. They never will be. They are master and slave, coconspirators in treason, and their personal feelings—for surely this has more to do with their personal relationship—matters so much less than everything else. How strange it is to find himself with such a relationship, one he craves, only to learn he can’t prioritize it above all things.

When they reach the frontline, Mydei’s century makes camp under the watchful eyes of his somatophylakes, and he retreats into the command tent with Phainon, even though Phainon’s company is poor at best. The silence between them is uncomfortable as they eat, as they prepare for bed—Mydei has already been briefed. He will go to the field in the morning and wait for Castorice there, as she has been waiting for him each morning.

More than just the silence, Mydei himself is uncomfortable. Death isn’t something he’s ever had to fear. Dying, yes, but death, no. Now, he not only faces the prospect of a gruesome death, but the prospect of staying dead,

and he wants. There's a yearning inside him, though he doesn't know what for.

It's only after their dinner is cleared and Mydei has washed his face and hands, after they've stripped to their loincloths and are well and truly alone—and Mydei feels so very alone—that Phainon speaks.

"I could go. In the middle of the night, I could simply leave."

Mydei startles, looking away from his mirror to study Phainon. He sits on the edge of the palette they're to share, his arms draped over his knees, his eyes fixed on the floor between his feet. "To what end?" Mydei asks.

Phainon doesn't look at him. "If your father has no leverage, you don't have to test Castorice in the morning."

They've seen the blackened field, the corpses of birds that flew too close overhead, pulled down by the wafting of Castorice's deadly miasma.

Frowning, Mydei sets his basin aside and goes to his knees in front of Phainon. Phainon's eyes remain downturned. "Would you really abandon your mission?"

Phainon's hands curl into fists. "There are other ways to accomplish it," he says, and there's something there, something Mydei should understand but doesn't. Phainon is still hiding things from him, and Mydei wishes he wouldn't but knows why he does. Some secrets must remain between them. They are not true allies—and his heart doesn't grieve that. "And if you really die tomorrow, that…"

"That will deal a deadly blow to Kremnoan morale," Mydei says, not hoping that Phainon trails off for another reason. "That will give Okhema the advantage. That will give your people a chance to strike deeper into the heart of the Empire, Phainon, and you, perhaps, the opening we both know your people need." Mydei isn't a fool. This isn't just about defeating the army. There is only one way to end this war. "But more likely, I'll be fine. Nothing has been able to keep me down yet."

“There’s a first time for everything,” Phainon says, his fists curling so tight his knuckles pop.

Mydei won’t let himself believe Phainon is afraid for him. That would be too much. “Your concern is appreciated but likely misplaced.”

At last, Phainon looks at him. “Mydei—”

“All the odds suggest I’ll be fine. Nothing has killed me yet. Why should we believe Castorice will?”

“She’s Thanatos’s heir,” Phainon says. “Handpicked and blessed. If anything—if anyone—is going to end your life, it’s her.”

A sad smile pulls at Mydei’s lips. “Why do you care so much?”

Phainon looks away. “We’re allies.”

“We’re enemies with a common goal,” Mydei reminds him, but he doesn’t know that’s true. Enemies don’t fuck each other the way Phainon fucks him. Enemies aren’t distressed about the prospect of losing a convenient ally, and Phainon is so clearly distressed. “Don’t worry for me, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

Phainon scoffs. “As you say.”

“I would go into battle forearmed and forewarned,” Mydei says, shifting to sit beside Phainon. “What do you know of Castorice?”

Exhaling heavily, Phainon tips his head back, staring at the top of the tent. “She’s from Aidonia.”

“Ah.” So she, too, has personal reasons to hate Mydei, Eurypon, and all of Castrum Kremnos, for the sack of Aidonia wasn’t a pleasant thing. “That’s… unfortunate.”

Phainon makes a quiet sound of agreement. “She was there during the sacking, already chosen by Thanatos. When the soldiers returned too maimed to survive, she was their Holy Maiden who took them into the

afterlife. But even before that, it was Castorice who released the dying from the shackles of mortal life." Phainon turns his hands palm up, staring at them. "With a touch, she took their lives. She's always lived apart, a harbinger for the end."

"Interesting," Mydei says. "You knew her in Okhema?"

"You could say that." Phainon flexes his fingers. "She's always been alone, set apart. She's desperate for human connection. She—" He laughs. "This won't help you fight her."

No. It won't. "Knowing her state of mind could be useful."

"Maybe. Probably not." Rubbing his jaw, Phainon stares into the distance, thoughtful. "In Okhema, wrapped in Aglaea's threads, she was less dangerous, and less potent. You could get close to her, but never more than five paces. No one ever sparred with her, that'd require getting too close, but I saw her learning ranged weapons. Throwing knives, slings, archery. The masters stood at a distance and gave her instruction."

"Then she'll come armed?"

"Doubt it. I expect she'll show up in a breastband and a loincloth and try to physically touch you. The miasma will confound you, slow you down, strangle you, but it's her touch that's deadliest." Phainon turns toward him, concern in his drawn brows. "You can't let her touch you. *You* have to stay at range."

"One-on-one combat with a bow won't be particularly effective," Mydei says dryly, "but I take your meaning. I'll bring my spear."

"Even that—" Phainon cuts himself off, looking away. "The spear is your best bet, if you're to engage her at all."

"I have no choice." Mydei says.

Phainon closes his eyes. "You do."

“I don’t,” he insists softly, hoping Phainon understands. “Do you think she will believe me a traitor if I tell her I’m on her side?”

Phainon flinches.

“Do you think she’ll play at killing me—or let me play at killing her? No, this will be to the death for one of us,” Mydei says. “There is no other way.”

They settle on opposite sides of the small pallet, backs touching, and Mydei presses his face into his hand. He doesn’t believe he’ll die, but the smallest kernel of fear kindles within him. There are so many things he hasn’t done, so many things he hasn’t prepared for. If he does die on the morrow—

But then Phainon rolls over, Phainon takes him into his arms and presses his face into Mydei’s neck, and Mydei relaxes. Phainon curls around him as though a shield, as though he can ward off the entire world.

At least for the night, Mydei will let himself imagine something more: a world where they weren’t born on opposite sides of a terrible conflict, where he wasn’t born a prince and Phainon the son of a farmer. He presses a kiss to Phainon’s knuckles, and Phainon rests his lips on the curve of Mydei’s shoulder, and Mydei pretends they aren’t on the front at all.

There is no pretending in the morning. In the morning, he rises with the sun, and his somatophylakes arrive to help him armor himself. They laugh and slap him on the back, the shoulders as they strap him into his tassets, his chest plate, his bracers. Leonnius speaks of Phylo’s and the agora; Peucesta, a newly composed song he thinks Phainon will enjoy; Ptolemy, a story he thinks Mydei should read. Their words betray them. Every last one of them is afraid this will be the last morning they see him alive, but they shouldn’t fear.

Nothing has killed Mydei yet. Castorice will be no different.

Only Hephaestion is silent, standing surprisingly close to Phainon. They don’t speak, but there’s some strange difference in the way they occupy such proximity. No one else remarks on it, and Mydei, uninterested in

sparking conflict, keeps his own counsel as anticipation for the battle flutters in his stomach.

This, at least, is a familiar feeling: the tightening of his muscles, the need to get a weapon in his hands, the excitement and thrill of oncoming combat. He has always enjoyed testing himself against new trials, and this won't be any different. The rules will be, certainly—this won't be armed combat against an opponent trying to gut him but rather him attempting to fend off someone who wants to touch him. A new and interesting challenge.

When he emerges from the tent, flanked by his somatophylakes, with Phainon trailing behind, the air in the camp is hums with a strange tension. His centurions are all waiting for him, armored and ready to observe the battle, but their helms can't hide their mixed emotions. Some are clearly jubilant, expecting this, as Mydei must, to be the final confrontation between Castrum Kremnos and Okhema. Their immortal prince will end Castorice and the war in one stroke. But there are those who are somber, those who, as Phainon, are possessed of a deep fear that Mydei's immortality won't extend to Thanatos's right hand.

Leonnius presents his spear to him, and Mydei takes it, hefting it high. "Today," he calls out over the hushed crowd, reflecting a little idly that this is better delivered to the entire army, "we put an end to Okhema's tyranny! Today, I meet the Hand of Shadow on the field of battle, and I will cast her down for the glory of Castrum Kremnos!" The words threaten to stick in his throat. He doesn't want this. He doesn't want any of this. "You, my century, are witness to our greatness, to the righteousness of our course. We defend the Titan of Strife and his mastery of all lands and peoples, his right to rule us under the banners of Reason, Tenacity, Sacrifice, Honor, and Courage. We bring these edicts to the barbarians, the outsiders, and show them the strength of our convictions. And with the strength of our convictions, of your convictions, I will crush the Hand of Shadow beneath my feet!"

The century roars with approval as nausea churns in Mydei's stomach. He doesn't believe any of what he's just said, and he fears a population that does. Castrum Kremnos is on the road to ruin, and there are no hands to steer it aside, none who can stand up to Strife.

He leads his century to the rest of the Kremnoan army, already gathered on the banks of the Acheron. Both armies are camped east of the river and just south of the nearby and very much destroyed city state of Ioannina. Here, a large bridge crosses the Acheron's depths, and the Okhemans control it. The bridge is broad enough to facilitate a retreat if necessary, but it will be a bloodbath if that's how this conflict ends. It's clear to Mydei—and likely the other generals at the front—that Okhema is betting on breaking the Kremnoan troops by killing their prince and routing them beyond the ruined city state.

Mydei grips his spear. He wants none of this, not to see his troops die or routed, nor to see the Okhemans slaughtered in a mad retreat across the bridge.

Hephaestion approaches him as he surveys the dead field before him. Beyond the field, across the river, is another line of death: Castorice's progress. She stands in the field already, all lavender hair and pale pink skin. Phainon was right.

"You have the blessings of Strife upon you," Hephaestion says with the tone of a man who might no longer believe in his gods.

"Let us hope," Mydei says, glancing back. Phainon stands with Mydei's other somatophylakes, his expression unreadable. Mydei turns back to Hephaestion. "Hephaestion."

Hephaestion doesn't look at him. He surveys the field, too, his hands clasped loosely behind his back. "Mydeimos." His voice is tight.

"I know things aren't well between us," Mydei says softly. He hesitates for just a moment and then sets his hand on Hephaestion's shoulder. Hephaestion stiffens beneath the touch. "I… I don't know how to fix any of it." He isn't sure he can. "But I want you to know that I'm sorry. For the pain."

"Put this ridiculous sentimentality behind you," Hephaestion says, shaking Mydei's hand off his shoulder. "You're not going to die today."

Mydei huffs a quiet laugh. “No. No, I’m not going to die today,” he says, trying to believe it beyond any doubt, but that little kernel of fear has grown roots in his gut. “All will be well, won’t it?”

“Of course it will. Even if we must suffer your mother’s spy among us.” Hephaestion’s words lack their usual bite.

“He’s a good man, you know. Phainon.”

Hephaestion presses his lips into a thin line. Finally, he says, “I’m not sure that I would classify any spy a good man by nature of their duties and deceptions. But you’ve always been a decent judge of character.” He snorts. “With one exception. Or, perhaps, two.”

Now, Mydei laughs. He releases Hephaestion’s shoulder with a squeeze. “Well. There’s no accounting for taste, is there?”

“There isn’t,” is Hephaestion’s dry reply. He sobers. “Kill her, Mydeimos. Kill her, protect what you love, and put an end to this.”

Mydei tightens his grip on his spear. “I will.” He hesitates, suddenly keenly aware of how much he wants to go to Phainon, to… he doesn’t know what he’d do. Accepting or giving any show of affection from or to his bed slave would be wildly inappropriate. He should’ve said something—anything—before his somatophylakes entered this morning. Should have taken the opportunity to say a goodbye, just in case, perhaps.

But he’s not going to die today.

Under the eyes of the Kremnoan legions, Mydei strides forward. The weight and hope of a nation settles across his shoulders as he makes his long, lonely journey, as he approaches Castorice. She’s younger than he expected, barely out of her adolescence, her face guileless and innocent despite the lives she’s surely taken. The corpses of birds litter the field around her, the grasses withered to nothing, the dirt soft beneath his feet. A purple miasma rolls across the earth like so much fog, billowing out from her feet. Where it passes over him, his skin prickles with faint irritation.

He stops five paces from her, setting the butt of his spear against the ground. “Daughter of the River of Souls,” he greets her.

“Mydeimos the Undying,” she replies, her voice soft and mellifluous. “I am very sorry.”

That irritates him, and he lifts his chin. “Presumptuous,” he says. “Your Titan has no hold on me.”

“Death is the one inevitability of our world. Even for you, Thanatos counts your days.” She speaks like his death is a foregone conclusion, and that irritates him more.

But briefly, he entertains the thought of extending an alliance to her. Perhaps they truly could play at one of their own deaths long enough to satisfy the opposing side. Perhaps they could work together as allies, as he and Phainon have. Gorgo would know how to manipulate this situation as she has manipulated him, but he isn’t his mother’s son. He’s Eurypon’s child.

He lowers his spear, shifting into an offensive stance.

Castorice remains where she stands, the wind catching her hair and lifting it from her mostly naked body. There’s a sorrow about her that only infuriates him. She closes her eyes and bows her head—and if she’s going to be so foolish, so be it.

He lunges forward.

She whips to one side, stepping around him, and he turns with her, pivoting on the ball of one foot. He expects her to dance away from him. Instead, she ducks around the thrust of his spear and launches herself at him with a wild, reckless abandon.

Castorice is no wrestler. She clearly has no idea how to brawl. But she doesn’t need to. If one touch from her is the sweet promise of oblivion, he can’t risk letting her anywhere near him. His men might trust his immortality—*he* trusts his immortality—but he isn’t much of a gambler, nor

is he particularly reckless. A deathblow will slow him down even if he doesn't kill him, and Castorice, while not a fighter, is quick. Extremely quick.

Ducking and weaving around him, she reaches for his back. He twists around and leaps back, putting space between them once again, but she pursues.

The more they move, the more the miasma pouring off her wafts around them. It swirls up from the ground, a translucent cloud. When he inhales, he breathes it in, and his lungs begin to burn—too soon for the pain to be exhaustion. The more of it he breathes in, the more his vision begins to swim and his chest ache. His legs tingle unpleasantly, and he almost loses his footing as he dodges her yet again.

Dread curls around his spine.

In any fight against her, were she a normal person, he would have killed her by now. But he can't take risky strikes, can't overextend, can't leave himself exposed to the possibility of her touch. And she is more than a little wild in her own attacks, unpredictable and hard to read. There's no fluidity to her movement, and while her own lack of experience should make her telegraph every move, he finds he mistakes her more often than not. An armed opponent shifting like *that* would have him moving toward her, and if he moves toward her, she will be able to grab him by the wrist, the arm, so he stays at a greater distance.

His spear swipes across her cheek, her shoulder, her side. He leaves lines of golden blood to drip down her skin but never manages to pierce her in any meaningful way. Miasma continues swirling around them, thicker and thicker, as though she's deliberately churning out more of it. Maybe she is. It chokes him, burning his lungs and stinging his eyes. His grip on his spear weakens, and he realizes whatever resistance he might have to it as another Chrysos Heir is minor. If the miasma kills small land animals, given enough time, it will kill him as well.

This fight has a timer on it, but he won't let himself become desperate.

He’s becoming desperate.

Sweat slicks down his back. His lungs labor heavily. His limbs grow sluggish, and his reaction time slows. He narrowly pulls away from Castorice’s grasping hands, panting hard. Stumbling back, he shakes his head, trying to focus.

More dread creeps through him, overwhelming in a way he’s unaccustomed to. A little anxiety about a fight is normal, but this is something else entirely, something all-consuming. It chokes him as much as the miasma.

Is it worth an attempt at telling her they are allies? Is now the moment he should speak? “Castorice,” he begins, but she lungs for him, and he twists away, raking the point of his spear across her belly.

A good hit, forcing her back. She gasps, clearly unused to the pain, and he throws himself forward. This is his opportunity to end their conflict, and he takes it, rushing in, gripping his spear in his weakening hands. He lunges forward, angling his spear to the side, with the intent to graze her ribs, to make this look like a death blow. To get in close and in that moment betray his people. He can’t betray his people. There is no honor in that, and he is nothing if not honorable. He—

Castorice’s eyes meet his.

He mistook her stumble as truth; it was an act. Victory lights her eyes as she steps to the side, as he overextends, as her hands wrap around his wrist and his forearm.

Cold. She’s so cold, icier than death, like the depths of a mountain river, and the cold spreads through him like a wave. It seizes his heart, his lungs. It chokes his throat, fills his mouth. He watches purple light ripple consume his arm, watches the limb disappear as the light travels up, up, up, until it’s eating his shoulder, his chest, his neck.

How surprising.

It doesn’t hurt.

There are two people on the battlefield below Phainon. There are two people, and then, in a ripple of violet light, there is one. There is Castorice.

A second passes. Two. He can't comprehend what he's seeing until the Okheman war horns sound, and then he's moving forward, is shrugging past Mydei's stunned somatophylakes, is reaching for Hephaestion's hip for his blade, is on his way to—to what? Kill Castorice? To assassinate a woman who is and has been his ally?

Hephaestion grabs his wrist before Phainon can draw his sword, rounding on him with a look of fractured and broken despair.

Kremnoan war horns answer and echo Okhema's, more like mourners' wails than calls to battle.

He's done this. Phainon has done this, has killed the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos, and, now, as he stands facing Hephaestion's grief, which can only eclipse his own, he faces his own death, too. Twisting his wrist in Hephaestion's grip, he pulls Hephaestion forward, toward him. "Kill me," he says as the war horns blare again, as the sound of marching fills the air. "You have to kill me."

Hephaestion stares at him with red-rimmed eyes bright and full of unshed tears. "This is impossible," he says, as if he hasn't heard Phainon at all. Maybe he hasn't.

Again, Phainon reaches for Hephaestion's blade, this time with his other hand, and that snaps Hephaestion out of his daze. He grabs that wrist, too, bearing down on Phainon with tremendous strength, until Phainon, gasping, sinks to his knees.

"You have to kill me," he says. "I have to—this isn't—"

Hephaestion goes with him, releasing him, embracing him, and Phainon freezes. Hephaestion embraces him, clutches at him, and Phainon holds his arms wide to either size, utterly stymied. "You are the last thing he loved,"

Hephaestion says, grasping Phainon's chiton in his fists and resting his forehead on Phainon's shoulder. "I cannot—will not—end your life."

Panic wells in Phainon's throat. "I'm the reason he's dead," he says, shoving at Hephaestion's shoulders. "Where is your hatred?" He has to die. Hephaestion has to understand that Phainon *has to die*.

"Dead with him," Hephaestion says, gripping Phainon harder, and Phainon can't comprehend this. He struggles against Hephaestion's hold, only for Hephaestion to wrap one hand around the back of Phainon's heads and bring their foreheads together. "He would choose you," Hephaestion says. "Every time, he would choose you."

"I don't deserve that," Phainon insists.

"You don't." He absolutely deserves that disdain. "But he would." Hephaestion releases Phainon and pulls back, clasping Phainon's right forearm with his hand.

Beyond them, the legions of two armies march onto the field where Mydei —where—

Eyes glittering, Hephaestion squeezes Phainon's forearm. "On Strife's own rock, this I swear."

Phainon's own eyes go wide. "No," he says. "No, don't you dare—"

"That your life is as my own, that I will bear your burdens as my own, that I will make your load lighter with my back."

"Shut up," Phainon hisses.

Hephaestion squeezes harder. "My blade is your blade. My breath is your breath." His eyes burn. "On Strife's own Honor, you are my brother, and I am yours."

Horrified, Phainon tries to shake Hephaestion off him, but there's nowhere for him to go. The other somatophylakes are there, surrounding them, and

Hephaestion drags Phainon up from the ground, forcing him to his feet. “I can’t accept—”

“It’s not yours to accept,” Leonnius says, taking Phainon’s arm from Hephaestion’s hand, his grip stronger still. He, too, is fierce as he recites the same oath, fingers digging into Phainon’s flesh.

This is the worst possible scenario, the worst possible outcome, as each of them swears to protect the life that Phainon needs desperately to discard. He is a dead man walking without Mydei, and their oaths mark them, too.

“The lot of you don’t even know,” he begins as Peucesta, the last to make his oath, releases him.

“That you’re a Chrysos Heir?” Leonnius asks. He snorts. “I’m not *that* stupid.”

Hephaestion slugs his shoulder. “I’m the one who told you.” He turns to Phainon. “You were extremely obvious at the Grove.”

Bewildered, Phainon drives both his hands into his hair. He’s surrounded by Mydei’s—by his own somatophylakes. Him. A slave. This is— “Surely you understand this will destroy your positions at court,” he says, desperate.

“Mydei loves you,” Hephaestion says sharply. “And we will honor his memory by honoring you. Let us deal with the court.”

Ptolemy clears his throat. “On the topic of the court,” he says, lifting a finger. “Who owns your slave contact, Phainon?”

Phainon, who has never once thought of a slave contract, who has no idea what a slave contract is, can only say, “What slave contract?” And he watches each of their faces crumble with horror.

“We need to find out. Immediately,” Ptolemy says, directing that to Hephaestion.

“Find out what?” Phainon asks.

They ignore him.

Hephaestion sets one hand on the hilt of his sword. “We’ll put the century under Drakon’s command with the order they stay with the main army. Ptolemy.” He inclines his head. “You’ll return to the palace as quickly as possible. Use whatever means necessary to quietly find out if the queen still owns the contract or if she turned it over to—” His voice catches. “—to Mydei. Bring word to us in Oleinus.”

“Why does it matter?” Phainon asks as Ptolemy nods again and retreats in the direction of the camp.

“Leonnius,” Hephaestion says. “Go to Drakon. Don’t waste time.”

Leonnius nods and trots off, too, leaving Phainon with Hephaestion, Peucesta, and Perdikkas. Perdikkas’s expression is drawn and nervous, and he fidgets, his fingers twisting together.

“We can’t stay here,” Perdikkas says. “Nor can we return to the palace without this information.”

Hephaestion grimaces. “If we don’t go back, our families…” He swallows hard. “The king will brand us traitors, and he *will* kill them.”

Peucesta swears and rubs his hand over his face.

“Would someone please tell me why my slave contract is so fucking important?” Phainon says, finally losing his patience.

Hephaestion turns to him, grave and somber. “When a member of the royal family dies, their slaves are put to death with them.”

Chapter End Notes

> aggressively taps the "temporary character death" and "happy ending" tags I PROMISE IT GETS BETTER. this is arguably the darkest point in the fic (there is one other dark point, but i think which one is darkest is subjective and depends on which blorbo is blorbiest)

also pls be gentle to me in the comments. i don't mind death threats when they're obviously jokes, i will ofc pay for your therapy, but /gestures vaguely/ this is the chapter i have been most nervous about posting for a long while <3

also also for those of you who were wondering what ptolemy did in ch11, it was ask who owned phainon's contract. i needed to rewrite the back half of this fic post 3.4 anyway, but ptolemy really catalyzed it with that question. additionally, i suspect many of you will now be able to identify what's up with phainon, but i will continue to dance around it in the comments until it's official

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They're gone from the camp in an hour, taking only what they can carry.

"Aren't you deserting?" Phainon asks as they ride for Oleinus. Hephaestion rides beside him, and the others surround them in a protective diamond.

Hephaestion's expression isn't reassuring. "Not technically. The five of us serve—served Mydei." His throat works. "We didn't have official positions within the army, and we're not running away from Castrum Kremnos." The *yet* goes unspoken. "But how the king sees it…"

"I still don't get it," Phainon says. "You hate me."

"Yes," Hephaestion agrees.

Phainon makes a frustrated gesture with one hand. "Then why?"

"Because I love him more than I hate you, and he would be furious if you died after everything he's done to protect you," Hephaestion snaps back. "It's not that complicated, but you are extremely stupid, aren't you?"

The smile that pulls across Phainon's lips is frigid. "You have no idea."

He waits the whole day for a moment alone, but even when they arrive at Oleinus, he doesn't get one. They buy a single room and pile into it, ordering a bath. Hephaestion insists Phainon go first, and Phainon, realizing the only privacy he gets is the screen in front of the tub, doesn't protest. He'd rather the clean water as he scrubs the dust from his skin. When he's finished, the others cycle through. Hephaestion goes after him and then vanishes to collect food from the kitchens with Peucesta's help, leaving him with Perdikkas and Leonnius.

Leonnius watches him as he sharpens his blade, and Phainon grimaces.

“Hephaestion I get,” Phainon says. “The others—no offense.” He nods to Perdikkas, but Perdikkas waves him off. “I get the others, too. But not you. Not considering the scales.”

Leonnius slides his whetstone across his blade, the sound of it awful in the otherwise quiet room. “Sometimes,” he says at last, “shit balances in ways we don’t understand. Sometimes, we leave it to Thanatos to take a pound of flesh from someone.”

“I didn’t realize you were a devotee.”

“I’m not,” Leonnius says. “But you get real friendly with death when you’re a somatophylax.”

Phainon takes a minute to digest that. “You’re not the only one.” He pinches the bridge of his nose. “You’ll kill me one day, won’t you?”

“Probably.”

“Why not now?”

Leonnius snorts. “That’d just devastate Hephaestion, and I don’t want to pick his ass up again. Your life gives him purpose.” His tone makes it clear what he thinks of Hephaestion’s newfound and certainly misplaced tolerance for Phainon.

Dropping his hands between his legs, Phainon stares at them. There was no way Leonnius would do him the courtesy of death, especially not with Perdikkas in the room, but it’d been worth a shot.

They hunker down in Oleinus, doing what they can to avoid attention. The rumors about Mydei’s death at Castorice’s hands arrive the next morning, bright and early, as they take breakfast. By early evening, the entire city sate knows the Kremnoan lines broke for Okhema’s forces and that Castorice marches ahead of the now-advancing Okheman army.

Instead of feeling relief, Phainon is terrified. The somatophylakes discuss what the advance means quietly, describing more city states that will be sacked and burned, more destruction, more death. Phainon wants to think better of the Okheman army, but he can't defend them. They will do as all armies are wont.

He should have anticipated something like this. Aglaea always has plans within plans, but he assumed she'd been honest with him, and she wasn't. She's marching on Castrum Kremnos with Castorice at the front of her armies, and Castorice will do the same work as the black tide.

Ptolemy returns the next day, exhausted, horse run ragged, but with news: the queen still owns Phainon's slave contract.

"We'll have to return you to her," Hephaestion says. They're all in the tiny room they're renting, crowded onto the too few beds. "Ptolemy? What can we do from there?"

Ptolemy shakes his head, spreading his hands wide. "Not much, I'm afraid. The queen isn't sentimental, so it's unlikely you could beg for Phainon's contract," he says to Hephaestion, who makes a face Phainon isn't sure how to read. To the group, Ptolemy adds, "We'd need to buy Phainon through manumission or buy his contract from her. Both will be a hefty expense."

"We could cobble it together," Peucesta says. "Surely. We are all of us wealthy men."

"But that wealthy?" Ptolemy asks. "Phainon is the queen's slave."

And Phainon is the queen's slave due to an agreement with Aglaea. He can only hope that Aglaea may have voided that agreement by marching her army on Castrum Kremnos, but for all he knows, Gorgo knows this part of this alternative plan.

"There are standard prices for manumission, aren't there?" Hephaestion asks.

“I doubt Her Majesty is going to be that generous with us,” Leonnius says. “The minute we express interest, she’s going to fuck with us. Especially if she still wants him for something.”

All five men turn to Phainon, who refuses to shrivel under the weight of their gazes. He sits a little taller, rolling his shoulders back.

“You wanna tell us why you were spying for her?” Leonnius drawls.

“Not particularly,” Phainon says.

Leonnius narrows his eyes, but it’s Hephaestion who speaks. “Surely, whatever you were doing for Her Majesty no longer matters in light of Mydei’s—Mydei’s death.”

Sighing, Phainon says, “She was worried about him after the two of you—”

“That’s a lie,” Ptolemy says, studying Phainon closely. “The queen has always used her interest in Mydei’s affections as a disguise for other motivations.” He lowers his voice, and it’s not a threat, but it’s close to one when he says, “Perhaps you should reconsider your allies and allegiances.”

Phainon laces his fingers together, gripping his hands. He’s reconsidered so much already, but there’s no way to explain that Ptolemy, to any of them, and he knows better than to try. He needs to get back to the palace, to get back to Gorgo, and he needs to finish what he came here to do. He needs to kill Eurypon. But, maybe, he doesn’t need Gorgo or her resources to do it. And if she was as unaware of Aglaea’s plan to march on Castrum Kremnos with Castorice as he was, she might view *him* as a traitor.

“Phainon of Okhema,” Ptolemy says thoughtfully, like he’s tasting the name, like he’s putting something together slowly in his head, and Phainon is sure he is. “Phainon of *Okhema*.” He cocks his head to the side. “Were you ever the queen’s spy?”

Leonnius scowls. “The fuck’s that mean?”

But Hephaestion has already figured it out and so have Peucesta and Perdikkas. Realization washes across their faces, and Phainon knows he's out of places to hide.

"Inasmuch as there's an alliance between Gorgo and Aglaea," Phainon says softly, meeting each of their eyes in turn.

"The truth," Ptolemy says, and Phainon could curse the man even as he's impressed.

Leonnius mutters an oath as Peucesta and Perdikkas both sit back, stunned looks on their faces. Hephaestion leans forward, a sharp look in his eyes.

"You're Aglaea's creature, then," Hephaestion says.

Phainon shakes his head. "It's more complicated than that. But I was working with her, yes."

"You were?"

"The current march on Castrum Kremnos wasn't part of the plan we agreed on," Phainon says. "I should've realized she'd have plans within plans, certainly ones I wasn't privy to, but I—" He rakes a hand through his hair, frustrated. "I trusted her when I shouldn't have."

Leonnius holds up a hand. "So, you're telling us—" He points at Phainon and Ptolemy. "—you're telling us that the queen is working with the Goldweaver? To what end?" He scoffs. "To kill the king?"

The entire room is silent, at least until Perdikkas rolls his eyes and says, "Leonnius, really?"

Leonnius's expression goes stark. "You're serious? You're all—you're serious." He leans back. "Shit. *Shit*. So, we *are* committing treason."

"Are you?" Phainon asks, strangled.

"That's your purpose, isn't it?" Ptolemy asks. "Chrysos Heir and spy sent by the Goldweaver. Get close to the prince, and use him to get close to the

king?”

“But what does that have to do with any of you?” Phainon asks in return.

Leonnius scoffs and Peucesta murmurs with laughter.

“Perhaps Okhemans forget their oaths,” Hephaestion says, “but Kremnoans don’t.”

And Phainon realizes all at once that he’s not alone in this anymore, and that, perhaps, he never had to be. If he’d just been direct and honest with Mydei, they wouldn’t be here. He lowers his head in shame and regret, closes his eyes, and wonders if he could get his hands on a sword fast enough. Unlikely with all of them watching him.

It doesn’t have to be this way. It doesn’t have to go this way.

He lifts his face, surveying them. “Get me back to the palace, return me to Gorgo. Let’s…” His voice catches, and something horrible that he’s been ignoring the past few days wells up within him. “Let’s grieve.” That hits all of them, their expressions faltering, falling, blanching. “And then decide what to do. An army marches slowly, and Aglaea will almost certainly loot and pillage the city states in her way. Your own legions will regroup to hold her back, too. We have time. We have time for this.”

They return to the palace a day later, riding up the main thoroughfare to the gates as the common people of the city part before them, as they emerge from their homes, as they stare after them, whispers following close behind and spreading like wildfire ahead. The crown prince’s somatophylakes ride without him. There’s only one reason they would do such a thing.

Phainon rides at the center of the somatophylakes, mostly alone, hating what this says about him, too. Hating the message he’s afraid it sends. His torc has never felt tighter around his throat.

Throughout the journey to palace, they haven’t left him alone, his new guardians. At first, he figured it was because of their oaths. Now, he’s not

so sure. They watch him carefully, and if they're all as clever as Ptolemy and Hephaestion, he's sure it's because they all saw him reaching for Hephaestion's sword. He's sure they heard him beg Hephaestion to kill him. And earlier that very day, Peucesta pulled his horse beside Phainon's to offer him a word of comfort and to assure him that he won't die, that he'll be safe with Gorgo. It'd come out more like an awkward threat, and Peucesta had maneuvered his horse away a minute later.

They think he's going to kill himself. They think he loves Mydei, especially Hephaestion, and he—he doesn't know what he feels. Not anymore. He's so tired as he dismounts the horse, as he slides to the dusty ground, as two palace guards flanked by four men wearing torcs approach in chitons too fine for most slaves. These must be the queen's own men, sent to retrieve what belongs to her.

Hephaestion grips his shoulder. "Be smart for once," he says softly.

Phainon rolls his eyes. "You—" He catches himself. Forces a small, sad smile. "I'll do my best."

One of the slaves steps forward. "Phainon. You are to come with us." He is cold, distant, expression imperious, and he even manages to flick a disdainful look at Hephaestion, as though he is above the other man. Phainon regrets never learning anything about the Kremnoan rules surrounding slavery, but certainly a citizen like Hephaestion outranks even the queen's slaves.

Still, he's not in the mood to make trouble. "Of course," he says, drifting out from under Hephaestion's hand and away from the rest of the somatophylakes.

Hephaestion takes a single step forward but catches himself. He says nothing more, and neither do the others, but there's nothing for them to say. They can't declare Phainon their charge, not without causing too many issues for everyone. Slaves aren't given guardians like them.

Phainon follows the queen's slaves, the guards falling into step behind him, cutting off any thought of escape. But if he'd wanted to escape, he

would’ve done it on the journey back. Maybe he should’ve. Maybe he should goad these men into slicing his throat, if that’s even possible. Kremnoan guards are notoriously unflappable.

They keep to the servants’ passages, out of sight of the court, passages Phainon doesn’t know particularly well. Part of him wonders if they’re taking him to the queen at all. Maybe this will be the end for him, too.

Titans. There’s that ache in his chest, that hollow pain carving through him. He’s been doing so well ignoring it, but now it throbs and pounds in time with his heartbeat, and he wants to lean over and vomit. He wants to rip something, someone, to pieces with his naked hands until his flesh is torn and bleeding. He wants to make someone else bleed, the desire directionless, untargeted. It’s not rage, it’s something else, something he doesn’t want to contemplate.

One of the slaves opens a door ahead of them, and they emerge into a splendid, gilded hallway, with murals alternating between carved reliefs of the Titans. No, not the Titans. Just Strife. This hall is a homage to Strife, is thick with his power, and at the end of it are two doors, one twice as large and ornate as the other. It’s the other, smaller door he’s led to.

“Thank you, Iason,” a woman’s voice says as Phainon passes through the door and into a lavish, open-air room that looks onto a broad courtyard.

“Your Majesty.” Iason, the slave at the head of the entourage, bows deeply. With a gesture to the other three slaves and the two guards, they all depart.

Phainon is, after all this time, alone with the Queen of Castrum Kremnos, and he doesn’t know what to say to her.

She is as he remembers: red of hair, like her son, with flashing golden eyes and handsome features. Pins of golden laurels hold her hair in elaborate twists around her head. As at the party, the tied-on sleeves of her chiton fall well past her wrists.

“Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,” she says, rising from her kline.

He should bow. He doesn’t. He’s too tired. “Your Majesty,” he says with as much deference as he can muster. It’s not much.

Stoic, expression neutral, she approaches him. He expects her to touch him, to grab him, to slap him. She folds her arms before her, craning her head to look up at him, and she says, “You killed my son,” with so little feeling, as though she can’t bear to feel anything, that it breaks him.

His heart cracks open, his grief pouring through him, a legion of men swarming a battlefield wielding his own emotions as a weapon. They stab him through the heart, stab into his guts. Eviscerated by his own grief, he swallows once, hard, and locks every muscle in his body to keep from trembling in front of her. Tears threaten his eyes, so he tips back his head and gazes upward, at the marble ceiling painted with yet another mural of Strife.

Anger replaces grief, a violent bubbling of it. It burns through him, a blazing wall of fire, evaporating his tears and leaving nothing but cold fury.

Phainon meets the Queen of Castrum Kremnos’s eyes. “Eurypon killed your son,” he says.

“Fool boy,” she says gently. “Would my husband have orchestrated such machinations as these, would he have forced Mydei onto the battlefield, were you not here?”

“And you?” Phainon demands. “Are you not equally responsible, by that measure? Did you not put me in Mydei’s household?” He doesn’t miss the faint widening of her eyes at his use of the nickname.

“Yes,” Gorgo says. “A move carefully calculated to put you close to my husband so you could do what no other Chrysos Heir has yet to manage. But you were too busy—” She breaks off, her lips pressing into a thin line. “What have you to show for my generosity? My husband still lives and yet my son, my only son, is dead. You have failed your mission, and your mistress has betrayed me. You should not have come back. You should have run.”

“My mission isn’t over. Not yet.”

Her mouth twists. “Oh? And what do you hope to gain now? Do you think I will protect you as Mydeimos did? Do you think I will step beneath Periander’s lash when you have done me so great a wrong? What mother wants to bury her only child—her only immortal child?” Each word lands like the crack of a whip, one after another, and he can only imagine this is a fraction of the pain that killed Mydei.

Phainon can’t deny the truth of her words. He cannot refute her. She is one of the Moirae, casting judgement on him. No one is more deserving of a mother’s disdain than he is. His choices, his actions, drove Mydei to a true grave, leaving nothing, not even a body to bury.

“He could still come back,” he says, and then he flinches back from her, expecting a strike.

But all Gorgo does is jerk back as though he struck her. “Could still—could still come back?” she asks, her voice sharp with her disbelief. “We have heard the rumors. Your Goldweaver’s Maiden of War didn’t just kill him. She erased his physical form from existence. She *unmade him*. And you would dare to suggest he might come back?”

“Then why are you here with me?” Phainon demands, his anger overflowing, turning sharp and acrid. This woman is right. She is right about everything. He is a murderer; he murdered her son. He may not have landed the final blow, but his every action drove Mydei to that battlefield with Castorice, and now he is full of loathing. For her, for himself. Oh, how he hates himself. “It’s been days, Your Majesty. Days, and you’re here instead of weaving his shroud and—”

She moves so fast he doesn’t register that she’s kicked his knees out from under him until his back hits the floor, until his head cracks against marble, until all the air is knocked out of him and he can only wheeze desperately. She’s on him a second later, her knees pinning his arms to the floor by his elbows, all her weight bearing down. Seething, she leans over him, stray hairs floating around her head like a flaming halo.

“Weaving his shroud?” she asks with a laugh. “*Weaving his shroud*. Do you know how Mydeimos came by his immortality, you fool child?”

Phainon gasps for air, trying to fix his interrupted breathing, trying to fill his lungs. Speckles of color cloud his vision, and his head throbs. Distantly, he wonders if he’s bleeding.

“The Oracle at Delphi prophesied that Eurypon’s line would end with him, so my husband threw Mydei into the Sea of Souls.” One of her forearms presses against his throat as he finally catches his breath only for her to threaten it again. “I begged him not to. On my knees, I pleaded with him to spare our child. He spat on me and then threw him into the Sea of Souls despite my pleas. And as soon as his back was turned, I reached into that Sea to save my boy.”

She removes her weight from Phainon’s throat, and Phainon, wheezing, draws in a full breath. His lungs burn, but his tunneling vision corrects itself in time for Gorgo to hold up her arms, for her sleeves to fall back, for him to see stumps at the ends of her wrists.

“This was the price of my love,” she says. “My husband took my hands, and you wish for me to weave my son’s shroud.” She presses one of her wrists to Phainon’s jugular, and he tries to buck her off him. But Gorgo is a warrior queen, and she moves with him, throwing her weight against him, and he can’t dislodge her. “All men do is *take*. I should have expected nothing less. I should not have trusted your mistress. For here I am, without even a body to bury while my husband yet draws breath.”

And then she’s off him, standing to the side of him as if she never kicked into the ground.

He rolls to his side, grasping at his throat as he sucks in great mouthfuls of air, as he looks up at her, radiant and terrible.

“You will serve me,” she says, shaking her arms until her sleeves fall over her wrists. “You will do my bidding, do you understand me?”

Dropping his hand, he pushes himself to his knees. She thinks he's a pawn—first Aglaea's, then Mydei's, and now hers in truth. But of course she does. She has no idea how many times he's played these games. "I understand," he says.

"I will use you for your intended purpose, Chrysos Heir," she says, and he understands that for the threat it is, but he doesn't care. Not anymore. "With you, I will tear down my husband."

He gives her a bow, fluid and practiced. "I am yours to command," he says, the lie coming easily. He has become such a good liar.

Gorgo smiles at him. "It is such a shame," she says, suddenly gentle again. "With you, I could have had two sons."

Though he's played these kinds of games so many times before, she elegantly guts him with those words, leaving him reeling. He lives an entire life in her words, a life where he wasn't a bed slave to a prince, where he and Mydei didn't meet this way, where—but that life is as much a lie as his words. No matter how much he wants it, it's a lie. There is no version of reality in which he and Mydei could ever be happy together.

He bows lower. "When do we begin?"

And then she's a woman again, a mother instead of a terrifying queen. "Allow me to mourn." She waves him aside. "The prothesis is tomorrow." She turns cold, disdainful. "At least those rites, I can perform. Iason!"

Phainon straightens as the slave enters, and he wonders how much the other slave overheard.

"Iason," she says, gentling. "Take Phainon to his room."

His room is small, smaller than the closet that should have been his in Mydei's suite, barely big enough to contain the hard palette that will be his bed. Iason bars him in the room with a bucket for his piss and shit. There's no death waiting for him here, only misery, only his own grief.

Sitting on the palette, he brings his knees to his chest.

This has all gone so very wrong. Mydei is dead, and for the first time in three days, he lets that reality wash over him. Grief, despair. Rage and fury. He wants to wrap his hands around Aglaea's throat and choke the life out of her with such visceral need that it frightens him. He imagines killing Eurypon, too—on his throne, by condemning him to the pyre, by slitting his throat like he slit the throats of that family. He detests them, loathes them. Every fiber of his being despises them so much he's surprised his own hatred doesn't somehow rewrite the fabric of reality, bending time and space to the force of his will.

Digging his fingers into his hair, he pulls at it until his scalp burns and his knuckles ache, until he's surely bruised himself. He wants to scream, but he won't give Gorgo or any of her slaves and servants the satisfaction of his breakdown.

Mydei is dead, and Phainon was the instrument of his destruction. Gorgo was right. Everything Phainon did, every action he took, sent Mydei onto that battlefield with Castorice. He drove Mydei to his own end, to dissolution.

There's no way for even an immortal body to come back from such a thing as that. Mydei is truly gone, and Phainon has never been so lost.

He doesn't understand why he's so lost. Mydei was—Mydei was—Mydei *was*, and that cuts through him, tears through him, rips him apart until he's nothing but a sieve for the hatred coursing through him. Mydei *was*, and he hates himself as much as he hates Aglaea and Eurypon and even Gorgo, because her machinations, too, put them in this place. She could have kept Phainon in her own household, could have found some other way to put him in proximity to Eurypon, but she gave him to Mydei. Mydei who *was* and will never be again.

There's a small, square window high on the wall of his cell, and through it, he's able to measure time. Another slave comes when the room purples with evening light, trading his slop bucket for a new one and leaving a tray of

meager food. Phainon forces himself to eat it, wondering if these are Gorgo's leavings and wishing, yearning for them to be Mydei's.

Darkness crawls across the cell, and he eventually lays down on the pallet. Eventually closes his eyes. Eventually dreams of the moment when Castorice must have killed Mydei, when she touched him, her hands on his arms, his face, his chest, melting him away into nothing over and over, and no matter how Phainon tries to run to Mydei, his feet never move from the hilly rise he stood on.

He wakes with the sun and the sound of women wailing. Wakes to more of an overwhelming grief that he can't possibly cope with, and so he seeks refuge in the hatred burning within him. No one brings him food, but he supposes the entire palace must be at Mydei's prothesis except for Strife, for even the Titans can be corrupted by death, and so have no place near it, excepting Thanatos. Nothing perverts the holy and divine like death. Phainon stares at one forearm, wondering if he'd bleed gold or black if he tore himself open.

The cell brightens. The wailing diminishes, and he wonders where the mourners will go, wonders if they'll pretend to cremate a body they'll never have.

He closes his eyes, resting his head against the cool wall of his cell, wondering when he'll be fed. It's almost noon, now, and there's a strange swelling of distant noise. His eyes still closed, he tries to focus on it, but it's too far away for him to make sense of it. He puts it from his mind and rises.

That distant noise grows louder, louder. He's in the middle of doing pushups off the wall when he realizes it's the sound of cheering.

Footsteps fill the hall, urgent and quick, slapping against the stone floor.

Phainon turns toward his door, a strange anticipation churning low in his gut.

Wood clatters against stone, the door's bar tossed aside, the door itself opened. Hephaestion stands there, a wild look on his face. "You must

come," he says before Phainon can even react to his presence. "It's—it's Mydei."

Chapter End Notes

a word of thanks to everyone for being so kind about the previous chapter! i was genuinely worried folks would react poorly, but you were all so wonderful <3

anyway, fun facts about gorgo ~~i originally was going to jazz hands here but that seems in poor taste~~

i wonder what that ending is about what's going on who can say

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon and Hephaestion race through the palace, Phainon so close that his toes rake down the backs of Hephaestion's ankles once, twice. Hephaestion doesn't complain. He leads Phainon through the myriad and vaguely familiar hallways, taking him toward the front entrance. As they run past guards and duck around members of the court, those rich citizens Eurypon deems worth of his attention, the distant cheering grows louder, louder. Rumbling turns into thunderous cheering, loud enough as they approach the front gates that Phainon can finally make out the words of the rhythmic chant.

Son of Gorgo, crowned in blood.

Hope swells in his chest, choking his throat. Something warm grips his heart, something so much more than mere hope, effulgent and effervescent.

They round a corner, and Leonnius peels away from the wall to join them. "Perdikkas is already at the gates with Ptolemy and Peucesta," he says, and Hephaestion gives him a clipped nod. "The queen's there, too."

But not, Phainon knows, Eurypon, who as a god must be sequestered from death.

They clear the inner gates, rushing into the courtyard. Mydei's own funerary procession is there, led by Gorgo, gowned in wine-dark robes. She is still at the head of the procession, her attention on the main gates.

"Shit," Hephaestion says, drawing to a stop. Phainon halts at his side, head cocked to the side. "Galenos is at the gates."

"I'll handle it," Leonnius says, striding forward. He beckons for Phainon to follow, and Phainon, frustrated by his own uselessness, does so. There's

nothing he can do here. He's a slave to every person in this courtyard, to every person in this city state. He has no sway with anyone except Mydei.

Beyond the front gates, the chanting is thunderous. *Son of Gorgo, crowned in blood*. Gorgo herself, closer now as Phainon and Leonnius approach the gates and the guard captain on duty, is bloodless with shock, one covered wrist at her throat. The wind catches the folds of her chiton, and it ripples in the breeze, snapping like a bloody herald.

"Captain," Leonnius says. He doesn't bother with a salute, but Phainon supposes he doesn't need to. He's separate from the guard and military structure of Castrum Kremnos. "Why are the gates closed?"

Captain Galenos, however, does salute, crisp and practiced. "It's against procedure to open the gates to a rioting crowd," he says with the patience of a man who thinks he's talking to an idiot.

"That's a welcome party, not a riot," Leonnius says. "And your men on the walls can confirm it. Our prince has returned."

Phainon's heart lurches.

The captain's eyes flick briefly toward the palace. "The prince is dead," he says, though his voice wavers with uncertainty.

A guard approaches with Perdikkas at his back, Perdikkas's expression grim and the guard clearly pressed beneath his helm. He, too, salutes both his captain and Leonnius. To the captain, he says, "Sir, there's a man—"

"Mydeimos," Perdikkas says, crossing his arms.

"—approaching through the crowd." The guard doesn't acknowledge Perdikkas. "He has the bearing of the crown prince."

"Open the gates," Leonnius says.

"We cannot allow a mob into the palace," the captain says, staring straight ahead, his posture set.

Leonnius steps closer to him. “You’d deny the crown prince entry into his own home?” he asks, voice low and threatening. “I can’t have heard you right.”

A wordless roar goes up from beyond the gates.

The captain flinches. “I—”

“Do you think the king will be pleased that you’ve refused entry not just to the crown prince but to the hero of Castrum Kremnos? The man who defeated death?” Leonnius presses.

The captain swallows.

“Open the gates,” Leonnius says again.

The captain continues to stare straight ahead, and he says nothing.

“Then order your men not to interfere,” Leonnius says, peeling away. “Phainon, with me. Perdikkas, to Hephaestion and the others at the gate.”

Phainon gives the guard captain a final look before following Leonnius. “Why wouldn’t he listen?”

“Loyal to the king,” Leonnius replies. “Like the vast majority of everyone here. And everyone knows that Eurypon doesn’t want an heir.” His lips twist in a snarl. “The sun will never set on Eurypon’s empire.” They reach the portcullis, surrounded by guards who take menacing steps forward at their approach. Leonnius glances over his shoulder, and Phainon does, too.

The guard captain is there behind them, staring past them still to his men. He gives a minute shake of his head. Whatever else can be said about Eurypon’s men, they are well trained. The guards stand down, stepping aside, and Leonnius and Phainon are on the winch, throwing their weight against it to turn it. The winch gives beneath their combined strength, but it’s meant for four men, not two, so they struggle, their feet digging into the ground as they labor to open the portcullis. The chains scream in protest,

pulling taut, but the portcullis lifts, and the roaring of the crowd grows louder still.

“To the gate,” the guard captain commands, and his men leave Leonnius and Phainon to their work.

“You really think it’s him?” Phainon asks as he struggles with the winch.

Leonnius grunts. “No one would chant these words for anyone else.”

Phainon’s heart lurches. “A pretender, though.”

“Would be put to death immediately. No one’s that stupid.”

The winch jerks to a stop, at its limit, and Leonnius holds it while Phainon secures it, and then they’re out of the gatehouse, they’re in the courtyard, and the palace guards are holding back a throng of people with the help of Mydei’s somatophylakes. The crowd’s chanting is deafening, but Phainon barely hears them.

His world narrows to the parting of bodies at the front of the crowd, people peeling back to reveal a narrow path and a man at the heart of the crowd with red-gold hair and leonine eyes, a man wearing a tattered chiton, bare-chested except for his tattoos.

Mydei.

Phainon shoves forward, through the line of guards, pushing them aside until he’s beside Hephaestion. Hephaestion who salutes his prince and joins the chanting of the crowd: *Son of Gorgo, crowned in blood*.

The other somatophylakes, too, have taken up the call. The guards say nothing as they form a barrier against the pulsating crowd, but their silence couldn’t matter less.

And Mydei. Mydei meets Phainon’s gaze, and Phainon’s lips part and his heart pounds, and he wants to go to his knees at Mydei’s feet. He wants to beg for forgiveness, but this isn’t the moment. It’s not his moment. It’s Mydei’s, and Mydei is resplendent in the afternoon sunlight, haloed and

golden and perfect, the warrior prince who defeated the Servant of Death's deadly touch.

"Phainon," he says, pressing his hand to Phainon's face. Lightning ricochets through Phainon's veins. Mydei's touch burns, and he grips Mydei's wrist with his own hand, caught in Mydei's arresting gaze, drowning in it.

"You're alive," he says, half expecting Mydei to condemn him, because Mydei wouldn't have died if not for Phainon's presence.

Mydei laughs. "My deaths are cheap," he says, and Phainon's stomach turns. Releasing Phainon's face, he turns to Hephaestion, clapping him on the shoulder. Hephaestion gives him a nod but doesn't stop his chanting until Mydei, ducking through the line of guards, ascends the steps to the palace's inner gates.

Gorgo separates from her fellow mourners, one arm lifted to her face.

The people surge against the line of guards with such force that Phainon expects them to break. They don't, but Phainon stumbles back beyond the line of men, caught between the people and Mydei on the steps.

Mydei raises both his hands, and the chanting comes to a slow, echoing halt.

The silence is somehow louder, the world holding its breath, and Phainon thinks the man on the palace steps isn't a prince. Mydei is a king.

"Castrum Kremnos," Mydei calls, his voice carrying like thunder through the courtyard.

Shouts from the crowd, a raucous cheer. Men and women raise their fists and shout, "Castrum Kremnos!" in echo. Only when their cries have died does Mydei continue.

"Castrum Kremnos," he calls again, "I stand before you having truly defeated death. The Daughter of the River of Souls took my form from me,

but I have returned from the depths of the underworld, escaping from beneath the thumb of Thanatos themself to stand before you."

Another cheer from the crowd, booming like thunder. The guards strain against the pressure of so many people, caging them in the threshold of the courtyard, and a strange anxiety curls in Phainon's stomach, a fear the crowd might surge forward and overwhelm them, might rush into the courtyard like a flood. And, too, there is the fear of where this speech might go, that Mydei, having been killed by Castorice, might not side with his father, no, but might still stand against Aglaea and Okhema and all she embodies.

Mydei lifts his hands again, calling for quiet, and he gets it except for the low murmur of people passing his words through the crowd.

"I come to you a changed man," he says, "having put on my flesh anew, traversing the Acheron itself from the depths of Tartarus to return to you. I have come to you in this time of endless war, where peace seems so distant, to ask you this: have you not paid enough?"

Relief washes through Phainon, so profound that his knees nearly give out. Fear chases in relief's wake, cold and cruel, and he shifts his stance so he can watch Mydei and the crowd and Mydei's mother, too. Gorgo remains stricken, pale against her dark robes, and the crowd has gone strangely still, as though they can't make sense of what Mydei has just said.

"Have you not paid enough in bread gone not to your tables but to the front?" Mydei asks. "Have you not paid enough in the limbs of your husbands and your sons, in children who will never come home, in empty bellies and barren fields?"

The only sound now is the murmur of people passing back Mydei's words. Tension fills Phainon's limbs, and he clenches his right hand in a fist, wishing he had a blade at his side. He stands alone between the crowd and Mydei, opposite Gorgo and her mourners, set apart, and he has no recourse, no way to defend himself—or anyone else—if the crowd decides it doesn't like Mydei's speech.

“Are you not tired?” Mydei demands. A ripple goes through the crowd. Unease, uncertainty. “Are you not exhausted, sick to death of hunger and loss?” Another ripple, this time of quiet agreement, and the guards are not so well trained that they disguise their own disquiet as they set their shields more firmly before them and reach for their blades. “I ask you, the people of Castrum Kremnos, is there no other way the world may live? Must we sacrifice our children to endless wars that see us maimed and broken and driven to the brink of starvation?”

Phainon’s breath trembles, shuddering as he inhales. Mydei has come back from death not to exhort the people to violence but to call for peace, and he could weep even as the fear remains—no longer that Mydei will incite more violence but rather that the people might turn on him. That the guards might turn on him.

“In this restored life, I seek to breathe new vitality into the empire of Castrum Kremnos, but we cannot have lives if we mire ourselves in death. We cannot pursue knowledge, cannot create, cannot renew, if we consign ourselves to death on the field of battle. Where is the honor in destroying ourselves for land the black tide consumes? Where is the reason in our repeated, endless sacrifice?” Mydei shouts each word, each question, and the crowd is silent except to relay his words, those at the front enraptured.

Only Gorgo is not fixed on Mydei, her eyes lifted to the second, interior wall, to the balustrade, and Phainon raises his gaze, too. There above them, above Mydei, stands a god who should be in seclusion, protected from the funerary rites of his own son.

Mydei raises his fist. “Castrum Kremnos, if we wish to see the rebirth of our own nation as a place of prosperity, we must find our way to peace!”

Phainon is moving before he has a chance to think, is rushing the steps of the inner courtyard. He slams into Mydei, yanking him to the side, as stone explodes where Mydei once stood, fractured by the tremendous force of a single, golden lance.

Mydei hits the stone, sliding across it. The pain registers distantly, the body on top of his much more presently, and the lance embedded in the stone where he just stood quite immediately. Screams erupt from the crowd as Phainon peels off him, as both of them watch Eurypon, wearing little more than a chiton of his own, alight on the ground beside his lance.

“Death has made you bold, Mydeimos,” Eurypon says, his lips stretching into a broad smile that doesn’t reach his eyes. His eyes are cold and dead, utterly lacking in humanity.

With Phainon’s help, Mydei rises. “Father.”

“Am I?” Eurypon asks. “Am I your father or your god?”

Mydei shifts his gaze beyond Eurypon’s shoulder, to where the guards keep back the press of people—who have, of course, opted not to flee—and to where his mother stands with the other mourners, expression inscrutable at such a distance. “Can you not be both?” he asks, meeting Eurypon’s flat eyes once more.

It’s a child’s question, one last plea from a boy loved only by his mother, a child cast aside and abused by his father, the final curl of smoke from the hope of a dying candle.

“No,” Eurypon says, gripping his lance and yanking its point from the stone.

And there it is, the last of whatever affection Mydei might harbor for the man who helped create him evaporating like so much dew on a hot morning. “You are mad,” he says, stepping forward, putting himself between Eurypon and Phainon. “And you aren’t fit to rule Castrum Kremnos.”

“I am your *god*,” Eurypon roars, echoing across the courtyard.

“Where is your honor?” Mydei demands. “Where is your reason? You are a defiled god, unworthy to lead our people.” He shifts his feet, bracing himself, but the impact of Eurypon’s attack still knocks him off his feet.

Air bursts from his lungs as he collides with a nearby column. His vision clouds over. He gasps for breath as his knees hit the floor, but he has no time to stay there. Eurypon is too fast for him to linger. Mydei rolls to the side before he's caught his breath, his back aching, as Eurypon drives his lance clear through the column, punching a hole through it.

Distant shouts fill the air; he recognizes Hephaestion and Leonnius's voices, but he has no time to wonder what they're doing. He hopes they're crowding the people, his mother, the mourners out of the courtyard, because this is not a place for humanity.

Eurypon wrenches his lance free of the column and rounds on Mydei. He's fucked. Without a weapon—maybe there are blades in the guard tower beside the portcullis, but that's so far—he has only his body to use against Eurypon, and there's no way he can hold up. Deaths rendered by blade rarely incapacitate him for long, but that period will be long enough for Eurypon to turn on his somatophylakes. On whoever's still in the courtyard. On Phainon.

Mydei crouches low as Eurypon rushes him. They collide, Mydei slapping aside the tip of the lance, letting it cut across his palm and shoulder. He slides backward, using his own momentum to twist away from Eurypon and drive an elbow into his back, into his kidneys. But Eurypon is a Titan, and Mydei only half a god, the promise of one. Instead of stumbling with pain, Eurypon releases a furious roar and rounds on Mydei, driving him back with wild thrusts of his lance.

The blade is barely visible as it punches through the air, whispering across Mydei's cheek, his ear, his arms. He dodges each strike instinctively; though he's not familiar with Eurypon's particular style, he knows these forms, has trained in them since childhood, and reading them isn't so difficult. This long-ingrained knowledge keeps him alive as he dances out of reach of Eurypon's lance.

How strange that he's not afraid. The lance blade slides across his side, and it hurts, but Mydei feels no fear, only a cool, dispassionate anger. This is the man who has held Mydei and the whole of Castrum Kremnos under his thumb for decades, who has tormented Mydei personally, who created an

empire only to drive it to the brink of ruin. Pathetic. This is a man who lacks all reason, all honor, and if he is allowed to persist, he will destroy the whole of the world.

Someone must put him down. Aside from Aglaea—and perhaps Thanatos—the other Titans have turned a blind eye to Strife's advancement across Amphoreus. They have been content to let city state after city state fall, doing nothing to turn Strife's blade and army aside.

Let it be Mydei, then, who will battle endlessly to his own death, who will turn the entirety of the palace into a battlefield if he must, who puts an end to this.

Sunlight glints off a blade, and Mydei lunges to the side. He catches Hephaestion's gladius just above the hilt, grimacing as it cuts into the fingers of his left hand. Tossing it into the palm of his right, he whirls to face Eurypon, knocking aside the blade of the mad god's lance just before it can pierce through his stomach.

"Do you think a blade will save you, boy?" Eurypon demands, bearing down on him with a wild flurry of blows Mydei can barely fend off. "Do you think you, a mere child, can defeat a Titan?"

He has to.

Sweat drips into his eyes and down his back. One of his borrowed sandals, poorly made, snaps, so he kicks both off his feet as he twists away from Eurypon's strikes. He dances across the packed earth of the courtyard, desperately trying to do too many things at once.

Protect his mother and the mourners. Keep Eurypon distracted from the people, now well on their way out of the gate. Deflect attention from Phainon, who—who is no longer on the steps.

There's no time to determine where Phainon has gone, not as Eurypon's lance strikes faster, faster. Mydei pants heavily, muscles burning as he strains to keep up with the mad god's terrible speed, as he barely manages to fend off hit after hit.

He misses, taking a nasty thrust between two ribs. He gasps, choking on the pain, as Eurypon tears the blade out of him sideways, ripping through his skin. He can’t falter. Doesn’t let himself give over to the blazing pain. He lunges into the space Eurypon has created, swiping his blade up, up, up, and the tip of his gladius cuts across Eurypon’s chest.

Gold blood pours from the mark, and Eurypon stands there, stunned.

Mydei doesn’t waste the opportunity. He lashes out again, thrusting his blade toward Eurypon’s soft belly.

Eurypon grabs the blade, ripping it from Mydei’s hands, and throwing it aside. He snarls, the sound barely human, reaching with gold-streaked fingers for Mydei’s throat, only to whip around at the last possible moment and duck beneath the flight of a javelin. The javelin soars over Mydei’s shoulder as he stands panting, as he stares past Eurypon to Phainon. Phainon who runs toward them, pulling a gladius from its scabbard.

He engages Eurypon, and they don’t fight, they dance. Mydei staggers back, one eye on the fight, disbelieving, as he searches for another blade.

Phainon moves with liquid grace, with the fluidity of a man who lives and breathes with his sword, not a farmer’s pitchfork. His footwork is quick, nimble, as he glides from one strike to the next, meeting Eurypon’s fevered attacks with measured ones of his own.

“Mydei.” He looks away long enough to accept the blade Hephaestion offers, his somatophylakes falling in around him. Hephaestion gives him a crisp nod. “We’re with you,” Hephaestion says.

And while that means the world to him, he shakes his head. “Not against a Titan.”

Leonnius watches the fight beyond them, watches Eurypon throw Phainon into a wall and Phainon recover with a speed that borders on inhuman. “No,” he says, expression fierce. “This a rebellion for men.” He grabs Mydei’s upper arm. “The gods should fear us. All of us.”

“We’ve got your back,” Hephaestion says. “Yours and his.” Mydei’s eyes widen, and he wonders what has changed in these three days he’s been dead that Hephaestion would willingly defend Phainon. “Command us.”

Mydei turns back to Phainon and Eurypon, watching with an even more critical eye as Phainon weaves between Eurypon’s strikes with the air of someone who knows this fighting style intimately. Perhaps defectors from Kremnos taught Phainon, but Mydei doesn’t have the time to play at analysis. He gestures his friends forward. “Leonnius, Hephaestion, shields.”

The two step forward, flanking him, holding their shields steady.

“Perdikkas. Peucesta.” They step up behind Leonnius and Hephaestion respectively, spears at the ready. It’s not an ideal, or even decent, shield wall, but it will have to do. He glances over his shoulder at Ptolemy, who stands unarmed. “Get my mother and the mourners out of the courtyard, then find your bow and take whatever shots you can.”

Ptolemy gives him a quick salute and hurries away.

“Harry right and left flanks,” Mydei tells his men, and they advance. “Break to protect yourselves, and if he uses the crystals to attack, get out.”

They’re too well trained to gainsay him, even though he knows they want to. He won’t risk their lives. Not for this. Not for Eurypon. And maybe a selfish part of him wants Eurypon for himself—for the lake, for Gorgo, for men like Strasanor.

Across the courtyard, Phainon has noticed them, and he has begun to do what Mydei can only think is impossible: he’s pushing Eurypon back. Phainon fights with a graceful fury that Mydei has never seen before, not from Phainon himself or any of Mydei’s own trainers. Not even Krateros is as fluidly beautiful, and Krateros is one of the best swordsmen Mydei has ever worked with, surpassed only by god-king Eurypon himself. But there is Phainon, beating down on Eurypon, driving him backwards one step at a time, until Mydei’s somatophylakes flank him and Mydei is at his back.

They harry Eurypon with their strikes, forcing him to fend off attacks from every angle. Perdikkas and Peucesta manage to land blows as Leonnius and Hephaestion ward off Eurypon's strikes, but they are only men. They groan under Eurypon's return attacks, staggering back, until Eurypon drives the point of his lance through Hephaestion's shield and tears it from Hephaestion's hands.

Hephaestion shoves Peucesta back, but the movement costs him. Mydei watches, one step too far, as Eurypon reaches out with an arm glowing virulent red with glittering crystal—only for Phainon to lunge forward and swipe his blade through the joint of Eurypon's wrist.

Eurypon staggers, howling, as golden blood pours from his wrist. His lance clatters to the ground.

If they weren't fighting a god, Mydei might call his men off. A man without a hand is surely defeated. But Eurypon *is* a god, and they must take every opportunity they can muster. While Phainon yanks a fallen Hephaestion to his feet and snaps, "Go, get out!" at him, Mydei leaps forward, gripping his blade overhead with both hands. He drives the point down, down, aiming for the soft hollow of Eurypon's collarbone. This is his moment, their moment. He tastes victory.

Eurypon surges upward, grabbing Mydei by the wrists with his good hand, and his strength is great and terrible. His fingers grind Mydei's bones together with such force that he drops his blade as pain claws up his forearms and into his shoulders. Grinning savagely, Eurypon's stump still dripping blood, he steps into Mydei.

"Fool boy," he hisses, and red crystal spears through the ragged flesh at the end of Eurypon's arm, forming into a new hand. "Did you think—"

Phainon drives his blade through Eurypon's spine.

Chest heaving, Mydei smiles, cold and cruel. "Did I think what?" he demands. "That we couldn't beat you?" He laughs. "Old man, your time is done."

Eurypon looks down at the blade protruding from his chest. He laughs, too, but his laughter is sharp, manic. It grows louder, hysterical, as an energy hums in the air around him, a vibration thrumming in Mydei's very bones.

His eyes go wide. "Phainon," he says, urgent. "Leonnius, Perdikkas—" But they've already thrown themselves back, stumbling away, except for Phainon, who barrels into Mydei. Mydei's shoulders scream in protest as the force of Phainon's impact tears him free of Eurypon's grip, so agonizing that he thinks he might've dislocated both arms. He hits the ground, rolling with Phainon until they come to a stop, and the pain is nothing compared to the terror that grips him when he looks up.

The thing that has replaced his father, all bone-white and shining gold armor, with four arms instead of two, is not man.

When he was a child, Gorgo told him of Nikador, of the Lance of Fury, and his god form. She described a Titan, a god descended to Amphoreus to rule not with might and terror but with justice and honor, a creature of reason.

What stands before him, eyes rolling as it throws back its head and shrieks, is not a creature of reason. It is a god gone mad, drunk on its own power, awful to behold.

"Run," he says to Phainon, grabbing at his arm and dragging him to his feet.

Phainon huffs out a laugh, wiping a streak of gold blood across his mouth. "Not a chance, Mydei," he says. He squeezes Mydei's elbow, hefting his sword. "I let you die before. Not this time."

"That's a god," Mydei reminds him.

Phainon grins at him, and there's a strange mania in his eyes, too, a wild look that Mydei has never seen before. Not on Phainon. "Good thing we're demigods, then." He slaps Mydei on the back. "You and me, Your Highness."

"Your life—"

“Isn’t more important than yours.” He steps on the hilt of a nearby sword, kicking it into his hand, and he offers it, hilt first, to Mydei. “Together.”

Mydei stares at him. “To—”

Eurypon moves. Like a flash of lightning, the Titan of Strife is between them, lashing out with too many lances. Lances of red crystal descend from the sky, piercing the ground, and Mydei throws himself back, dodging between the falling missiles.

“Run,” he shouts at his somatophylakes. “Flee!”

On the other side of the courtyard, Leonnius drags Perdikkas to his feet, looking not at Mydei but at Phainon. Something passes between them in that strange, frozen moment. Leonnius nods, and maybe Phainon responds, but Mydei doesn’t see it, too busy searching out Hephaestion. Hephaestion leans heavily on Peucesta as Peucesta carries him toward the palace steps, staggering up it, and then all four of them are clear of the courtyard, leaving just Phainon and Mydei to fight a god.

They’ve never fought together, but Phainon moves with Mydei like an extension of Mydei’s own body. Mydei barely has to think and Phainon is acting as if he’s inside Mydei’s head, sharing his thoughts. Together, they trade Eurypon’s lightning-fast blows between them, shoring up each other’s weaknesses. They are, both of them, exhausted, drenched in sweat, the lone bastions standing against a mad Titan.

Eurypon summons barrage after barrage of lances, calling them down from the heavens themselves. They pierce through the palace walls, gouge deep into the earth, sending up sprays of dirt and rock, but when Mydei stumbles, Phainon covers for him, and when Phainon stumbles, Mydei does the same.

Red crystals explode out of the ground, ripping through the earth, forcing them apart, but they work back to each other, guarding each other as they take turns striking at the Lance of Fury. What first appeared to be armor is no more than flesh; they rip at it with their blades, bleeding the Titan, but that’s not enough. Mydei knows it’s not enough. They need to strike a

decisive blow, need to incapacitate Eurypon. They are mortal; Eurypon is not. They tire, but Eurypon's energy seems boundless.

Once more, he splits them apart, and he turns on Mydei as Mydei sprints away, trying to put distance between them. Lances pierce his sides, and it's with alarm that he realizes a dreadful truth: Eurypon knows his weakness. How, he isn't sure, only Gorgo knows the full truth of it, not even his somatophylakes are aware, but Eurypon now targets his back, his spine—only for Phainon to rush in and bat aside the blades at Mydei's back, giving him time to whirl about and recover.

This isn't working. Fighting Eurypon fairly isn't working. He keeps them at bay with crystal and lance, ripping into them, bleeding them, and they can't keep doing this. They need a decisive blow.

Panting at Phainon's side, Mydei wipes his brow.

Eurypon stands on the opposite side of the courtyard, laughing hysterically even now. "My own son!" he crows. "My own son seeks to kill me!"

As every son of Castrum Kremnos's kings has sought to kill his father in turn, but Mydei doesn't waste his breath on that commentary. "The coreflame," he manages, breath coming hard. "We need to get his coreflame."

Eurypon charges forward, separating them. They whirl away from him, coming back together for a brief moment.

They don't have much time left. The wounds Mydei has accrued have healed, but he's exhausted, and Phainon's wounds can't heal. Blood drips down his arms, across his chest, over his side. There's a deep cut in the meat of his thigh. Phainon will die if they don't deal with this quickly, bleeding out in the courtyard.

"Make an opening. Get his lance out of his hands," Phainon says. "I'll hold him. You—"

Lances hammer down from the sky, forcing them apart once more, but it’s a good plan.

Mydei rushes Eurypon, baiting him, distracting him, turning him away from Phainon until Phainon can get behind him. Until Phainon can lunge for Eurypon’s back. Strong arms wrap around Eurypon’s chest from behind, and Phainon slings his legs around Eurypon’s waist. He flexes, straining, and uses his own momentum to take Eurypon to the ground.

In an instant, Mydei is on them both, straddling the mad god’s stomach, helping Phainon to hold him down. It’s not that Phainon is stronger than Eurypon. He’s not. He can’t be. Eurypon is a full god, and Phainon merely a Chrysos Heir with the capacity to become one, but Phainon moves as though he knows what Eurypon will do. As though he’s done this before, as though he’s intimately familiar with how Eurypon reacts to being bound.

Mydei brings his blade to Eurypon’s throat.

“You won’t do it,” Eurypon rasps, his voice wrecked from his hysterical laughter. “You won’t—”

Mydei does. He slices the blade through Eurypon’s neck without any hesitation. The thing beneath him isn’t his father, isn’t his god, isn’t any god worthy of worship, and he slays him.

Throwing aside the gladius as Eurypon chokes on his own blood, Mydei reaches for Eurypon’s chest. Something deep inside him vibrates like struck crystal, resonant with something else inside Eurypon—and he wants to reject it. Wants to reject anything he shares with Eurypon. But this must be their blood, not the blood of family but that of divinity. His golden blood and Eurypon’s harmonizing as Mydei grasps some strange power in the aether itself.

It shouldn’t be him. This shouldn’t be him. He wants nothing of his father, not even the power of a coreflame, but there’s no one else except Phainon, and Phainon is many things but he is not the embodiment of Strife. Mydei isn’t, either. Mydei has rejected Eurypon’s vision for Castrum Kremnos, the empire, its war, its deaths. He doesn’t want anything to do with it, sees no

honor in it. But giving up the coreflame means turning it over to Phainon, and Phainon—Phainon possesses yet too many secrets to be given such an overwhelming power that will surely drive him to madness, too.

There is no choice. This, then, must be Gorgo's ultimate goal. Not just to see her husband killed but her son ascended to godhood, and for a single, aching moment, Mydei feels used. Feels taken advantage of. He never wanted this. Never wanted to kill his father, to slay a god, to pick up the mantle of Strife. Eurypon's vision of Strife was never one Mydei wanted to emulate. To be a Titan is to be bound by power and ritual and ancient law that Mydei wants nothing of, but he has no other choice.

A crystallized teardrop emerges from Eurypon's chest.

He gurgles, gasping, flailing weakly in Phainon's hold.

Mydei pities him. The mad god, reduced to this, alone, not even his guards attempting to defend him.

Leaning over Eurypon's body, Mydei finds his eyes in the strange form he possesses. "I will be better than you," he vows. "In every possible way, I will be better." And he takes the coreflame in his hand and presses it to his own chest.

Lightning fills his veins. Fire burns through him. He gasps, eyes going wide, as power surges beneath skin that is suddenly too tight, too small, to contain everything he is. Beneath him, Eurypon's armor fades, leaving only a broken, bloodied man with his throat slit wide open, and Mydei *burns*. He shoves himself to his feet and stumbles away from Eurypon's dying body and from Phainon, certain he must be blazing.

Pain radiates through him, consumes him. He goes to his knees, bending until his forehead touches the ground, and he screams through it as power remakes him, reforms him, forging him in the crucible of a burning star. He is suddenly so much *more* than he was, his world expanding the power of Strife and conquest and destruction.

And then Phainon's hands are on him, cool in comparison to the burning of his own flesh, gentle on his back, his shoulder, his face. "Mydei," he says, and Mydei climbs on top of the power coursing through him. Mydei takes control of it, forcing it to fit his flesh, demanding it bow to him instead of breaking him.

The pain diminishes. The burning fades.

He is on his knees in the middle of the courtyard, golden blood all over his hands, splattered on his chest, and he looks up to find Phainon before him, a terrified look on his face.

"Mydei?" he asks, his hands like cool water against Mydei's cheeks.

Mydei wraps his fingers around Phainon's wrists. "I am—myself," he manages, hoarse.

Relief washes over Phainon's face. He bends forward, resting his forehead against Mydei's. "Thank all the Titans," Phainon breathes.

The courtyard around them is silent, Eurypon's death rattles quiet, now. There are no crowds chanting Mydei's name, no guards cheering his victory, only the quiet susurration of the wind through the strawberry trees.

And then Gorgo's voice cuts through the silence. "Hail, Mydeimos, Savage God, Master of Legions, and Lance of Fury," she calls.

He turns toward her voice, turns to find her standing atop the stairs to the inner gates, her veil thrown back from her hair, her expression fierce.

"Hail," she calls out again. "Hail the King of—"

Mydei rises. "No," he says, and his voice carries like thunder through the courtyard, silencing her.

Behind her, there is an army of people. His somatophylakes stand flanked by members of the court, those rich citizens who curried Eurypon's favor. They have seen everything, he is certain. They watched him take the

coreflame of Strife, and they know he is their god and their king, but he doesn't want it. Doesn't want any of it.

Gorgo descends the stairs toward Mydei, lifting her arms as though to embrace him, and he is horrified to realize he wants to step back. That same feeling washes over him, the sense that his own mother used him, and it takes everything he is not to pull away from her. "Strife is complete once more in you, my son," she says, her voice pitched lower so that only he and Phainon can hear. "His honor and reason are restored—in you."

"What do you mean?" Mydei demands, a cold dread griping him.

"Strife has always been made of his tenacity, his courage, his sacrifice, reason, and honor, but your father cast off reason and honor," Gorgo says, low and urgent. She lowers her arms, the wind catching her robes. "He thought them useless. Before he could seal them beyond reach, I used sorcery to bind them to *you*."

Mydei recoils.

Phainon touches his arm, a steadying presence, but otherwise says nothing. His expression is a strange mix of pensive and disbelief, though Mydei is reeling too much to understand that combination.

"You—did what?" he asks, stunned.

Gorgo leans toward him, pressing one wrist to her chest. "I bound reason and honor to you when you were freshly born, on the same night your father split those aspects away from himself, and when he discovered the truth, he sought to throw you into the Sea of Souls."

"He drove himself mad," Phainon says.

"Yes." Gorgo nods. "He thought honor and reason had no bearing, no meaning. That they were lesser traits for Strife to embody, so he cast them aside, but I knew if we were to have peace, we would need them reunited once more." She smiles at Mydei, and Mydei can't help but feel he is about

to devastate her. “Behold the Titan of Strife,” she shouts for the onlookers to hear. “Mydeimos, the Lance of Fury, the king of—”

“I am no king,” Mydei says, turning away from Gorgo. He approaches Eurypon’s corpse, looking down at it, and the blood that pools around the fallen Titan’s ruined throat. Bending down, he takes the laurel crown from Eurypon’s head, and he holds it up for the crowd of onlookers to see.

The guards begin to pour through the gate, murmuring with alarm at the sight of their fallen king and Titan, but no one approaches Mydei.

“I am no king,” he says again. “For decades, the god-king Eurypon has led Castrum Kremnos closer and closer to ruin. No more. The crown of Castrum Kremnos will no longer rest on the head of the Titan of Strife.”

“Mydeimos,” Gorgo whispers, her expression stark and face blanched. “Mydeimos, what are you doing?”

He turns to her, approaching with the laurels held high, and Phainon slips behind her, caging her in, intuiting Mydei’s purpose only a moment before Gorgo does. She has no time to duck away. Mydei lowers the laurel crown onto her shining copper hair.

“Hail, Gorgo!” he shouts, turning first to the guards, who are the most immediate danger, who have been trained not to be loyal to the crown but to Eurypon.

The guard captain looks at Eurypon’s corpse. Looks at Mydei. Looks at Gorgo. His mental arithmetic doesn’t take him long. He clearly understands his position, and he lifts his fist in salute. “Hail, Gorgo!” he calls, and his men fall in line, offering salutes of their own and echoing his cry.

“Hail, Gorgo!” Mydei shouts again, turning this time to the stairs, to the inner gates, to the congregated crowd of onlookers, those noble citizens and members of the military. These represent dangers less immediate but no less crucial, for if Gorgo has no support from them, her rule has no legitimacy.

His somatophylakes respond first. “Hail, Gorgo!” Hephaestion shouts. The others take up the cry, and the pressure of their ready acceptance ripples through the crowd. The citizens echo Hephaestion, but Mydei notices among them the silent generals once allied with his father.

“You mustn’t,” Gorgo whispers, harsh.

Mydei turns to her once again, dropping his hands from her crown. “It is the duty of Strife to hold back the black tide,” he says, loud enough for the guards and the watching crowd to hear. “But not to rule. The rule of Castrum Kremnos passes to Queen Gorgo, and I will turn my attention toward the tide, to hold it back, to protect Amphoreus as Strife did in decades past.”

“Good,” says a new voice, a familiar voice.

The guards react as they were trained, turning their spears on a green-haired man with an eyepatch, barring Anaxagoras from stepping through the main gate and into the courtyard.

He stands with his hands behind his back, his expression placid. “Good,” he says again, speaking directly to Mydei, “because the black tide has overtaken the Grove.”

Chapter End Notes

> well that was exciting!
>
> as a small fyi i'll be on vacation for the next two weeks, but i have the next two chapters written (i have a significant backlog, thank goodness), and they'll still go up more or less on time just later in the day
>
> as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With only three generals, Themistocles among them; Mydei's somatophylakes, including Phainon; Gorgo; and Anaxagoras and a young, pink-haired woman who follows behind him, Eurypon's war room feels empty. Mydei isn't surprised that the bulk of generals aren't here, though; they shuffled away in the chaos that followed Anaxagoras's announcement in the courtyard, slinking into the shadows, presumably to flee the palace itself. Well Mydei knows that plenty of them were only loyal to Eurypon and the crown out of fear, but others were loyal for the rewards he gave them, and now is as good a time as any for generals in either category to escape.

He wonders if he's a terrible man for mourning the lack of generals more than Eurypon's death. There is no sorrow within him for the man who was the Strife Titan. No part of him regrets what he did in the courtyard, and he wonders if that doesn't make him a horrible man, a terrible son. But Eurypon was barely his father, did little more than spend his seed inside of Gorgo to create him; he deserves no grief and less regret.

His eyes drift across the people at the war table, over Themistocles, whose presence surprises him. Themistocles was his father's most loyal general, and yet here he stands beside Gorgo. Anaxagoras is across from them, his hands braced on the table, that bright-eyed girl at his back, and Mydei's somatophylakes fill in the spaces between. Phainon lingers behind Hephaestion, beyond the end of the table, his expression a study in neutrality.

Mydei watches him, wary, curious, uncertain. No mere spy, no farmer's son, could have fought Eurypon the way Phainon did. There is so much more to Phainon than what he's revealed, and they will need to discuss all of it if there is to be trust between them.

Their eyes meet. Phainon looks away first. His expression is too inscrutable to read.

“—tide is Amphoreus’s most immediate concern,” Anaxagoras is saying, speaking directly to Gorgo.

“You will address the king of Castrum Kremnos,” one of the generals snaps, and Mydei resists the urge to turn his eyes to the heavens in supplication—if only because he is now one of the Titans to which men pray, but also in an effort not to reveal his own exasperation.

He turns to the general. “Did I not give the crown to my mother?” he asks.

“Indeed,” Gorgo says dryly, “Mydeimos abdicated in front of the court and other numerous witnesses.”

“By laws both ancient and modern, Her Majesty now the queen of Castrum Kremnos,” Themistocles says to the general, his expression frigid, and Mydei wonders at that. Wonders if there isn’t something between Themistocles and his mother that he’s missed in these recent months. “Anaxagoras is right in addressing her.”

The general’s face mottles red, but he gives a stiff nod of his head to Gorgo while Anaxagoras rolls his eyes and drawls, “Now that you have the order of succession ironed out, can we focus on what matters? The black tide will be on Castrum Kremnos inside of a week.”

That stuns everyone at the table into momentary silence, until Themistocles leans over the war table and assembles pieces representative of legions around the Grove. “Show us,” he says.

“I can do better,” Anaxagoras says, extending his hand. “Hyacinthia.” The girl, Hyacinthia, reaches into a bag at her side and removes from it a rolled parchment. Anaxagoras takes it and snaps it open, laying it across a clear space on the table.

As one, all the men surrounding the table except for Hephaestion lean over the map, and they take in a collective breath. Mydei rubs a hand over his

face, staring at the detail of the black tide's advancement, at the notations Anaxagoras has made of its inevitable progress toward Castrum Kremnos.

"This is accurate?" Themistocles demands. "What proof have we that you aren't lying to us?"

Anaxagoras makes a derisive noise. "Why would I waste my time—?"

But Hephaestion, who had turned away to accept another rolled parchment from a servant, unrolls a second map. "I can confirm it," he says, laying his map across the table, too.

"What is this?" Gorgo asks.

"A map," Anaxagoras volunteers.

The rest ignore him.

"I've had my own men keeping an on the black tide's progress," Mydei admits, "but this…" There are miles of difference between the edge of the black tide on Anaxagoras's map and Hephaestion's. "This is too quick a change."

Anaxagoras shakes his head. "The tide's forward momentum has increased exponentially these past few weeks," he says, indicating its progress on both Hephaestion's map and his own, showing where the progress is mirrored. "See here, it was here two weeks ago, and it covered twice the distance between these two city states in half the time it took to reach between these. If the progress is dated correctly on your man's map—"

"It is," Hephaestion says.

"—then we can confirm the two maps show the same rates of change." Anaxagoras taps on the black tide's closest frontier line on his own map. "A week," he says again, and Mydei inhales deeply. That's barely enough time for an evacuation, and they will certainly need to evacuate. "And you will notice something particularly strange about both maps," Anaxagoras adds.

Mydei leans closer, peering at the lines describing the black tide's most recent front on both maps. His eyes go wide, and he parts his lips to speak.

"The black tide points toward Okhema," Phainon says before Mydei can.

Mydei lifts his eyes to Phainon, who remains behind Hephaestion. Perhaps if he craned his head, he might be able to see the table, but surely not clearly enough to make such an observation.

Again, Phainon meets his eyes. Again, Phainon looks away.

Themistocles utters a mild oath to ward off evil. "Its path will take it directly though Castrum Kremnos," he observes.

"As I have intimated," Anaxagoras snaps, clearly irritated. He jabs a finger at the map. "If the tide continues, it will destroy the entirety of the known world."

"Then we will send Mydeimos," Gorgo says. "Strife is the tide's ancient enemy. He will push it back."

"Will we trust a man who abandoned his birthright to uphold his oaths?" another of the generals demands.

Themistocles frowns. "And what of the Goldweaver's armies?" he asks. "Do any of us think she will withdraw in the face of the black tide?"

"Let her conquer an empty city," Hephaestion volunteers. "Evacuate Castrum Kremnos."

"And then we will leave our women, children, and elders vulnerable to her forces," Themistocles says.

Anaxagoras scoffs. "They'll die regardless if you stay here," he says.

"Who's to say the people will accept their new queen while Mydeimos yet lives," that first general says, pounding his fist on the table.

The gathering turns to shouting—Themistocles maintains his concerns over Aglaea's forces, which one of the generals insists will have to turn back or come face to face with the tide as well. Anaxagoras is relentless about the tide's approach not just on Castrum Kremnos but on Okhema as well, and Gorgo takes up the position that Aglaea isn't unreasonable, that she, in the face of certain destruction, would welcome Castrum Kremnos's vulnerable population. Anaxagoras is quick to point out that falling back to Okhema won't save anyone.

Quickly, the back and forth devolves into insults, though Mydei is amused by how Anaxagoras manages to position himself as the mental superior to them all while slinging as much verbal mud as the rest of them. His head begins to throb, but he's quick to note that though even his somatophylakes join in, Phainon is uncharacteristically silent. He regards the maps over Hephaestion's shoulder, his jaw flexing.

He knows something about this. Somehow, Phainon knows something about Anaxagoras's map, or perhaps the black tide itself. Mydei leans over the table, parting his lips to call Phainon's name.

"Enough!" Gorgo shouts, throwing both arms in the air with enough force that her long sleeves fall away from her wrists. All of the generals but Themistocles look away; Anaxagoras, always the contrarian, looks too closely, as if he can discern some fundamental truth about Gorgo through the loss of her hands. "Enough," Gorgo says again in the quiet that follows. "My son has returned from the dead, Eurypon's body is still warm, the vast majority of our generals have deserted us, and the transfer of power from Mydeimos to me isn't yet complete." She closes her eyes for the briefest of moments. "It has been… a long day."

A murmur of assent ripples around the table.

"The black tide will be here in a week, but we can take this afternoon and evening to rest," she says. "These few hours won't hurt us."

"Won't they?" Anaxagoras asks sharply.

Gorgo fixes him with a cold look, one that quailed even Mydeimos as a boy, but Anaxagoras doesn't back down. "They will not," Gorgo insists. "None of us are ready to make decisions in this moment. I will find a room for you and your student, Anaxagoras. The rest of you are dismissed."

The generals push away from the table, but Themistocles lingers. Mydei's somatophylakes drift into a clump around Phainon—and how strange that is to see—as Hyacinthia approaches them with an offer of healing. Mydei steps forward; she is a stranger, he doesn't trust her, not with Phainon, but Gorgo touches his arm in supplication.

"A moment, my son," she says.

Mydei flicks one last look at his somatophylakes and peels away from the table. He and Gorgo move across the room toward the interior courtyard, and they stand between two pillars, silhouetted by the late afternoon sun, silent. Mydei doesn't know what to say to her. She used him. He killed her husband, her king, and took Strife's power into himself, exactly as she must have wanted.

"I…" He can't bring himself to apologize, and he wonders if he should hate himself for that, but nor can he rail against her.

Gorgo shakes her head. "No," she says softly. "You needn't apologize to me. My husband died long ago when he separated himself from his honor and his reason in pursuit of building an empire. The Titan you felled today was not Eurypon, but rather a pale shadow of him. An imitation." She smiles, but it's a sad thing, and her eyes are wet with tears.

This guts him more than slaying his own father did, and he reaches for her, wiping a tear from the corner of one of her eyes. "Did you want this?" he asks. "Have you plotted this end over the long years?"

She leans into his touch and closes her eyes. "I had hoped," she says. "If anyone was to end his reign, it was always going to be you."

This time, there is no feeling used, only a hollowness that spreads through his abdomen. "Then why send Phainon to me?"

Gorgo opens her eyes and takes her face from Mydei's hand. "Because I needed someone to catalyze you. I had hoped his presence would be radicalizing one. Aglaea's letters to me made it very clear how much he loathed Eurypon."

Did he? When he spoke of Aedes Elysiae, certainly there was hatred for the man who destroyed it, but Mydei struggles to think of other conversations where Phainon outwardly loathed Eurypon. Perhaps he took Mydei's own warning to heart, burying his sentiments, but Phainon has never been one to be cowed. "I see," he says.

She laughs quietly. "You don't believe me."

No, it's not that he doesn't believe her, it's that the world doesn't align with her premise, and it's a strange thing to see someone fool Gorgo. He shakes his head. "I suppose I don't," he says, surprising himself. But there is more going on with Phainon than he knows, and it needs addressing before he is truly honest with his mother. "You took him after my death?"

"I did." She regards him. "He is a useful tool." Mydei tries not to react to that, but something must show in his eyes, in his face, because Gorgo says, "But not, I think, as much now that Eurypon is dead."

That startles him, and he can't hide his surprise at all. Gorgo never gives up someone she can user—he is proof of that.

"He's yours again, child," Gorgo says. "I'll have Iason transfer the contract officially, and—"

"Don't transfer it," he says. "Free him."

Gorgo lifts a single brow. "That's your desire?"

Mydei gives her a clipped nod. There will be no unraveling of Phainon's secrets if there isn't parity between them, and he was never meant to be more than a spy posing as a slave. This farce needs to end.

"Then it will be done," Gorgo promises him. "You have my word."

They are, all of them, in various states of disarray, covered in blood and wounded, and Phainon, who tied off the gouge in his leg with a strip of his own chiton, wants to sink into the ground and perish. He is exhausted, and he shouldn't be in this war room, but no one turned him aside, and now Mydei's somatophylakes—his somatophylakes—have closed ranks around him as though to protect him from everyone else. Themistocles watches him with clear distrust, and he supposes that's a reasonable reaction to his presence. A slave, a spy, his presence in the war room is a problem for everyone. He's surprised Themistocles didn't throw him out immediately, but maybe Gorgo's silence motivated Themistocles's own. Gorgo surely has her reasons for wanting him here.

He watches as she and Mydei pull to the side of the room, heads bowed, intimate space between them, a nervous frisson running through him. Gorgo controls his contract, Gorgo commands his obedience, but surely he has no use to her now that Eurypon is dead. Unless she means to use him against Aglaea, which—

"I'd like to help," Anaxagoras's young charge says. Phainon watches her through the barrier of his somatophylakes. There's no guile on Hyacinthia's face, no indication of deception, and she holds up both hands to reveal a healthy, verdant glow. "I'm a healer." She was never one to lie.

"And a Chrysos Heir," Leonnius says. "Where were you when we visited the Grove last?"

She smiles pleasantly. "Away. Please. Your companion is very injured."

The weight of those injuries grows, and Phainon touches Hephaestion's shoulder. "Let her," he says, weary, light-headed. To his surprise, Hephaestion gives way, allowing Hyacinthia to approach.

Phainon holds out his hand to her, and she, though startled for a brief second, takes it. A cool, soothing energy rushes through him, and his skin tingles in the wake of its passing.

“This will do most of the work,” Hyacinthia explains, her gaze pointedly fixed on him and not at all on the somatophylakes who watch her like a hawk. “But you should still mind the deeper wounds.”

“Thank you,” Phainon says.

“It’d be better if I could—”

“This is enough,” he assures her, not wanting her to touch him more than necessary.

She frowns but doesn’t fight him, releasing him a moment later. Her healing hasn’t restored his energy—he’s still exhausted—but the wounds all over his body have closed, even the viciously deep one on his thigh.

“Would you tend to them, too?” he asks, releasing her hand and gesturing toward the others.

Her eyes linger on him for another second before she beams. “Of course,” she says, and she turns to Hephaestion first, laying her hands on his side as she explains her healing powers to him. When she moves on to Leonnius, Hephaestion drifts toward Phainon’s side, joining him in studying Mydei and Gorgo.

“It’s divine justice,” Hephaestion says. He speaks quietly, a murmur barely audible beneath Hyacinthia’s chipper explanations. “Three days dead and he comes back to slay a Titan with your help.” Awe flavors Hephaestion’s tone, and Phainon doesn’t quite know what to do with it.

“You’re not…” Phainon frowns. “Angry?”

“My loyalties have always been to Mydei before anyone else,” Hephaestion says. “And, now, to you after him. Castrum Kremnos will change.” His voice shakes with faint tremors. He’s afraid, and Phainon supposes he should be. “But we will weather those changes at his side.”

He wants to speak of Mydei’s survival, the reality of it only now starting to dawn on him, but he doesn’t have the words. His throat swells with

unnamable feelings, forcing him to swallow them back lest they choke him. Mydei is alive, and together they slew a Titan. Mydei is *alive*, and Phainon will have to answer for so many things.

He hazards a glance at Leonnius, who leans against the table as Hyacinthia sweeps her hands over him, speaking in low tones to Peucesta. As though sensing the weight of his gaze, Leonnius glances Phainon's way and inclines his head ever so slightly before returning to his conversation. Strange how that isn't relieving. Maybe ending Eurypon's reign was enough to balance the scales in Leonnius's mind, but Phainon doesn't think that's the case. Can't.

"Hey," Hephaestion says, and he lifts his chin in the direction of Mydei and Gorgo.

Phainon turns as Mydei approaches, an inscrutable expression on his face, and Phainon finds he doesn't know what to do with himself. There's so much between them, all of it confusing, that he remains rooted in place.

"Good news," Mydei says.

"You're alive?" Phainon proposes, a vain attempt to lighten the heaviness in the air around him.

A grin cracks Mydei's face. "There is that. But better news." Nothing can be better than Mydei alive, but Phainon remains silent. "My mother has agreed to free you." No, not even that is better than Mydei being alive, because Phainon, despite the torc around his throat, has never truly been a slave, nor can he be kept as one.

But Phainon allows himself a surprised expression, a hopeful one. "Will she really?"

"Her word is good," Mydei assures him, and he reaches forward, reaches toward Phainon, only to catch himself and pull back. Everything is strange, and Phainon doesn't know if he should step forward and bridge the gap between them. They aren't truly lovers, and Phainon's actions killed Mydei.

He’s responsible.

“Thank you,” he says, and he means it, but this isn’t the place.

An awkward silence hangs between them, and he wonders if Mydei wasn’t expecting more.

Leonnius saves the moment, slinging his arms around both their shoulders and hanging between them with such aggressive cheerfulness and force that he drags them both forward. “No somber moments,” he declares. “One of you is back from the fucking dead! Both of you survived felling a Titan. One of you *is* a Titan!” He laughs, and Phainon is certain it’s a forced laugh, but it helps to break the strange tension even more. “We should celebrate!” Leonnius charges forward, all but dragging them with him, and Mydei begins to laugh, too.

“You fought a Titan,” Ptolemy says, clearly meaning it as a point of celebration. But instead of cheering, the group falls silent, no one willing to speak, to name the truth: Mydei fought and killed a Titan, but that Titan was his father.

Hyacinthia lifts her hands from Perdikkas, gives a brief bow in Mydei’s general direction, and ducks away, leaving them to their silences.

“Enough of this,” Mydei says, shattering the moment. “There was nothing of Eurypon left to mourn. There’s no need to dance around his death. Let us be glad.”

The strangeness persists even as Leonnius lets out a raucous whoop and begins to drag Phainon and Mydei from the war room. “We feast! We celebrate our prince’s return from death!”

“We must have the story,” Peucesta says.

Phainon allows himself to be pulled along, wishing everyone would forget about him, wishing Leonnius would release him so he could fade away into the aether. But Leonnius’s grip remains firm, and he hauls him and Mydei

—though Phainon thinks it's mostly him—through the palace to Mydei's rooms.

"A feast!" Leonnius says again, all but kicking Mydei's door open.

Hephaestion clears his throat. "Perhaps," he says, "Mydei and Phainon might like time to recover from their ordeal before you force feed them lamb and wine until they burst."

Leonnius stares at him for a long moment. And then he breaks away from Mydei and Phainon, clapping his hands together. "Of course, of course," he says. "For tonight, we'll leave you in peace so you can rest." He grins, broad and cheerful, as though he can't read the room at all. "But tomorrow, there will be feasting, celebrating, and the telling of tales."

"Tomorrow," Mydei agrees.

And then they are alone, Phainon and Mydei, neither of them willing to regard each other, both looking everywhere else—the hallway, first, and then the half-packed room beyond Mydei's door. His suite is quiet, devoid of servants, and Phainon finds the silence stifling.

He doesn't know how to break it.

In the end, by unspoken mutual agreement, they make their way to Mydei's bathroom, where the pool-like bath has yet to be emptied. Mydei sinks into it with a groan, but Phainon lingers at the edge, unsure of himself, of his welcome. He's fucked up so many things over the years, and this… He could have done all of this better. Could've saved Mydei so many deaths. He sinks into the silence, rubbing his face, embracing the cruel weight of it broken only by the quiet sound of rippling water.

"Phainon," Mydei says.

Not yet. Just a little more silence, even if it's uncomfortable. He's not ready to explain everything yet.

"Phainon, you're still covered in blood and dirt. Come here."

Phainon opens his eyes. Mydei stands in his bath, one hand outstretched, and Phainon shouldn't go, but he does. He rises carefully, mindful of his leg, and crosses the bathroom. He steps into the pool but sits on the edge of it, watching Mydei warily, uncertain of his own welcome despite the overture he's been given. "I owe you an apology," he says. "Many apologies."

Mydei approaches through the water, a cloth in one hand and soap in the other. "You do," Mydei agrees, and those two words land like a blow even though they're fully justified.

"Everything I've done here… you died because of everything I've done." Phainon stares at the water between his knees, and he closes his eyes when Mydei shifts between them, when Mydei runs the wet, soapy cloth over his chest, his shoulder. He doesn't deserve such care, but he can't bring himself to knock Mydei's hand away. "We thought you were gone."

"I did," Mydei agrees. "And I was. I spoke to Thanatos themself in the underworld."

Phainon swallows. "Did they force you to bargain with them to return?"

"No." Mydei's cloth pulls down Phainon's arm and then back up, a gentler caress than he deserves. It ghosts over his chest once more, his abdomen. "They haven't had a hold on me since my mother plucked me out of the Sea of Souls."

"But your body…"

"It came back to me as I trudged from the underworld as nothing more than a spirit."

Phainon shudders, as much from the gentleness of Mydei's touch as from the horror of his words. "Did it hurt?" he asks.

"Tremendously." Mydei runs the cloth over the outside of Phainon's leg, and he finally opens his eyes, watching Mydei wipe away the dust and blood that coats his skin.

Hoarse, Phainon says, “I’m sorry. For being the reason for that pain. You went because of me, because of what I told Cipher, and—”

“You’re not as important as you seem to think you are,” Mydei says gently, moving to Phainon’s other leg. “But you’re not wrong. If I hadn’t gone to the field to fight Castorice, you would have died.”

“You should have let me.”

Mydei’s lips quirk. “We’ve had this conversation. My deaths are cheap. Yours aren’t.”

His deaths are cheaper than Mydei realizes, but he can’t say that, can’t tell him that, not yet. Not ever, no matter how much some traitorous part of him wants to. Maybe this time… “Mydei,” he begins.

Mydei curves his hand around Phainon’s jaw, his thumb pressing against Phainon’s mouth. “Don’t,” he says, letting the cloth go. It sinks beneath the surface of the bath, and Mydei leans closer to him. “You aren’t as important as you think you are, except to me.”

Titans, it wasn’t supposed to be like this. Phainon’s heart aches as he presses a soft kiss to the pad of Mydei’s thumb.

“I would die a thousand times over for you,” Mydei continues.

Now it’s Phainon’s turn to say, “Don’t,” ever so softly. It truly wasn’t supposed to be like this, but here he is, so-called enemy between his knees, vulnerable in a way he’s never allowed himself to be.

Mydei leans into him, moving his thumb aside and pressing a kiss to Phainon’s lips. Phainon answers with a quiet groan, his hands sinking into Mydei’s hair, and he kisses Mydei back with a banked but desperate hunger. He died. Mydei *died*, and it shouldn’t have mattered to him, but it did, and for so many terrifying reasons.

Their mouths part, a scant breath of space between them. “I don’t deserve your forgiveness,” Phainon murmurs.

“That’s for me to decide.”

His heart aches. “Mydei,” he breathes, bringing their mouths back together for another kiss, just as slow and tender as the first. They linger over each other, lips never separating for more than the space of a moment, and the world becomes something soft and hazy. Phainon lets himself forget that Aglaea’s army still marches on Castrum Kremnos, lets himself forget that he just helped Mydei kill his own father, that the black tide encroaches rapidly on the city. He sinks into the heady burn of Mydei’s mouth against his, of their tongues sliding into each other’s mouths, of their rough and callused hands on each other’s faces.

The lingering throb in his leg becomes a distant afterthought, barely noticeable as desire hums through him. He wants to push off the side of the bath and sink into it, but this is good enough. Just having Mydei’s mouth on his is good enough.

Time crawls by, and Phainon measures its passing in the way Mydei gasps quietly against his lips, in the way Mydei’s free hand flexes on his good thigh. Mydei presses closer to him, and Phainon groans, trying to grind his half hard cock against Mydei’s stomach. The flex of his hips pulls at his still-tender wound, and he flinches back, hissing.

Mydei lets him go, though not too far. “This isn’t the right place, is it?” he asks, his eyes closed but his lips quirked in a wry smile.

Laughing, Phainon shakes his head. “No where’s going to be the right place with this wound.” He exhales. “But, Titans, I—” He catches himself with another laugh. “Is it weird if I swear oaths by you?”

“No,” Mydei says, biting down on Phainon’s lower lip until he gasps, until he rakes his nails over Mydei’s scalp. The pain is *good*, a sharp contrast to the ache in his leg and the smoldering pleasure low in his stomach. “Swear by me and me alone, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

Among the many Titans, Mydei alone deserves Phainon’s oaths.

“I want you, Mydei,” he murmurs, thumbing the corner of Mydei’s lips. “I want to be inside you. But I am so damn tired.” He breathes out a laugh. “And I don’t deserve you.”

“That’s for me to decide,” Mydei says again. His hand pulls down Phainon’s jaw, resting on his neck and over the torc enclosing it. “We should remove this.”

Phainon tips his head back, giving Mydei more of his neck, and Mydei’s mouth brushes along his skin, punctuated by suckling kisses. “Aren’t there a bunch of legal processes that come first?”

“Fuck them,” Mydei says. He pulls back, pinching his fingers together, and in his hand he has conjured a small, red crystal in the shape of a blade. “Do you trust me?”

Phainon eyes the edge of that crystal, keenly aware of how dangerous it might be but equally intrigued. This crystal, wielded as an instrument of death by Eurypon, becomes an instrument of freedom in Mydei’s hand. “More than Periander,” he says.

Snorting, Mydei presses the crystal’s sharp edge against the torc. “Anyone is more trustworthy than Periander. Hold still.”

Beneath Mydei’s blade, Phainon doesn’t move. Barely breathes. Its sharp edge brushes over his skin as Mydei presses it through the metal of the torc, cutting it like so much fat. The two pieces of the torc fall away, and Phainon catches one half, Mydei the other.

“This is a despicable practice,” Mydei says, staring at the piece of metal in his hand before looking at Phainon, before letting the metal fall from his fingers to take Phainon’s face gently once more. “You have always been my equal.”

Phainon lifts a brow. “Was, maybe. Hard to be the equal of a Titan.”

Mydei slides his hand around the back of Phainon’s neck, drawing him close until their foreheads touch. “As men, we are equals, Phainon of Aedes

Elysiae.”

“As men,” Phainon agrees, and he thinks it might be true.

Mydei helps Phainon to the bedroom, where, thankfully, the bed still stands with a sheet still draped across it. Phainon sinks heavily onto it, grimacing. Pain throbs in his thigh, persistent enough to be distracting, and he sprawls across the bed with an arm thrown over his face.

“We should call your friends,” Phainon says.

Settling beside him, Mydei makes a quiet sound of denial. “Tomorrow can be for them and for the rest of the people. Tonight can be for us.” He lays on his side, his head propped in his hand, and he rests his hand on Phainon’s chest. His thumb rubs idle circles across Phainon’s skin, and Phainon melts beneath the touch. “This is the first time we’ve ever been truly alone.”

Phainon smothers a grimace, keeping his face relaxed and serene. “If only I had the energy to fuck you.”

“Is that all you think about?”

There’s a glib answer on the tip of his tongue that Phainon swallows back. Instead, he says, “I want to be close to you.” It feels like a profound confession, and he wonders if Mydei understands the layers of meaning behind his words.

Mydei shifts closer, pillowing his head on Phainon’s shoulder, and Phainon loops a hand over Mydei’s waist. “Then talk to me,” Mydei says. “Tell me of Aedes Elysiae before Eurypon ruined it.”

Haltingly, Phainon speaks. He describes endless fields of golden wheat, a vast blue lake rippling with possibility, a family that loved and cherished him—a mother and a father, no siblings. His voice catches as he describes his teachers, his friends, his extended families of aunts and uncles who oversaw his safety during the day. He skips over the children who teased

him for his dreams of being a swordsman, mentioning them only to say, “Cyrene was the only one who believed I could become a warrior.”

“She sounds like a true friend,” Mydei says.

“My best.” Phainon laughs. “Maybe my only.”

“That cannot be true.”

Warmed by Mydei’s words, Phainon urges him closer. He presses into Phainon’s side, and Phainon bends his face to touch a kiss to his forehead. “I was a strange child. Farmers’ sons don’t dream of changing the world.”

“But you did.”

Phainon is quiet for a moment, turning his gaze back to the ceiling. “I did. I… just wanted everyone’s dreams to come true.” His lips tug in a lopsided, sad smile. “My dream was to make everyone else’s dreams real.”

“You were a selfless child,” Mydei says, drawing idle designs on Phainon’s chest. “And now?” He lifts his head, leaning over Phainon.

“Still working on it,” Phainon admits. “The world’s a lot more complicated, and some dreams clash.”

Mydei studies him, and Phainon wonders if he’ll see through to the truth. “A hard truth for a child to learn.” He leans down, returning Phainon’s kiss with one of his own, one that lingers, one that offers succor. Phainon drinks down Mydei’s kindness, letting it fill him, renew him. Mydei draws back, expression intense. “Will you help me fulfill my dreams, too?”

Another glib reply dances on Phainon’s tongue—but he doesn’t want to hide behind sarcasm. Not with Mydei. Not anymore. As much as possible, he wants to reveal himself to the man beside him. “And what’s your dream?” he asks.

“To push back the black tide,” Mydei says.

Phainon tips his head to the side. “Is that really Strife’s concern?”

“It should be every Chrysos Heir’s concern,” Mydei says. “Strife used to sweep across the borderlands with an army of Chrysos Heirs, holding the tide at bay. Eurypon destroyed that tradition. It’s time to renew it.”

“That was decades ago,” Phainon says, the protest weak.

Mydei snorts. “Are you worried for me?”

Yes, but that’s not all. “Of course. You were dead for three days. You—”

“Came back. Castorice herself couldn’t keep me down. Do you think the black tide will?” Mydei scoffs, and he is right and righteous in his indignation.

“I’d prefer you to not spend three days dead again,” Phainon replies dryly.

Mydei settles against Phainon’s side once more, his head returning to Phainon’s shoulder. “Then I will not die.”

“You say that with such surety. Maybe your immortality is gone now that you’re Strife. All the Titans can be killed. Maybe—”

“You worry for nothing,” Mydei insists. “The black tide has always been Strife’s concern, and it will be mine, too.”

Phainon relents. “As you say, oh great Titan.”

Huffing, Mydei slaps his hand across Phainon’s ribs, pulling a laugh from him. Phainon wrestles Mydei onto his back, settling over him to drink more lingering kisses from his lips, and he holds his peace.

The black tide has, historically, been Strife’s problem. But it is also Phainon’s.

Chapter End Notes

> vacation is lovely, quickly getting this up for yall <3 who's figured out what's up with phainon? tune in next week for the whole story!
> anyway, the map is what hephaestion was working on that time

phainon barged in on him and he had to spell out the situation for phainon

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“We will begin with a message to Aglaea,” Gorgo says.

The morning is cool, the war table filled with juice and a smattering of fruits and cheeses, and the air tense. Gorgo has reconvened her council, though this time it’s even smaller: one of the other generals fled in the night, leaving just Themistocles and the second, Anaxagora, Mydei and his somatophylakes, Phainon, and Gorgo herself. It’s not a phenomenal start, and Mydei’s concern is deep. His mother lacks military support, and that frightens him with Aglaea’s army marching toward them.

“I remain concerned that any messenger we send will meet with swift death at Castorice’s hand,” Themistocles says, studying the war map before him. He doesn’t countermand Gorgo, but he is more honest with her than he ever was with Eurypon. But Gorgo hasn’t gone around burning Chrysos Heirs at the stake and exploding men with virulent, red crystals.

Mydei looks at his own hand, flexing it, watching his skin ripple with a strange light. His stomach turns.

“The general is right to be worried.” Every head in the room turns toward Phainon, who has been silent up until now, who has hung back behind Hephaestion and Leonnius as though the men could be some kind of shield for him. Now, though, he’s at the center of everyone’s attention, and his expression is grim. “If Aglaea is marching on Castrum Kremnos, I’m not sure she’ll stop just because Eurypon is dead and Her Majesty is queen.”

Themistocles throws an open palm in Phainon’s direction. “And who is this?” he demands. “Why have we included the prince’s bed slave in our war council?”

Leonnius shifts forward, a sneer on his face. “As the only Okheman in the room—”

“An Okheman!” Themistocles exclaims.

“An Okheman who helped eliminate Eurypon,” Ptolemy says.

Themistocles’s face reddens with anger, and he leans forward. “And we should trust a king-slayer at our war table?”

“You trust me,” Mydei says, earning a vicious glare from the general.

Gorgo brushes her arm against Themistocles’s own. “Enough.” She inclines her head toward Phainon. “Phainon was part of a plan I hatched in secret with the Goldweaver.” Themistocles stares at Gorgo not with shock but rather a curious sort of appreciation. “I had intended for him to kill Eurypon directly and, perhaps, take his coreflame from him.” Gorgo makes a soft sound and then says, “He is a Chrysos Heir after all.”

Mydei suddenly finds himself the recipient of sidelong glances traded between him and Phainon, but he is unsurprised to note that his somatophylakes are unbothered. They knew. Well, Hephaestion certainly always knew, but Phainon must have told the others when Mydei was dead.

“And so now you ask us to trust a double agent,” Themistocles says to Gorgo, clearly unwilling to bend on this. “That man is almost certainly Aglaea’s creature.”

“He is trustworthy,” Mydei says, ignoring the way Anaxagoras watches them as if they are all insects he’s studying, how he takes them in with a curious, almost gleeful expression.

Choking on a disbelieving laugh, Themistocles gestures toward Phainon again. “Trustworthy? This man who came to you under not one but two false pretenses? Who saw the skin flayed from your back and your death at the hands of the Maiden of War? No.” He holds up a hand to keep Mydei silent. “Everyone who stood in the war room at the time knew you went to that battlefield to keep your father from killing your bed slave.”

“Phainon was never a slave,” Mydei hisses. “That was a pretense—”

“So the torc on his neck was—”

“General,” Gorgo snaps. “Mydeimos.” Her cutting gaze silences them both, and Mydei is perversely pleased to see her so easily cow Themistocles despite his annoyance at being cowed alongside him. “Phainon’s history with us is no longer a point of contention. He knows Aglaea well and thus is valuable for our current pursuits.” She turns her attention to Phainon. “The Goldweaver is no conqueror. The Titan of Romance is rarely vindictive.”

Phainon regards the map on the table, studying the position of the armies, Aglaea’s advancement, and he rubs a hand over his mouth. “Aglaea is…” He inhales deeply. “She’s not a conqueror, but I don’t think this is about conquering. She’ll see this as retributive justice, crushing Castrum Kremnos so it can’t crush anyone else. You can try sending a messenger, but I wouldn’t hold out hope she’ll stop her advance.”

“Do you think she’ll kill a messenger?” Gorgo asks.

Shaking his head, Phainon says, “No. I don’t think she’d kill someone who came under a banner of peace.” His jaw flexes, and Mydei wonders if anyone else notices.

“Now is not the time for secrets,” Gorgo says softly. Of course, she would notice the subtle tell.

Phainon sighs. “Aglaea has been the Titan of Romance for a long time, and it’s changed her. She… she cares about humanity, but she is ruthless in her pursuit of protection for those she considers her own. Compassion isn’t easy for her. Not anymore.”

“You know her very well,” Anaxagoras observes.

Waving this off with a shrug, Phainon says, “Anyone who spends a reasonable amount of time with her would be able to tell these things.”

Mydei—and clearly everyone else at the table—doesn't think that's so true. Phainon talks about Aglaea with a casual familiarity that suggests he spends more than a reasonable amount of time with her. Perhaps this isn't such a strange thing: Phainon is a Chrysos Heir, and all Titans have kept Chrysos Heirs close to them for one reason or another over the centuries. To some, as with Nikador, Chrysos Heirs were squires to help fend off the black tide. To others, like Eurypon, they were a nuisance, kept close to be controlled or, more often, killed.

"Send a messenger," Phainon says to Gorgo. "Tell Aglaea that Eurypon is dead, that you've assumed control of the city, and you would like there to be peace between Okhema and Castrum Kremnos so that no one else has to die. If you emphasize wanting peace… that should be enough."

"Should be," Themistocles says, low and gruff.

"No guarantees, of course," Phainon replies.

"Then I will draft a message to Aglaea in the hopes that our old alliance moves her heart," Gorgo says, "and telling her that we have accomplished our mutual goal even if the outcome is not as we anticipated."

Mydei stares at the map, ignoring the way gazes fall on him.

"Aglaea is all well and good," Anaxagoras says, "but the black tide remains a more pressing concern."

"More pressing than an army bearing down on us?" Themistocles asks.

Hephaestion hits his fist on the table. "We are caught between two monsters, but an army of men is more easily turned aside than an eldritch force."

"But we have Strife," Mydei reminds them. "And we can gather up any other Chrysos Heirs to fight back the tide as Nikador once did." He leans over the table, indicating on the map where the black tide has speared forward in the direction of Okhema. "I will take my somatophylakes and Phainon—"

“As the only one of us who knows Aglaea,” Gorgo says, “I would prefer to keep him here.”

Mydei presses his lips together. “The blood of Chrysos Heirs can help push back the tide,” he reminds her.

“Only Strife’s blood,” Phainon says with a studied casualness that raises Mydei’s hackles. There’s much Phainon isn’t saying, that he’s trying to avoid saying.

“Any Chrysos Heir,” Mydei begins.

“No,” Anaxagoras says, cutting him off. He lifts his left hand, removes a dagger from his belt, and cuts his own palm. Golden blood wells there.

Frustration replaces shock, a quiet irritation that Anaxagoras was right under his nose the whole time he was in the Grove at his father’s request. Not that he would have turned the man in, not that he would have seen the man executed, but—

Mydei gives him a tight smile. “And you’ve tested this?” he asks.

“Yes,” Anaxagoras says, wiping his dagger on his chiton before cutting a piece of it to heal his hand. His protégé, who should have been a tell, too, Mydei supposes, is not present. “Both Hyacinthia and I tried to use our blood to ward off the tide, but it fears only Strife. While we can safely traverse the tide and confront its monsters as humans cannot, we can’t turn it aside the way you can.”

Phainon knew this. Phainon knew this when they were at the Grove. Now, he stands at the end of the table, sandwiched between Hephaestion and Leonnius as though to protect himself, not looking at Mydei, and Mydei knows he’s hiding more.

“Then Phainon remains,” Gorgo says.

“I would advise against that, Your Majesty.” Anaxagoras wraps his hand. “Phainon’s blood won’t deter the black tide, but to send your son and his

somatophylakes will see the latter all dead and the former ineffective. Phainon may know Romance—”

Phainon continues staring at the map without looking at anyone else, and Mydei is even more certain that he’s still hiding so many things.

“—but he will be of greater service delaying the black tide’s inevitable progress.”

“If it’s inevitable,” the other general says, “then we must evacuate Castrum Kremnos immediately. Let it take us *and* Okhema—”

Themistocles lets out a loud, wordless protest, echoed by most of Mydei’s somatophylakes, though Mydei himself remains silent. There’s wisdom in giving up the city, but his gut churns at the thought.

What surprises him, though, is Anaxagoras’s mocking laughter. “Ah, yes,” he says. “Let’s destroy the known world out of spite, nationalism, and xenophobia.”

“We can’t let the black tide reach Okhema,” Phainon agrees, his expression fierce as he rounds on the general.

“Indeed.” Gorgo leans over the table. “Castrum Kremnos and Okhema are the greatest of Amphoreus’s cities. We can let *neither* fall if we mean to preserve society.”

Anaxagoras claps, and Mydei can’t help but think there’s mockery in it, and it takes everything in him not to lash out at the so-called feeble scholar. There’s an energy about him, a strange resonance that hangs in the air, that rattles Mydei’s bones and leaves him uncomfortably on edge, and he wants to eliminate it. Escape it.

“I will not be responsible for the downfall of civilization in my first act as queen,” Gorgo continues. “And so this is what we shall do: I will recall the Senate.” Mydei startles, but he shouldn’t be surprised. Eurypon feared the citizens’ power. Gorgo would not. “The Senate will decide how we will answer the black tide’s progress.”

“Too slow,” Anaxagoras mutters.

Gorgo speaks over him. “The citizens must have a say. While the Senate comes together to vote on whether or not we evacuate, we will send a messenger to Aglaea’s army in the hopes that she will spare not just Castrum Kremnos but the other city states in the way. The black tide *is* the most pressing concern, so we will inform her of our discovery that its goal seems to be Okhema. Meanwhile, Mydeimos will take his somatophylakes and Phainon to buy us what time they can.”

“You send away our most valuable wartime assets,” Themistocles says.

“My century is the queen’s,” Mydei says.

Themistocles gives him a pointed look. “It is not your century that matters. If Castorice attacks us…”

Mydei throws wide his arms. “I should die again to slow her down? It took me three days to recover, you might remember. Throwing myself at Castorice will do little good.”

“This from the man who—”

“Be silent,” Gorgo says, her voice a roll of thunder through the war room. “Hyacinthia,” she continues, and Mydei smarts at how she ignores him and Themistocles. “Anaxagoras, you will send Hyacinthia as a messenger. Aglaea is unlikely to outright kill a healer and a Chrysos Heir.”

Anaxagoras looks supremely displeased. “No, she’ll just keep her as a hostage.”

“Would you prefer to go in her stead?”

His expression transforms into an almost feral smile. “You would trust me with your message?”

“No,” Gorgo says flatly. “Nor do I trust your Hyacinthia, which is why I will be sending a sealed scroll and two guards alongside her.”

“How boring,” he drawls, crossing his arms and turning away.

Gorgo eases away from the war table, settling on a kline placed behind her. “Then let us go. I will draft my message. Themistocles, call in the senators. Mydeimos, I trust you will be able to rally your friends and depart as soon as possible.” She is quiet for a moment. “You will take Phainon as well,” she says, with obvious reluctance. “The scholar is right about this.”

Mydei nods. “Of course,” he says, offering her a respectful dip of his head.

“Then let us be about our business,” the Queen of Castrum Kremnos declares.

After sending his somatophylakes to their rooms to collect what they’ll need, Mydei corners Phainon in his own.

“You’re hiding something still,” Mydei says, standing in the entrance to his bedroom. The servants worked fast this during their time in the war room, unboxing everything they’d boxed during his death, returning his room to its proper state.

Phainon, just inside the doorway to the little closet that should be his own room, freezes—and that’s all Mydei needs to know he’s right, even as Phainon says, “I’ve told you everything you need to know.”

“Everything I need to know,” Mydei echoes, prowling toward him. “That implies there’s more that you think I don’t need to know.”

Panic flashes in Phainon’s eyes, there and gone in an instant, and Mydei knows he’s right. He catches the sides of the door, leaning into the closet, forcing Phainon deeper. Phainon has precious few belongings, little that needs packing for a journey such as this, but the armguards Mydei bought him lay on his pallet.

“Phainon,” Mydei says. “Do I not deserve the whole truth?”

And to his surprise, Phainon crumples to the ground, sitting on his pallet as he pulls his hands down his face and draws his knees to his chest.

Mydei glances back, but his servants are busy in the main room of his suite, affording them at least the facsimile of privacy. He slips into the tiny room and sits beside Phainon, studying him.

“It’s too much,” Phainon says into his hands.

“We’re going to risk our lives pushing back the black tide, and you know something.”

“I know,” Phainon groans. “I know so much.” He drags his hands away from his face.

A lone window high on the wall offers a pittance of light, a slash of it across their sandaled feet. Shadow enshrouds the rest of them, hiding the bulk of Phainon’s expression but not the agony of his words.

“Then why is the black tide traveling as the crow flies toward Okhema?” Mydei asks.

Phainon shudders and leans back, resting against the wall. “Because that’s where THEY are,” he says with tremendous resignation. “That’s where THEY’ve always been, trapped in a prison beneath the city, biding THEIR time.”

A strange feeling of dread curls around the base of Mydei’s spine. “THEY?” he asks, perturbed by the weight Phainon gives the word.

“The primordial ones, the precursors, the Titans’ own gods who created the universe,” Phainon says, closing his eyes. “But you don’t believe me. That’s fine. I’ve done this… thousands of times, and Aglaea’s only ever believed me once.”

Silent, Mydei sits beside him, waiting for Phainon to laugh, to make some joke of the nonsense he’s just said. In isolation, Mydei understands all those

words, but the way Phainon has strung them all together has him baffled. Bewildered. And angry.

“What lies are you spinning?” he asks, his voice a low hiss. “I ask for the truth, and you—you give me… mythology?” He pulls away.

Phainon takes him by the wrist. “When Eurypon drowned you,” he says quickly. “You were five, and you’d secreted a palace cat with a broken leg into your room, intending to help it heal.”

Now, Mydei goes still, staring in disbelief at Phainon. He’d told Phainon about his drowning, yes, but not what precipitated it.

“One of your servants betrayed you to Eurypon, and he drowned you and the cat to teach you a lesson. That you shouldn’t care for anything outside of yourself,” Phainon continues. “That *care* is *weakness*.”

Mydei tries to shake off Phainon’s hand. “Did Hephaestion tell you that while I was dead?” he demands.

“No,” Phainon says, holding tighter to his arm. “Eurypon did maybe… fifty cycles ago? One hundred?” He shakes his head. “I’ve seen so many, they blur together. It was the last time I tried to work with him to stop the black tide from reaching Okhema.” His expression is shadowed but still clearly earnest as he looks up at Mydei. “You don’t believe me.”

“Because you’re speaking nonsense,” Mydei snaps, frustration boiling within him. “At every opportunity, I have helped you, protected you. Just last night, you apologized to me, you—” He bares his teeth, a terrible smile as he breaks into ragged laughter. “More lies, Phainon?”

Phainon lets go, his head drooping between his shoulders, his arm falling limply to the ground. “Every time,” he says, his own laughter weary. Broken. Pained. “Every time I try to tell someone.” He draws back, curling around himself, and the sight is so disconcerting that it roots Mydei to the spot.

He’s never seen Phainon look so small, and he tries to tell himself it doesn’t matter, that he doesn’t care, that Phainon has cut him with lies one time too many. But it does matter, he does care, and he finds himself on his knees, his anger fizzling out. Eurypon always acted out of anger and fear, and he will do neither.

Taking a deep breath, he sets a hand on Phainon’s leg, just above his knee, inviting. “Try again,” he says, with more patience than he thinks Phainon deserves.

Phainon doesn’t move for a long moment, so long he wonders if Phainon somehow didn’t hear him. But then, Phainon says, “The first time, Cyrene and I had traveled to Okhema. Eurypon’s armies razed Aedes Elysiae, and we were the only survivors.”

Mydei frowns. When Phainon has spoken of Aedes Elysiae and Cyrene, he has always made it sound like Cyrene died in the attack.

“We took refuge there, scared and alone, until Aglaea heard of us. Two Chrysos Heirs, one a priestess in service of Oronyx.”

“Oronyx is dead,” Mydei says. “Nikador killed them.”

Phainon shakes his head. “No. No, Cyrene… she…” He sits back and rakes a hand through his hair, lifting his face to Mydei. Unshed tears brighten the brilliant blue of his eyes, and he looks so vulnerable, so pained. So very distressed and alone.

How many times has Mydei felt that way? How many times has he crawled into his own bed, afraid to let anyone see his vulnerability after Eurypon visited some horror on him?

“What did Cyrene do?” Mydei asks, willing to hear Phainon out.

“When the black tide came to Okhema that first time,” Phainon says, “it revealed a mausoleum beneath the city. THEY are entombed there, the ancient gods who wove together the universe, and the black tide seeks THEM. Seeks to wake THEM. We didn’t understand, not at first. THEY

woke and begin to rip apart the universe." He looks aside, ashamed. "I couldn't react fast enough, but Cyrene did. She bargained with Oronyx, sending me back to my childhood so that I could prevent THEIR awakening. But doing that shattered Oronyx's coreflame and killed Cyrene." He touches his chest. "They're…" He swallows hard, lifting his eyes back to Mydei's. "They died for me, too. So that I could do this again and again. So that I could stop the black tide."

Mydei leans back. "I don't understand." The words are hard to say; ignorance so often leads to death for him.

Grimacing, shuddering, Phainon exhales. "It's hard to explain. It's all… jumbled in my head. I've done it so many times." He runs both hands through his hair, pushing it out of his face, clearly distressed. "Cyrene created a loop in time. Every time I die, I go back to the day Eurypon razed Aedes Elysiae to the ground. She created the loop so that I can find a way to stop the black tide from freeing the primordial gods entombed beneath Okhema, the gods who created the universe and the Titans."

"The Titans created the universe," Mydei insists, reeling. "Janus—" He catches himself. Janus was born from the primal coreflame, created by the confluence of fate and chaos, and then split that primal coreflame into the other Titans' own coreflames. "Where did fate and chaos come from?" he asks.

Hope lights Phainon's eyes. "The primordial ones. THEY created whatever was there at the beginning, and THEY crafted the environment for life, for Janus to emerge from the aether," he explains, low and urgent. "But THEY fought with the Titans, a brutal war before even Era Luminosa, and the Titans sealed THEM away."

"Why would THEY want to destroy THEIR creation?" Mydei asks.

Phainon shrugs. "I don't know why, only that when THEY were freed in that first cycle, THEY went first for the Titans, retaliating against them, and then began to pull apart the very firmament, ripping it asunder." There's a stark look on his face. "Even now, I remember… I remember blue hands and a doll's jointed fingers tearing through the sky as something with a

great, red eye rent the very earth until magma spewed forth from the rocks." He shakes his head. "It sounds unbelievable."

"It does," Mydei agrees. "Like something out of an epic." But it's so absurd that it rings of truth. No one would lie about this. Phainon, certainly, would pick something else. Something more believable. "You have… attempted to stop the black tide multiple times?"

A hysterical sound catches in Phainon's throat. "Thousands," he whispers, hoarse. "I've lost count. I don't know—I don't know any more how many times." Raw, visceral pain fills his every word, and there's a terrible hollowness in his eyes, an ancient haunting of time passed, and Mydei realizes he believes Phainon. He believes him entirely, no matter how ludicrous the story sounds.

His hand squeezes Phainon's leg, and Phainon jumps. "I believe you," Mydei says.

Phainon lets out a sob, bending his head to cover his eyes, and Mydei is silent, allowing him the time he needs to collect himself. He doesn't cry, but he shakes, his hands pressed to his face as though to hide himself. Not knowing what else to do, wanting to give him the privacy his grief demands, Mydei sits silently, leaving his hand on Phainon's leg until Phainon takes it in his own.

"You're the second," Phainon says, red-eyed when he looks up. "In all this time, you're the second."

He doesn't quite like being second to Aglaea in this, but he supposes he's second to her in many things. It's hard not to be when the Romance Titan has been alive for so long. But instead of saying that, he squeezes Phainon's hand. "This whole time, your whole goal has been to fight back the black tide? Why come here?"

"Because I hadn't tried it yet," Phainon says. "I've recruited Eurypon to my side a handful of times, but—" He catches himself. "There's something you need to know about the black tide and the Strife Titan." His voice shakes.

Mydei strokes his thumb over Phainon's hand. "Tell me."

"Every time I've brought Eurypon to face the black tide and fight it back, it has possessed him," Phainon says softly. "It has overtaken him, ravaged the battlefield and our other allies, if we've had any, and then freed THEM from THEIR prison."

That can't be right. "But Strife is the tide's old enemy. It fears my blood. Strife's blood."

Phainon turns away, brows drawn. "You… you always contained Strife's honor and reason," he says slowly. "Perhaps that's why it feared you, and why it could possess Eurypon so easily." He laughs, the sound unpleasant, and Mydei squeezes his hand again. How Phainon hasn't gone truly and completely mad, he doesn't know and can't begin to imagine, but there is a hint of madness in Phainon now. "I never would have known if I hadn't come here, in this way. Thousands of these cycles and I'm still learning new secrets." He tips his head back and makes a sad, mournful noise.

"You're one secret closer," Mydei tells him, surprising himself with his own insistence. But Phainon has let so many of his walls down, and now Mydei sees how close he truly is to broken, and it terrifies him. Phainon, who would never have broken as a slave, worn down by endless repetitions of time. "We will be careful when we pursue the tide. We won't take risks, but we have to try to push it back." He pauses, thoughtful. "What do you know about it? What have you learned?"

Phainon shakes his head. "Surprisingly little. Every time I've met the tide myself or with allies, we've been killed and time has restarted in Aedes Elysiae. A few times…" His lips twist. "Many times, I've killed myself when I've thought a cycle lost."

Mydei's throat works. All this time, Phainon has known death as intimately as Mydei himself. They could have shared this, though he recognizes that he wouldn't have believed Phainon previously. Can barely believe him now.

"Surely, you've spoken with Anaxagoras," Mydei says. "You've sought his understanding."

Another shake of Phainon's head. "He knows less than I do. The tide hasn't been his mission. I know that it originates somewhere to the west, but I've never been able to cross to its origin by myself, and when I've tried with help, they've all been overwhelmed and then killed by monsters."

Mydei squeezes Phainon's hand again. "Then we will go together, and it will be different."

"The definition of insanity is doing the same thing over and over expecting different results."

Mydei hesitates. "You've never gone with me, have you?" he asks, suddenly unsure of himself, his heart thundering. What if they've done this before? What if they haven't? But if they had, surely Phainon would have known Gorgo's secrets from a previous cycle.

A smile pulls at Phainon's lips. "I've never gone with you," he admits. "I've never tried this route before, killing your father and recruiting you in his stead. It's… hard to remember what I have and haven't tried, truthfully, but I've attempted to be methodical. I've burned so many cycles with Aglaea, with Cipher, with Castorice. Your father. This is the first time in any cycle you've become Strife." His smile widens. "Maybe this time will be different."

"It will be," Mydei assures him, not quite liking the assurance. If they fail… If he's wrong… But he won't let himself think like that. Not yet. "I have a question for you, though."

"Ask. I'll answer."

"Why didn't you kill yourself when I died?" Mydei asks.

Phainon's laughter this time is something genuine, and genuinely amused. "I tried to. I wanted to. I thought the cycle lost without you, and I… I couldn't bear it. Then, Hephaestion swore himself to me. Then the rest of them did, too, and they must have thought I wanted to end my own life, because they wouldn't leave me alone for a minute." His smile is genuine,

too. “They looked after me, and because they did, I…” He touches Mydei’s face, thumbing the corner of his lips, and Mydei leans into the touch.

“This is the first time you’ve recruited me,” he says. “Then this is the first time we’ve…?”

“It’s the first time I’ve loved,” Phainon admits, a whisper, and Mydei sucks in a sharp breath. “And Mydei, Mydeimos, my prince—” He shifts onto his knees, taking Mydei’s face in both his hands, tipping it up and back until their eyes meet, and his gaze is fierce. “If I lose you, if we fail this time, I…” He swallows hard, and Mydei sees how close to the edge of broken Phainon truly stands. There is a yawning precipice at Phainon’s feet, the edge crumbling beneath his sandals, and no one to pull him back.

Mydei could pull him back. Mydei wonders if he should, if he ought to, if he should sacrifice this much more for Phainon’s sake. But of course he will. He can’t not, if only because he’s so profoundly selfish.

It’s the first time I’ve loved.

In all these cycles, Phainon has never given his heart away, and now he’s given it to Mydei. This is precious, and Mydei can’t bear to lose it. Can’t bear the idea of forgetting this, of forgetting Phainon, of forgetting the indelible mark Phainon has left on his very soul.

“Then we won’t fail,” Mydei says, lifting his mouth to Phainon’s for the barest whisper of a kiss. “You must know I love you, too.”

An aching sound pours from Phainon’s mouth, and Mydei wraps himself around Phainon’s body as though he can be some kind of shield. He doesn’t have the power to stop the cycles. Titan he may be, but he is no Oronyx. Strife can’t unwind what Time set in place. But the future isn’t some foregone conclusion, the world is a twisting, confusing thing, and forces swerve from causal paths constantly. He will be one of these forces rewriting Phainon’s own fate. He will use every ounce of his newly acquired divinity to help Phainon to succeed, if only so that this doesn’t become one more cycle. For his sake. For Phainon’s.

His mouth finds Phainon's again. His hands wrap around Phainon's shoulders and draw Phainon down, down, as he lays himself out on what should have been a slave's pallet but never was. He draws Phainon over him, and Phainon brings their bodies together as their lips part only to meet again.

"You weren't supposed to," Phainon whispers against his mouth. Rough fingers stroke over Mydei's cheeks and sink into his hair. Phainon's thumbs brush against the corners of Mydei's mouth, and Mydei arches into Phainon's body with a hungry groan. Heavy atop him, Phainon's weight is grounding, his warmth sizzling like lightning across Mydei's skin. "None of this was supposed to happen like this. You weren't supposed to care. *I* wasn't supposed to care."

"But you do," Mydei says, turning his face to rake his teeth along the pad of Phainon's thumbs. "I do." And failing this time might destroy whatever is left of Phainon's sanity. Phainon clings to his sanity by the fragile thread joining their hearts, and Mydei will do anything to strengthen that thread, to protect it. To protect Phainon, who should be his enemy. "We will succeed, Phainon." It's a promise, an oath, a binding, and he wraps his hand around the back of Phainon's head to draw him into another kiss.

Phainon's mouth is desperate against his own, suckling and hungry, their lips clinging, their kisses slow but hardly drugging. There's a deep longing in how Phainon takes Mydei's mouth with his own—a profound loneliness. Phainon has been so utterly set apart for uncountably many years. Thousands of cycles, a decade of his life repeated over and over, and no one to comfort him, to help him, to believe him when he told them the truth.

No more.

Mydei's tongue slides into Phainon's mouth, licking, tasting. He slings one leg high on Phainon's hip, inviting him closer still, and Phainon sinks into him like a man starved.

Thousands of cycles, tens of thousands of years, and no one has seen Phainon. No matter the relationships he built, no one knew the truth, the weight across his shoulders. Not just the conflict between Castrum

Kremnos and Okhema but the fate of an entire world, borne alone by a single man no one believed—a single man the world continuously forgot. How unimaginably painful.

Hot tears splash against Mydei’s cheeks as Phainon kisses him, as Phainon pulls at his chiton, working it free. Mydei strips Phainon in turn, their hands hungry across each other’s bodies, grasping and clutching as though they can devour each other with their fingertips and palms.

Naked, they move against each other, their cocks rocking together, smearing precum across their bellies. It’s messy and fumbling, all clumsy hands and arrhythmic rolls of their hips, but it’s real and its *theirs*, something all theirs, something that no one should be able to take from them. Death or time will surely make an attempt, and that spurs Mydei on, makes him desperate, too, as he tugs Phainon closer still, as if they could melt into each other.

When they are spent, slick with sweat and cum and still tangled around each other, Phainon’s lips still press urgent kisses to Mydei’s—fearful, fretful. Mydei strokes his hands down the length of Phainon’s back. He wants to offer reassurances, but anything he says will be empty. There’s too much they don’t know, too much Phainon still doesn’t know. But they will find out together.

His heart clenches. Phainon has sought such answers with others and failed to find them. If this time is to be different—no. No, it will be different, and he will allow himself to think nothing less.

Chapter End Notes

> fun times: i got laid off on wednesday (along with 10% of my company) while STILL ON VACATION so i'm treating myself and you with this chapter i suppose. it's the greatest gift i can give you: the truth about phainon. i also treated myself to the most amazing pastries i've ever eaten in my life so there's that, too
>
> even funnier times: this isn't even the craziest thing that's happening in this fic. imo that's next chapter, so we have that to look forward to!

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They depart with the sun, mounting their horses and speeding off in the direction of the Grove. Without a century at their backs, they cover ground quickly as the sun slides lower and lower on the horizon.

Phainon has put himself back together as best he can, sealing up the cracks in his mind and his soul with Mydei's affections. It's not fair, it's not right, he shouldn't depend on another person so much, but he does. If Mydei hadn't believed him in that little closet, he would've fallen apart. Even now, every hoofbeat beneath him rattles, and he grips his reins until his nails press crescents into his palms.

"You're going to ruin yourself if you keep sitting like that," Leonnius calls out to him, pulling his horse alongside Phainon's own.

Scoffing, even though Leonnius is right, Phainon adjusts his posture and lets the tension flow out of him. "I know how to ride, thanks," he fires back.

"Has our good prince been teaching you?" Hephaestion asks from ahead of Phainon, where he rides beside Mydei.

Phainon, flushing, has no idea what to say to that.

Mydei saves him. Sort of. "HKS," he says without much feeling, reaching out to smack Hephaestion upside the head.

Laughing, Hephaestion bats Mydei's hand away. "Right, right, our prince knows plenty about riding, doesn't he?"

Phainon sputters.

“And you!” Perdikkas calls from behind Hephaestion. “When was the last time *you* took someone to bed? What experience do *you* have that allows you to malign our prince and his lover so?”

“I should think I’m the best positioned to do just that,” Hephaestion shoots back, voice warm with yet more laughter.

Phainon can’t decide if he should be horrified at the reminder that he’s the final bough in the funeral pyre of Mydei and Hephaestion’s relationship or if he should sink into the ground and simply cease to exist.

“You deserve this,” Leonnius says casually, reaching out to slap Phainon’s shoulder.

Groaning, Phainon drags a hand down his face. “Do I?”

“Scales,” Leonnius replies.

Phainon throws both hands in the air. “Did helping Mydei kill Eurypon do nothing for me?” he asks, bewildered.

“Oh, it did quite a bit. But that doesn’t preclude this sort of thing, which will only get worse until the two of you end up married.”

Phainon chokes.

“Leonnius,” Mydei says, his voice a low warning.

Leonnius throws a grin over his shoulder at Mydei. “Am I wrong? You overthrew an empire together. As far as Kremnoans are concerned, that’s the purest form of love.”

“I will kill you,” Mydei growls, but he shoots what can only be described as a nervous look at Phainon, and Phainon offers him a reassuring sort of smile.

It’s a strange thing for Mydei’s friends to see their relationship so clearly. He’s been alone for so long, he’s forgotten what it’s like to have people see right through him, and though it’s unnerving, there’s something pleasant

about it, too. A reassurance that even if he lies to himself, he can't lie to everyone else. But the somatophylakes relent, turning from their jokes about his and Mydei's relationship to Kremnoan epics, to stories of heroes the ranks of which they're sure to join if they can only turn back the black tide. They play about their epithets and titles, making up increasingly gregarious and utterly insane appellations until even Phainon is hunched over his saddle, laughing so hard his sides hurt.

When they make camp that night, the seven of them in a ring around a small fire, they grow more somber. They'll reach the Grove by noon the following day, and Phainon knows he can't hide truths from them any longer. Quietly, haltingly, and with Mydei's hand on the small of his back, he reveals to them what he knows of the world with more cohesion than what he gave to Mydei. He tells the story of his own cycles of existence, the horrors buried beneath Okhema, and the mystery and danger of the black tide.

"Gods more powerful than the Titans?" Leonnius asks, scoffing. "That sounds like a child's story. Something to make scared little Okhemans sleep better at night when they're scared of Strife."

"I was suspect, too," Mydei says. "But then I remembered the story of Janus's genesis, her coreflame emerging from fate and chaos. Surely, fate and chaos came from somewhere."

Peucesta idly plucks the strings of his lyre, cradled in his lap. "Hesiod speaks of this," he says thoughtfully.

Leonnius snorts. "You're joking." He turns to each man in turn, spreading his arms wide, and Phainon cannot help but grimace. Of course Leonnius would doubt him. "You buy into this insane story?"

Fingers moving over the strings of his lyre, Peucesta closes his eyes and begins his recitation. "At the first, Chaos came to be, and in opposition to Chaos came forth all-consuming order, who separated night from day and cleaved the wide-pathed abundance of earth from the firmament, who carved out the memory of past and present and future, and the end of all things, and the ability to understand it. From Chaos sprang endless creation

and destruction and the pursuit of death. Wild these forces warred until THEY beget the journey of fate itself, from which grew the coreflame of Janus." His fingers still and his eyes open. "Hesiod's *Theogony*." His lips quirk. "Few pay much attention to this brief creation myth, preferring the exhortation of the muses at the start and the creation myth of the Titans that follows."

A stick snaps in their fire, sending up a shower of sparks, spiraling toward the heavens above. Leonnius is silent, rubbing his face with his hand. Hephaestion sits quietly, elbows brace on his knees, expression intense.

"It is said," Ptolemy begins, "that Okhema was built on the ruins of ruins. That it was the Holy City before Janus manifested herself and carved out Janusopolis for her seat."

Leonnius swears.

"I know how it sounds," Phainon says quietly, taking no small comfort in the weight of Mydei's hand against his back. "And I have less proof than what Peucesta and Ptolemy have said. My word…" He exhales heavily. "I understand if it's not good enough for you."

"Does the Goldweaver know?" Perdikkas asks.

Phainon shakes his head. "No. The only time I managed to convince her, I brought her to the tomb beneath Okhema." He laughs, the sound bitter. "We still failed, that time." Raking his hands through his hair, he stares at the ground between his feet, at the flickering shadows washing over the earth, painting it in midnight stains. "The next time, I brought her to the tomb earlier than the previous, and she took me for a herald of the primordial ones instead. She stabbed me in the back, and I bled out while she watched."

"Surely, the Titans would know of this history," Leonnius says. He gestures to Mydei. "Did your accession come with some kind of… enlightenment?"

"No." Mydei says. "No, and perhaps that's the trouble. There are hundreds of Chrysos Heirs who have become Titans over the centuries, and we've…

lost the Titans' origins."

The men are quiet, but their silence isn't disbelief. It's shocked resignation, the slow acceptance of the truth. Phainon finds himself shaking. Mydei's hand draws along the length of his spine, and some of the tension eases out of him. He sinks into that touch.

"Then we must stop the black tide before it reaches Okhema," Hephaestion says, lifting his gaze first to Mydei and then to Phainon. "If these primordial ones are the Titans' creators, are greater than even them—" He breaks off, thoughtful. "Have you never recruited all the Titans at once?" And then he laughs. "No, that was foolish. Getting even two of them to agree the sky is blue would be a small miracle."

"Perhaps because the sky isn't blue," Ptolemy drawls.

Hephaestion rolls his eyes. "Be silent. No one needs your unique brand of pedantry right now."

"Oh, is that what it is?" Ptolemy asks, but his tone is good-natured. He shoves at Hephaestion's shoulder, and Hephaestion casually shoves him back—hard enough that he totters into Perdikkas instead.

Hephaestion turns his attention back to Phainon, to Mydei. "If it is our prince's command, we will ride with you in the defense of the world, Phainon," he says. And then he chuckles. "Perhaps even if it wasn't."

Phainon's throat threatens to close, his chest swelling with emotion. He can barely breathe around the fullness of his heart.

"Let us make this the last cycle Phainon lives through," Mydei says, his hand warm on the back of Phainon's neck, comforting. His thumb presses against the base of Phainon's skull, and Phainon could melt into that touch.

"Thank you," Phainon says softly. "I… I have done this so many times and have made so many different allies, but over the millennia, men have become as tools." He places his hand on Mydei's knee, squeezing gently. "I lost sight of the power of good friends at my side." And he is, he realizes,

terrified of losing them. “I hope I can say that of you. There’s… still a lot I need to make up for.” Leonnius grunts. “But to have all of you beside me in this is a relief. It’s been a long time since I’ve allowed myself to think a cycle might end well.”

“It *will* end well,” Mydei insists.

“We will see to it.” Hephaestion agrees.

The others put up a cheer of agreement, even Leonnius.

Blinking back threatening tears, Phainon grins. “You are, all of you, good people.”

“Oh, shut up,” Leonnius groans. “For the love of the Titans, enough of this sentimentality.” He leans forward, extending the waterskin in his hand. “I at least need to be drunk to deal with all these *feelings*. Let us drink to our future successes!” He roars the last word, earning more cheers from the other somatophylakes, and even one from Mydei, who also lifts his skin in toast.

Water is a poor substitute for wine, but the company is good and it’s warm, and for the first time in many, many centuries, Phainon allows himself hope for the future.

The sun is bright above them when they reach the boundary of the black tide, the Grove on the nearby horizon, and Phainon’s internal resolve surprises him. With Mydei at his side and the somatophylakes at his back, he’s supported in a way he hasn’t been in so many cycles—perhaps in any of them. Perhaps, with these men at his side, with this support, he can finally put an end to these miserable cycles.

“We can go no further than this,” Hephaestion says, reining in his horse at the edge of the tide.

Mydei nods, surveying the scorched forest beyond them, the desiccated husk of the land. “I’ll leave you with defending this border for us,” he says.

“Push back the monsters where you can but take no risks. Don’t sacrifice yourselves.” He turns toward Phainon with a deferential nod of his head.

It’s a strange thing to have a prince and a Titan defer to him, to have Mydeimos specifically defer to him, but it’s not the first time a god has bent to him. It’s not like it goes to his head—everyone who’s subordinated themselves to him has ended up dead thousands of times over.

Sitting straighter in his saddle, Phainon considers his next words carefully. He’s made allies of so many Titans and Chrysos Heirs, but they’ve never been his friends, not in the way these men are. “We’ve guessed from Hephaestion’s map and Anaxagoras’s that it will take us two days on foot to reach the epicenter of the tide,” he says. “If we aren’t back on the fifth day…” He trails off. If they run into trouble, he’ll have to kill himself and reset the cycle, but the very idea terrifies him. With resolve, he continues, “If we aren’t back on the fifth day, return to Castrum Kremnos and advise the queen to evacuate the city, if she hasn’t begun to do so already.” He spreads his arms in something almost like defeat. “If Mydei and I fail here, the cycle will reset.” His voice remains steady despite himself. “But save as many lives as you can in advance of that.”

Hephaestion leans forward, grasping Phainon’s forearm. “This time will be different,” he says with a conviction Phainon hasn’t felt in so very long. His expression is fierce, eyes blazing. “It will be. Believe in that.” He releases Phainon and wheels his horse to the side.

Each of the somatophylakes say their goodbyes, both to Phainon and to Mydei, as he and Mydei dismount and pass their reins to Hephaestion and Perdikkas.

In the end, it’s just Phainon and Leonnius, and Leonnius takes him by the forearm as Hephaestion did, that ancient Kremnoan salute. “Don’t fuck this up,” he says.

Phainon can’t help his quiet laugh. “Save the world and balance the scales?”

Leonnius grins. “Save the world and balance the scales,” he agrees, shaking his head. “I don’t claim to understand it, but you make him happy, and that’s more than he’s had in years.”

Another reason this cycle has to be the last one. Phainon squeezes Leonnius’s arm before releasing him. “I would do my best to make him happy for years to come,” he says quietly.

“Then you’ve got the motivation you need to figure it out this time.”

“But no pressure,” Phainon drawls.

Leonnius lets out a booming laugh. “None at all.” He steps back, nodding toward the tide and its meandering monstrosities. “Cut your way through, sons of Amphoreus.” He makes a sharp salute, and the others follow suit as Phainon and Mydei step onto the oily surface of the tide.

Short, fat fingers of the substance lift from the ground, clawing at their sandals only to shrink away from Mydei. A patch of bone-dry earth appears beneath his feet, and both he and Phainon grimace. If that’s what remains beneath the tide, recovering Amphoreus from it will be a long, arduous task.

They give their somatophylakes a final wave each and then set off across the tide at a loping gait. Without their horses, the going is slower, but the tide consumes all flesh that doesn’t belong to a Chrysos Heir, human and animal alike. Where they pass, the tide pulls away from Mydei only to close ranks behind them, somehow even more ominous in their wake. As they progress deeper, their somatophylakes becoming distant smudges on the horizon, the air grows oppressively heavy. Stagnant, it hangs heavy on Phainon’s shoulders. The sun above them reflects off the oily surface of the tide, the heat wafting around them with such strength that it distorts the landscape ahead.

“You said the black tide possessed Eurypon in previous cycles,” Mydei says abruptly.

Phainon, suddenly wary, nods. “It did. Why?”

Mydei looks at his feet, where the tide has peeled away from the ground like so much decayed flesh. “I don’t think that’s going to be a problem this time.”

“At least one thing is going well for us,” Phainon says, gesturing toward the monstrous creatures staggering toward them.

There remains considerable distance between them, but Mydei’s eyes narrow. “We will need to measure our progress carefully.” Speed against the possibility of combat. “Pace ourselves.”

“It would be a problem if we exhausted ourselves only to be set upon,” Phainon agrees.

They slow their pace, their hands on their weapons, but the beasts keep their distance. Perhaps it’s Mydei’s presence that wards them off, Phainon isn’t sure, but he is grateful that they aren’t attacked as they cross the tide, piercing deeper into its territory until there’s nothing green left on the horizon and the sky itself takes on an eerie, reddish hue.

Above them, the sun dips lower, sinking in the cradle of the earth, and they’re forced to stop for the night on a barren stretch of earth, no shelter in sight. With no trees, they cannot light a fire, so they tuck into each other against the easy slope of a hill, draping a linen blanket from Phainon’s gear over their shoulders.

“Phainon,” Mydei says.

“Mm?” Phainon’s head rests on Mydei’s shoulder, and he sits in the crook of Mydei’s arm, wrapped in warmth despite the lack of fire.

Mydei is silent for a moment before he tips his head to the side, looking down at Phainon, who looks up at him from his shoulder. “Are you afraid?” he asks.

A papery roar issues from the darkness, but it’s distant. The black tide’s monsters have kept well away from the incarnation of Strife.

“Yes,” Phainon says anyway, because it’s not the monsters that scare him. “For all these cycles, I’ve had so little to lose.” He reaches for one of Mydei’s hands, lacing their fingers together, trying not to cling and failing. “It didn’t matter if an ally fell. I could fail or kill myself, and they’d be fine in the next cycle. But the cycle after this one…”

Mydei makes a quiet, encouraging sound, his nose in Phainon’s hair.

“You would be alive. All of our—our friends would be alive. But you wouldn’t know me. Wouldn’t love me.” Phainon swallows, looking down at Mydei’s hand in his. He turns Mydei’s hand palm up, and with his free hand traces the lines and calluses that define it. “If we were to love each other again in the next cycle, it would be a different you. And I don’t want a different you, Mydeimos.” He tips his head back, meeting Mydei’s golden eyes. “I want this you, and I’m scared I’ll lose you. That I—that we—will fail again.”

Instead of offering him empty platitudes, Mydei kisses him. A slow kiss, a tender one. Sweet and reassuring in its own way, but innocent of lies of certainty.

When he lifts his face, Phainon manages a small smile. “I don’t deserve you.”

“Perhaps not,” Mydei agrees, earning a small laugh from Phainon. “But you have me. I’m *with* you, Phainon. Until the end, until we have no options left, and beyond even that.” He turns his face toward the starry skies. “You’ve already learned valuable information about Strife, and now you’re trying something new and wholly different than previous attempts. Even if we fail—” Phainon’s heart squeezes with fear. “—you will have gained valuable information for next time.”

“I don’t want there to be a next time,” Phainon says, hoarse. “I don’t know if there can be a next time.”

“Maudlin,” Mydei accuses.

Maybe he is. “Realistic,” Phainon counters. “You saw me. When I told you the truth, you saw…” He makes a vague gesture, encompassing the whole of himself. “There’s so little left of me.”

“There is enough,” Mydei replies.

What’s left of him is surely built on the foundation of Mydei’s own regard, and Phainon can’t stand the thought of losing it, of waking in world where there’s no familiarity in Mydei’s eyes.

“There is enough,” Mydei says again, and Phainon tucks himself closer into the comfort of Mydei’s embrace.

Maybe there is. Maybe he isn’t the shattered shell of a man who has seen too many horrors. Maybe, with Mydei, he can prevent the primordial ones from destroying the entirety of the world. Maybe hope isn’t a blade with two edges.

On the morning of the second day, Phainon spots smoke on the horizon.

“There’s nothing to burn,” he says, baffled.

Mydei frowns. “That’s the direction in which we must travel.”

They trade wary looks.

“Only a Chrysos Heir could survive here,” Phainon says. “But even one of us needs food, water.” There have been precious little of both. Black tide monsters fade into nothing when they’re killed, their corpses disintegrating. There are no animals, there is no water, just an endless expanse of slick, oily blackness. “I don’t feel good about this.”

“Nor I.”

They make their way toward the smoke regardless, trekking over ground that continues to reflect the brutal heat of an unrelenting sun until they are soaked with sweat. Their water runs low, though they’ve been careful to

ration it. Neither expected to bake on the black tide's expanse, and they've consumed more of it than anticipated as a result.

Phainon holds out some small hope that the smoke indicates a break in the tide, a bastion of civilization where they might find more water, but the very idea of that leaves him disconcerted. The tide devours without discretion. For it to have spared any part of Amphoreus is a variable he doesn't know how to account for.

"Stop overthinking," Mydei says as they climb a sloping hill, its slippery surface like so much glass.

"What makes you think I'm overthinking?"

"You've got that funny, constipated expression."

Phainon rears back. "Constipated?" he demands.

And Mydei laughs, offering him a hand to help him up the hill. "Your brows come together like you're straining very hard."

Phainon sputters.

"Try not to hurt your small brain."

"I don't know why I like you," Phainon mutters as they gain the crest of the hill and find themselves looking down into a shallow valley.

A valley untouched by the black tide.

Grass spreads for an easy mile in either direction. Tall carobs spread wide their boughs to offer shade over a pond of clear, sparkling blue, fed by a bubbling spring. Bushes of oleander bloom throughout the valley, a mad tangle of uncultivated beauty. And in the center of it all is a squat, one-story oikos, smoke puffing from a fire in a cozy, well-maintained courtyard. Lilting birdsong fills the air, twittering and sweet.

There are no monsters nearby. Nothing prowls the borders of the valley. In fact, it occurs to Phainon that they haven't seen any of the black tide's

creatures for the better part of an hour.

“Is this better or worse than finding a city?” Mydei asks.

Phainon shakes his head, bewildered. “I can’t decide. But I don’t have a good feeling about it.”

“We’re in accord, then.” Mydei puts his hand on the hilt of his sword. “Stay on guard.”

“Trust only each other.” Phainon slides carefully down the hill, stumbling onto the soft grass of the valley’s floor with Mydei close behind.

As they approach the oikos, a humanoid figure—a human man, stooped with age—emerges from a door painted vibrant blue. He lifts a hand high, waving it once, twice, above his head. “Ho, travelers!” he calls.

It’s an awkward thing to trot up to him, neither Phainon nor Mydei increasing their pace. They are of silent agreement: as before, neither wants to waste energy now when it might be needed later.

“Travelers,” the man says again as they approach the oikos’s courtyard. Heavy lines weather a bearded face, and thick, bushy brows overhang eyes of piercing gray. “How good it is to have company after so many years! Welcome, welcome!”

Phainon trades a wary look with Mydei as they cross into the courtyard. He half expects the air to change, to feel somehow different, but it doesn’t. “Grandfather,” he says, taking in the worn fabric, tattered around the hems, that wraps the man’s lean form. Lean, but not gaunt. “Grandfather, how have you come to live here, at the center of the black tide?”

The old man laughs, warm. “Ah, now that is a story. But first, let us trade names.” He offers a Kremnoan salute, and at Phainon’s side, Mydei stiffens. “Once a senator of Castrum Kremnos, I am Lygus.”

Chapter End Notes

at least one of you saw this ending coming, and for that, i applaud you. for everyone else... jazz hands?

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 17

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Eurypon disbanded the Senate before even Mydei's birth, one of his first acts as Castrum Kremnos's tyrannical king, and so Mydei has never met a senator before, but normal men don't live so long as this Lygus must have. Mydei trades a look with Phainon, whose gaze is sharp with the same suspicion.

"Then you've been here for many years," Mydei says slowly.

"Oh, yes," Lygus agrees with a congenial smile, as though he doesn't understand the implications of this. Even Mydei knows young men weren't elected senators. "A decade or two, certainly."

Phainon sets his hand on the hilt of his sword. "Respectfully, grandfather, how has the tide not killed you?"

"The tide has no reason to bother an old man," Lygus says.

"Nor is it particularly discriminating," Mydei replies, equally on edge.

Lygus laughs, not unkindly but with joviality of a man amused by the impetuous youths surrounding him. "Warriors true, and you with the look of your mother," he says to Mydei, but that isn't enough to startle Mydei. It's no surprise that senator would recognize Gorgo in his features. "Come, come, let us have this discussion over fruit and bread." He turns away, giving them his back, and Mydei briefly considers plunging his blade into it. There is danger here, and he'd rather address it swiftly.

Phainon's fingers brush his wrist. "This is strange," he murmurs, "and we shouldn't act rashly."

“This from you,” Mydei replies with amusement. “But you’re right. Perhaps he knows a way to hold the tide at bay.”

Phainon nods. “He may. He’s worth talking to.”

“For now,” Mydei agrees. He releases his grasp on the hilt of his sword, and he and Phainon follow Lygus through the oikos’s courtyard and into an open-air room.

There, Lygus has laid out a tray of fruits—dates, pomegranates, persimmons—and flat breads alongside an amphora, presumably of wine.

“Sit, sit,” he says, gesturing to the seats around his table. “We have much to discuss, if you have sought me out at last.”

Mydei trades a look with Phainon, and they both take seats flanking each other, opposite Lygus, with the table between them and their backs to an interior wall. From here, Mydei can watch the oikos’s few doors, and nothing can sneak up on them from the valley beyond. A prickling unease washes over him, and he regards the food before him with no small amount of distrust. Surely, there’s no way this Lygus could have anticipated them. Surely, he harbors them no ill will.

“How did you come to be here?” Phainon asks. He, too, sweeps his gaze over the food before them without touching it.

Lygus has no compunctions about his offerings, pouring himself a cup of wine and biting into a fig. “I was run out of Castrum Kremnos ages ago,” Lygus says, “and found this place after many days of wandering.”

“Why?” Mydei asks, leaning forward. Though Lygus peruses the spread of food with impunity, he still doesn’t trust it. “Not just because of my father. Other senators remained behind.”

Lygus’s mouth pulls at the corner, and Mydei can’t tell if it’s disdain or amusement on his face. “Your father didn’t approve of my unique perspective on lawmaking,” Lygus replies, sipping his wine. When Mydei and Phainon remain silent, he continues, “I have always sought the

enumeration of order, and your father has long been an instrument of chaos."

He doesn't know, then, that Eurypon is dead. But how could he? He is isolated in the midst of the black tide, and its creatures know no language. Beneath the table, Phainon touches Mydei's knee, and Mydei intuits his meaning well enough. Say nothing on Eurypon's death. Don't let this man know someone else has taken up Strife's mantle, least of all Mydei.

"Eurypon would disagree with you," Mydei says instead. "He seeks to bring order to Amphoreus under his rule."

Lygus laughs. "And what will he do when he has succeeded? He cherishes conflict and violence, and when he has achieved his goals with both, will he not grind society into the very earth? Such behaviors are a cancer."

"You disagreed with him publicly, then," Mydei surmises.

Spreading his arms wide, Lygus inclines his head. "I had hoped he and I might be allies in restoring order to the world, but our methodologies were… at odds. He sought conquest. I sought the rule of law, but tyrants are quick to discard the laws that do not favor their views."

"And so you fled," Mydei says.

"How have you survived here?" Phainon asks.

Lygus sets his cup down and picks up a knife from near the tray. While Phainon and Mydei draw back, increasingly guarded, he merely presses the tip of the blade against the pad of one finger. "Is it not obvious?" he asks, displaying the finger for them to see.

Golden blood beads on his skin.

Mydei's eyes narrow. A Chrysos Heir who opposed Eurypon from the start? "You're the reason Eurypon fears and hates the Chrysos Heirs," he says.

Lygus's bushy brows lift. "What measures has he implemented in my absence?"

“He purges Amphoreus of Chrysos Heirs at every opportunity,” Mydei says. “Often, he burns them at the stake, publicly, but he has crucified some and simply slit the throats of others.” His expression is grim. “It depends on wholly on his mood.”

“And yet you both live.” Lygus’s tone is musing, curious. “You, he must be unaware of,” he says, nodding to Phainon. His gaze shifts to Mydei. “And you, he must suffer.” Lygus makes a thoughtful sound. “Ah.” He chuckles. “Eurypon is dead, isn’t he? He wouldn’t allow his son an excursion into the black tide were he alive.”

A chill washes through Mydei.

“A fortunate thing,” Lygus says, smiling, “though I’m sure you mustn’t agree.” He gives a deferential nod toward Mydei. “He was your father, after all.” Mydei says nothing. “Who, then, bears Strife’s mantle in his absence?”

Another touch of Phainon’s fingers against his knee, though Mydei needs no warning to keep his silence on this topic. He doubts it will matter.

“It can’t be that Anaxagoras,” Lygus continues. “For he has been Reason’s creature for years.”

Mydei startles at that. “Anaxagoras is Reason?”

“No, no,” Lygus says, waving him off. “Although, by now, who can say. Only that when I was still in Castrum Kremnos, Anaxagoras was, even as a child, much beloved by the previous Reason. I wouldn’t be surprised to learn he killed Cerces, took her coreflame, and ascended himself in these past few years.” He regards Phainon and Mydei each. “If not Anaxagoras, then… Is it you, my boy?” he asks Mydei. “My condolences. Patricide may be the way of Castrum Kremnos, but I cannot imagine it an easy thing.”

Unease wells within Mydei. Though the sun is bright above them, the world takes on an ominous cast, and he can’t help but think they have somehow walked into something very dangerous. Lygus is too keen.

“Your silence betrays you,” Lygus says. He reaches for another date.

They need to wrest control of this conversation from Lygus. “And you,” Mydei says. “You live in the midst of the black tide, able to push it back as only Strife can. What power is this?”

“Oh, that.” Lygus laughs. “Why would the tide bother its father?”

They are both out of their seats, weapons drawn, a moment later. Mydei’s heart hammers in his chest, a cold sweat beading on his brow despite the warmth of the day.

Lygus is unperturbed. “There’s no need for violence,” he says mildly. “Have I done you harm?”

“Yes,” Mydei says.

“Great harm,” Phainon replies. “You’re destroying the world. You claim your methods are different from Eurypon’s, but you seek the same destruction.”

“Eurypon’s ambitions were small, his methods petty. He wanted to rule the world. I desire nothing more than to see it remade into something more… orderly. Something neat.”

Beside Mydei, Phainon trembles. He wants to reach out, to touch Phainon, to offer him some comfort, but he doesn’t dare take his eyes away from the man still seated so casually in front of them, possessed of the same affectation someone might use to discuss the weather.

“To remake it,” Phainon says, his voice shaking, too.

Lygus gestures to the valley beyond his oikos, as if to the whole of the world. “Eurypon is a prime example of why. The world is fundamentally corrupt, evil. Born from chaos, it possesses no inherent order. Men like Eurypon crawl across Amphoreus at the head of a swarm of locusts and visit suffering upon us all.” He gives Mydei a pitying look. “Surely, you understand.”

“I understand you’re mad,” Mydei replies, not lowering his blade.

This. This is why Phainon is trapped in endless cycles: because this man seeks to cleanse the world of evil.

“Great men are usually considered mad. Eurypon was a great man, uniting Amphoreus beneath one banner, was he not? How far did he get before you killed him?” Lygus asks.

Mydei says nothing.

“Okhema still stands,” Phainon says. “Okhema resists.”

“And with his death, Okhema will become the aggressor Eurypon was,” Lygus says. “The Goldweaver may temper her people, if she has the humanity left to do so, but they will call for Kremnoan blood. The people who Eurypon wronged over the many years will rise up in his absence to tear down whatever legacy of his remains. You.” He indicates Mydei with a fig. “Your mother, if she still lives. Ah, she does. Marvelous. Gorgo would have made an excellent ally.”

“Gorgo would never have allied with you,” Mydei snarls. “She doesn’t want the world to burn.”

“Nor do I,” Lygus says mildly. “The rot of humanity goes too deep for us to cleanse the world with mere fire. No, it must be completely destroyed. Remade.”

Phainon makes a strangled noise. “So you plan to release the primordial ones from THEIR prison. To annihilate not just Amphoreus but the divine heavens above us?”

Here at last, Lygus is taken aback. “How do you know of the primordial ones?” he asks.

“Even my bard knows of the primordial ones,” Mydei says sharply, grateful for Peucesta’s recitation.

Lygus makes a thoughtful noise. “Some pay attention to Hesiod, but everyone knows he was a dreamer and prone to embellishment. That’s why no one has ever taken his *Theogony* seriously.” He takes another sip of his wine. “Do sit back down.”

They don’t sit, but they do lower their blades. Somewhat.

“You talk like you knew him,” Phainon says. “Hesiod.”

Lygus gives him a wan smile. “We all have our curses. Mine is endless life.”

“Immortality?” Mydei asks, startled.

Lygus shrugs. “Perhaps. I have never died. In light of everything, I simply… continue. I reached this age one… two thousand years ago and never changed—and neither did the world around me. Do you think I came to this conclusion that the world must end lightly?” He scoffs. “No. I have watched men become increasingly degenerate over these two thousand years, their depravity unmatched, and so I created the black tide some centuries ago.” He bares his teeth in a facsimile of a smile. “But you,” he says to Mydei. “Your legacy of Strife has always stood between the tide and its ultimate goal. It is why you have been such an inconvenience in my search for an adequate vessel.”

Phainon’s face blanches of color. “All those times,” he whispers. “All those times the Titans were possessed.”

“The Titans?” Lygus asks. “No, they would never do. They are too fixed in what they are, too *ordered* for something like the black tide to control.” His smile becomes something terrible, something almost feral, as his attention shifts to Phainon. “But you…” He rises, and their blades rise with him. “Time bends around you. You are… familiar. As though the tide has seen your reflection as you bear up under the strange weight of time.” He spreads wide his hands. “You would do quite nicely.”

Phainon lurches back a step, hitting the oikos’s wall behind him, as Lygus’s form shudders, as it distorts, as it begins to grow. His skin tears like so

much fabric, coming apart at the joints, bloodless but no less disturbing. Flesh peels away to reveal a twisted form of black metal surrounding a magma core of molten gold. Heat spills from it as Lygus—or the creature who once was Lygus—shakes himself free of his skin. Gone are his human proportions, replaced by gargantuan hands tipped with magma-like claws and legs that spiral into a sharp, pointed spindles. Fiery wings emanate from his back, as golden as the core of him. He towers above them, hunched against the oikos's ceiling, which cracks as he grows larger still.

"Run," Mydei says, grabbing Phainon by the wrist and yanking him out of the way as stone crumbles and begins to fall.

No sooner has Mydei dragged Phainon to the side than Lygus attacks, crashing his massive fist into the wall. It, too, shatters, exploding outward into a cloud of rock shards that slice along skin.

Phainon tugs his wrist free of Mydei's hold as they reach the courtyard. Together, they turn, brandishing their weapons as Lygus recovers from his missed strike.

"Do you think he's still…" Phainon trails off.

"Child of Time," Lygus growls, his voice grating like the clash of two blades. "Your flesh will be mine."

"Still in there," Mydei confirms.

Lygus slams both fists down. Terrible spikes of virulent gold burst from the ground. Mydei dodges in one direction and Phainon in the other, the both of them throwing themselves out of the way of the attack.

Recovering quickly, Mydei rushes Lygus from one side. Phainon moves in a mirror of him, coming at Lygus from the opposite, and Lygus makes his intentions clear. He lifts one hand and fires a volley of magmatic lances at Mydei as he rounds on Phainon.

Mydei twists through the volley, knocking the lances aside with his blade and ignoring the ones that graze his shoulders, his hip. By the time he's

cleared the lances, Lygus is hammering Phainon's own sword with mighty fists, pounding Phainon back, back, back toward the entrance to the courtyard, where a small army's worth of black tide monsters are rushing toward them.

"Fuck," he mutters, crossing the courtyard in a rush, engaging the oncoming monsters to protect Phainon's back while Phainon deals with Lygus.

Twin behemoths roar from backline as more humanoid terrors bear down on him. Mydei's blade is quick; he carves through him efficiently, twisting to dodge their scythe-like arms and the hammers of their fists. With a dancer's grace, he cuts them down, and when they come too close, he touches the coreflame's power within him and summons a burst of vibrant red crystal. Shards of crystal pierce the ground in concentric circles, spearing through the monsters. They fade into a black and gold mist, but he pays the defeated ones little mind as he turns to the approaching behemoths.

Though he hates to admit it, he recalls the conflict with Eurypon and how Eurypon fought them not just with blade but with his Titan's power. He, too, is the Lance of Fury, and much like Lygus just now, he calls forth great lances from the sky, spearing the behemoths to the ground.

The wave of monsters seems endless. The more that fall, the more arrive, and Mydei finds himself panting as he cuts them down, as he glances behind him to find Lygus chasing Phainon across the courtyard.

This isn't enough. Separated, they aren't as powerful. Together, they took down a god, and Lygus, for all his talk of cleansing the world's corruption, is no god.

Mydei grasps the power of Strife within him and summons a mighty wall of crystal, sealing off the courtyard. The monsters on the other side of it pound against it, their inhuman wails filling the air as they throw themselves repeatedly onto the barrier. It holds strong.

Dispatching the last few monsters, Mydei whirls on Phainon and Lygus.

Lygus leaps backwards, taking to the air with those glowing wings of flame. He hovers, spreading his arms wide and then bringing them together, clapping his massive fists. A boom precedes a burst of flame, one that Phainon barely dodges.

But with Lygus's attention focused squarely on Phainon, Mydei has an opening.

Adjusting his grip on his sword, he lunges forward, rushing the creature from behind. He kicks off a shattered column that once supported the oikos's roof and drives his sword into Lygus's back.

Howling with rage, Lygus whips around. The force of the spin hurls Mydei off him, but he manages to take his sword with him as he rolls across the grass, tumbling to his feet in a crouch.

Phainon is at his side a moment later. "Glad you could join me."

"Don't expect me to apologize for dealing with the other monsters."

Phainon laughs, panting. "Oh, I wouldn't dream of it. Ready?"

"Ready."

As one, they rush Lygus. They are twin whirlwinds, ducking under the pounding attacks of his fists as they parry with quick strikes of their blades, ripping into the dripping core of him. Phainon fights with thousands of years of experience, anticipating not just Mydei's support but Lygus's attacks, forcing Lygus onto the defensive.

With Lygus on the backfoot, Mydei calls lances from the sky, hammering them down in the courtyard, forcing Lygus to dance between them. He moves with a monstrous grace, deeply unsettling to behold, dodging each lance until one clips one of those fiery wings.

Crashing to the earth with a howl, he slaps the ground.

Mydei and Phainon leap backward as more yellow-gold crystal explodes from the earth, giving Lygus the space he needs to recover.

“I am far older than either of you,” Lygus says, voice booming across the courtyard.

The howling of the monsters on the other side of the crystal barrier grows louder, and Mydei chances a look back. It holds, but through the transparent crystal, cracks have formed on the far side.

“With more experience than you can hope to muster!” Lygus clenches a first, and searing light bursts forth from his wings. Only just turning back, Mydei isn’t blinded, but Phainon, who was looking directly at Lygus, staggers. “What are you ants to the millennia I have lived?”

Mydei lunges forward, ready to defend Phainon, but Phainon, eyes closed, deflects Lygus’s crystalline spears.

“Time bends around me,” Phainon says with a laugh. “Because Oronyx broke it for me. Your two thousand years are *nothing* to me, Lygus!”

Mydei catches himself, hanging back as Phainon, eyes still closed, engaged Lygus with a perfectly executed flurry of blows, his blade flashing in the sunlight. He slices through one of Lygus’s arms, ducks beneath his guard, and cuts clear through the center of that molten core, cleaving it in half. It is a perfectly executed attack, built on the experience of a man who has suffered for thousands upon thousands of cycles, an incalculable number of years, and while Lygus shrieks in horror, there is nothing he can do to prevent the deathblow.

In pieces, Lygus crumples to the ground. The disparate parts of his tide-tainted body linger there as Phainon stands over him with his bloodless sword, and then even he dissipates into nothing, dissolving like so much chaff.

The howling of the monsters beyond the barrier ceases. Mydei looks over his shoulder, spying the dark smudges of the creatures through the crystals. They remain, but with the loss of their commander, they are, perhaps, confused. Uncertain of what to do. He grimaces, not sure if that’s better or worse. But for now, he turns back to Phainon.

Phainon who stands over the spot where Lygus fell, his face an expressionless mask.

“Phainon,” Mydei says.

“He created the tide,” Phainon says, voice hollow. “He could have told us so much. But he forced us to kill him.” He lifts his face to Mydei’s own. “If he controlled the tide, too—”

A strange groaning fills the air, and they both turn toward the tree beyond the courtyard, watching as the tide consumes it, watching as the tide covers the oikos, as it eats away the grass beneath their feet until Phainon stands on that slick, black surface, and Mydei occupies the only green space that remains.

“Fuck,” Mydei says, raking a hand through his hair. “It’s never moved that fast before.”

Phainon shakes his head. “No, never. It—” He goes utterly, terribly still. “Castrum Kremnos. If it’s moving this quickly, can Leonnius outrun it back to Castrum Kremnos?”

Horror washes over Mydei. “I… don’t know.”

“And then onto Okhema.” Phainon rushes up to Mydei, grabbing him by the shoulder. “How long until it reaches Okhema, if it moves so quickly?”

Mydei isn’t Ptolemy. He doesn’t know how to do this math. “I don’t know.”

“We need to get to Okhema,” Phainon says.

Mydei’s heart aches. “Castrum Kremnos—”

“The tide may take Castrum Kremnos,” Phainon says, his voice cracking, his face breaking with grief. “It may, Mydei, but we can’t let it take Okhema.”

Throat closing, Mydei wraps his hand around Phainon’s wrist. “My friends. My *mother*.”

Phainon’s eyes are bright, his expression as pained as Mydei’s own. “We can’t be in both places. We can’t save both cities.”

And Mydei, for all he hurts, knows Phainon is right. “Castrum Kremnos for Okhema,” he says softly. “Castrum Kremnos for the world.”

“We will save what we can,” Phainon promises him, gripping his shoulder now for comfort. He pulls Mydei close, embracing him. “We will fix this. Somehow, we will stop the primordial ones, and we will fix this.”

Mydei presses his face into Phainon’s neck, taking a shuddering breath. He allows himself the pain of loss, the ache for his mother, for his friends, for the whole of Castrum Kremnos, knowing there’s no way for them to evacuate the entire city before the black tide arrives. Maybe—maybe—Themistocles will evacuate his mother ahead of the people. Maybe—maybe—his friends will outrun the tide. Maybe, maybe, so many maybes but nothing certain.

Now isn’t the time for grief. The world hangs in the balance.

Withdrawing from Phainon, he chokes down his sorrows and his fears. “We can’t outrun the tide on foot, but Strife can cut through the air.”

Phainon’s eyes widen. “You mean to take Strife’s form?”

“For this, yes.” Mydei’s lips twist in a rueful smile. “Though I have no idea how to do as Eurypon did, I will try. Step back?”

Phainon does so. “I believe in you,” he says, and Mydei’s heart swells. “You’re the only hope for Amphoreus.”

“But no pressure,” Mydei drawls, an almost ironic echo of Phainon’s words to Leonnius.

Closing his eyes, he takes a deep, centering breath. Drawing on Strife’s power isn’t difficult. It craves conflict and wants to be used, springing easily to his hands. His blood pounds in his veins, burning with the desire to turn to the creatures beyond his crystal wall to cut them down. Wrestling

past the desire to fight, he cuts deeper into himself, plunging into the depths of the coreflame inside him.

Power throbs through him, and he discovers the transformation is an easy thing. His desire to crush the primordial ones fuels it, twisting his limbs into white and gold, until he is a massive creature, towering over Phainon, something beyond human ken. A Titan.

Phainon stares up at him, so small and fragile, and Mydei is seized with the desire to protect him, to hide him away from this. But Phainon is at the heart of all this turmoil and protecting him will do nothing to solve it.

Growling low, he bends down, offering Phainon his three-fingered hand. “Climb on,” he grates out. Phainon steps into his palm, holding to his thumb. Mydei bears Phainon to his back, and Phainon climbs onto him. “Do not let go,” Mydei warns.

“You’re all smooth armor. Holding on isn’t going to be easy,” Phainon shouts back. But he finds a seat and settles himself, his small hands grasping onto a piece of Mydei’s armor. Phainon is like an ant, an itch on his back that he wants to scratch. “Right. Ready.”

Strife launches himself into the sky. He hangs there for a second, orienting himself in the direction not of Castrum Kremnos but the Holy City of Okhema. With a howl, he launches himself forward, racing the tide.

Chapter End Notes

> jazz hands
>
> posting a little early since the archive will be down when i usually post. next week we'll be back to our regular friday (2-3pm ET) posting time
>
> as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It takes them far too long to outstrip the tide, and Phainon's stomach churns with anxiety. Somewhere down there, their somatophylakes are hopefully astride their horses, fleeing. Somewhere down there, the city of Castrum Kremnos is likely under siege by the black tide. And somewhere down there, Aglaea's army will need to turn and flee lest they, too, are devoured by a force of nature that renders the machinations of men meaningless. All the politicking, all the subterfuge and war, and none of it matters in the face of the black tide racing them to Okhema.

Mydei—Strife—does manage to outpace the tide. They catch up to it and then push ahead of its frontier, but it moves at a visible pace, consuming the land in a rolling wave of darkness. Clutching at Strife's armor, Phainon shudders, but he has a sliver of hope—the black tide was created. A man, a Chrysos Heir, crafted it. If it was created, surely it can be destroyed. Nothing made by men, or even by Titans, can't be undone somehow. Their confrontation with Lygus gave him this small hope, and he clings to it as Strife races above the ground, touching down but briefly to launch himself into the air once more, cutting through the skies.

Okhema grows large before them, and Phainon briefly entertains the idea of landing and approaching as men—but if they do that, they will be arrested, certainly, and have to go through bureaucracy they don't have time for to meet with Aglaea. No, they'll make an entrance. Perhaps Strife is of the same mind because he doesn't balk as they approach.

The great statue of Kephale rises above the city, the Worldbearer bearing a golden sculpture of the world, and it's there that Phainon directs Mydei, to the amphitheater beneath Kephale's watch where Aglaea and her own senate meet. As they approach, golden threads spear through the air around them in shimmering beams, and Strife snarls.

“Don’t fight her,” Phainon calls out. “We’re here as friends. Let her restrain us—a show of good faith.”

Strife snarls again, clearly displeased with this, but allows Aglaea’s threads to weave around his wrists, his ankles. More threads, delicate and gentle, wrap around Phainon, and though they don’t fully pin him down, he knows that the wrong move will see them painfully tight and restrictive.

With the threads wrapped around them, they’re borne down to the center of the curia, a large, circular area set apart from the rest of the city and surrounded by standards of each of the Titans. And as they approach, to Phainon’s shock, the Titans stand before the glowing sigils representing their coreflames. There is Law and Death, Passage and Ocean. Earth. Aglaea stands apart, closer to the center of the curia, her face uplifted toward them as she takes them to the ground, her expression one of fierce concentration.

All of them are present—except for Sky and Reason—and Phainon is as relieved as he is frightened. In no previous cycle have the Titans all gathered together like this. He tried a handful of times to convince them to work together, but they defied him in each attempt, keeping their own counsel. Thanatos was always the most difficult, one of the Titans who survived from the genesis of the world, content to keep themself in their underworld where they thought they would remain untouched by the black tide.

“You’ve done the impossible,” he says to Aglaea as she binds Strife to the ground. “How did you manage to bring them all together?”

She looks up at him with narrowed eyes. “You used me, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae,” she says in lieu of answering him.

He inclines his head and, mindful of the threads still loose around his body, slides from Strife’s back. “And you, me. So maybe we agree to let bygones be bygones and focus on the larger issue of the black tide.” He extends a hand to Aglaea.

She doesn’t take it.

Law steps forward. She is a slight thing, all long and willowy limbs, with a chiton of vibrant violet edged in gold and a waterfall of black hair spilling down her back. No one knows how she slew Cerydra so many centuries ago, only that she did, and that no one has been able to dethrone her since then. But where Cerydra was, like Eurypon, obsessed with conquering all of Amphoreus, Eunomia believes only in the letter of the law and executing it. She serves as judge and jury for the Titans, a calmer hand than Cerydra was. “Indeed,” she says, “we are convened to discuss the black tide.”

Aglaea’s threads abruptly tighten, and Phainon wheezes, gasping. Strife makes a pained sound as they are both forced to their knees under the oppressive force.

“And we must thank you,” Eunomia continues, “for bringing its source to us.”

Phainon freezes. “I—what?” The statement is so preposterous he can’t even begin to make sense of it.

“For nearly one hundred years,” Aglaea says, “we have struggled against not just the encroachment of the black tide, but its master, as Eurypon’s advance cleared the way for the tide’s destruction. And now you come to Okhema, heralds of the end, with the black tide rushing after you.” She crosses her arms. “You must be proud, for at last Okhema’s armies are defeated.”

Cold horror grips Phainon. If the army is dead, then Hephaestion and the others—he has killed—he can’t think about this. Not now.

Beside him, Strife howls with fury. “Eurypon is dead,” he snarls. “Do you think I would uphold Eurypon’s legacy? Did you not receive my mother’s messenger? Do you not know I struck the final blow against Eurypon, felling him and taking his power?”

“We know,” says Amphitrite, Titan of Ocean, who wears a gown made of water. Small fish swim through it, swirling around her knees, her thighs, her hips. “We felt your accession. But this changes nothing. Your father—”

Strife growls. “—sought to conquer the world with his sword in one hand and the tide in the other. You, apparently, seek only to use the tide.”

Phainon swings his gaze over the Titans. Tribbie and her many siblings cluster together, holding onto each other, their eyes downcast. They are sweet and well-meaning, and perhaps if this was just Aglaea, they would speak in Phainon’s defense, but its unlikely they’ll speak against Law and Ocean—and the other Titans, many of them murmuring in agreement with Amphitrite’s words.

“The black tide is Strife’s ancient enemy,” Phainon protests, bewildered. But he’s seen men—and Titans—believe in stranger things than this. “It flees before Strife’s might and—”

“A ruse,” Eunomia declares.

“It was shortly after Mydeimos’s accession that the tide began its rapid advance,” mighty Kephale says, crossing his arms over his chest. He wears a shining breastplate and a wickedly curved sword on his hip. A helm rests near his feet; he is dressed for war.

Phainon makes a frustrated noise. “It was *days*,” he corrects. The threads around him grow tighter. They cut into his wrist, his ankles, and wind around his abdomen and his throat as he struggles against them, wanting to rise to his feet.

But even Titans are blind to the truth when they’ve made up their minds, and Kephale waves him off.

Phainon whips his head around, searching out Cipher. She hangs back, her expression clouded. “You know,” he says to her. “The information I gave you about the Acheron—that came from Mydei. He betrayed Eurypon to help us. You know—”

“I know what?” she asks, glib and dismissive as always, though her eyes remain shadowed. “I know that you told me the crown prince would be at the Acheron, which allowed us three days to advance on Castrum Kremnos. Now you claim that information came from him? Why should we believe

that?” She, at least, doesn’t sound convinced of her disbelief. And if he can bring Cipher to his side, then he can sway Aglaea.

“Think, Cipher,” he says. “How would I have had insider information about troop movement if Mydei hadn’t given them to me?”

Her frown deepens, but she says nothing as she leans deeper into the shadow of her own standard.

“Enough of this,” Kephale says. He doesn’t draw the blade at his side but rather manifests one of brilliant black light in his hand. It writhes with shadow at its center, and glows horribly at its edges, rippling with the heat of lightning. “We have Strife before us. We will end him.”

Phainon’s eyes grow wide. “Mydei is immortal. He—”

“A Titan can be slain,” Kephale says, cold and cruel. “We will take his coreflame and give it to an ally.”

Phainon jerks in his bonds as Eunomia and Amphitrite summon their own weapons. Earth follows suit. Even Tribbie and her sisters call their own weapons, though their eyes remain downcast. Aglaea’s threads tighten even more as Strife bellows with fury.

“You can’t!” Phainon shouts. “Strife, whole and complete, can fight back the tide! You have to listen to—”

But they’re not listening. Kephale lifts his blade. Amphitrite hefts her hooked spear. Eunomia brandishes a bow. The eight of them ready their weapons, excepting only Cipher, whose laughter has a nervous edge.

“For Amphoreus,” Kephale says with complete conviction. He brings his sword down in as sweeping arc, and curved, black-white light leaps from it. Strife roars once more, rearing back, and Phainon realizes they have completely and utterly failed. Once more, his actions will see Mydei dead. Once more, he has ruined a cycle. He’ll die, too. There’s no way Kephale won’t kill him, and he’ll lose the only person he’s ever loved in all these cycles, and he doesn’t think he can bear that. He doesn’t want to find Mydei

again, doesn’t want to fall in love again. He wants *this* Mydei and *this* world, and he just can’t fucking win.

He screams, too, in furious defiance of the destiny he’s wrought, straining against the threads until one snaps, another, but it’s not enough, not fast enough, as that terrible light slices through the air toward Mydei.

Only for thick roots to burst forth from the earth, taking the hit on Strife’s behalf. Kephale’s attack shears through a layer of the roots, but can only make it halfway through the thicket of them.

“That,” Anaxagoras says, striding into the curia, “is quite enough of that.” His apprentice, Hyacinthia, is at his side, clutching a staff glowing with green light.

The other Titans turn their blades on him, Kephale frowning deeply. “Reason,” he says, and Phainon is less surprised than he thinks he should be to hear that. No, he’s relieved to hear that.

“The only voice of it,” Anaxagoras agrees. “You old fools are so set in your hatred for Eurypon that you can’t see the truth of this situation.” He waves at Phainon and Strife. “They come to you at an inflection point, and you choose to destroy the only people who could potentially save you?” He pinches the bridge of his nose. “Truly, I am surrounded by idiots. Destroy Strife, and you destroy the one Titan capable of holding back the black tide.”

“What proof do you have?” Kephale demands.

Anaxagoras scoffs. “Did you not stand shoulder to shoulder with Gnaeus at the first incursion of the tide, watching him bleed to push it back? Did Nikador not bleed himself almost dry not three hundred years ago? The centuries are long, but *your* memory is longer, and we all know it. You’re blinded by hatred.” He laughs. “Aren’t you better than that?”

Kephale’s face mottles with rage. “You dare—”

“And do you really think Strife would come here himself and lay himself before your blades if the situation wasn’t dire?”

Strife growls, somehow sounding like agreement, and Phainon looks from Anaxagoras to Kephale and then onto Aglaea. Kephale may lead the Titans, but if enough of them question him, if Aglaea dares to, the others will turn, too, and he’ll be forced to acknowledge the truth of Anaxgoras’s words.

“The black tide is no more Strife’s creation than you are, Kephale,” Anaxagoras continues. “While you can be exceptionally dense—”

Kephale points his blade at Anaxagoras. “Watch yourself, Reason.”

“—you aren’t *that* much of a fool. Set aside your pride.” He rounds on Aglaea. “And you. You have been in the right, defending your people against Eurypon, but now you lash out at his son—why? For the circumstances of his birth?” Anaxagoras sneers. “Are we not supposed to be better than this? Are we not supposed to care more about the whole of Amphoreus than our petty city states, vying for power between each other? The black tide has swept over Castrum Kremnos—” Phainon’s heart sinks, and he drops his head. “—and encroaches on Okhema, but you focus on assassinating Strife to feed your own egos?” He points a dramatic hand at Phainon. “Listen to him. *Hear him*.” When Phainon doesn’t immediately start talking, Anaxagoras snaps his fingers. “Speak, boy.”

Lifting his head, Phainon does. “The black tide was created hundreds of years ago,” he says. “By a madman who wants to destroy the world so it can be remade. It will do that by freeing the primordial ones, ancient gods entombed in a mausoleum beneath Okhema.”

Many of the Titans scoff at this, laughing as they glance between each other, but Aglaea is silent, her brows drawn tight, and Thanatos leans forward, extending darkness from their form like a reaching hand.

Phainon turns to Thanatos, who stands silent before their standard, cloaked in wine-dark hues, a veil over their face. “You must remember THEM. The others, they’re all newer, but you and Kephale were there.” He glances at Kephale, whose face has begun to fall into one of dawning horror.

Phainon’s attention return to silent Thanatos. “The black tide seeks THEIR prison. Seeks to free THEM. All of this is in service of using THEM to destroy and remake the world.”

“This must be a joke,” Eunomia says, laughing.

“No,” Thanatos rasps, their voice like so many whispers, like sheafs of parchment rustling. “No, the boy speaks true. Before the Titans, the primordial ones were.” Thanatos inclines their head toward Kephale. “You remember, brother.”

Waxen-faced, hand covering his mouth, Kephale nods. “I remember. THEIR wars were the things of nightmares. THEY created and destroyed with indifference, neither act different from the other. We entombed THEM.” He touches his chest. “With the coreflames, we locked THEM away where THEY could do no harm.” He leans forward. “Who is it who created the tide and seeks to free THEM?”

“An old man calling himself Lycurgus,” Phainon says.

Aglaea chokes. “The senator from Castrum Kremnos.”

Eunomia looks sick. “I taught him.”

“He’s dead,” Phainon says. “For what it’s worth.”

Aglaea twists her wrist, and the threads restraining him and Strife finally fall away. In an instant, Mydei stands beside him once more, rubbing his wrists, disdainful. He steps closer to Phainon, and Phainon rises from his knees, desperately wanting to take Mydei’s hand and fearing any indication of affection will be seen as weakness.

“We killed him,” Mydei says. “And his death expedited the tide.” He looks to Anaxagoras, expression tight. “Castrum Kremnos fell?”

Anaxagoras nods. “But I convinced your mother to flee before the tide arrived. How many survived, I do not know, but she races ahead of it to Okhema.” He gestures to Hyacinthia. “We were simply faster on our own.”

Relieved, Mydei exhales, closing his eyes. “Thank you, scholar,” he says.

The other Titans have turned on Kephale and Thanatos, Aglaea first among their number, fierce with her anger. “You have known?” she demands of them. “All this time, you have known the black tide sought to free monsters entombed beneath *my* city?”

“No,” Kephale says, warding her off with upraised hands. “We knew the primordial ones were buried there, but THEY were meant to be forgotten. That this Lycurgus discovered THEIR existence, that he meant to free THEM…” His fingers brush over his own chest.

Phainon notices. “You said the coreflames were used to entomb them,” he says. “If they were strong enough to overwhelm and lock away the primordial ones, could they not be used again to turn back the black tide? Wouldn’t they be powerful enough?”

Unease passes over Kephale’s face. “It’s not so easy a thing to master all the coreflames, and with Oronyx’s missing… I worry the balance would be unstable.”

“Then we stand aside?” Aglaea asks softly. “We stand aside and let the black tide destroy us?”

“We can’t,” Phainon says, clenching his fists.

They all fix him with heavy gazes, weighty and terrifying; he is the lone human man among the Titans. An ant. They could crush him.

“Tell them,” Mydei murmurs, reaching out and touching his fingers to Phainon’s shoulder, an incredible comfort. Aglaea’s lips part with realization, but she says nothing. “Tell them what you’ve done,” Mydei says.

“This has happened before,” Phainon says, lifting his eyes to meet Kephale’s. “Not exactly like this, but the black tide has reached Okhema before, destroying it, freeing the primordial ones to let THEM destroy the universe. But when it did, my childhood friend, Cyrene, she was there—we

were both there—and she and Oronyx shattered Oronyx's coreflame to create a time loop. They destroyed themselves for us. For me. So that I could do this again and again, so that I could stop the primordial ones." He swallows hard. "I have done this… so many times."

Aglaea presses a hand to her chest.

"This is a lie," Amphitrite says. "Oronyx has been dead for thousands of years."

"Because in this cycle, Oronyx never existed," Phainon insists.

"*Liar*," Amphitrite hisses.

Cipher finally steps out of the shadows. "The truth," she says. All attention turns to her, and though she quails, as if she hates to be so noticed, she doesn't step back. She fixes her gaze on Aglaea. "We know I can tell truth from lie."

"Because you yourself are a liar," Eunomia drawls.

"She did not lie when she brought news of the Acheron to me," Aglaea says, quick to Cipher's defense.

Eunomia scoffs. "One instance of honesty doesn't mean—"

"Believe me or not," Cipher says. "We waste precious time arguing when Phainon is telling us the truth: Oronyx shattered themself, as he says, to create a loop for him." She studies him. "How many times?"

He allows his weariness to show, allows himself to slouch. "Thousands? Tens of thousands? I've lost count. But this time, you're all here, and I've learned more from you. The combined power of the coreflames locked away these primordial ones. Surely, even without Oronyx, if Kephale is careful—" For who else but Kephale could do this? "—then we can use that same power to drive back the black tide. To destroy it."

Anaxagoras claps, slowly and with great irony. "Now that we have reached our inevitable conclusion, perhaps we can act." He gestures to the red-

stained horizon, where slick black coats the ground and rolls increasingly closer. “We don’t have much time.”

Still clearly uncertain, Kephale shakes his head. “Without Oronyx’s coreflame…”

“If we give over our coreflames, we will make ourselves defenseless,” Eunomia says. “This could all serve the tide’s ends.”

“And what other choice do we have?” Mydei suddenly demands, rounding on her and Kephale both. “Janus—Passage—may have been the first among you—us—” He throws a hand in the air, frustrated. “—but the Worldbearer has always led the way for the others. Will you gods condemn a human man to repeat more of these cycles out of fear and arrogance? Out of worry that you will lose power?” He slaps his hand against his chest. Golden sparks crackles around his palm as he draws it back, removing with it the coreflame housed inside him. “If we fail, we are destroyed, and Phainon lives again, knowing he can’t trust any of us to do what we should: protect humanity before ourselves and our own interests.” Mydei extends his hand and his coreflame to Kephale, thunder in his voice and lightning in his eyes. “Do as you were created to do,” he says to Kephale, “and bear the weight of responsibility for this world.”

Silent, Kephale reaches for Mydei’s coreflame. He takes it in cupped hands, reverent in his quiet. “You are right, Strife,” he says. “What are we if not the guardians of what we created? Let us protect it once more, as we did in the days of old.”

“Let epics be sung in our honor,” Aglaea says as she, too, coaxes her coreflame from her chest. When Kephale has absorbed Strife’s coreflame, he takes Romance’s into himself as well.

Anaxagoras spares a scathing look for the other Titans before offering Reason’s coreflame, and Hyacinthia follows with Sky’s. Cipher is hesitant, ducking forward and giving over Trickery before skuttling back.

Hope burns in Phainon’s chest. His skin tingles as power wafts through the air, as the other Titans, slowly and haltingly, come forward with their own

coreflames. Next Thanatos. Reluctantly, Amphitrite. Reservedly, Eunomia. Tribbie and her sisters with more enthusiasm, offering their coreflame with a smile.

Anaxagoras leans over Phainon's shoulder. "You're sure Oronyx's coreflame was destroyed when your Cyrene bent time?" he asks, sotto voce.

Phainon hesitates. He remembers only Cyrene's impassioned prayers and the moment she grasped pure power between her hands, Oronyx's coreflame in her palms. And then the world was sundered, and he in that cellar beneath his home in Aedes Elysiae, listening to slaughter. "I'm sure," he says.

"Hm." Anaxagoras withdraws.

Letting a frown fade, Phainon turns to Mydei. "Thank you," he says.

Mydei answers with a small smile. "This will be the last," he replies, gripping Phainon's hand.

Finally goes Earth, a boy child locked in eternal youth, who has kept his peace this entire time. "For the future of humanity," he says to Phainon, not Kephale, before giving over his coreflame, too.

Kephale, panting, takes this last coreflame into his hands. Strain marks his face as he absorbs this final coreflame.

"It is done," Aglaea says. She reaches for Kephale. "Go forth and turn back the black tide."

Kephale takes her wrist in his hand—and Mydei and Phainon see it in the same moment: the blue-black of Kephale's eyes. Fear carves through Phainon, but it doesn't paralyze him. He lunges forward with Mydei, both of them striving for Aglaea. They cannot reach her before Kephale snaps her wrist, summons his blade of black-white light, and drives it through her stomach.

Chapter End Notes

so that happened

i feel like i should apologize for the talky chapter but it all needed to happen to facilitate the rest of the climax, so here we go. also there are 21 chapters now /jazz hands

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 19

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Tribbie screams. Cipher, too.

Phainon grasps Aglaea by the shoulders and pulls her back, off of Kephale's sword, as Mydei catches the next blow of the Worldbearer's blade on his gauntleted fist. Blood pours from her wound, staining her belly, and Phainon drags her backwards as Hyacinthia rushes forward, her hands glowing with healing energy.

"Let me!" she exclaims, pressing her hands to Aglaea's wound as Aglaea, white as her dress, groans.

Mydei isn't alone engaging the Worldbearer. The Titan swings his blade wildly, and Anaxagoras and Thanatos both lunge forward to deflect his strikes from landing on Mydei. The three of them barricade Kephale as Kephale lets his sword vanish, drives his hands into his hair, throws back his head, and roars.

Black-white light pours from his mouth, piercing the skies.

A mistake. Giving Kephale the coreflames was a mistake—another mistake—Phainon can't stop making mistakes—there has to be a right answer in here somewhere, but as he clutches Aglaea's shoulders, as Hyacinthia heals her and Tribbie sobs and Cipher pleads, he can't find it.

Kephale screams, turning his face toward the former Titans, and Mydei tackles him to the ground, catching him by the jaw and angling his face up so he can't hit anyone with that beam of terrible light, but Kephale quickly throws him off and flings him halfway across the curia, into a pillar. Mydei's impact cracks it in half.

“Go,” Hyacinthia says. Phainon whips around to look at her, her expression drawn with concentration as she heals Aglaea’s wound. Tribbie wails, and Cipher clutches Aglaea’s hand. “Go help them,” Hyacinthia says again. “You’re a warrior. You’re wasted here.”

She’s right. He can’t help Aglaea, but he has fought alongside Kephale before; he recruited the Worldbearer for one cycle, and fury floods him. Kephale hadn’t believed him about the black tide, and they’d failed. Kephale lied to him. Kephale damned the world. And now, ripe with the power of all the coreflames, Kephale is insane with power, damning the world again.

Phainon passes Aglaea to Cipher, climbing to his feet. Mydei, too, staggers upright.

This time, somehow, Phainon won’t let the world be damned, to hell with Kephale’s weakness.

They need to trap him.

“Pelius,” he says to the former Earth Titan. “Can you still manipulate rocks?” Pelius inclines his head. “Create a domed barrier and do everything in your power to hold it. Amphitrite, share your energy with Pelius. Keep him shielded at the same time.”

She sputters. “That is—”

“Your only fucking option,” Phainon snaps, drawing his sword. “Keep Kephale trapped here unless you want him to do the tide’s work for us.”

“He warned you,” Eunomia hisses, grabbing at Phainon’s sword arm.

He throws her off him, turning his blade on her as Anaxagoras and Thanatos batter Kephale back. “You,” he says to her. She has limited power over the rules that govern the world, and he’s not sure he trusts her to actually help. “You can increase our strength, our speed.”

She sputters.

“Do it,” he says. “Bless us with superior, Titan-like capabilities, or we will all die here.”

“We’re going to die anyway,” she says.

“Then die *fighting*.” He whirls away from her and throws himself into the fray alongside Anaxagoras and Thanatos.

Mydei is by his side a second later, sword in hand.

Kephale wastes no time pretending to be mortal. He blasts them all back with tremendous force, giving himself meager seconds—seconds he takes to transform into something grotesque and monstrously glorious. A goat’s head emerges alongside a lion’s from a lion’s torso. A long tail slithers across the floor, ending in a snake’s head that hisses at them. Kephale stands on his hind legs, two humanoid, golden arms sprouting from either side of his abdomen. Wings of white ivory burst from his back, and he hovers off the ground, not unlike Lygus. Flowers sprout along his limbs, glowing with verdant life.

Mydei swears. Thanatos says nothing but growls low in the back of their throat. Phainon, who has seen all these parts in different configurations, feels his heart drop.

“A chimera,” Anaxagoras says, adjusting his hold on his blade. “Don’t let the snake head bite you.”

“He’ll have all the powers of the Titans at his disposal,” Phainon warns.

A hand touches his back. “Good thing you have me to reinforce you,” Eunomia says. She slaps her hand between his shoulder blades, and he launches himself forward at a superhuman speed.

Kephale matches him.

They clash in the center of the curia, their impact rattling the earthen dome closing above them. Phainon grits his teeth, pushing against one of Kephale’s black-white blades. The ground beneath his feet cracks. Shatters.

Mydei feints at the Worldbearer's side, and is joined by Anaxagoras, forcing Kephale to turn from Phainon to defend himself. He sweeps a fist at them, trailing deadly arcs of black-white lightning. The scent of ozone fills the air, and Thanatos descends from above, driving a spear downward and forcing Kephale to leap backwards. Eunomia weaves between them, touching them on their shoulders to give them bursts of speed and strength as they take lancing stabs and sweeping strikes at Kephale.

Sweat drips down Phainon's face as he calls out to the others, directing them to leap back when Kephale summons bolts of lighting, warning them before more of those sweeping attacks hit home. At his urging, Anaxagoras swings around Kephale's back, dancing with the snake-headed tail, keeping it occupied.

While Mydei and Phainon stab at Kephale's heart, Thanatos manages to shear off one of those golden arms—only for two to grow back in its place, each wielding spears of virulent red crystal.

"Fuck," Mydei gasps.

A wave of earthen spikes burst from the ground, followed by those crystals. One catches Eunomia's ankle, closing around it. She screams, hammering at the crystal with her fist as crystalline lances coalesce in the air above her.

"Mydei," Phainon shouts.

Mydei swings around Phainon, sheathing his sword in one motion and driving his gauntlets into the crystal encasing Eunomia's ankle in a one-two strike. The crystal shatters. She scrambles backwards as Mydei fluidly turns back to Kephale and the lances strike where she was trapped not seconds before.

Throwing herself to her feet, she weaves once more through the fray, undeterred, reaching for Mydei to bolster him, too. "A life for a life, Strife," she calls to him.

Mydei grins back at her, all teeth.

Energy sizzles through the air as Kephale reaches into the very fabric of reality, twisting it, tearing it, summoning orbs of that same black-white light to smash down on Phainon and the other former Titans. They dodge the strikes, but the damage they do is minimal. Kephale can see every attack, has eyes in all directions, and when they pin him down, he launches himself upward. No, he can't go far, but he hovers out of reach as Eunomia switches to her bow and—

"Snowy! Ahead!" Phainon doesn't glance back at Tribbie. He's done this with her before, he remembers this from previous cycles. He runs forward at her command, and a gate opens before him. The portal drops him in the air above Kephale, and he plunges downward, landing on his back.

Golden threads snap around Kephale's limbs, and now he does glance up to see Aglaea on her knees, her hand extended, her face a mask of concentration. Hyacinthia still has her hands pressed to Aglaea's stomach, working a healing power diminished by the lack of her coreflame, but clearly determined to do what she can.

Beneath him, Kephale explodes with black-white light. It bursts out of him like so many shooting stars, peppering the curia. One line of void-color rips through Thanatos's shoulder, and they cry out in agony, clutching at the wound. A series of lines streak after Mydei, who dances away from them with a warrior's fluid grace, quite literally punching them from the air and creating small explosions. He is beautiful, deadly, and he doesn't see the void-color line approaching him from behind.

"Mydei!" Phainon calls out.

Kephale roars, shaking violently beneath him, forcing him to pay attention to his unstable footing on the Titan's back. He can't spare attention to make sure Mydei is alright, can only fist his hand in the lion's mane. Clinging, he drives the point of his blade into the side of Kephale's throat. Golden blood bursts from the wound as he forces his sword through flesh, leaving a ragged slash in his wake.

One of Kephale's hands reaches back, and he grabs Phainon around the middle before Phainon can skid away. He hurls Phainon away, and Phainon

tumbles through the air only for Anaxagoras to snatch his wrist, and drag him down. They slide across the ruined rock of the Curia's floor.

"Quickly," Anaxagoras pants. "We can't keep this up."

Kephale lets out another bellow, so loud it knocks Phainon back a step. Aglaea's threads sag, and in that moment Kephale leaps forward, pouncing on Eunomia. He pins her down as she screams, opening the maw of his lion's mouth. Fire coalesces between his teeth.

No. No, they can't afford to lose a coreflame's vessel.

"Mydei!" he shouts, and Mydei rushes Kephale in time with Phainon.

Tribbie opens twin gates, one in front of Mydei and another before Phainon, and neither hesitates. They plunge inside, appearing in the air above Kephale once more. Time stretches before them, the world slowing down. Mydei lets out a wild war cry, summoning a giant spire of red crystal up from the earth to spear Kephale through the middle as they descend on the lion's neck. As one, they bring their blades down with tremendous force, their momentum aiding them as they sever the head from the body.

Golden blood gushes forth, and the fire sputters out as the head tips forward. Anaxagoras is faster, snatching Eunomia out from beneath Kephale's paw before the dead Titan's head crashes down.

Phainon hits the floor hard, his knees rattling, sweat dripping down his back. He's panting as he turns to the Worldbearer's dead body, relieved and horrified in equal measure. The Worldbearer is dead.

"We must take our coreflames back," Eunomia says around her own labored breathing. "This was a fool's errand. If Kephale could not bear their combined might—"

But Kephale was out of balance. Kephale didn't have Oronyx's coreflame.

You're sure Oronyx's coreflame was destroyed when your Cyrene bent time?

Anaxagoras's question rings in his mind as Eunomia shrugs him off, as she staggers toward Kephale's body with an outstretched arm.

She's not as close to Kephale as Phainon, who plunges his hand into Kephale's back, driving it in up to his shoulder, reaching as deep as he can. Fingers spread wide, instinct guiding him, he strains toward the burning power of all those coreflames and feels an answering resonance from within his own chest, a strange stirring.

"No!" Eunomia shrieks.

"Phainon—!" Mydei lurches forward.

Anaxagoras yanks them both back as Phainon finds the power in the center of Kephale's being and, instead of taking it from Kephale as the others did from themselves, simply absorbs it directly into his body.

Agonizing pain drives him to his knees. Power hammers through him, cracking inside his skull, and he grips his own hair, gasping, staring blankly at the ground in front of him as he screams, as fire consumes him, as he drowns, as thorns pierce his flesh, as rock crushes him, as he loses Mydei over and over and over again. He is tormented by the law, driven mad by the need to reach the heights of the sky itself only to fall from grace. He is trapped in a maze from which there is no escape, chased by the shadow of Death itself, possessed of the desire to tear the very world apart and reduce it to its foundations.

No.

Over thousands of cycles, over countless years, he's seen the world reduced to so much ash. No, he doesn't want that at all.

And he remembers. He remembers every time he failed with sudden, perfect clarity. Remembers every attempt he's made to stop the primordial ones, remembers each failure, every death, both the ones caused by his own hand and the ones caused by THEIR destruction. He's never won. All this time, and he's faced nothing but defeat—and he thinks this time will be

different? He thinks he can create a new memory? Carve a new path for the world?

Who is he, a farm boy from Aedes Elysiae, to want a better world? Should he not be content with the one he has, with the time he has? Is he not exhausted, sick of trying?

Tears cut down his face. He sinks lower, closer to the ground, scratching at his clothes, his chest. He burns, he aches, he is nothing but pain, but regret. Remorse cuts him into ribbons, savaging him as he bows his head and howls with misery.

His name cuts through the agony. “Phainon!” Hands grip his shoulders, warm and callused, wet with golden blood.

He lifts his head. Phainon lifts his head, and he stares into golden eyes, blazing with resolve.

Phainon is a farm boy from Aedes Elysiae who wants to change the world. At first, for everyone else—for so long, for everyone else. For Cyrene, for the friends he’s made and lost, for the people of Amphoreus. But, now, for none of them except Mydei. For Mydei, who deserves to live. For Mydei, who he loves, who is more important than any of it, who he wouldn’t die for because to die for Mydei would be to lose Mydei and he will—not—lose—Mydei.

Clutching Mydei’s wrists, staring into Mydei’s eyes, Phainon wrestles back the power that burns through him, hotter than the sun, than a thousand suns. He is in one of Eurypon’s fires, but he has the Ocean at his fingertips, and he draws on that power now, letting it wash through him, braiding it with Sky’s healing. Soothing power surges forth, washing away the agony of the flames.

“Mydei,” he grits out, squeezing harder.

“Phainon.” Mydei’s fingers dig into Phainon’s shoulders. “Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, Deliverer of Okhema. Of Amphoreus. Will you yield to this?”

He binds the pain with Romance's threads, buries it with Earth's rock, restrains it with Reasons's vines. He climbs on top of it, of the memories. His failures have worn him down, exhausted him, but this time—*this time*—he has so much more to fight for. So much more to win for.

"Will you yield?" Mydei demands.

Phainon grasps the power within him in a mighty fist—and then lets it go. Like Sky's power sweeping through him, he embraces it. Wraps himself around it. Victory is not about control.

Releasing Mydei's wrists, he extends his hands, glowing with golden light, and takes Mydei's face. "Never," he rasps. "For you. For you, I will *never* yield." The power settles inside him, finding a home in his chest, twelve coreflames burning relentlessly. They hurt, but they can't destroy him. Not when he has this thing worth fighting for. Not when he has Mydei.

Mydei has done so much for him. Now, he will make the world a place where Mydei can live.

He pulls Mydei close and kisses him. Mydei's hands find his jaw, his neck. They cling to each other as the last of the pain fades to a dull burn in Phainon's chest, not defeated but manageable.

For Mydei. He will do this for everyone, but for Mydei most of all.

They break apart, panting, resting their foreheads together.

"Well," Anaxagoras says. "That was quite something."

And then they're laughing, Phainon ducking his head with embarrassment as Mydei lifts his own with that princely arrogance he wears so well.

"Can we assume Phainon won't be attacking us the way Kephale did?" Anaxagoras asks, sheathing his sword.

Hyacinthia has moved from Aglaea, who stands nearby, holding both Tribbie and Cipher's hands, to Thanatos, who is no longer bleeding gold but whose arm hangs limp and useless at their side.

“No,” Phainon says, trying and failing to suppress a smile as he glances at Mydei. “No, Phainon won’t be attacking anyone.”

Amphitrite and Pelius drift toward them, but Eunomia keeps her distance, fury on her face. “Was this your plan?” she demands. “To poison Kephale with power and then—”

“Oh, shut up, Eunomia,” Anaxagoras says. “Kephale didn’t have Oronyx’s coreflame within him.” He gestures to Phainon. “But Phainon did.”

“I didn’t…” Phainon presses his hand to his chest, rising with Mydei’s assistance. “I didn’t know. I just… hoped. When I reached into Kephale’s body, I simply hoped. You knew?”

Anaxagoras shakes his head. “Surmised. Presumed.” His expression is smug. “It’s pleasant to be correct.”

“Then what now?” Aglaea asks. “Attempt to turn back the black tide as planned?”

They turn toward the horizon, the former Titans and Phainon, and Phainon’s heart sinks. The green lands beyond Okhema are a sea of black, the sky tinted red. The far walls of the city are slick and dark.

“The black tide is here,” he breathes. Fear shivers down his spine, but he ruthlessly suppresses it.

Aglaea makes a pained sound. “Then we’re too late.”

“Not yet,” Mydei says, his hand still in Phainon’s. “Kephale said the primordial ones’ original prison was made with the coreflames. Phainon, go to the prison, you know the way, and maybe you can reinforce it. We can hold the monsters at bay and evacuate as many citizens as we can.” He looks toward Aglaea. “You have collected plenty of Chrysos Heirs.”

“They man the walls,” she says softly.

“Then they’re already doing what we need them to do,” Mydei says. “We hold the line for Phainon.”

Anaxagoras smiles. “That’s the smartest thing any one of you have said since I arrived.”

Rolling his eyes, Mydei turns to Phainon, taking his face in his hands once again. “For our friends,” he says softly. “For Castrum Kremnos and Okhema. For the world.”

Phainon gives him a hard kiss, a desperate one. The kind of kiss lovers exchange when the world is on the line and one—or both—might die. No. No, neither of them will die. Not this time. “For you,” he says, hitting his fist against Mydei’s chest. “For you.”

Aglaea’s threads bear her command to the Chrysos Heirs at the wall: defend. They bear her command to the former Titans: organize the people. They bear her command to the people throughout the city: flee. But the people are panicking, and Mydei can’t get them to organize neatly ahead of the oncoming tide. Their panic causes them to flood the streets, clutching their children and precious possessions—and some that seem less precious, but he doesn’t have the time or energy to judge them too harshly. Despite his attempts to keep them orderly, they push and shove, and he spends more time fishing people off the ground to prevent them from being trampled than he does actually getting anyone out.

He is wasted here, and he knows it, but he can’t do much at the walls, either. The other Chrysos Heirs will have to hold back the tide’s monsters and, hopefully, the tide as an extension. If he goes to them, they will want him to bleed across the battlements, and there’s only so much of that he can do before killing himself.

Groaning, he yanks a little girl off the ground, sets her on her feet, and pushes her toward her father. “Go,” he says to her, as gently as she can, and she takes off at a run, her short legs working.

People are going to die today in uncountable swaths, and he hates how pointless this feels. If Phainon isn’t successful, if the tide continues, then everyone in Amphoreus will die, the tide will consume the world, and these primordial ones will tear down the very heavens. He wants Phainon to

succeed. He hopes Phainon will with everything he is. But as he urges the people toward the northern gate and out of the city, away from the oncoming tide, he can't help but fear the odds are against them. The weight of Phainon's previous failures are heavy on Mydei's heart, and he hates himself for that. He should believe with everything he is, but he is afraid. He is so very afraid.

Screams pierce the air, and Mydei whips around. Black tide monsters fill the sky, and though the Chrysos Heirs at the walls are doing the best they can, many have broken through. They careen downward, striking at the crowd and infecting those they touch.

Swearing, Mydei pushes through the crowd as the people flee, shoving against their flow. He breaks through them to find spindly creatures lashing out at those who are unfortunate enough to be too slow at the back of the crowd.

He leaps forward, insinuating himself between the people and the monsters, grasping one creature by the face and throwing it through a nearby wall. Though he's given up his coreflame, he's still a Chrysos Heir, still stronger and faster than a normal human, and he uses these strengths to his advantage, the vanguard of an entire city. He beats the monsters back, holding them at bay until the street behind him is empty, and then takes off at a run to find the next street that needs his protection.

There comes a distant explosion, loud enough to ring in his ears, forceful enough to knock him back a step, and he mutters another oath. He clambers up a nearby ladder, taking it to the roof of an abandoned home, and turns in the direction of a plume of smoke, squinting against the distance.

Aglaea's threads light up, carrying the whisper of her voice to his ear. "The southern wall has fallen to the tide." Mydei's heart seizes. "Fall back to the agora. All Heirs, fall back to the agora."

They're going to lose the city. Of course they're going to lose the city. They can't fight the tide itself, only its monsters, but they don't need this hit to their morale.

“Do not give up,” Aglaea’s voice says, vibrating through the threads. “Remain strong. We are the bastion standing between the tide’s monsters and the annihilation of all of Amphoreus. What we save today we will use to rebuild our world from the ashes. Stand firm, children of golden blood, and fight to weave a new fate, a new future.”

Pretty words. Mydei can only hope they’re enough.

Steeling himself, he turns in the direction of the agora.

Energy slams into him from behind, and he staggers forward, gasping. This isn’t the force of an explosion, it’s pure power, and with it comes a terror that eclipses reason. He drowns. He’s back in the lake, weighted to the bed, clawing at the water, desperate for air as he dies and dies and dies. He’s choking on vomit as poison courses through his system. He’s kneeling at Eurypon’s feet, shaking and cold, with Eurypon’s sword resting against his shoulder. Every horrible moment he’s survived, every terror, every fear, screams through him. He relives them all at once, the agony of them hammering down on him.

Mydei finds himself on his knees, vomiting bile, trembling. His vision tunnels; he can see only the limestone roof beneath him, and his every instinct screams that he run, that he flee, that he get as far away from Okhema as he possibly can.

And he knows.

Whatever has sealed THEIR prison has broken.

Chapter End Notes

so anyway that happened

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 20

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The entrance to the primordial ones' prison is deep in the heart of the Marmoreal Palace, hidden behind a maze of storerooms and locked doors for which the keys have long been lost. Phainon breaks down these ancient doors, shoving bodily through rotting wood until he reaches a staircase long, narrow, and curving.

Cold sweat beads on his forehead. His palms go damp and clammy, and he swallows convulsively as his mouth floods with saliva. Every muscle screams in protest as he forces himself to take the first step onto that staircase, hundreds and thousands of failures in this very same place rushing over him. Aglaea's betrayal. Kephale's. He's died here so many times that his body is convinced he'll die here yet again.

"Not this time," he says to himself, forcing his foot onto the first step. "Not this fucking time." He takes another step down. "For Amphoreus." Another. "For Cyrene." He picks up his pace. "For my parents. For Queen Gorgo." He rests his fingers against the curving wall for stability as he descends faster. "For each of those stupid bastards." He laughs, thinking of the somatophylakes, of their wit and their wisdom, of their slow-won friendship. Of Leonnius's scales and Hephaestion's warming heart. "For Mydei." His hand clenches in a tight fist, knuckles dragging over ancient stone. "For *Mydei*."

This time will be different. It has to be. Not just for himself—he can't start over again, he can't—but for Mydei, this Mydei, who he loves.

The stairwell grows darker, darker, but he's been down this way so many times that he doesn't need light. And then, ahead of him, long minutes later, the faint glow of luminous moss. Phainon emerges into a massive underground cavern, carved and polished by Amphoreans long dead, a place that reeks of stale air.

Once, this ancient mausoleum instilled in him a sense of wonder. The cavern is vast, its curving walls extending high above his head, as though there's only a thin layer between the roof of it and the city above. Thick stalagmites have been carved into towering columns, adorned with depictions of the primordial ones instead of the Titans. He walks between these monoliths on a fragile bridge of dark rock. Far below, an underground lake glows with more of that iridescent moss.

Ahead of him, the bridge opens into a circular space not unlike the curia except that it's several times smaller. More intimate. Statues of eighteen impossible creatures ring the space, each more bizarre than the last. Looking at them makes Phainon's head hurt and his stomach heave with nausea, and so he turns his attention to the center of the space. There stands a small altar, and on the altar, an empty basin carved with the symbols of each Titan.

He doesn't know what to do. He carries the twelve coreflames inside of him, but he doesn't know what to do with them. Doesn't even have an inkling of—

Stone cracks. Shatters.

Phainon, standing at the end of the rock bridge, reels back. He forces his gaze onto the statues, fighting visceral nausea and a sudden, pounding headache. There. Golden light shines between hairline cracks that grow and grow as the statue closest to him begins to crumble.

Pain slices through his head, and Phainon collapses to his knees with a cry, pressing his hands to both eyes. His head pounds, he feels his pulse in his ears. He can't breathe, and bile climbs his throat, and when he drops his palms to the rock beneath him to heave, they come away bloody. And they land not on rock but on slick, red-tinged blackness.

"No," he whispers as the tide consumes the rock bridge, reaching for the statues before him. "No, not this."

The tide creeps closer to the statue, and the statue breaks more, great pieces of stone falling away to reveal a man's broad and naked back. White hair

spills around THEIR shoulders as THEY stretch and twist, freeing arms that —that aren't attached to THEIR body. Arms that look like ribbons of curled papyrus.

This is the end. The black tide reaches for the statue, for the primordial *thing* crawling free of its stone prison, and Phainon knows this is the end. The tide will destroy this prison once more, Phainon will fail, and the world will be torn apart only for him to try again. He curls his fingers into fists as blood drips from his nose.

It splatters on the tide, and the tide recoils.

Phainon's breath catches.

Reeling upright, he casts his gaze around himself and discovers the tide has given him a wide berth—just as it does Mydei. He contains Strife's coreflame, and the tide has always fled from Strife. But not just Strife. He contains all the coreflames, and those pieces of crystalized power, born from the chaos of the world, created this entire prison.

A power to imprison gods, and a power to free them.

More of the statue crumbles, the man-shaped thing contained within shaking rock off THEIR hips, THEIR legs.

Phainon reaches out. He digs his fingers beneath the edge of the tide as it tries to race away from his touch, and he closes his fist around the strange, slippery surface of it, grasping it.

"You with the power to destroy a prison meant for things older than gods," he says, mesmerized by the oil-slick surface. He pulls against its retreat, pressing his fist against his chest. "What is destruction if not a vehicle for the creation of something *new*?"

The tide fights his hold, but he has had thousands of years to hone the strength of his will.

“If twelve coreflames can contain the gods that created the universe,” he says, driving the edge of the tide into his chest, “then they can contain whatever you are, too.”

With the force of his will, he grasps the raw power of twelve Titans. With the force of his will and that power in his hand, he grasps the black tide. And he feels the tide’s destructive intent, its need to tear down to make room for something new.

The first of the primordial ones shakes off the last of THEIR prison. THEY turn toward Phainon, expressionless. Bored.

“Yes,” Phainon breathes, watching THEM in turn as he whispers to the tide. “Let’s do that. Together, we can do just that.”

The tide stops fighting him.

Instead, it consumes him.

The agora is full of monsters, of creatures that were once men twisted beyond recognition. Every time Mydei cuts one down, his heart grieves. Was that a mother? A father? A child? Was that monster from beyond Okhema’s walls? Has he just struck down one of his somatophylakes? His own mother?

He can’t think like that. None of them can. With black tide monsters surging around them, the Chrysos Heirs scattered throughout the city, they hold the line for Phainon, for whatever Phainon can do in the depths of the earth against the primordial ones. Mydei strikes down monsters who were innocents so that Phainon can have more time. He kills to stave off what feels more and more like the inevitable end, the certainty that they will do this again and that he won’t remember and that Phainon will well and truly break.

“Do not despair.”

She is at his back. Castorice, the Hand of Shadow, Thanatos's heir. They have been protecting each other for agonizing minutes now, for what feels like hours. Her miasma is thin, and his arms are weary, but neither of them gives up. If there are people left in Okhema, the two of them provide protection to their fleeing backs. And if there aren't, if all are gone or turned to monsters, they do what they can for Phainon.

For *Phainon*.

"I don't," Mydei grits out, cutting down another monster. Where it falls at his feet, the black tide glimmers strangely, more like rushing water than a stable coating over the earth beneath. "I won't."

Castorice whips out a tendril of her miasma, disintegrating an approaching monster as she dances around him. "Stay focused," she admonishes.

But his attention is wholly arrested by the way the black tide seems to move beneath him, the way it ripples and shimmers. Where it has covered the earth in the past, it is still. But this tide isn't still. This tide shivers with movement.

A sudden compulsion seizes him.

"To the roofs," he says to Castorice, swinging to the side as he pulverizes the abdomen of yet another monster and offers a prayer for forgiveness to whatever benevolent gods may exist—if any. The Titans don't answer prayers like this, and the primordial ones likely don't care to; Mydei can't imagine there's anything left beyond these powers. "We need to get to the roofs."

Castorice throws a bewildered glance his way as she circles behind him. "Why?"

"Trust me," he says, though she has no reason to. But he has no reason to trust her, either. Not truly. She killed him, once. The end of the world makes strange bedfellows, and he supposes it's better to have Death's heir on his side than against him.

Together, they cut through the surging tide of monsters, making their way to a tall building on the edge of the agora. The door has already been battered down, and Mydei hurries through it, ducking between the broken boards of wood.

Castorice follows. “There’s nothing to barricade the doors,” she warns him as he slams open another door, revealing a staircase up.

“So we keep fighting. This way.” He hurries up the steps, taking them two at a time, his heart pounding in his chest not from the exhilaration of the fight but rather something else entirely. Something is different. Something has changed. The tide doesn’t shimmer and ripple like that, and he has his suspicions. He just has to confirm them.

A ladder greets him on the second floor, and he takes that, too, throwing open the hatch to the roof when he reaches it. He hops onto the roof, reaching through the hatch for Castorice. She takes his gauntleted wrist in her hand.

“Hurry,” she says, and he yanks her up through the hatch, depositing her on the roof beside him.

They both move quickly, slamming the hatch down. Mydei keeps his weight on it, holding firm against the black tide monsters that batter it from below, until Castorice manages to drag several heavy crates over it. Only then does he pull away, closing his eyes for a second just to breathe. But they don’t have seconds, and he can’t afford to take this time. He turns to the horizon, where the world should be dark and glassy from the black tide’s consumption and finds only naked, barren earth.

Castorice approaches from the side. “Where is the tide?” she asks softly, her voice trembling. “What’s happened to it?”

Mydei throws himself to the side of the roof, leaning over, and he is just in time to watch the backline of the tide crawl across the ground of the agora, glimpsing it between the clashing of monsters and men, as it rushes through Okhema as though being pulled somewhere.

Where it passes, the monsters go still. Some of the Chrysos Heirs take the easy shots, but others step back, horrified, as monstrous flesh melts away. Humans stand where once were monsters, naked, reeling.

Dread cleaves through him.

“What’s happening?” Castorice whispers as she joins him.

“Phainon,” Mydei breathes. “Phainon, what are you doing?”

Freedom tastes of stale air and the desperation of dying men.

Disgusting.

Even if destruction wasn’t THEIR nature, THEY would be motivated to tear this place, this world, this cosmos, to pieces.

THEY shake off the confines of THEIR statue prison, tearing THEIR way free of THEIR stone sarcophagus. Behind THEM, an ant falls to its knees, and THEY glance back to observe the insignificant creature. It burns with light, with golden blood, but it’s less important than the red-black tide of death approaching THEM. This is a foreign destruction, a dismantling power that isn’t THEIR own, but it’s old and somehow familiar—and friendly, too. It whispers promises of freedom not just for THEM but for THEIR siblings. The very corners of THEIR lips turn upward.

Good. Let THEIR siblings break free of the shells that cage THEM, too, and let THEM all tear down this putrid, rotting universe and its upstart gods.

THEY step out of THEIR stone prison, shaking off the last of THEIR shackles, and crouch to reach for the destructive energy. THEY will nurture it, guide it, make it so much *more* than what it currently is. THEY will help it evolve and—

And it swerves away from THEM, a tide pulling out to sea before the terrible wave of a tsunami crashes down on the shore.

THEY lift their face toward the ant on its knees before THEM, watching it absorb the blackness. This is intriguing, this is fascinating. This is a creature that has the potential to be so much *more,* and THEY want to peel back its skin to find out how it can grow to eclipse itself. THEY are not prone to nurture, that's the domain of one of THEIR myriad siblings, but this little ant could be cultivated into something of use. Something that could help THEM tear down the universe to make room for a new one, and perhaps there might be a place for it in that new universe, a tool for continued destruction.

More, more, the ant takes in yet more of the blackness, absorbing the tide into itself, and the air vibrates with expectant power. Static fills THEIR mouth. A strange sensation twinges in their belly.

No simple human ant could absorb this power. Now, THEY see beyond its skin to the golden light beneath, the twelve hated coreflames it carries inside itself, and that uncomfortable sensation grows. THEY rise. THEY take a step back only to catch THEMSELF. THEY are destruction incarnate and THEY flee from nothing, especially not an ant like this.

"You," the ant says as darkness disappears into its body, as it absorbs the strange tide that should be THEIRS by right. It rises, the ant, and hatred burns in its eyes. It draws a puny, human blade, and the darkness inside it envelops the sword, changes it until it glows with a white-black light, a void of death. The ant laughs, low and strained and unhinged. "You don't get to win this time." It lunges for THEM.

That strange sensation in THEIR gut churns.

Casually, THEY sway the ant aside, throwing it into a nearby wall. There is work to be done, and THEY cannot be bothered by such trivial things, even if the ant has claimed what should be THEIRS. Later, THEY will take that black tide back. Now, THEY must ready the way for THEIR siblings.

THEY leap from the ground, pulverizing rock above THEM with a mere thought, annihilating that which is between THEM and THEIR goals.

THEY burst free of the earth, emerging into a sun-drenched agora filled with more golden ants. Ants that stare up at THEM, agog, baffled, and THEY allow THEMSELF a moment of contented satisfaction. This is how it should be, these tiny, insignificant creatures paralyzed by THEIR presence. A shame none of them will survive the remaking of the world.

Extending THEIR hand, THEY work their fingers into the spaces between atoms where the world is thin and the laws of the universe mean nothing. The air around THEM cracks so much like THEIR stone prison, and THEY work THEIR fingers deeper as the ants begin to scream, as they begin to pepper THEM with pathetic attacks that barely register as sensation. What can they do to THEM? How could these ants possibly interfere with THEIR driving motivation? This universe will end, and THEY will be one cause of that ending. THEY will—

Something that is not an ant slams into THEM, tumbling THEM from the sky. THEY crash through a building, battering down walls as THEY slide across the ground. When THEY catch THEMSELF, when THEY gain THEIR feet, THEY look up to find a creature alight with golden energy, bathed in it as though in flames.

THEY realize at once what that strange feeling is in their stomach, that twisting, knotting sensation that so persists.

Fear.

THEY are afraid.

Burning, burning, burning, inside and out, he is on fire.

Golden blood stains his skin, there is a ringing in his head from his collision with the rocks, but he is burning and he is fury and he will take his fury out on the creatures that have driven him past the point of all reason. He is hatred, and he hates THEM. Oh, he hates THEM the way the night hates the day, the way the moon hates the sun. THEY have taken everything from him—*everything*—over and over until there’s nothing left, until he’s an empty shell, and still THEY take yet more, ripping him open, hollowing

him out, but now he has something and he won’t let THEM take from him again.

No, he will burn THEM as he burns, he will light THEM up until THEY, too, are consumed as he is consumed, he will reduce himself to ash and take THEM with him.

Roaring, screaming, throat raw, blade of void and light in hand, agony within and without, his form twisting, changing, becoming more more *more*. Golden light, red-black slick, he is everything in the universe and the desire to consume it, to free the wild chaos of creation dressed in the mourning veil of destruction.

He plunges from the sky, shattering limestone homes into splintered spiderwebs, atomizing the rock. The world screams in protest, the air exploding in his wake like so much thunder, a mighty boom that cracks his eardrums—he doesn’t need them, doesn’t need to hear, doesn’t need to see, either, because THEIR power is a lodestone pulling at his own.

THEY aren’t there. THEY aren’t there when his sword meets stone, THEY are gone, THEY are above him, wrenching open reality to summon forth monsters from beyond Amphoreus to assault him. They are but ants, these creatures, and he towers above them, engulfing them in the fire that pours from his flesh, so hot it is as liquid. He rips them asunder and burns them alive, and they scream as THEY back up, up, up, putting so much space between them, and THEY can command space, THEY can twist it bend it break it change it rend it but he won’t let it twist bend break change rend.

He *remembers*.

The air splits and magma pours from it, but he remembers there are no volcanoes, not here, not in this place, never in this place. Resolute, he remembers the world as it was and is and has been because he has seen it so many times, thousands of times—it is etched into his memory as he carries the past into the future.

The future, the future, he will make the future anew, he will destroy what threatens the future he cherishes so deeply. How strange. He remembers

hating the future, fearing the future, but now the future is red-painted flesh and golden hair and leonine eyes and it is laughter and warm hands slapping his back and friendly mockery and empty wineskins. It is scales that will never balance but the desire to strive to make them so, and THEY will try to take all this away from him, and he—

HE will not allow it.

HE screams, embracing the fire inside HIM, and it burns burns burns into wings of shining red-black and glittering gold.

"Flee!" Aglaea cries along her threads, but Mydei doesn't move. He stands rooted to the roof as a flaming Phainon clears the agora of black tide monsters, burning them away. The heat of him blazes across the agora, reaching up the sides of the buildings, scorching Mydei's every breath, but still he doesn't move. He is transfixed by the sight of Phainon leaping into the air, of white-black light trailing Phainon's sword, as he closes rifts in the world with one hand and swings on THEM with the other.

The primordial one swerves away from Phainon's strike, barely escaping the smoking line of destruction the attack leaves both in its wake and before him. Though Mydei is too far from THEM to make out THEIR expressions, there is clear terror in the way THEY hold THEMSELF, an almost disbelief that some mere mortal might challenge THEM.

But Phainon isn't a mere mortal. Blazing light erupts from him as he chases down the primordial one, framing twin wings of red-black and gold. A halo like the sigil of Worldbearing gleams at the back of his head, and he is—he is—*HE is*.

HE is so much more than anything Mydei has ever seen before, something beyond human, akin to a Titan but still *more,* bearing the tide in one hand and all the coreflames of the Titans in the other.

When the primordial one tears reality, HE stitches it back together, dancing across the open skies with HIS midnight bright sword. The primordial one screams with fury, and Mydei falls to his knees, suddenly somehow *less*

than he was before, and the remaining trees untouched by the tide turn to dust and the light from the sun *dims*, and, oh, THEY are consuming the very essence of the world as THEY surge forward to meet Phainon's blade with THEIR own.

HIS weapon is a midnight sun, blackness haloed by light, but THEIRS is pure absence, the space between all things crafted into a sharp-edged blade, and when THEY cut against Phainon, THEY cut through the world itself.

There are worlds beyond imagining visible through the holes in the sky, echoes of impossible things that crumble into nothingness. Pink skies and orange oceans, creatures with shapes that bend the mind. THEY absorb the destruction of these worlds, taking some essence into THEMSELF, and Phainon isn't quick enough to close all of the holes in reality as HE parries relentless attacks.

The two of THEM dance across the darkening sky, light visibly streaming from the far-distant sun into the primordial one as THEY destroy it, as THEY beat Phainon back, as they dip beneath HIS guard to slice through arm and wing, and Mydei struggles to his feet with a cry, watching Phainon crash to the ground.

"No, Mydei, don't—!" Castorice reaches for him, but he fights the strange gravity of their dying world, throwing himself over the edge of the roof.

He hits the ground hard, glancing toward the sky, but THEY have no interest in him. THEY have put away their blade as THEY once more rip into the fabric of the world, tearing it open, exposing the soul of the world for THEM to consume. This is destruction in its purest form, the end of all things. They are going to die.

Weaving through the corpses of Chrysos Heirs, through the debris fallen from two gods clashing, Mydei makes his way to HIM, to Phainon, to what remains of HIM in a pool of golden blood. The heat pouring off HIM is too much. It dries Mydei's eyes, singes his throat, scalds his skin, but he pushes closer, closer, splashing through simmering blood to fall to his knees at Phainon's side.

He presses one hand to Phainon’s chest, so hot it burns away layers of his skin. Unimaginable pain screams along his nerves, but pain has never mattered much to him. He has survived worse than this.

“Phainon,” he says, leaning over HIM. “Phainon!”

HIS breath is shallow, HIS eyes are closed, HE isn’t moving, but HE is still alive. All that matters is that HE’s still alive.

“Is this what puts you in the ground?” Mydei demands, pressing his hand firmly against Phainon’s burning chest, fighting the excruciating pain of it. “Will you give up here?” Phainon’s bleeding, HIS right arm gone, HIS body bruised and battered and covered in cuts. Those cuts glitter at the ends, the skin sparkling and ragged—like the edge of the black tide, but golden instead of red-black. When HE opens HIS eyes, they don’t focus. “You have the coreflames and the black tide itself, you madman. You have all the power Amphoreus has to offer. Get up.” Phainon doesn’t move. “Get *up*, damn you, and live. Do not let us die.” His nails gouge into Phainon’s flesh. “Do not let *me* die.”

Phainon’s gaze fixes on Mydei’s, HIS eyes golden and bright. “I—”

“Save me,” Mydei says, weaponizing himself, his life, his very existence. “Love *me* and only me, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, Deliverer of Amphoreus.”

A horrible, steaming breath wheezes out of Phainon’s battered body, and he is a man again. An incredible man, a man who has survived thousands of years against all odds, but a man nonetheless. A man who Mydei loves—a man who loves Mydei in turn.

Phainon shoves himself up, blood dripping from his severed arm. He clutches Mydei’s wrist, gasping, shuddering, visibly steeling himself. “Bring the surviving Titans to the prison.”

“Where—” Mydei begins, but the answer is there in his mind as if he always knew, and he stares at Phainon, at the creature he’s become, until he finds the man buried beneath the veneer of godhood. “We’ll be there.” He

turns his wrist in Phainon’s hold, clutching his hand. “Don’t fucking die on me, Deliverer.”

“I love you,” Phainon says fiercely, and then HE launches HIMSELF into the air.

THEY drive THEIR essence deeper, deeper, forcing it into the core of the world, cracking it open, spilling out its essence in turn. THEY consume it, devour it, take it into THEMSELF to strengthen THEIR spirit. THEY must be the herald for THEIR siblings, leading the way into a new universe, for this one must be destroyed. The Titans have tainted it with their greed for power. And, oh, taking in the soul of a planet as it crumbles beneath THEIR hands is an ecstasy THEY had forgotten while in THEIR prison. THEY are flush with new power, growing in THEIR strength, becoming every minute more and more of what THEY were before THEY were imprisoned beneath the earth. THEY are—

Pain explodes through THEM, a blade protruding from THEIR stomach.

No. No, that isn’t possible. Not even the strange *thing* that emerged from THEIR prison to fight THEM could have—but it *has*, and it—IT?—is gowned in fiery authority, as if IT can rival THEM. Nothing has ever rivaled THEM before, not even the Titans. Twelve of them united could barely stand against THEM and THEIR siblings, but now here is this tiny creature, and IT tears ITS blade from THEIR side, ripping THEM open.

THEY tumble from the sky. Essence flows out of THEM, and there isn’t any time to gather it back up, because IT attacks again, ITS sword flashing in the light of ITS dying sun.

Barely, THEY parry the blade with another one of THEIR own.

THEY took ITS arm. THEY took ITS sword arm, and yet IT persists, screaming, launching a furious volley of attacks on THEM that THEY can only just keep up with. THEY are stronger in every way, but IT anticipates THEM as if IT understands combat better than THEY ever could, and the fear that kindled in THEIR belly previously comes roaring back.

In all the universe, nothing has compared to THEM but this thing, this ant that has become more than ITSELF, and THEY are afraid. THEY are terrified. This is not how the universe works. This is—this is an anomaly, one not even THEIR siblings could have predicted, for all of THEM knew there would come a day when THEY would break free, but none of THEM anticipated resistance. None of THEM anticipated IT.

IT is rage and violence, and ITS burning hatred is so very familiar. THEY should be able to manipulate that vehement fury, but when THEY grasp it, the emotion slips through THEIR fingers. There, burning at the heart of IT, is not hatred. ITS hatred is a mask covering an emotion that is far greater and far more terrifying.

IT isn't rage and fury.

IT is *love*.

THEY stumble beneath ITS onslaught, ducking ITS blade in strategic retreat, trying to find space to put between THEMSELF and IT, but IT is relentless. IT chases THEM, hounds THEM, bullies THEM toward a crater in the center of the city, and it is with no small horror that THEY realize where that crater leads.

In vain, THEY attempt to dodge away from the crater, but golden strings capture THEIR wrists and drag THEM down as IT slams its sword into THEIR gut. THEY fall, stunned by a hit that feels like a meteor strike, plummeting deep, deep into the earth.

They are already there, the Titans. Their faces have changed, but THEY recognize THEIR children and ancient adversaries, these things THEY created with THEIR siblings. THEY climb to THEIR feet, struggling against the golden threads that bind THEM. Romance has tried this trick before, and THEY lunge for her—only for IT to crash into THEIR back and drive THEM to the ground.

"*Bind him*," IT snarls.

NO, THEY shout, rattling the firmament itself, but the Titans are firm in their resolve. They take their coreflames and offer them up to the altar rising before THEM, its basin full not of water but golden blood.

THEY thrash violently beneath IT. Surely, having given up the coreflames, IT can't stand against THEM, but IT remains strong in a way THEY cannot comprehend, powered by the strength of the love at ITS core. IT grinds THEIR face into the ground, and THEY *scream*.

The Titans stagger, but they aren't defeated. Each of them presents their coreflame to the altar, and IT reaches out, giving over the final two. Symbols flare above them, ancient binding magics invoked against THEM, THEIR prison reforming. Stone crawls up from the earth, encasing THEIR hands, THEIR legs.

THEY scream again, desperately trying to roll IT off their back, but THEY can't dislodge IT, and THEY can't shake off the stone that closes around THEM. Fury burns within THEM, but it's nothing like the blazing core of IT. Even now, even lacking all those coreflames, powered solely by that red-black destructive force that should be THEIRS—it should be *THEIRS*—IT is stronger.

Very well. If THEY cannot avoid imprisonment, THEY will take IT with them. THEY redouble THEIR efforts, forcing IT to restrain THEM, and a grim, vindictive satisfaction cuts through THEM. THEY will destroy this enemy even if that means destroying THEMSELF.

He's burning himself out. He knows it. The coreflames rest on the altar, the black tide surges within him, and there's nothing left within him to give. Now, at last, perhaps he can give up. Stone climbs over his fingers as he holds THEM down. Wraps around his wrists. A prison that can contain a primordial one can surely contain the black tide, too, and he will finally, finally, have his rest. Because he can't live again.

He can't. He will make this sacrifice, locking himself away with the primordial ones, to trap the black tide, too. For himself, yes, and for Mydei. For the somatophylakes. For everyone, for the people he has met and

known and loved along these many millennia. Mydei owns his heart, but he's loved them all in different ways, and it is his love, now, that sustains him as rock climbs his wrists.

"You know," a woman's voice says.

He looks up.

There, standing above the altar in a white gown, is Cyrene with her soft, kind smile.

"You know you can depend on other people, too," she says, and the world is still, the rock isn't consuming him anymore, and no one is moving, not even her. "You don't have to do all of this on your own."

Tears burn in his eyes. "You're gone," he says, those tears spilling over his cheeks. "You've been gone so many years."

"Silly," she says, stepping down from the altar. Her chiton isn't purely white, he realizes, and her hair isn't just that familiar shade of pink. She is an iridescent rainbow, a culmination of so many things. "I've been hiding inside you all this time, putting myself back together. You gave me a safe place to rest." Her hand touches his face, holding it. "You've been so busy saving all of us, Phainon. Why don't you let us save you?"

His jaw works, the words stuck in his throat as he weeps. "I—I don't know how."

"Let us share your burdens," she tells him, touching the wound on his chest where he took the black tide into himself. "Let it go, Phainon. Rely on us, too."

There remain faint lines of golden light connecting him to each of the twelve coreflames where they float over the altar, lines of meaning and relationship that stretch back over tens of thousands of cycles. Some are thicker than others, Aglaea's the thickets of them all, but there shines Mydei's, his connection to Strife a beacon in the darkness.

He touches his chest, the stone on his hand crumbling away, and he's not worried at all that the primordial one will escape. He flattens his palm over his sternum, over the deep gouge there, and when he withdraws his hand, something red and black and slick pools there.

"We're with you," Cyrene says. "Even me." She laughs, quietly. "I never even left."

"I didn't know," he says, apologetic.

She tuts. "I didn't want you to." Her hand falls from his cheek and curls around his. Gently, she guides his hand to the golden light rooted in his chest, the one that extends to all the others. "Let us help you for once."

Shaking, he wraps his hand around the golden tether. The black tide surges along it, hungry to consume, to destroy, and it splits along all twelve lines of light, sinking into each of the coreflames in turn, emptying him out until he's hollow and aching, a shell of himself.

"I…" He stares up at Cyrene. "I don't think I have anything left," he admits.

She huffs. "Oh, Phainon. We both know that's a lie." She pokes her finger against his chest. "Your greatest sin has always been that you've loved too much. Now why don't you wake up?"

Phainon gasps, his eyes flying open. He lays across Mydei's lap, and Mydei's hands are pressed to his chest. There's a wild look in his reddened eyes, his cheeks mottled, his lips trembling.

"Phainon," he rasps, and then he's clutching Phainon against him, and Phainon is clinging to him, too, clutching at his shoulder and crying and laughing at the same time. He wasn't so hollowed out there was nothing left. Cyrene was right—she was always right. She—

He jerks away from Mydei, raking his eyes over the assembled Titans. Aglaea, Tribbie, Cipher, Amphitrite. Eunomia and Pelius are gone, replaced

with faces of Chrysos Heirs Phainon knows only vaguely. Castorice stands where Thanatos should have. Anaxagoras has survived. So has Hyacinthia. Mydei still holds him, thrumming with Strife's power, and Worldbearing burns within Phainon's own chest.

But there, standing before the altar in her iridescent chiton, stands Cyrene, too, and she's smiling at him. "Thank you," she says, and he's weeping again, for real this time, as he turns his face into Mydei's neck and sobs with relief.

"It's over," he says, clinging to Mydei, and Mydei's clinging to him, too, the two of them wrapped around each other in the broken remains of a tomb for ancient gods.

"It's over," Mydei whispers back to him.

Chapter End Notes

special thanks to tea for betaing this chapter to make sure that it was an understandable kind of weird, because writing from an aeon's pov sure is odd

anyway, look, ma! no one's dead! :D

as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

Chapter 21

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hyacine heals and bandages Phainon's right arm as much as she can, but not even the Sky Titan can restore a severed limb. Phainon's sure he'll have a whole host of feelings about his lost arm later, but for the moment, he's simply glad to be alive. Is glad Cyrene is alive. Is glad Mydei is alive and at his side, holding onto his remaining hand, clutching it within a bruising grip.

It's Aglaea who calls them to order, who leads them from the mausoleum beneath the earth into the light of day. The sun above them blazes as though the primordial one never drank from it, and the rends in space are gone, but the destruction remains. The people remain.

They are everywhere in the agora, the Amphoreans who became monsters who were then returned to themselves when Phainon took in the tide. Chrysos Heirs move through their ranks, already seeing to them, offering clothes and blankets alongside cups of water.

"I don't understand," he says to Cyrene while leaning heavily on Mydei. "How did this happen?"

She shakes her head. "I was living inside you when you did that. How am I supposed to know?"

He gives her a half-hearted glare. "You seemed to have a whole lot of answers thirty minutes ago."

"Well, that was thirty minutes ago. This is now. Now, I have no idea what you did," she says, waving him off.

He looks up at Mydei.

Mydei shrugs. “Don’t expect me to know, Deliverer,” he says, his lips quirking.

Phainon tries to drag his missing right hand down his face—and a small pit forms in his stomach.

Mydei must read his sudden distress on his face. He gentles, at least as much as he ever does in public, and rests his forehead against Phainon’s. “You saved the world,” he reminds him. “You saved me.”

It takes several seconds for a faint smile to turn Phainon’s lips. “I suppose I did.”

Anaxagoras, of course, is the one who eventually proposes an explanation later that evening as the Titans gather in the Marmoreal Palace. There’s a strange pull between them, one that Phainon assumes has always been present but that Mydei explains is new. Anaxagoras has an explanation for that, too.

“Phainon undid the curse of the black tide,” he says. “By drawing it into himself, he extracted it from the land and the people.”

“We will have to explore the farms and the wilderness between the city states,” Aglaea says. “There was grass on the horizon, but we don’t know how much Phainon managed to save.”

They all look at him, and he turns away, embarrassed by the weight of their stares.

“As for the black tide itself,” Anaxagoras continues, “all of us now hold it within ourselves and our coreflames. We are its guardians.” He taps his chest. “Not only are we bound by its presence shared between us but by the weight of the cycles Phainon experienced.” He makes a thoughtful sound. “This will change what it means to be a Titan.”

“How?” Hyacine asks.

A grin splits Anaxagoras's face. "We will have to find out, won't we? And that will be the most exciting thing to come out of any of this."

Phainon and Mydei share brief looks of incredulity. But of course this new mystery would please Anaxagoras.

Aglaea takes command of Okhema the following morning, martialing her Chrysos Heirs to see to those who are recovered monsters and to help rebuild. She employs the Titans, too, all except Anaxagoras and Hyacine, who disappeared in the night—presumably to return to the Grove. But when she turns to give orders to Mydei, he declines them.

"My loyalties are first to my own people," he says, bowing politely to her. "Let me return home and assess the damage there. If it's minimal, I will speak to my queen mother on your behalf. I will convince her to send support to rebuild Okhema."

Aglaea studies him for a long, quiet moment, tapping her finger against her lip. "Very well," she says at last. "You are right that I cannot keep you here. And I will, too, send messengers to the recovered army to ensure it no longer marches on your city. You are not Castrum Kremnos's king—" And Phainon sees the relief in Mydei's eyes at that statement. "—but I will consider you a proxy for your mother." She extends her hand. "Let this be a tentative peace between us."

He takes her hand. "Let it," he agrees.

Her hand falls away, and she turns to Phainon, who lingers at Mydei's side, not sure where he belongs in this conversation or the larger one about the world more generally. He has spent so long in his cycles that he doesn't know where to go. What to do. But when Aglaea turns his way, fear spikes through him. How funny. He faced down a Titan's god and he's still afraid of Aglaea.

But her expression is soft when she regards him. "Phainon," she says warmly, taking both his shoulders in her hands. "I should one day like very

much to hear about all the adventures we went on throughout your many lives."

"One day?" he ventures.

"One day," she says again. "But not this day." Her hands fall away from him. "I release you from your service to me in light of everything you've done for Amphoreus. You are a free man, no longer beholden to Okhema." She smiles, and it's a sad thing. "Whatever debts may have existed between us in this cycle of your life are no more, and they never should have been. Live your life as you will."

Even if she hadn't granted him this freedom, he would have simply taken it, but her kindness is an olive branch, and he accepts it gratefully. "Thank you, Aglaea."

Lips curling, she glances from him to Mydei. "Will the two of you travel together?"

Phainon's face heats. It's not as if their relationship is a secret, and they have been painfully obvious about it since arriving. He'd hoped that most people wouldn't notice, not for any greater reason that he didn't want to deal with external nosiness, but of course there was that kiss. And Aglaea's not the sort to let that go. Romance sees all such relationships far more clearly than anyone else. "If he'll have me," Phainon says, not looking at Mydei.

Mydei makes a noise in the back of his throat that promises trouble. "If I'll have you?" he asks. "If? And what if I won't?"

At that, Phainon snaps back around. "What does that mean?"

"What do you think it means?" Mydei asks, one brow lifted in princely arrogance.

Phainon has no idea, but he's not about to lose whatever this argument is that he's stumbled into. "That you're planning on leaving without me."

Mydei rolls his eyes. “If I found our somatophylakes without you in tow, they’d probably string me up and leave me for dead.”

“They would not.” The thought warms his heart, but he affects a cool expression.

“Well, no,” Mydei admits, a small grin appearing on his face. “But at least one of them would probably consider it.”

“Probably?”

“Maybe.”

Aglaea makes a sound that manage to be both amused and disgusted, drawing their attention back to her. “Once you two work out precisely who’s going where and stringing up whom, Okhema will supply you with horses for your journey and whatever food and water we can afford to part with.” She places a hand on Phainon’s left arm, warm and reassuring. “And if you ever desire to return, your welcome will be a warm one.”

Mydei wants to leave immediately, but Phainon has unfinished business. He convinces Mydei to wait until after lunch, and while Mydei makes ready for their departure, Phainon goes in search of Cyrene.

She stands on a balcony near the pinnacle of the Marmoreal Palace, still in that iridescent chiton, her expression serene and inscrutable. As he approaches, she turns to him with a smile, and she hooks a lock of hair behind her ear. “I wondered when you’d come find me.”

“I thought you might be avoiding me.”

Her smile widens. “Never. I’ve just needed some time alone.” She returns her gaze to the distant horizon, green once more with the removal of the tide. There are perhaps less trees, but the world appears to be as it was before the tide. There is hope for the future of Amphoreus. A future he couldn’t have created without her help. “It’s been… a long time since I’ve been alone.”

She’s smiling, but he grimaces. “How much of my life have you seen?”

“Oh, all of it,” she replies.

He wonders if he can spill the black tide out of himself and let it destroy him. That sounds nice. “All of it?” His voice is uncomfortably high.

“Don’t worry. I closed my eyes for a lot of the more recent bits.” She winks.

He could die. “Cyrene,” he begins, strangled.

Expression softening, she beckons him closer, and he joins her against the rail, watching the sky, bright and blue and clear. “You’re going off with Mydei, aren’t you?” she asks.

He closes his eyes and nods, turning his face into the sunlight, letting it wash over him. “I am.” A part of him doesn’t want to. They’re different people, now. She’s seen all of his life, has lived all of his lives. She knows him, but he doesn’t know her. He wants to know her again. Wants to rekindle their friendship. But he suspects she’s had enough of him for many lifetimes. “You’re welcome to join us,” he says anyway. “We’re going to find his—our—somatophylakes and then head back to Castrum Kremnos. You could join us. See the world for what it really is.” Instead of what it was through the prison of his eyes. He looks at her, a little hopeful, but knowing already what she’s going to say.

“I think I want to stay.” She hops onto the railing, letting the wind catch her hair, and he wants to pull her back, but he’s not her keeper. “Aglaea’s asked me to help, and my abilities as the Time Titan are uniquely suited for fixing things, don’t you think?” She laughs, but it’s a sad sound. “I hope you understand.”

He does. That doesn’t make losing her when he’s just gotten her back hurt any less. “We’ll have to come visit you,” he says. “Mydei and I. Here, in Okhema. If Aglaea and Gorgo don’t decide that they want that war after all.”

Her eyes go vague and unfocused, and she lists to the side. He leans forward, reaching out to—but he doesn't have his right arm anymore, and he has to awkwardly grab her with his left hand instead. She catches herself on the railing before he can. "I don't think they will," she says. "Go to war. I think they're both tired. I think they both want something new."

"That's… good, then," he says, resting his arm on the rail once more, trying not to worry about her balance, about her tumbling off and falling to her death. But even if she did, she could just reverse the course of time and soar back to safety. She doesn't need him. The world doesn't need him. Not anymore. "It's time for something new."

She touches his shoulder, his bad one, the one no else will go near except Mydei. "Live, Phainon," she says. "For once in your life, be selfish, and live."

They leave in the early afternoon, astride horses that have seen better days but that are all Okhema can bear to part with. The younger horses, the stronger horses, are needed to rebuild the city and restore the farmlands.

Mydei carries with him a papyrus from Aglaea to Gorgo and one of Aglaea's seals—safe passage for them both, in case they come across her army. Phainon carries their supplies and the weight of something that isn't regret but certainly feels like it. He misses his arm. He misses his sense of purpose. Another cycle would have crushed him, but without the endless churning of those cycles, he has nothing to offer the world.

"You're upset," Mydei observes as they make camp that first night. They tie their nags nearby and build a fire by unspoken agreement; they want the potential company. "Why?"

Phainon sits against Mydei's side, tucking himself beneath Mydei's arm, seeking the comfort his victory affords him. Mydei is *alive*, and he should be happy. "Who is Phainon of Aedes Elysiae?" he asks. "Without the cycles, who am I? What do I offer the world?"

Mydei loops an arm around Phainon's back, settling his hand on his hip. He nuzzles into Phainon's neck, and Phainon closes his eyes. "What do you need to offer anyone anymore, Deliverer?" Mydei asks, lightly teasing.

A frustrated sound catches in Phainon's throat. "That's not—I've had purpose for so long. And now it's just… gone."

Mydei's mouth finds the curve of his jaw, not to arouse but to soothe, offering comfort and kindness. "The world is vast," he says, "and there are paths and purposes a plenty. We will find something that fulfills you."

He wants to believe that so very much, but he's afraid. "And if we don't?"

"Since when have you been a pessimist?" Mydei asks. "If you can't find faith of your own, then trust in me. I believe there's more for you." There's a tightness, a pain in Mydei's voice, and Phainon aches.

Maybe Cyrene was right about his sins.

"Then I'll believe in you," Phainon says, tipping his head to the side and brushing his mouth against Mydei's. "I'll believe in my love for you."

Dawn comes too early, and Phainon peels himself away from Mydei, rousing him. They break their camp after a brief meal, pack their supplies, and mount their horses. Castrum Kremnos is several days away by horse, and while they could use Mydei's form as Strife, neither is keen on scaring the tide's survivors with the Titan's form.

On the second night, still camped by the side of the road, the two of them unwilling to inconvenience the villagers between Okhema and Castrum Kremnos, human figures emerge from the darkness. Mydei's hand goes to his sword, resting at his side, and Phainon rises from where he sits. He is one-armed but ambidextrous and more than capable of helping Mydei defend their camp if needed.

"Ho, there," a man's voice calls. A familiar voice.

Mydei is on his feet in an instant, his expression wild, pained, hopeful. “Hephaestion?”

The shadows pause, and then they step into the circle of firelight. The somatophylakes are clothed in rags, their expressions both haggard and joyful, and they are on Phainon and Mydei before Phainon can react. Phainon finds himself enveloped in back-slapping hugs, with tears in his eyes, and he decides he doesn’t care if these men see him crying because they’re crying, too, all of them, as they grab hold of each other, as they embrace each other like they’ve just escaped the gallows.

They have, all of them.

“You fucking maniac,” Leonnius says when he finds Phainon in the fray. He grabs him in a rough embrace. “You did it. You actually fucking did it.” He shoves Phainon back, holding him at arm’s length. “Fuck me,” he breathes.

Phainon gestures to his arm. “How are those scales?”

Leonnius swats the side of his head. “Fuck the scales, you Titansdamn madman.”

And then Hephaestion is squeezing his forearm, is tugging him into another embrace. “Everything between us,” he says seriously, his hand on the back of Phainon’s neck, “is washed away. You fixed the world.”

Phainon offers him a wan smile. “I suppose I did.”

“Tell me you have wine,” Leonnius roars, throwing his arms around Perdikkas and Peucesta. “Tonight, we should drink!”

“We have travel food and water,” Mydei replies dryly. “Enough for two to reach Castrum Kremnos.”

Leonnius sighs, visibly aggrieved. “Then we will tell our stories with water and empty bellies!”

They crowd around the fire, the five bullying Mydei and Phainon until they give up the story of the Battle of Okhema. He and Mydei take turns,

interrupting each other in the retelling of events, though Mydei has to recount his combat against the primordial one. Phainon's memories are too disjointed and surreal for him to accurately describe any of it, and he listens to his own story with wonder. He did that. He fought something stronger than a Titan—and he won.

"They'll write songs about you," Peucesta declares. "No. No, *I* will write songs about you, because no one else is going to get it right."

"They'll all make him too handsome," Leonnius agrees.

Phainon scoffs, warmed not just by the fire. This easy camaraderie fills some of that gaping hole within him. "You only say that because you're so ugly, Leonnius."

And then they're fighting, taking sides, arguing over who among them is the least attractive and who the most. Mydei defends him, and he defends Mydei, until the somatophylakes as a whole turn on the two of them, mocking them in the way of friendship for the love they have for each other.

Much, much later, when it's just Hephaestion and Phainon awake, Phainon turns his face to the sky and says, "What was it like when you were one of those monsters?"

Hephaestion is silent for a long, long time, so long that Phainon thinks he'll ignore the question entirely. But then, quietly, he replies, "Terrible. There was nothing left in me but the hunger to destroy. Even now, I still feel it, this… yawning emptiness and the need to fill it with carnage."

Phainon leans back. He can't bring himself to look at Hephaestion, not wanting to take away the illusion of privacy. "I think I left part of myself in those cycles. What's left of me has…" He trails off. He doesn't have nothing. He has Hephaestion. He has Leonnius, Perdikkas, Ptolemy, Peucesta. He has Mydei. "Everything ends."

"Profound," Hephaestion drawls.

“We can’t have new beginnings without endings. We’re both hollowed out now, in different ways, but we’ll find something to fill the voids within us.” He drops his hand on Hephaestion’s shoulder.

Hephaestion does the same, and they sit there, holding each other. “We will,” he says.

Castrum Kremnos is alive. Mydei could weep with relief to see the gates guarded, to see a city that lives and breathes, that pulses with energy, even if that energy is somewhat subdued. His people—but they aren’t his people anymore, not really, and that sends a pang through him. They are alive. They have survived. But they aren’t his. Not anymore. Now, all of Amphoreus must be his, and he has some obligation to its recovery from the collective trauma of the black tide.

A strange weight settles in his guts. He doesn’t know what to do with this truth, with this realization. He doesn’t know how to save people.

Subdued himself, he glances at Phainon, and Phainon catches his eye. “Excited to be home?” he asks, with the hollow expression of a man dreading his current location. Though Phainon is a free man by every measure, all the chains of his bondage broken, Mydei cannot imagine he loves Castrum Kremnos.

And Mydei, too, doesn’t love Castrum Kremnos the way he once did. He loves what it stands for. What is has been historically. What it could be again. But he doesn’t love what it became under Eurypon and what it must move away from under his mother.

“It’s a strange feeling,” Mydei admits, slipping his hand into Phainon’s. “But I’m not sure Castrum Kremons is home anymore.” Phainon looks taken aback but says nothing, and Mydei remembers what he called Phainon so many weeks ago, before his world changed so dramatically. Phainon of Nowhere. “Perhaps I’m now Mydei of Nowhere.” His lips quirk, but his smile is sad.

Phainon squeezes his hand. “The Lance of Fury. Mydei of Amphoreus.”

The titles bear a strange weight, and Mydei isn't sure he's ready to accept them. Not yet.

Word still travels ahead of them, reaching the palace well before they do. Gorgo waits for them in the inner courtyard, her expression cool but approving. How strange, but his mother's approval means so little to him, now.

Still, he slides off his horse and goes to her, kneeling without hesitation. She has always been Castrum Kremnos's queen before she was his mother. At his back, Phainon and the somatophylakes kneel, too.

"Rise," Gorgo says. "The Strife Titan does not bend his knee to Castrum Kremnos."

He obeys, and she offers him a small smile, the faintest indication of her approval. How strange that it means so little to him now. He helped Phainon to save the world, and his mother's regard, which once would have made his heart soar, has become a much smaller currency.

Later, much later, when they are feted at Gorgo's behest, Phainon leans over and says, "Tell me she's embraced you in private."

Mydei regards the wine in his goblet. "We have had no private moment." Fury flickers across Phainon's face, and Mydei touches his thigh beneath the table they share. "Put away your anger," he says softly.

"For you," Phainon replies, just as soft.

That Phainon is angry for him means more to him than his mother's affection. How the world has shifted on its axis. Mydei's heart swells. He allows himself a small smile, hidden by his goblet, and he smooths his hand higher on Phainon's thigh.

Even later than that, when the hour is late and the sun kisses the distant horizon, when Phainon and Mydei return to Mydei's old room, Mydei says looks around himself and feels only loathing. "I don't want to stay here," he says.

“I don’t, either,” Phainon says.

They look at each other and they smile and then they laugh. They cry, too, and find themselves on the floor in front of a kline, leaning against each other and once more emptied of everything they could feel.

“I don’t want to sleep in that bed with you,” Mydei says, staring at the ceiling above him. “And I don’t want to live in this palace with you. But I don’t know where we could go instead.”

Phainon tucks Mydei into his side, leaning their heads together. “The world is vast, and there are places beyond number.” His lips quirk. “Despite living for so long, I’ve barely ventured beyond our city states.”

“Then we should go to these places,” Mydei says. “Far to the east, and then to the north, where it’s so cold we can see our own breath.”

“South, too.” Phainon laces their fingers. “To sandy deserts dotted with oases.” He pauses. “Will you not miss your mother?”

Mydei lifts their fingers to his lips and kisses Phainon’s knuckles. Will he? “I will.” And he means it. His ties to her remain strong—perhaps that’s why they hurt so much. “But my presence here will only harm her. My *existence* will harm her, but it will be even harder for her if I remain.”

“She’s still your mother.”

“She’s the Queen of Castrum Kremnos first,” Mydei says. “She always has been. It’s why she used us so well.” He exhales, his breath shuddery, and turns into Phainon’s body. He doesn’t miss the warmth of Phainon’s lost arm but takes refuge in the strength of Phainon’s body beneath his. “Let’s leave. Let’s see the deserts and the mountains. Let’s go east and taste strange new foods.”

Phainon curls around Mydei. “You’re sure?”

“I’m sure.” They don’t belong here anymore. This isn’t home—not for him, not anymore, and never for Phainon.

“Then let’s go,” Phainon says, giving him a kiss, one that Mydei returns with fervor, with hunger.

Leaving Castrum Kremnos is as easy as entering it. While Phainon tells the somatophylakes what he and Mydei have decided, while he gives them the chance to honorably renounce their vows and stay with their families, Mydei makes his goodbyes to Gorgo. The somatophylakes, to a man, commit themselves to the unknown journey.

“We can’t trust you to survive without us,” Leonnius says.

“I should like to learn the music of these farflung places,” Peucesta says.

“And I their knowledge of numbers and the world,” Ptolemy adds.

Perdikkas smiles broadly. “It is said that eastern medicine is more advanced than our own. Can we start there?”

“Your homes,” Phainon says. “Your families…”

Hephaestion claps Phainon on his right shoulder. “Home is people,” he says. “Mydei has always been that person for us.” He sighs, a touch dramatically. “And, now, unfortunately, so are you.” He slaps Phainon on the back and goes to collect his things, but his words linger.

Home is people.

Gorgo gives them healthy horses and a cart full of supplies for their journey though she doesn’t see them off. Perhaps it’s better that she doesn’t, that she and Mydei made their farewells in private. Hephaestion brings his maps and takes charge of their journey immediately, turning them, as Perdikkas had hoped, to the east.

“There’s so much we can learn in the east,” Perdikkas says excitedly, all but vibrating in his saddle. “I’ve heard of a technique that utilizes needles to—”

“That’s not why we’re headed east,” Hephaestion says.

They all stare at him, bewildered.

“It’s not?” Mydei asks.

“It’s not,” Hephaestion confirms.

Phainon’s brows come together. “Then why?” he asks.

Hephaestion rolls up his map, tucking it into a pouch at his side. “There is a temple to Romance in the next city,” he says dryly, “and there is no better place to celebrate a union.”

Phainon sputters, but Mydei laughs. He takes Phainon’s hand in his, stretching their arms between their mounts, and grins broadly. “I hadn’t gotten around to asking you, yet,” he says. “If you’d marry a man who is no longer a prince.”

Home is people. Home is *people*, is a single *person*, and Phainon hasn’t been home in so long. He squeezes Mydei’s hand in his own, fighting back the burn of tears through a smile so broad it hurts his face. “Would you marry a one-armed madman?” he asks.

“I would have no other,” Mydei replies.

“Nor would I.”

Home is people.

“For fuck’s sake,” Leonnius barks. “Why is it always this ridiculous sentimentality with the two of you?”

Perdikkas shoves him. “Let them be in love,” he snaps back.

“Let us all have this one good thing for more than ten seconds,” Ptolemy says. “And anyway, a marriage celebration means wine for you.”

Leonnius grabs at Hephaestion. “Then we should get married, too, so there’s more wine for everyone.”

“I’d rather die,” Hephaestion replies.

“We need new friends,” Phainon says directly to Mydei, who laughs and laughs until tears stream down his cheeks.

Peucesta plucks a string of notes on his lap harp, the beginnings of a bawdy drinking song about newlyweds. Leonnius launches into the verse with too much gusto and not enough sense of pitch, and is joined shortly after by Mydei, who’s still wiping tears from his eyes. And Phainon, laughing, gives up on fighting them and lifts his voice alongside theirs.

These are his people, and they are his home.

Chapter End Notes

> and with that, we reach the end of Those Heirs Uncrowned. a special word of thanks to hale who was an early reader for this chapter and helped me make sure i stuck the landing <3
>
> i really hope you've enjoyed this fic, and i'm so grateful to all of you who came along for the ride :3 you made my fridays wonderful!
>
> as always, you can find me on twitter and bluesky

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